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Early Childhood

The Great Afternoon

Cartoons Are for Life: The Secret Password & The Afternoon Sanctuary

Date: 1994-05-18 at 15:30 America/New_York

3:30 PM — The Secret Password

Three polite, measured knocks sounded against the painted wood of my closed bedroom door just as the red digital clock on the cable converter box ticked to 3:29.

“Cartoons are for life,” came Katie’s voice through the wood, hushed and completely serious.

The secret password was given. Immediately, I scrambled up off the dark low-pile carpet of my deep-blue bedroom and swung the door open to admit my twin sister just in time for our favorite afternoon block of cartoons. Having just turned nine years old back on April eighth, neither of us cared what the other kids on our street in Virginia Beach were doing after the school bus dropped us off. School was six straight hours of scraping desks, unpredictable bells, and teachers who tried to seat fraternal twins on opposite sides of the hallway just because I was a boy and Katie was a girl. To the teachers at school and the adults in our extended family, I was Nathaniel, though Dad and Katie half the time just called me Nate; behind this door, I was simply the other half of Katie’s perimeter.

Katie slipped inside, her long, straight platinum-blonde hair swinging past her shoulders as she pulled the door shut behind her until the latch clicked. We didn’t need to explain to anyone else why we had a password for a room ten feet away from her own bedroom down the hall. Out in the rest of the house, the afternoon air was already heavy—Mom had locked her bedroom door at two o’clock with another headache and a glass from the kitchen cabinet, and Dad wouldn’t be home from work until five-thirty to start dinner. Behind my closed door, however, the rules belonged entirely to the two of us.

I rushed back across the carpet and pressed the power button on the front of the television and the cable converter box just as the Majestic Studios castle logo and the afternoon cartoon block bumper flashed across the curved glass tube.

The opening brass fanfare of the *Galactic Samurai Geckos* theme song burst out of the small speaker grille, and instantly, both of us got completely carried away. Katie grabbed both of my hands, and for the next sixty seconds we bounced on the balls of our feet in the middle of the carpet, belting out every single word of the intro theme in unison while the animated title cards rolled across the screen.

Then, just as quickly, the final drumbeat of the opening theme faded out, the episode title card appeared, and the two of us were brought gently back to earth.

Without letting go of my hand, Katie dropped down onto the carpet right beside me, leaning her shoulder firmly against mine. I adjusted the volume knob down two notches so the dialogue wouldn't echo into the hallway, rested my back against the side of my bed frame, and let my sister's weight anchor me in place while the afternoon cartoons glowed across the quiet room.

Summer Camp at Virginia Dominion University

The Parallel Pair: Dominion Mall & The VDU Fieldhouse

Date: 1994-07-12 at 08:45 America/New_York

8:45 AM — Two Pairs on Dominion Mall

"All right, Youth Division, let's buddy up in two lines for the walk across Dominion Mall!" Counselor Brad announced over the splash of the circular concrete plaza fountain, tapping his wooden clipboard with a grin.

Standing on the wide, sun-bleached concrete plaza of Virginia Dominion University in Norfolk at eight-forty-five in the morning, wearing matching royal-blue VDU Summer Camp t-shirts over our shorts, Katie immediately tightened her fingers around my right wrist. When our dad, David Prairie, had signed the two of us up for this two-week, all-day camp block—running from nine o'clock in the morning until four o'clock in the afternoon—he had wanted to keep us safely out of the house in July while he was at work. Katie and I had our own rule for surviving six hours a day around fifteen noisy, unfamiliar kids: we were not letting go of each other.

Two paces ahead of us in the Youth Division line, I noticed we weren't the only brother and sister operating on that exact protocol.

A nine-year-old boy with reddish-blond hair and wire-rimmed glasses—whose name tag read *Michael*—and his seven-year-old sister *Rachel*, who had dark shoulder-length hair and glasses of her own, were standing hip-to-hip with their fingers laced together in a white-knuckled grip while their fourteen-year-old sister adjusted her backpack beside them before heading over to the Senior Division group. Just like Katie and me, Michael and Rachel didn't care about the cartoons or baseball cards the other campers were shouting about; they were holding onto each other like their lives depended on it.

Naturally, the two college-age counselors running our Youth Division—Counselor Brad and Counselor Kelly—looked at the four of us and reached the exact wrong conclusion.

"Look at this—we've got two brothers and two sisters right next to each other!" Brad called out brightly. "Let's mix it up today so the boys can hang out with the boys and the girls can hang out with the girls! Michael, step right back here and pair up with Nathaniel! And Rachel, you team up with Katie!"

Before I could protest, Brad guided me a step forward beside Michael, while Kelly gently steered Katie two steps back beside Rachel.

For four seconds, the counselors' geometry held.

I looked sideways at Michael through the thick Tidewater humidity. Michael looked sideways at me behind his wire-rimmed glasses. Neither of us had anything against the other—in fact, I could tell in half a heartbeat that his brain hated the sudden change in the line just as much as mine did. Behind us, Katie wasn't saying a word to Rachel, and Rachel wasn't saying a word to Katie; both of our sisters were staring straight at the backs of our blue camp shirts with their shoulders stiff and their jaws locked tight.

Michael and I didn't need to say a single word out loud. As soon as Counselor Brad turned his back and held his clipboard up in the air to lead the group across the light-gray concrete squares of Dominion Mall, Michael gave me a tiny, solemn nod, and I nodded right back.

I stepped half a pace to my left. Michael stepped half a pace to his right. In the exact same motion, Katie slipped forward to grab my hand again, and Rachel stepped right back into place on Michael's left flank.

By the time our sneakers clicked across the second concrete expansion joint past the circular fountain toward the precast-concrete and blue-glass facade of the University Library, the boy-and-girl experiment was completely over. It was brother and sister on the left, and twin brother and twin sister on the right.

9:30 AM — Terminal 4 and Terminal 5

At nine-thirty, the counselors ushered us out of the ninety-degree heat into the sixty-eight-degree air conditioning of the university computer lab.

Thirty beige desktop towers running *Quantum OS* and curved CRT monitors lined the walls, their cooling fans humming in a low, steady chord behind rows of mechanical *KeyMech* keyboards. I loved computers almost as much as I loved our afternoon cartoons, and Katie loved sitting beside me while we took turns with the mouse and keyboard.

Counselor Brad, however, still hadn't given up on his clipboard chart.

"Okay, campers, listen up!" Brad called out from the front desk, holding up a plastic tray of 3.5-inch floppy disks. "Boys on the left wall row—we've got *Wagon Train West* and *Where on the Map Is Scarlet Devereaux?* loaded up! Girls on the right wall row for *Digit Chompers* and *PixelPaint Junior*!"

Brad pointed Michael to Terminal 4 and guided me into the rolling plastic chair right next to him at Terminal 5. Across the blue carpet, Counselor Kelly led Rachel and Katie to Terminals 19 and 20 against the opposite wall.

The moment Katie's hand left my wrist, the hum of the computer lab stopped feeling calming and started feeling like a trap. Down the row to our left, a boy in a basketball cap was pounding his mechanical spacebar with both thumbs and yelling at the screen as his wagon sank in a river. I didn't touch my keyboard at Terminal 5. Instead, I twisted halfway around in my plastic chair and looked straight across the center aisle.

At Terminal 20, Katie was sitting completely motionless in front of the flashing five-by-five number grid of *Digit Chompers*, twisting the hem of her royal-blue camp shirt around her fingers while looking back across the carpet at me. Right beside her at Terminal 19, Rachel Ragsdale had pulled both hands off her desk and tucked her knuckles tightly against her chest.

Next to me at Terminal 4, Michael pushed his chair back six inches and looked at his sister. At the exact same moment, I tapped the open corner of my desk at Terminal 5 and motioned to Katie.

While Brad was kneeling beside the dot-matrix printer at the front of the room, Katie and Rachel slid off their chairs in perfect synchronization and walked three quiet steps side by side across the carpet.

Rachel squeezed onto the right half of Michael's seat at Terminal 4, and Katie pulled the empty rolling chair from the end of the row right up against my right side at Terminal 5, her long platinum-blonde hair brushing my sleeve as she exhaled a long, quiet breath of relief.

"Hey, girls, your computers are still running over on the right wall—" Counselor Kelly started, walking down the aisle before stopping short as she took in the two identical brother-and-sister teams sitting shoulder-to-shoulder at Terminals 4 and 5.

"She's playing with me," Michael told her quietly from Terminal 4, his left hand resting on the arrow keys while Rachel's right thumb hovered over the spacebar for *Digit Chompers*. "I steer the square, and Rachel chomps the multiples. That's how we play."

I rested my left hand on the keyboard of Terminal 5 and placed Katie's hand over the beige two-button mouse for *Wagon Train West*.

"Katie's my twin," I said, looking up at Kelly with quiet, unshakable certainty. "We always play together."

Kelly looked from Michael and Rachel to Katie and me. Neither pair was making noise, neither pair was arguing, and the panicked stiffness had vanished from all four of us the second the sisters were back beside their brothers. Slowly, Kelly smiled, pulled an extra chair over for Rachel so both pairs had two seats pushed flush together, and jotted a quick note on her clipboard.

"Okay," Kelly said gently. "Michael and Rachel on Terminal 4, Nathaniel and Katie on Terminal 5."

For the next hour and a half, Katie and I guided our pixel wagon all the way across the western rivers without losing a single ox—trading turns with the mouse while Michael and Rachel cleared screen after screen of *Digit Chompers* two feet to our left.

1:30 PM — Pair 1 and Pair 2 at the Fieldhouse Pool

After eating our grilled cheese sandwiches side by side in the Monarch Commons dining hall at noon—just a few seats down from where Michael and Rachel's fourteen-year-old sister Jessica used her written lunch exception on the camp roster to sit with them and quiz them on campus landmarks—our group walked down Hampton Boulevard to the VDU Fieldhouse.

The Fieldhouse was a massive brick athletic building where the Lady Admirals played women's basketball during the school year while the men's team played downtown under the concrete dome of the Norfolk Prism. Down the rubber-floored hallway, through the double doors of the Fieldhouse Natatorium, the indoor swimming pool echoed with splashing water and bouncing whistles.

As soon as I stepped out of the boys' locker room in my swim trunks, Katie stepped out of the girls' locker room door in her navy one-piece swimsuit, walked straight across the wet white tile, and grabbed my hand with both of hers. Right next to us on the bench, Rachel Ragsdale did the exact same thing with Michael.

Up on the deck beside the white plastic Buddy Board, Counselor Brad held up his thick black grease pencil and tried the gender split one last time.

"Every fifteen minutes when the lifeguard blows the long whistle and yells *Buddy Check*, you and your buddy have to find each other in the shallow end, grab hands, and hold them up in the air!" Brad called out over the echoing cavern. "Michael and Nathaniel, you guys are Pair Four! Rachel and Katie, you two are Pair Nine!"

Katie squeezed my fingers tightly as thirty kids splashed into the pool at once. I didn't let go of her hand, and four feet to my left, Michael didn't let go of Rachel's. Together, both pairs walked down the wide fiberglass steps into the warm, three-foot shallow end along the side wall.

Two minutes later, the head lifeguard on the high white chair raised his silver whistle to his lips.

TWEEEEET!

"BUDDY CHECK!" the lifeguard shouted through his red megaphone. "Find your buddy and hands in the air!"

Out in the middle of the shallow end, kids who had been chasing each other in *Admirals and Anchors* pool tag splashed around in circles trying to remember who their assigned partner was.

Along the shallow wall, Katie's left hand was already laced tightly through my right hand, and Rachel's right hand was already laced tightly through Michael's left. Before the whistle had even stopped echoing off the steel roof trusses of the Fieldhouse, all four of us raised our joined hands straight into the air above the water.

Up on the deck, Counselor Brad stared at our two pairs of raised brother-and-sister hands, looked at Counselor Kelly laughing softly behind her clipboard, and finally surrendered. Wiping his rag across the grease pencil on the white plastic board, Brad wrote two new permanent assignments at the very top of the list:

PAIR 1: MICHAEL + RACHEL PAIR 2: NATHANIEL + KATIE

Katie looked at me as we lowered our arms back into the warm water, a bright, triumphant smile breaking across her face, and across the lane Michael and Rachel shared the exact same quiet grin. For the rest of the two-week camp block—from the morning walk across Dominion Mall to afternoon *Four-in-a-Row Grid* and *Wild Draw* cards in the Fieldhouse multipurpose room—nobody at Virginia Dominion University ever tried to separate either pair of siblings again.

Big Family Christmas

The Newport News ARTS Train & The Downstairs Sofa Bed

Date: 1994-12-23 at 18:15 America/New_York

6:15 PM — The Newport News ARTS Platform

The evening train pulled into the brick ARTS—American Rail Transit Service—station in Newport News with a long hiss of air brakes and a cloud of white steam rising into the cold December air.

Up on the concrete platform, Katie and I stood side by side in our winter coats with our hands tucked into our pockets, watching the stainless-steel ARTS passenger doors slide open. Moments later, Grandma, our Aunt Elizabeth, and our twelve-year-old cousin Chelsea—Aunt Liz's developmentally disabled daughter, who was three years older than us—stepped down onto the platform carrying their holiday suitcases, and the whole family crowded together to exchange hugs and greetings.

True to form, before we had even walked ten feet past the station canopy toward the parking lot, Aunt Elizabeth wasted no time digging into her coat pocket and lighting up a cigarette.

Beside us, Chelsea immediately scowled and angrily plugged her nose with two fingers.

"Mom, that's gross," Chelsea stammered, waving a hand in front of her face as all of us were forced to stand on the cold curb waiting before we could load into the vehicles.

"Liz, put that out," our dad snapped, his breath fogging in the December chill as he hefted two suitcases into the trunk of our Holt sedan. "You know damn well that's not good for you!"

"Alright, alright," Aunt Liz snapped back, stubbing the cigarette out on the heel of her boot as we sorted ourselves into the two vehicles for the drive back across the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel.

Chelsea climbed into the middle of the back bench seat of the Holt sedan right between Katie and me, while Dad and Aunt Liz sat up front. Behind us, Mom—who was having a rare sober evening so Grandma wouldn't ask questions at the ARTS station—drove Grandma in the pickup truck following our taillights down Interstate 64.

As soon as our sedan cleared the tunnel and turned onto the familiar streets of Virginia Beach, Katie leaned forward slightly to look across Chelsea at me, her eyes bright with holiday excitement.

“Welcome to Virginia Beach!” Katie squealed happily, squeezing Chelsea’s mittened hand. “Now, the three of us are going to have to squeeze into one room!”

8:00 PM — Downstairs Sanctuary

When we pulled into the driveway at home, Katie, Chelsea, and I pitched in right away to help Grandma and Aunt Liz carry their overnight bags through the front door.

Standing at the foot of the stairs in the foyer, Dad laid out the holiday room assignments.

“You three will share the sofa bed,” Dad said to us kids, gesturing toward the living room. Turning to the adults, he added, “Mom, Katie’s room is closer to the upstairs bathroom. Liz, you get Nathaniel’s room.”

In a lot of houses, getting evicted from both of our upstairs bedrooms for the holidays would have felt like a punishment. To Katie and me, however, Dad had just handed us the greatest logistical gift of Christmas. With Grandma in Katie’s room, Aunt Liz in my room, and Mom and Dad behind their closed door at the end of the upstairs hall, all four adults were confined to the second floor—which meant the entire first floor belonged exclusively to the three of us kids.

“Chelsea, there’s a bathroom down here we can use,” Katie explained immediately, pointing down the short hallway off the living room. “It has a shower. We can stay downstairs while the adults are upstairs.”

“Okay,” our cousin replied, setting her backpack by the couch. “Where do we sleep?”

“The three of us will sleep down here. This sofa is a sofa bed,” Katie replied proudly as the three of us finished carrying the last of the adults’ bags up the stairs.

Because the train had arrived late in the evening, dinner was fast and simple—warm bowls of soup and buttered rolls around the dining table—and before nine o’clock, the adults retreated upstairs for the night, leaving the first floor completely to the three of us.

“I want to take a shower,” Chelsea announced to Katie and me once the upstairs footsteps quieted down.

Katie walked her down the short hall to show her how to turn the downstairs shower faucet on and where the clean towels were stacked, then came back out into the living room where I had already changed into my long-sleeved flannel pajamas and was busy pulling the heavy metal frame of the sofa bed out from inside the couch. Working together, Katie and I unfolded the mattress, smoothed out the clean cotton sheets, and spread two thick winter quilts across the top.

A few minutes later, the bathroom door clicked open. Instead of putting her pajamas on inside the bathroom, Chelsea wandered straight out into the living room wrapped only in a bath towel, making her way casually toward the sofa bed Katie and I had just finished setting up.

“CHELSEA!” Katie stammered, her hand shooting out in a flash to clamp firmly over my eyes. “Your cousin shouldn’t be seeing all of you!”

Before Chelsea could even blink, Katie spun her right back around by the shoulders and shunted her straight back into the downstairs bathroom to finish drying off and put her flannel pajamas on properly.

“You need to stop blushing,” my twin sister admonished me once the bathroom door clicked shut behind Chelsea—except she didn’t truly admonish me at all, letting out a quiet, bubbly giggle as she took her hand off my face. “You promise not to tell anyone?”

“Promise,” I replied, rubbing the bridge of my nose as we both climbed onto the left side of the wide sofa bed in our flannel pajamas and pulled the heavy winter quilt up to our chins.

“You know Chelsea sometimes forgets the rules when she’s in a different house,” Katie whispered, leaning her head against my shoulder underneath the quilt and lacing her fingers through mine. “As long as we look out for each other down here, nobody upstairs is going to yell at anyone.”

“Not a word to anyone,” I whispered back, squeezing her hand.

Two minutes later, Chelsea came back out of the hallway wearing her full green flannel pajamas, fuzzy socks, and a sheepish grin, and climbed under the quilt on the far side of the sofa bed. With the living room lamp clicked off and only the colored lights of the Christmas tree glowing softly in the corner, Katie stayed tucked right against my side—the two of us holding down our downstairs sanctuary while the winter wind rattled the front windows.

Middle School & The Blizzard of ’96

The Blizzard of ’96

Snow Day in Virginia Beach & The Backyard Promise

Date: 1996-01-06 at 11:30 America/New_York

11:30 AM — Waiting for the First Flakes

“You think we’re going to have snow?” Katie asked, her breath fogging a small circle on the cold glass pane as the two of us stood shoulder to shoulder at my upstairs bedroom window.

“Hope so. SNOW DAY!” I said, practically vibrating with excitement as I pressed my palms against the wooden sill and looked out at our residential street in Virginia Beach.

Outside on the first Saturday of January 1996, it was bitterly cold, and heavy, slate-gray clouds were rolling in off the Atlantic until the sky looked like brushed steel. Behind us on my bedroom stand, the local Norfolk GBS news station had cut into regular Saturday morning programming, the meteorologist standing in front of a swirling radar map warning all of Hampton Roads to prepare for the Blizzard of ’96. Even on a Saturday, a real blizzard meant Monday and Tuesday would be wiped clean off the school calendar.

“Snow,” Katie replied hopefully, leaning her shoulder against mine as the news anchor continued to drone on and on about wind gusts, coastal flooding, and how many inches were expected later in the afternoon. Both of us were thrilled at the thought of the whole neighborhood shutting down.

At twelve-thirty, while Katie and I were sitting side by side at the kitchen table eating our lunch sandwiches, the first white flakes began to drift past the dining room window. At first it wasn’t much—just fine, powdery crystals swirling across the dry grass—but within twenty minutes the flakes grew thick and steady, dusting the wooden fence rails and the roof of Dad’s car.

“Wonder if it will stick,” Katie giggled, pointing her finger toward the patio.

By late afternoon, it didn’t just stick; it buried the entire backyard under a clean, silent blanket of white.

Inside the house, however, the quiet didn’t last. Around five o’clock, the familiar, sharp sound of Mom’s and Dad’s voices started rising from the upstairs hallway—first a slammed cabinet door, then the bitter, overlapping shouting match that always followed whenever Dad found another empty bottle hidden behind the pantry cans.

5:45 PM — The Backyard Bear Hug

Katie and I didn’t wait for the yelling to reach the staircase. We pulled on our heavy winter jackets and boots and slipped out the back door into the twilight snow.

Out in the backyard, inside the perimeter of our white wooden picket fence, the falling snow acted like a giant acoustic blanket over the neighborhood. The streetlamps glowed pale orange through the swirling flakes, and every footstep made a soft, muted crunch under our shoes.

Standing near the center of the yard with the snow settling onto my short blonde hair, the cold wind hit my face, and all at once the weight of everything we had been carrying over the past year caught up with me. My chest tightened, and before I could stop myself, I started sniffling in the cold air.

Katie turned around immediately. She didn’t hesitate for a second—she stepped straight through the snow and pulled me into a tight, fierce bear hug, wrapping both of her blue-jacketed arms around my shoulders.

“What’s wrong?” Katie asked softly against my ear, holding onto me with all her strength.

“I’m just so happy you’re willing to do all of this for me,” I whispered into her shoulder, my voice shaking slightly as I held onto the back of her winter coat, unsure of how to put the rest of the knot in my chest into words.

Katie didn’t need me to explain it. Because she was my twin, she already knew the exact two things crushing my ribs.

“You’re still upset with last year, and that girl everyone thought you had a crush on?” Katie asked gently.

“Yes, I am,” I whimpered, burying my face against her collar, overwhelmingly grateful that my twin sister was hugging me instead of telling me to toughen up. All through the previous spring at school, a pack of kids in our grade had latched onto a rumor that I had a crush on a girl in our homeroom, turning every hallway change and cafeteria period into a relentless, mocking gauntlet that wouldn’t stop no matter what I said. “And it does not help that Mom and Dad are arguing with each other again. I just want to enjoy the snow without the screaming.”

“I’m right here, and I will never leave you,” Katie replied fiercely, pulling me into an even tighter bear hug as the heavy January snow came down all around us in the twilight. “I’m your sister, and I would just never, ever leave you.”

She held onto me for a long moment in the quiet yard, letting the steady pressure of her arms slow my breathing down, before she spoke again.

“Your classmates are mean,” Katie continued, her voice firm against the cold wind. “Especially when they refuse to back down. When we go back to school, I will gladly play my part of pretend girlfriend so they leave you alone.”

“Thank you, but I think everyone knows that you’re my sister,” I whispered, managing a small, shaky laugh even as my teeth started chattering from the twenty-degree air.

“Come on, let’s head back inside before we freeze,” Katie said, taking my hand and leading me back across the snow-covered grass toward the back door.

Inside the warm kitchen, the shouting upstairs had finally stopped—Mom had gone to bed for the night, and the house was still again. Standing beside the dark green laminate counter with the snow piling up against the dining room window glass behind us, Katie wrapped her arms around my neck for one more long, warming hug until the chill left my fingers.

“Let’s use my bed tonight,” I whispered as we started walking up the stairs together. “This way we can see the street from my window when we wake up in the morning.”

“Sure,” Katie smiled. “I hope we wake up to snow on the ground like there is right now.”

At the top of the landing, I paused outside my bedroom door and looked at her. “Real quick, if you’re going to spend the night with me: what should we do about getting changed?”

“I’ll go change into my warm pajamas in my room and grab my pillow, and I’ll knock when I’m ready,” Katie whispered with a practical nod.

Three minutes later, after I had pulled on my own heavy winter flannel pajamas and climbed under the covers by the window, three quiet knocks sounded against my door.

“Cartoons are for life,” Katie whispered from the hall.

“Come on in,” I whispered back.

Carrying her pillow under her arm in her purple fleece pajamas, Katie crossed the carpet and climbed under the heavy blanket right at my side. Outside my bedroom window, the Blizzard of ’96 howled silently across Virginia Beach, piling deep drifts against the curb under the glow of the streetlamp, while inside the warm perimeter of my bed, my twin sister and I fell fast asleep holding hands.

Katie Is Dumped

No More Fighting & The Dinner Dance Promise

Date: 1997-10-16 at 16:15 America/New_York

4:15 PM — Tears Under the Blue Butterfly

“Leave me alone! You’d never understand,” Katie sobbed, turning her head half away as I pushed her bedroom door open and stepped onto the carpet.

I had just walked up the stairs after seventh grade when I heard the sound echoing right through her hollow wooden door into the upstairs hallway. Katie was standing near the foot of her bed against the bright magenta-purple wall beneath her framed blue morpho butterfly print, crying up a storm with her shoulders shaking inside her dark navy t-shirt and both hands pressed over her face.

For the first month of middle school—while I spent my afternoons quiet in my blue bedroom with my *Nova 64* video games and Katie tried her hardest to fit in with the girls from her English class and a seventh-grade boy named Donnie—the stress of the loud hallways and Mom’s worsening drinking at home had pushed the two of us into the stupid habit of bickering whenever we passed each other in the hall.

Hearing the ragged sound of her crying, I dropped every trace of that irritation at the door. Stepping quietly across her room, I placed my hand gently on her shoulder.

“What is it?” I asked softly.

Katie continued sobbing for several seconds, her chest heaving as she tried to catch her breath. I realized immediately that this wasn’t a small hallway argument—this was serious. It took her a long moment to realize that I wasn’t going to tease her or make fun of her for crying.

Slowly, she lowered her hands from her tear-streaked face.

“Donnie dumped me,” Katie choked out, fresh tears spilling down her cheeks. “I loved him, and he dumped me!”

I reached my hand out to gently wipe the tears from her eyes. Never having had a girlfriend myself—and never having been dumped—I didn’t fully understand the mechanics of middle-school romance, but I didn’t need to understand romance to see how badly my twin sister was hurting.

Katie reached out with both hands and took mine, holding onto my fingers tightly as if she were drowning and I was the only solid ground in the room.

“Please… don’t let go,” she whispered, her voice raw.

I closed both of my hands around hers and held on firmly. Looking straight into my eyes with a sudden, desperate seriousness, Katie asked the question that mattered most to survival in a middle-school cafeteria:

“Will you sit with me at lunch?”

The look on Katie’s upset face told me the only answer she needed to hear—and it was the exact answer I wanted to give her anyway.

“Yes,” I answered without hesitation. “I’ll sit with you at lunch.”

Katie burst into fresh tears of pure relief, letting go of my fingers only to throw both arms around my neck and pull me into a tight hug.

“Thank you,” she whispered against my shoulder.

I could hear how raspy and sore her throat was from all of her crying, so I offered to run downstairs and get her a cold glass of water, but she shook her head and held onto my shirt even tighter. As I wrapped my arms around her waist and hugged her back in the quiet room, I felt something shift permanently inside my chest. All the petty squabbling we had done over the past few weeks felt completely, utterly stupid. Katie didn’t want to stop hugging me, and I didn’t have a single problem with that.

“Please, no more fighting,” my sister sobbed softly into my shoulder.

“I understand,” I promised, resting my chin against the top of her blonde hair as we continued to hold onto each other.

“I’m still upset, but thanks for this,” Katie murmured a minute later as I felt a few more warm tears soak into the shoulder of my maroon t-shirt.

“Katie, I’m here for you,” I told her. And as I said the words out loud, squeezing my arms around my twin sister, I realized just how much more I loved hugging her and keeping her safe than arguing with her.

5:00 PM — The Pretend Date & PB&J Sanctuary

When her crying finally began to subside, the two of us sat down side by side on the edge of her green-and-gold patterned bedspread, our shoulders pressed together and our hands still linked.

“Thank you,” Katie said quietly, wiping her eyes with the back of her wrist. “Thank you for being there for me. Someday, I know I’m going to repay this.”

She went quiet for a beat, looking down at our joined hands, before she suddenly whispered:

“Take me to the Dinner Dance this week.”

The seventh-grade Dinner Dance was tomorrow night in the school cafeteria, and half the reason Katie had been crying so hard was the thought of either staying home alone in embarrassment or walking into that room by herself while Donnie was there.

“Of course we can go together,” I said immediately, knowing I didn’t have a date of my own—and wouldn’t have wanted to go with anyone else even if I did. “Even though you’re my sister, we will go on a pretend date.”

“Oh, thank you. Thank you,” Katie breathed, the last of the heavy sobs finally leaving her chest as she leaned her head against my shoulder.

“Would you like it if I made you dinner tonight?” I asked, deciding right then and there to start playing my part as her protective pretend boyfriend.

“Let’s just have something simple, like sandwiches,” she said softly.

“Alright,” I replied, giving her hand a gentle squeeze as the two of us stood up and headed downstairs together.

In the quiet kitchen, I made us both thick peanut-butter-and-jelly sandwiches and poured two tall glasses of cold milk to soothe her sore throat. After we finished eating at the table, Katie looked across at me.

“Could we watch a movie together?” she asked.

“Sure,” I replied warmly. “Let’s pick something together.”

We walked back upstairs to my deep-blue bedroom, picked out our VHS tape of *House Guard 2: Lost in Manhattan* from the shelf beneath my television stand, and pushed it into the VCR. As the opening Majestic Studios credits began to roll across the CRT screen, Katie kicked off her shoes and climbed into my single bed right at my side, resting her head on my shoulder and pulling the blanket across our legs.

Near the end of the movie, when the closing music faded in, I glanced down and saw that my sister was fast asleep against my arm, her breathing slow and completely peaceful after an afternoon of crying her eyes out.

I reached carefully for the remote, clicked the television off, and decided right then to let her sleep. I decided that I would tell her that I didn’t mind after we woke up in the morning. Katie was exhausted, and the last thing I wanted was to see her become a grouch because she was woken back up without enough sleep. Part of me

marveled at how natural it felt sharing my narrow bed with my twin sister again—just like we had during the Blizzard of ’96 and on the downstairs sofa bed at Christmas. We had chosen this close brother-and-sister bond together, and enjoying the warm, quiet company of the person who mattered most to me in the world, I slid down onto the pillow beside her and let myself drift off to sleep at her side.

The Pretend Boyfriend & Twins’ Day

Twin Brothers Always Stay: Spirit Week & The Living Room Sofa

Date: 1997-10-17 at 07:30 America/New_York

7:30 AM — “Twin Brothers Always Stay”

The next morning, when the pale autumn sunlight filtered through the blinds of my bedroom, I woke up first—and sure enough, Katie was still fast asleep right at my side in the small bed.

“Katie,” I whispered softly, gently prodding her shoulder so I wouldn’t startle her in case she didn’t realize right away that she had fallen asleep in my room the night before.

My sister stirred against the pillow, blinking her blue eyes open in the quiet blue room before looking from the wall to me in mild surprise.

“Morning, sleepyhead,” I whispered with a small smile.

“I slept in your bed?” she asked groggily, rubbing her eyes.

“Yep, and I did not mind,” I replied, looking her straight in the eye. “Let’s play a game together.”

For the first time since Donnie had broken her heart yesterday afternoon, Katie’s face lit up with genuine excitement. While she sat up against the headboard, I slipped out of bed, walked across the carpet to the television stand, and powered on my *Nova 64* video game console. I was still in full protective-brother mode, determined to keep cheering her up until I heard her laugh again.

Before I picked up the controller, I turned back to face her.

“I’m your brother. I will always be here for you. Promise,” I told her, my voice steady and earnest in the quiet room. I paused for half a beat, then added the truth I knew we would live by for the rest of our lives: “Boyfriends come and go, but Twin Brothers always stay. Always.”

Before the console title screen had even finished loading on the CRT television, I found myself wrapped in Katie’s arms again. She stood up from the edge of the mattress and hugged me with everything she had, making it unmistakably clear that she had no intention of letting go of me. She held onto my shoulders while the video game rolled through its opening demo sequence on the screen behind us, then sat down on the carpet right at my side.

“We should probably get dressed,” Katie said after a moment, glancing down at her wrinkled shirt from yesterday. “Guess I will pop into my room real quick. Leave the game on this screen while we get dressed?”

“Sure,” I replied, gently ushering her to the bedroom door. “I’ll open my door when I’m dressed.”

8:00 AM — Spirit Week: Twins’ Day

Five minutes later, after I had pulled on a clean maroon short-sleeve t-shirt, medium-wash blue jeans, and my tan sneakers, I opened my bedroom door. Katie walked right back in from across the hall—and the second I saw what she had picked out of her closet, I had to grin.

Without planning it, she had put on the exact same shade of maroon short-sleeve t-shirt and medium-wash blue jeans with a dark belt.

“Next week is Spirit Week at school,” I said as she stepped into the room. “Want to have a little fun on Twins’ Day, since, well, we *are* twins?”

Katie giggled as I handed her the second black controller from the floor stand. “Yeah, we are twins! Wonder how many others will really be twins compared to how many will do it just for fun.”

We both laughed out loud at that remark, and right there in front of my computer desk and television stand, we stubbornly made up our minds.

“I think it’s settled, then,” I declared. “We will dress exactly the same, and we will enter the contest.”

We laughed again, already looking forward to seeing how the teachers and our classmates would react to actual fraternal twins walking into the Spirit Week Twins’ Day assembly dressed identically and holding hands.

“Too bad we don’t have matching shoes,” Katie remarked, looking down at her grey-and-red sneakers next to my tan ones.

“Ah, well. Still, let’s do what we can. I think these pants and shirts look close enough,” I said, setting the controllers on the desk and pulling her into another tight, standing hug in the middle of the room. Both of us laughed into each other’s shoulders, our matching maroon sleeves wrapped around each other’s backs. Yesterday’s tears were completely gone.

5:30 PM — Macaroni & Cheese on the Living Room Sofa

Later that evening, after spending the afternoon practicing our co-op levels and getting ready for the weekend, Katie and I walked downstairs and decided to sit together on the tan-brown living room sofa, curling up side by side while we waited for dinner to be made.

As usual in our house, Dad was in the kitchen working over the stove after a full day at his job, while upstairs Mom was already passed out drunk in bed behind her closed door.

“Mac and cheese is what I smell,” I whispered as Katie slid flush against my right side on the sofa cushions, draped her left arm warmly around my shoulders, and rested her right hand across my forearm to hold me close to her.

“Our favorite,” she replied softly, resting her cheek near my shoulder as the two of us sat there, happily snuggled up together beneath the blue-framed underwater painting on the living room wall.

We had a few quiet minutes to ourselves before the timer on the stove went off, and neither of us wanted to get off the sofa. After years of feeling like we had to keep our guard up against loud classrooms and the unpredictable storms upstairs, snuggling together on the couch felt like the safest, most comfortable place on earth.

As we sat there in the warm glow of the living room lamp, Katie whispered, “Snuggling up is just so comfortable.”

“It is,” I replied quietly, leaning into the warmth of her arm around my shoulders. Neither of us moved an inch; we were both completely content holding onto each other and letting the rest of the house fade away.

A few minutes later, Dad stepped to the doorway of the dining room with a pot holder in his hand, looking over at the two of us curled up together on the couch before calling us in to eat.

When we sat down side by side at the dining table over our steaming bowls of macaroni and cheese, Dad looked across the table at the two of us, his tired eyes softening with genuine gratitude.

“I really appreciate that you both don’t fight and argue with each other,” Dad said quietly, his voice heavy with emotion. “Honestly, I wish your mother didn’t drink her life away. I want to do my best to not only be your father, but also be a proper dad to both of you. Your mother’s drinking is not your fault, and I don’t want either of you to think that. Please don’t let your grades suffer because of it.”

Underneath the edge of the dining table, Katie reached her hand over and laced her fingers tightly through mine, and I squeezed right back. Whatever happened upstairs, and whatever happened in the hallways at school, my twin sister and I had our sanctuary—and we were never letting go.

Sixteen & Summer Sanctuary

Bonding With My Sister

Summer Sanctuary: Hearthstone Pizza, The Sunlit Valley, & Katie's Room

Date: 2001-06-18 at 08:30 America/New_York

8:30 AM — First Full Day of Summer

"Summer is here," I said, blinking open my eyes as the warm June sunlight filtered through the blinds of Katie's bedroom.

"Our first full day with the house to ourselves," my sister replied softly as we started waking up.

Having both turned sixteen back on April eighth, the two of us were curled up side by side in our pajamas on top of her green-and-gold patterned bedspread beneath the framed blue morpho butterfly artwork hanging on her magenta-purple wall, completely used to being pretend dates and full-time anchors for each other. With both of our parents already gone for their morning shifts and two quiet weeks stretching ahead of us before Summer School started, the entire house was finally calm.

Katie rubbed her eyes, then looked over at me and asked, "Get dressed and have breakfast?"

"Sure, I am getting hungry," I replied, giving her hand a quick squeeze as I climbed out of bed.

I stepped across the upstairs hallway into my own deep-blue painted bedroom to pull on a clean maroon crew-neck t-shirt and jeans while Katie changed in her room, and two minutes later we met right back at her doorway, exchanging a warm, familiar smile before making our way down the stairs together.

"Let's just have some cereal, then we will figure out what we want to do for the day," I said as we reached the bottom landing. "I want to spend the day with just you."

Our stomachs were calling us, as was our daily routine of taking our morning dose of medication before the day got underway. In the quiet kitchen, I pulled two ceramic bowls out from the cupboard and set our morning medication tablets beside two glasses of water while we picked out our cereal from the pantry—being twins, of course it was the exact same box—and sat down at the kitchen table, pulling our chairs right up against each other so we were as close as possible.

After we took our morning medication and started on our cereal, my twin sister reached across the table, took my hand, and looked straight into my eyes.

"What would you like to do today?" Katie asked.

“I was thinking of snuggling on the sofa over a movie,” I suggested as we continued eating our breakfast side by side.

“I know just the movie I want to watch,” my sister said, squeezing my hand. She gave me that unmistakable look like she had a big secret and started giggling. She wanted me to ask what movie it was, but after sixteen years as her twin brother, I knew she wouldn’t tell me—I would have to wait and see what it was when she popped the tape into the VCR.

Since I had made breakfast, Katie took it upon herself to carry our bowls and spoons over to the counter and load our dishes into the dishwasher.

“I will get the tape, then will join you on the sofa,” Katie called over her shoulder as I headed toward the living room.

“Alright, Katie,” I replied, settling onto the cushions of our tan-brown living room sofa beside the coffee table, where Dad had neatly stacked the slightly outdated *Quantum Basic 5.0* programming textbooks—complete with clear plastic mylar covers and barcode stickers on the spines—that he had checked out from the Virginia Beach Public Library to get a head start on his upcoming fall *Quantum Basic 6.0* class at the Community College of Hampton Roads—CCHR. Over the past few weeks, Katie had started reading Dad’s library books cover to cover and teaching the programming exercises to me, and when Dad found out, he had beamed with pride and actively encouraged both of us to keep coding.

Even better, when Summer School started in two weeks, Katie and I weren’t going because we were behind. We had intentionally signed up to knock out an academic credit over the summer so that when our main high-school year started in September, our schedules would line up with a free period and lunch block together every single day. Until those summer classes began, I was looking forward to having unbroken time with my twin sister.

9:30 AM — *Hearthstone Pizza & Journey to the Sunlit Valley*

A minute later, Katie walked into the living room holding a familiar white clamshell VHS tape behind her back, slid the cassette into the VCR beneath the television, and walked over to sit on the sofa right next to me.

Immediately, she lifted her arm and made it clear she wanted me to snuggle up in her arms. I slid flush against her side and rested my head against her shoulder, glad that I got to curl up with Katie now that the two of us had become so close.

Across the room, the CRT television flickered to life. My eyes lit up as the sweeping orchestral welcome theme to one of our favorite companies—*Majestic Studios*—played across the screen, and then my eyes lit up even further as the previews transitioned and I recognized the exact childhood VHS movie that my sister had put on for us: *Journey to the Sunlit Valley*.

“I knew you would like it,” Katie whispered, resting her cheek against my hair as she looked down into my eyes.

“Of course,” I whispered back with a grin as the tape rolled through its iconic opening bumper before the feature presentation—the familiar, upbeat birthday party commercial from *Hearthstone Pizza* where the older brother was supposed to be nice to the little girl.

We happily stayed curled up together on the cushions as Sprout and his friends began their journey across the screen, wanting nothing more than to sit there quietly in each other’s arms watching the movie. Both of our parents were away at work, the house was completely peaceful, and we had decided that all we wanted was each other—just brother-and-sister time together in our sanctuary before Summer School was set to begin.

9:00 PM — Katie’s Room Beneath the Blue Butterfly

By the time evening rolled around and the June twilight faded outside the living room windows, we had spent the entire day side by side without a single argument, a single raised voice, or a single interruption from the outside world.

As we walked up the stairs together after dinner and paused on the second-floor landing between my blue-painted bedroom and her magenta-purple bedroom, Katie turned to me and took my hand.

“Share a bed?” Katie asked softly.

“Sure,” I replied without hesitation. “Your room or mine?”

“How about my room tonight,” Katie suggested with a gentle smile.

After I stepped into my blue room to brush my teeth and change into a comfortable t-shirt and flannel pajama pants, I crossed the hall and knocked lightly on Katie’s door. Inside her room, under the warm amber glow of the bedside lamp and the framed blue morpho butterfly on her wall, we climbed onto her bed together, propped our pillows against the headboard, and pulled the green-and-gold covers across our legs. Katie draped her arm around my shoulders and laced her fingers through mine, and as the house settled into quiet around us, we drifted off to sleep side by side.

End of Summer Cruise

Part 1: The I-95 Haul, The Quantum Basic Library Book, & Ditching Captain Barnaby

Date: 2001-08-19 at 09:30 America/New_York

Saturday, August 18, 2001 — The Twelve-Hour Grumble Down I-95

"If *Command1_Click* calls the subroutine before the text box validates, the whole form throws a type-mismatch error," Katie murmured beside me in the back seat of our Holt sedan, tapping her finger against page 142 of the thick paperback resting across our knees as another green Florida mileage sign flashed past the window on Interstate 95 South.

"That's only in *Quantum Basic 5.0*," our dad, David Prairie, called back from the driver's seat, his eyes flicking warmly to the rearview mirror despite the fatigue of ten straight hours behind the wheel. "Wait until we test it on the *Quantum Basic 6.0* compiler at the CCHR lab next month. Though I'll be honest with you two—I'd a whole lot rather be sitting at our kitchen table in Virginia Beach testing that code right now than driving to Port Canaveral."

"So would we, Dad," I grumbled, shifting my stiff legs on the bench seat while Katie laced her left hand through my right.

None of the three of us—not Dad, not Katie, and not me—had wanted to go on this seven-day Caribbean cruise at the end of August. Back in July, Katie and I had worked hard through our high-school summer school class, knocking out a required academic credit early so that when eleventh grade started in September, our main school-year schedules would free up for a shared lunch block together every single day. All the three of us had wanted for the final two weeks of summer was to stay home in peace so Dad could study for his upcoming fall semester at the Community College of Hampton Roads—CCHR.

To get a head start before classes began, Dad had gone to the Virginia Beach Public Library and checked out the newest programming manual they had left on the shelf—a slightly outdated, dog-eared copy of *Learn Quantum Basic 5.0 in 21 Days* wrapped in a clear plastic mylar library jacket with a barcode sticker on the spine. Within forty-eight hours of Dad setting that book on the dining table, Katie had started reading it cover to cover and teaching the event loops and form layouts to me on my bedroom computer. When Dad caught us working through his library book together, he hadn't been upset at all; he had beamed with pride and started actively encouraging both of us to follow our dreams.

Up in the front passenger seat, however, our mother, Brenda, hadn't cared about Dad's CCHR classes, our summer school credit, or the fact that twelve hours crammed into a sedan was making Katie's and my legs ache from hip to ankle. Mom had insisted on booking this seven-day Eastern Caribbean cruise—and when we finally rolled over the causeway into Port Canaveral on Saturday afternoon, the visual irony hit Katie and me right through the windshield.

Docked at the premier terminal across the blue channel stood a gleaming, navy-and-gold *Majestic Cruise Line* ship, its twin funnels shining in the Florida sun.

We didn't turn into the *Majestic* terminal. Instead, Mom directed Dad toward Pier 3, where a boxy, bargain-rate mass-market ship called the *M/S Sunward Tropics* was loading passengers.

By four o'clock that afternoon, standing packed shoulder-to-shoulder in bulky orange foam lifejackets out on the humid teak planks of the Deck 4 Boat Promenade for the mandatory twenty-minute safety muster drill—with all of the ship's elevators shut off—I felt the first warning tremor shoot down both of my calves. Beside me,

Katie was leaning almost her entire weight against my right arm just to keep her knees locked. Both of us had lived with mild cerebral palsy since birth, which had always made our balance uneven, but standing on that hot deck before climbing two flights of metal stairs back to our cramped inside cabin left our legs shaking and our arms strangely weak on the brass banisters in a way neither of us had ever felt before.

Dad walked right behind us up every step of the stairwell, one hand braced behind Katie's back and the other steadying my elbow, his brow furrowed with quiet concern as he watched how hard our arms were straining just to pull ourselves up the railing.

Sunday, August 19, 2001, 9:30 AM — Ditching *Captain Barnaby* for the Deck 8 CyberCafé

"Look at the two of you—you're going to be late for the character breakfast!" Mom snapped at nine-twenty on Sunday morning, shoving two neon-yellow *"Camp Sunward Youth"* lanyards and a printed activity sheet into Dad's hand before disappearing out the cabin door toward the Lido Pool Bar. "And I put Katie's name down for the two o'clock beginner ballet and ballroom workshop in the Starlight Lounge!"

Katie stared at the pink dance slip in horror, her fingers tightening around my wrist as the ship rolled gently on its first full day at sea heading toward Nassau.

"Come on," Dad said quietly, his jaw tight as he picked up his canvas backpack—with the Virginia Beach Public Library *Quantum Basic 5.0* book tucked inside—and led Katie and me down the narrow corridor to the elevator. "Let's go see what your mother signed you up for."

Five minutes later, the three of us stood outside the double glass doors of the Starlight Lounge on Deck 6.

Inside, thirty screaming six- and seven-year-olds were banging plastic spoons against paper placemats while accordion music blared from the speakers. Waddling between the tables were two sweaty crew members zipped into bargain-bin polyester foam mascot suits—*Captain Barnaby the Buccaneer Parrot* and *Salty the Starfish*—whose faded fabric looked like it had been pulled out of a carnival dumpster.

At the podium by the door, a twenty-two-year-old youth counselor glanced down at her clipboard—where Mom had written *Prairie, Nathaniel* and *Prairie, Katie*—and then looked up at two sixteen-year-old high schoolers standing side by side in t-shirts and jeans. Her face turned bright red with second-hand embarrassment.

Dad took one look through the glass doors at the foam parrot, looked at Katie's and my mortified faces, and didn't hesitate for half a second.

"Take those yellow lanyards off, kids," Dad said calmly.

Stepping up to the podium, Dad handed the lanyards back to the relieved counselor, drew a clean line through both of our names on the character breakfast roster, and asked her to cross Katie's name off the afternoon ballet workshop sheet as well.

“Where are the computers and the arcade cabinets on this ship?” Dad asked the counselor.

“Deck 8 Midship, sir—right next to the quiet library and card room,” she replied gratefully.

Ten minutes later, sitting side by side in two padded armchairs inside the air-conditioned quiet of the Deck 8 CyberCafé overlooking the deep blue Atlantic, Katie and I finally exhaled. Dad swiped his cabin card to buy two hours of desktop terminal time, pulled the thick, mylar-wrapped *Quantum Basic 5.0* library textbook out of his bag, and set it open on the desk right between our keyboards.

While Mom spent the entire Sunday at sea up at the pool bar, the three of us spent the afternoon right there by the ocean windows—Katie pointing out how to nest *For…Next* loops on the screen, my fingers typing the syntax into the editor, and Dad sitting right beside us smiling with genuine pride.

Part 2: The Nassau Pier, Guest Services, & The Last Straw

Date: 2001-08-22 at 14:00 America/Puerto_Rico

Monday–Wednesday, August 20–22, 2001 — The Nassau Pier & The Honest Question

“Hold onto my arm, Nate—don’t look down at the concrete,” Katie breathed against my shoulder as the ninety-two-degree Bahamas sun beat straight down onto the endless gray concrete expanse of Prince George Wharf in Nassau on Monday morning.

Ahead of us, Mom was already a hundred yards down the pier, marching briskly toward the duty-free liquor stores and open-air bars along Bay Street without once looking back to see where her children were. Halfway between the ship’s gangway and the terminal gate, my right knee buckled without warning. When Katie tried to catch my weight with both hands, her own wrists gave out, and both of us nearly went down onto the hot concrete before Dad caught us under the arms and guided us onto a shaded wooden bench beside the port tram stop.

“Neither of you is walking another step in this heat,” Dad said firmly, kneeling down to check our trembling ankles before flagging down the port courtesy shuttle and hiring an air-conditioned island van driver to take just the three of us over the bridge to the step-free underwater glass aquarium tunnel on Paradise Island.

Over the next forty-eight hours—as the ship steamed south from the Bahamas toward Charlotte Amalie in St. Thomas and Philipsburg in St. Maarten—the gap between what Mom wanted and what our bodies could handle grew wider by the hour. Every time the ship rolled in the Caribbean swell, walking the long metal passageways felt like wading through wet cement, while Mom spent every afternoon running up the cabin bar tab and complaining whenever she passed us that Katie wasn’t attending the ship’s dance classes.

On Wednesday afternoon, Dad collected Katie and me outside the Deck 8 arcade, led us to a quiet, shaded alcove of deck chairs, and looked straight at the two of us.

“Please be honest,” Dad asked quietly. “Are you two not enjoying the cruise?”

When Katie and I looked at each other and struggled to come up with an answer, Dad leaned forward and rested his hands on his knees.

“I want to let you both in on how I feel,” Dad said earnestly. “Katie, this especially goes for you. I watched you teach your brother the *Quantum Basic* programming that I am learning in school at CCHR, and I am absolutely encouraging both of you to keep at it if you both like it. I see that your mother is trying to talk you into being a ballerina, but I get that you don’t want to.”

“I don’t have the balance to dance,” Katie said honestly, looking down at her sneakers. Mom still refused to accept that we had cerebral palsy—let alone whatever was making our arms and legs grow weaker this summer—insisting she saw two completely healthy kids. “I like this coding thing.”

“And I am encouraging you with this coding thing… I am encouraging both of you,” Dad said warmly.

“I didn’t appreciate that Mom tried booking us on the kid stuff,” I added, thinking back to the foam parrot mascot at Sunday morning’s breakfast door. “Katie and I are sixteen and already in high school, and I don’t want to meet the characters. It’s not even the characters that little kids want to meet, because it’s not *Majestic Cruise Line*! I want to play the computer games.”

“I get it,” Dad said, nodding firmly. He took a deep breath, his expression turning solemn. “There is something else I wanted to confide in both of you, and that is Mom’s drinking issue. Our next stop will be the front counter where I want to attempt to cut off the flow of alcohol to your mother.”

2:45 PM — Cutting Off the Flow at the Front Counter

The process at the Purser’s Desk in the Deck 5 Atrium Lobby seemed to drag on forever, and Katie and I found a padded seat across the lobby while we waited for Dad to be finished.

Because every bar on the ship operated on cashless plastic stateroom keycards—and because Dad’s *Anchor Federal Credit Union* card was the sole payment method guaranteeing our cabin’s Master Folio—Dad had the authority as the primary account holder to revoke all charging privileges on Mom’s keycard and have the Watch Purser place a mandatory alcohol cut-off flag on her passenger ID across the ship’s point-of-sale network.

When Dad finally walked back over to our bench, he held out three plastic cabin keycards, each newly stamped with a small holographic fountain-cup sticker.

“I bought the three of us a soda package, and we can get sodas and juice every fifteen minutes,” Dad told us. “Your mother is going to be mad, but I don’t care. I am so sorry to both of you that it is turning out like this, but I have to protect both of you.”

Sitting down beside us for a moment, Dad lowered his voice to a quiet whisper.

“I know that you two have decided that you are inseparable, and I am okay with that, and I won’t tell the world about your little secret,” Dad whispered, looking at Katie and me with steady, unconditional protective warmth. “Yes, I know, and I think I’ve known for a while. Just don’t go blabbing to everyone, and be careful with things.”

3:30 PM — The Corridor Breakdown & The Ultimatum

The three of us rode the elevator down to Deck 4 and walked to our stateroom—and to our horror, though not to our surprise, when Dad opened the door, our mother was passed out drunk across the three-cushion convertible sofa that was supposed to unfold into the bed that Katie and I shared at night.

“Oh, I’ve had enough of your mother’s nonsense,” Dad said, pulling the door shut and turning Katie and me right around in the passageway.

We walked a long way through a narrow, windowless maze of identical stateroom hallways—our legs trembling and our feet stumbling against the carpet seams with every roll of the ship—until we finally reached a quiet stairwell seating alcove and sat down on the built-in bench.

Right there under the brass wall sconces, Dad buried his face in his hands and absolutely lost it, breaking down and crying.

Katie and I were completely at a loss for words. Our mental image of Daddy being tough and unbreakable came crashing down all at once, and for the first time in our sixteen years, we were seeing the exhausted, hurting human side of our father.

Katie and I sat close against his sides on the bench and just waited, holding hands because this was something neither of us knew how to respond to.

“I guess it will have to be a cruise for three,” Katie whispered softly to me.

“Yeah, I guess,” I whispered back to my sister. We both looked over at our father, who was the most upset we had ever seen him in our lives. I didn’t even remember crying this hard when taking a bad fall on the pavement, and yet here the three of us were.

“I’ll try my best to handle this. Daddy needs us right now,” Katie whispered, resting her hand on Dad’s arm. “This is going to be a long and painful cruise.”

That was when we heard a screaming rage echoing down the metal hallway toward our alcove.

“The heck was that?” I asked, my heart jumping as a startled Katie looked up beside me.

“Where is my fucking beer?!”

Our mother had woken up from her drunken nap on our sofa, stormed up to the nearest deck bar, discovered that her keycard had been cut off at the register, and tracked us down the corridor—drunkenly screeching profanities at our visibly upset father.

Spotting Katie and me sitting on the alcove bench directly beneath the black dome of the stairwell's ceiling security camera, Mom's bloodshot eyes locked onto us.

"And you two ungrateful brats!" she slurred loudly, staggering forward toward our bench. "I signed you up for the character meet-and-greet and the dance class, and you ditched them and got your father to cut off my card!"

As she lunged toward our bench and swung her arm wildly in my direction, her balance gave out and she missed completely as Dad surged to his feet and stepped squarely between her and the bench, blocking her path in full view of the ceiling security camera.

"Don't you ever raise a hand toward them!" Dad said, his voice turning to iron as he wiped the last trace of tears from his eyes. "I've had enough, and so have the kids. This cruise was supposed to be family time, and the three of us are tired of your drinking. Nathaniel, Katie, and I are giving you a choice right now: us, or the alcohol."

Mom glared at us and slurred something bitter that none of us could even understand.

"Message received," Dad said flatly. "You pick the bottle over your husband and children."

Turning his back on her, Dad looked down at Katie and me and reached out both hands to help us stand up as our mother drunkenly stumbled away down the hall.

"Come on, you two," Dad said gently. "I want you to show me what you two would like to do."

As he supported our elbows and led Katie and me away down the passage, Dad made a vow that neither of us would ever forget.

"I'm making both of you a promise: I want to be a dad, and I want you both to help guide me through this," Dad said quietly. "It will be painful, but your mother does not seem to want to be a mom. I'm sorry, but I have to do right by both of you."

Holding onto Dad's arms as our exhausted legs shook beneath us, the three of us stumbled through what felt like an endless hallway of cabins until we finally stumbled out into the bright light of the lobby.

Part 3: Stateroom 6004, The Loaner Wheelchairs, & Pizza for Three on the Aft Deck

Date: 2001-08-23 at 18:30 America/Puerto_Rico

Wednesday, August 22, 2001, 4:15 PM — Domestic Separation, The Brig, & Two Manual Wheelchairs

"My kids can barely stand up after walking down that Deck 4 corridor, and my wife is screaming profanities at us in the passageway," Dad told the Chief Purser flatly as the three of us reached the front counter in the Atrium Lobby, my knees trembling so

badly that I had both hands braced against the marble counter edge while Katie leaned against my side. “I am not putting my son and daughter back in Stateroom 4118 with her tonight. I don’t want her in the cabin with us anymore.”

The Chief Purser glanced down at the black security radio clipped to his lapel, took one look at Dad’s raw, red-rimmed eyes and one look at Katie and me struggling to stay upright on our feet, and immediately picked up a brass master key.

“Deck 4 Security just radioed up after reviewing the stairwell alcove security camera feed, Mr. Prairie,” the Chief Purser said quietly. “Our camera recorded your wife’s outburst in the corridor and her attempt to swing at your son on the bench before you stepped in. We hold two wheelchair-accessible contingency staterooms right off the Deck 6 midship elevators for medical and family safety emergencies. I am placing a confidential Domestic Separation Flag on your manifest right now and moving you, Nathaniel, and Katie into Stateroom 6004. Only your three soda-package keycards will open that door, and our staff is strictly prohibited from disclosing your new cabin number to your wife.”

Dad let out a long breath of pure relief, then glanced down at Katie’s shaking ankles and mine.

“Is there any chance the ship has two manual wheelchairs my twins can use for the rest of the cruise?” Dad asked, looking back at Katie and me to make sure we agreed.

Both Katie and I nodded immediately. Neither of us cared what strangers on a cruise ship thought—we were exhausted from fighting our own legs every time we crossed a deck.

“Consider it done, sir,” the Chief Purser replied. “I’ll have the Medical Center bring two folding *SwiftChair* manual wheelchairs straight up to Stateroom 6004 while our stewards transfer your bags and your library books from Deck 4.”

By five o’clock that afternoon, Dad, Katie, and I were safely upstairs inside Stateroom 6004—a wide, quiet room five steps from the elevator lobby with a clean double sofa bed that unfolded without a single obstacle and two folding manual wheelchairs waiting by the door.

At seven-fifteen that evening, while Katie and I were sitting together on the sofa bed reading Dad’s *Quantum Basic 5.0* library book, a polite knock sounded on our cabin door. When Dad opened it, the Chief Purser stood in the corridor with a clipboard under his arm.

“I wanted to check on you and the twins in person, Mr. Prairie, and let you know that you won’t have to worry about running into your wife on the decks for the rest of the voyage,” the Chief Purser told Dad evenly, his voice carrying clearly to where Katie and I sat. “About an hour ago, Mrs. Prairie returned to Stateroom 4118, found your luggage gone, and came down to the Atrium Lobby after her keycard was declined at the Lido Bar. When we refused to disclose your new cabin number or unblock her alcohol privileges, she tried to climb over the Purser’s counter and swung a fist at one of our Security officers. The Staff Captain has placed her in the ship’s brig down on Deck 2.”

Katie’s hand tightened around mine on the sofa cushion as we listened.

“Because we have already cleared our final Caribbean port of call and are steaming north,” the Chief Purser continued, handing Dad a thick, sealed manila envelope, “she will remain in security custody until we dock at Port Canaveral on Saturday morning, where she will be escorted off the vessel and handed a permanent lifetime ban from *Sunward Cruise Lines*. Inside this envelope is a certified copy of our Shipboard Security Incident Report along with a duplicate VHS tape from the Deck 4 stairwell security camera documenting the 3:30 PM corridor incident, in case your family attorney in Virginia needs official documentation. I also want to assure you, Nathaniel, and Katie that your names are completely clear—none of the three of you are excluded from sailing with us in the future.”

Dad thanked him quietly and closed the door. Mom had managed to get herself banned from a cruise line yet again—not that Dad, Katie, or I ever wanted to set foot on a cruise ship again in the first place.

Thursday, August 23, 2001, 6:30 PM — Pizza & Soda Refills on the Aft Deck

“Two pepperoni slices, two extra-cheese slices, and three fifteen-minute fountain refills—two colas and an orange juice,” Dad announced with a genuine smile on Thursday evening as he set a steaming stainless-steel pizza platter and three tall plastic tumblers down on our round table out on the open wooden aft deck.

Sitting side by side in our two ship-provided folding manual wheelchairs right at the back rail of Deck 9, watching the white foaming wake of the ship stretch out across the turquoise Caribbean Sea under a golden-orange sunset, Katie and I reached across the space between our wheelchair armrests and laced our fingers together.

Inside the main dining rooms tonight was Captain’s Formal Night, where hundreds of passengers were crammed into noisy banquet halls in stiff suits and high heels. Out here on the breezy fantail deck, wearing comfortable t-shirts and jeans with zero pain in our calves or knees thanks to the manual wheelchairs, the last two days of the voyage had finally become what Katie had whispered in the corridor alcove: a peaceful cruise for three.

“How do the chairs feel?” Dad asked softly, pulling his deck chair right up beside our wheels and picking up a slice of pizza.

“So much better, Dad,” Katie said, leaning her head briefly against my shoulder as she took a sip from her straw. “My legs aren’t shaking at all.”

“Mine either,” I agreed, looking down at our three soda-sticker keycards resting together on the table next to Dad’s library copy of *Quantum Basic 5.0*. For the first time all week, nobody was yelling, nobody was trying to force Katie to dance or shove us into a room with foam parrot mascots, and as the warm ocean breeze blew past the stern rail, the three of us talked for two straight hours about the programs we were going to write when we got home to Virginia Beach.

Part 4: Back on Dry Land & The Twelve-Hour Drive Up I-95

Date: 2001-08-25 at 08:30 America/New_York

Saturday, August 25, 2001, 8:30 AM — Back on Dry Land

"Nathaniel. Katie. I'm sorry that your first cruise was wrecked, and somehow I want to make it up to both of you," Dad said earnestly as two crew members helped us transfer out of the ship's loaner wheelchairs onto the gray cloth back bench seat of our Holt sedan at the Port Canaveral pickup curb. Resting a steady hand on each of our shoulders through the open door, Dad continued, "Here is what we will do: neither one of you wanted to go on that cruise, but your mother insisted. I want to finish school at CCHR so that I can do a better job at being a dad without having to worry about money as much."

Before Katie or I could answer him, an angry screech tore across the concrete baggage drop from behind us.

"You! You told the ship to stop my drinks!"

Looking through the open rear doorway, I saw our mother being escorted out of the customs terminal doors by two *Sunward Cruise Lines* security officers after being released from the ship's brig, clutching a folded white sheet of permanent lifetime ban paperwork in her fist. Her face was flushed dark red in the morning Florida heat as she stormed up to the rear fender of our car.

Every muscle in Dad's jaw tightened as he straightened up beside our open door and looked at her.

"If we were anywhere near Hampton Roads right now, Brenda, I would hand you twenty dollars for a bus fare and leave you standing on this curb," Dad told her, his voice as cold and flat as steel. "The only reason I am unlocking this front door is because we are seven hundred miles from Virginia. Get in the front passenger seat, and don't say a single word to the kids for the next twelve hours. The second this car pulls into our driveway in Virginia Beach, you are packing your bags and getting out of our house."

Without waiting for her to reply, Dad closed our rear door securely, walked around to the driver's side, and pulled out of Port Canaveral toward Interstate 95 North.

12:15 PM — Exit 94 Near Savannah, Georgia: The Gas Pump, The Restrooms, & Brenda's First Angle

For the first three and a half hours heading north out of Florida across the Georgia state line, the inside of the car was dead silent except for the hum of the tires and the air conditioner. In the back seat, Katie and I sat pressed shoulder-to-shoulder with our inner hands laced together and Dad's mylar-wrapped *Quantum Basic 5.0* library textbook resting across our knees.

Just past noon, the low-fuel chime dinged on the dashboard, and Dad signaled right at Exit 94 near Savannah, pulling under the canopy of a highway travel plaza so we could get gas and use the restrooms.

That stop was when the physical reality of leaving the ship hit Katie and me all over again.

On Thursday and Friday aboard the *Sunward Tropics*, we had rolled everywhere in the Medical Center's two folding loaner wheelchairs. Those wheelchairs belonged to the ship, which meant they were still back at Port Canaveral. When Dad opened our rear door beside Pump 6 and I swung my sneakers out onto the ninety-degree Georgia concrete, my knees and calves trembled so violently that I had to grab the roof frame with both hands just to keep from sliding onto the pavement. Beside me, when Katie tried to push herself up off the bench cushion, the strength in her right forearm gave out halfway up, and she gasped softly as she sank back against the seat.

Up front, Mom didn't even glance back at our door. She slammed the front passenger door shut and marched briskly across the concrete apron toward the air-conditioned travel store restrooms on her own.

Dad saw us struggling immediately. Leaving the gas nozzle clicking in the tank, he stepped right between Katie and me, braced his left arm firmly around Katie's waist and his right hand under my elbow, and took half of our weight onto his own shoulders.

"Take your time, kids—I've got both of you," Dad murmured close to our ears as he walked us slowly, step by shuffling step, across the hot pavement and up the curb ramp to the restroom hallway. He stood waiting right between the men's and women's doors until both of us came back out, then supported us all the way back to the back seat of the Holt before topping off the tank and paying at the window.

When Mom finally strolled back out of the convenience store carrying a bottle of water and buckled herself into the front passenger seat, her furious scowl from Port Canaveral was suddenly replaced by self-pity. As Dad checked in the rearview mirror to make sure Katie and I were buckled securely into our back-seat shoulder belts, shifted into drive, and merged back onto I-95 North, Mom launched into a bitter, non-stop tirade about how "unfairly" she had been treated down in the ship's brig.

"David, honey, look—let's be reasonable now that we're off that awful boat," Mom complained, turning slightly toward him in the front seat. "Do you have any idea how terrible life in a cruise ship brig actually is, or what I just went through for sixty-two straight hours? It was completely unfair! That purser had it out for me from the moment we boarded, and those security guards treated me like a common criminal over a couple of drinks!"

In the back seat, Katie and I glanced at each other and squeezed hands as Mom kept going, oblivious to the way Dad's jaw was clenching harder with every word out of her mouth.

"They put wrist restraints on me and marched me down a steel freight elevator to the Deck 2 crew corridor below the waterline, right on top of the diesel engine room!" Mom ranted, her voice rising with indignation. "They confiscated my cabin card, my wristwatch, my belt, and even my shoes! For two and a half days I was locked inside a windowless steel box that vibrated twenty-four hours a day from the ship's engines. No porthole, no clock, no television, no pillow—just a hard vinyl mat bolted to the steel floor with a stiff Velcro blanket, an institutional stainless-steel toilet welded to the sink in the corner, and a blinding fluorescent ceiling light with a security camera staring at me that never turned off once!"

Beside me, Katie leaned her head close to my shoulder. Both of us could see the muscles in Dad's neck and shoulders stiffening against the driver's backrest. Mom thought she was winning sympathy, when in reality every single complaint she made was hardening Dad's resolve like poured concrete.

"And the food!" Mom went on, gesturing with her water bottle. "While the three of you were upstairs doing whatever you wanted, they wouldn't even let me have a soda! Every four hours the ship's doctor or some nurse slid open the metal slot in the door to take my blood pressure and hand me paper cones of lukewarm tap water and salt packets while my head was splitting open! Three times a day a guard shoved a paper plate of bland crew-galley mush through the slot with a bendable plastic spoon, and every fifteen minutes day and night a guard slid the peephole open to write on a clipboard! Then yesterday afternoon they had the nerve to tell me that stewards had packed my clothes out of Cabin 4118 with red security tape and handed me a lifetime ban! I've been punished enough, David—there's no reason to talk crazy about me packing bags when we get home."

Katie looked at me and gave a tiny, unmistakable shake of her head. *Every argument she makes,* Katie's eyes said to mine, *just weakens her case even more.*

I thought the exact same thing. For sixty-two hours down on Deck 2, Mom hadn't spent a single minute worrying about her sixteen-year-old twins or her husband—she had only cared about her confiscated watch, her crew-galley trays, and her cut-off beer tab.

From the back bench seat, I watched Dad's knuckles turn white against the top of the steering wheel. In the rearview mirror, his eyes met mine and Katie's for a brief, steady second before he answered without even looking at Mom.

"You swung a fist at a ship security officer because they wouldn't serve you beer at four o'clock in the afternoon, Brenda," Dad said in a low, gravelly voice that carried clearly to the back seat. "That headache you had down on Deck 2 was sixty-two hours of forced sobriety. And while you were passed out drunk on the kids' sofa bed before security locked you up, I had to hold our sixteen-year-old son and daughter up by their elbows because their legs and arms were giving out on them. Just ten minutes ago at that gas pump, neither one of them could stand up out of the back seat without leaning on me, and you walked right past them to the store without looking back once. That brig wasn't unfair. It was the consequence of who you've chosen to be."

4:45 PM — Rocky Mount, North Carolina: Drive-Thru Dinner & Cementing the Lawyer Decision

By quarter to five that afternoon, as the green highway signs ticked past Fayetteville and into Rocky Mount, North Carolina, the three of us were starving and needed another restroom stop.

After Dad helped Katie and me carefully in and out of the roadside rest-area bathrooms just off the exit—where my wrists shook so badly I could barely push the heavy metal restroom door open by myself—Dad didn't make us walk inside a crowded highway sit-down restaurant and try to carry plastic food trays on trembling arms. Instead, he pulled the Holt sedan straight into the drive-thru lane of

a *Penny's* hamburger restaurant next to the interstate ramp, ordered four cheeseburger meals, and handed a warm white paper bag of cheeseburgers and fries back to Katie and me before merging back onto the highway.

Buckled safely into our three-point shoulder seatbelts side by side on the gray cloth rear bench seat as the pine trees and green *I-95 NORTH* signs rolled past our rear window, Katie held the white paper *Penny's* bag on her lap while Dad's mylar-wrapped *Quantum Basic 5.0* library textbook rested open across mine, with our inner hands clasped tightly together on the cushion between us.

Up in the front passenger seat, as Mom finished her sandwich, I heard her abandon the brig complaints and try a second angle—cold financial bargaining.

"Think about this logically for two seconds, David," Mom said, her voice sharp and calculating in the quiet car. "You're taking classes at CCHR. How exactly do you think you're going to pay the house note in Virginia Beach, buy groceries, finish your degree, and take care of two sixteen-year-olds all by yourself without my income? Look—I'll cut back to drinking only on Friday and Saturday nights. We can put this behind us and go back to normal on Monday."

Beside me in the back seat, Katie squeezed my left hand with her right. Neither of us was even afraid that Dad would give in anymore—watching the back of Dad's shoulders, both of us could tell that Mom was digging her own grave deeper with every sentence.

"She doesn't get it at all," Katie whispered so softly that only I could hear her over the hum of the highway tires.

"Not even a little," I whispered back, looking down at our joined hands between my open *Quantum Basic* book and her lunch bag. Since the day we were born, Katie and I had been each other's anchor, best friend, and safe harbor—and in the lifelong bond the two of us shared, there was simply no room left for someone as bitter, selfish, and mean as our mother. All we needed was each other and our dad.

Up front, I watched Dad slowly set his cup into the center console holder, glance briefly toward the passenger seat, and speak in a calm, ironclad voice I had never heard from him in my life.

"Thank you for saying that out loud, Brenda—because if I had one percent of doubt left about seeking a lawyer's advice when we get home, every argument you've made since Florida just erased it," Dad told her evenly. "You spent three hours complaining about a steel bunk in the brig, and now you're bargaining to drink on weekends—and you still haven't asked Nathaniel or Katie a single time in eight hours why their legs and arms are failing them. I don't care if I have to work double shifts around my CCHR classes to pay the bills. First thing Monday morning at eight-thirty, I am calling a divorce lawyer to file for divorce and full custody of the twins, and my very next call is going to be to Dr. Carter's office to get both of them examined. We are never going back to 'normal.'"

Mom opened her mouth, saw the look on Dad's face, and snapped her jaw shut without another word for the rest of North Carolina and Virginia.

9:15 PM — Home in Virginia Beach: Packing the Bags

At nine-fifteen that night, after more than twelve hours on the road, the headlights of our Holt sedan finally swept across our driveway in Virginia Beach.

Before touching a single suitcase in the trunk, Dad walked around to our rear door, helped Katie and me out of the back seat, and supported both of us up the front steps and straight inside to the living room sofa, propping two throw pillows behind our backs and setting his *Quantum Basic 5.0* library book on the coffee table within easy reach.

Then, true to his word from Port Canaveral, Dad walked back out into the front foyer, folded his arms across his chest, and stood watch at the bottom of the stairs for forty-five straight minutes while Brenda packed her suitcases, dragged them out the front door to her car, and backed out of the driveway.

When Dad clicked the front deadbolt shut and walked into the living room to check on us, our house was finally, mercifully peaceful.

Part 5: Monday Morning in Virginia Beach — The Divorce Lawyer, The PCP, & Borrowed Time

Date: 2001-08-27 at 10:15 America/New_York

Monday, August 27, 2001, 10:15 AM — The Divorce Lawyer, The PCP, & Borrowed Time

“Squeeze my fingers as hard as you can, Nathaniel, and hold it for five seconds,” Dr. Evelyn Carter instructed gently inside Exam Room 2 of her Virginia Beach family practice clinic on Monday morning.

Sitting side by side on the crinkly white paper of the padded exam table in our t-shirts and jeans, Katie and I kept our inner hands laced tightly together between our knees while I reached my left hand out to squeeze Dr. Carter’s fingers.

Earlier that morning at eight-thirty, while Katie and I sat at the kitchen table eating cereal with the sealed *Sunward Cruise Lines* manila envelope resting beside the napkin holder, we had listened as Dad stood by the kitchen wall phone and kept the first half of his highway vow—calling a family law and divorce attorney’s office off Independence Boulevard.

When Dad told the attorney on the line that he had a certified Shipboard Security Incident Report and a duplicate VHS security camera tape from Deck 4 showing Brenda’s corridor outburst and her attempt to swing at me on the bench over the character meet-and-greet, we watched a wave of relief wash across Dad’s face. Hanging up the receiver, Dad had turned to Katie and me and explained what the lawyer had just told him: under Virginia law, the one-year separation waiting period only applied to no-fault divorces. Because the ship’s security camera had caught her attempt to strike a minor child and her subsequent detention in the brig, Dad qualified to file immediately on fault grounds of cruelty and reasonable apprehension of bodily hurt—allowing the lawyer to petition the Virginia Beach court right away for sole custody of the two of us, exclusive possession of our house, and a protective order without waiting a single year.

The moment he finished writing down our afternoon appointment time with the lawyer, Dad dialed Dr. Carter, our Primary Care Physician, and explained how badly our arms and legs had been giving out on the cruise and at the Interstate 95 rest stops. Dr. Carter's nurse had told him to bring both of us straight in at ten o'clock.

For the first two seconds, my grip held around Dr. Carter's fingers—and then, no matter how hard I concentrated, the strength in my forearm and wrist drained away like water through a sieve. When Dr. Carter tested Katie's grip, her shoulder resistance, and the dorsiflexion in both of our ankles, the exact same drop-off happened.

Dr. Carter stepped back, slipped her reflex hammer into the pocket of her white coat, and looked gravely at Dad, who was standing protectively right beside us.

"David," Dr. Carter said quietly, "bringing them in immediately after you got back from Florida was the exact right call."

"They've had mild cerebral palsy since they were little," Dad said, his hand resting warmly on Katie's shoulder. "Brenda always ignored it and acted like they were two completely typical kids, so at first I assumed the ship's movement was just aggravating their balance. Why are both their arms and their legs getting worse at sixteen?"

"Because cerebral palsy does not degenerate over time," Dr. Carter answered clearly, looking from Dad to Katie and me with deep compassion. "Cerebral palsy is a static, non-progressive condition. When sixteen-year-old twins begin losing measurable motor strength in both their lower extremities and their upper extremities over the course of a single summer, something else is happening."

Beside me on the exam table, Katie squeezed my fingers with every ounce of strength left in her hand, and I squeezed right back.

"I'm ordering a full neuromuscular blood panel, nerve conduction studies, and a genetic workup this morning," Dr. Carter continued gently, picking up her chart clipboard. "Until those test results come back and tell us exactly what condition we are dealing with, I need all three of you to prepare yourselves for the reality of what I'm seeing in their muscle tone today. When it comes to walking, Nathaniel and Katie are on borrowed time. Eventually, neither of them is going to be able to walk, and because their upper arms and wrists are fatiguing too, they are eventually going to need power wheelchairs."

The quiet exam room seemed to hold its breath around those words—*on borrowed time*.

"How soon will the test results be back, Evelyn?" Dad asked quietly, his hand resting steady and warm on Katie's shoulder.

"The genetic and nerve-conduction panel takes about two and a half weeks," Dr. Carter answered, writing an appointment card at her desk and handing it to Dad. "Let's schedule their next checkup for Friday afternoon, September fourteenth, at three o'clock—right after their two o'clock dismissal at Northwood High School. You can pick them up when the final bell rings at two, bring them straight here for their three o'clock appointment, and we'll check how their arms and legs are holding up and go over every test result together."

Yet as I looked sideways at my twin sister, and felt Dad's steady, unwavering arm wrap around both of our shoulders at once, the fear didn't break us. Whatever the test results showed when we came back for our three o'clock checkup after school on September fourteenth, Mom's screaming was gone, Daddy was standing right beside us, and Katie and I were going to face every single mile of it together.

Junior Year at Northwood High & The Prognosis

Part 1: The Fault-Grounds Filing, The Protective Order, & Junior Year at Northwood High School

Date: 2001-09-04 at 11:40 America/New_York

Monday, August 27, 2001, 2:00 PM — The Lawyer's Office off Independence Boulevard

"Timestamp fifteen-thirty-two and eighteen seconds," family law attorney Arthur Vance read aloud in his quiet, wood-paneled conference room off Independence Boulevard, pressing the pause button on his office VCR remote so the grainy black-and-white frame from the *M/S Sunward Tropics* Deck 4 stairwell camera froze on the television screen.

Sitting side by side on the leather sofa across from Mr. Vance's desk with our inner hands clasped tightly together, Katie and I looked at the frozen image on the screen. Right there beneath the ceiling camera's timestamp—*AUG 22 2001 15:32:18 CAM-04B*—was our mother lunging toward our alcove bench with her arm raised, and Dad standing like a shield squarely between her and the two of us.

"Mr. Prairie, in twenty-four years of practicing family law in Virginia Beach, I have rarely seen a cleaner, more airtight evidentiary packet," Mr. Vance said, setting the remote down beside the Staff Captain's notarized *Shipboard Security Incident Report* and permanent lifetime exclusion notice. "Normally in Virginia, when minor children are involved, a couple has to live separate and apart for one full year before filing for a no-fault divorce. You do not have to wait a single day."

Across from us, Dad leaned forward in his chair, his hands folded on the edge of the mahogany table.

"How fast can we get the court orders in place so Brenda can't come back to the house or show up at their high school when classes start next week?" Dad asked.

"This afternoon," Mr. Vance answered firmly. "Because the ship's security camera captured her attempting to strike sixteen-year-old Nathaniel while intoxicated—and because the ship's brig and medical logs corroborate every word—we are filing a fault-based Complaint for Divorce on grounds of cruelty and reasonable apprehension of bodily hurt under Virginia Code Section 20-91(A)(6) before the Circuit Court clerk's office closes at four o'clock. Alongside it, I am walking an emergency *pendente lite* petition and family protective order straight in to the duty judge."

Mr. Vance counted the points off on his fingers so Katie and I could follow every step.

“First, you get immediate temporary sole legal and physical custody of Nathaniel and Katie,” Mr. Vance said. “Second, you get exclusive use and possession of the marital home in Virginia Beach—meaning you are legally authorized to change every lock on the doors tonight, and Brenda cannot set foot on the property. Third, the protective order bars her from coming within five hundred feet of the twins or setting foot on the campus of Northwood High School. And fourth, because fault grounds of cruelty bar an offending spouse from receiving alimony under Virginia law, she won’t get a dime of spousal support.”

Beside me on the leather sofa, Katie tightened her fingers around my hand and looked across the mahogany desk at the attorney.

“Mr. Vance,” Katie said quietly, her voice trembling for just a heartbeat before steadying with the quiet resolve we had both shared in the back seat of Dad’s car on the drive over, “after what she did to us on that ship—dragging us onto a cruise we never wanted to go on, screaming at us in the passageway, and trying to force two sixteen-year-olds to go to a costumed children’s character meet-and-greet like toddlers—Nathaniel and I talked about it together. Neither of us wants her carrying the last name Prairie anymore. Is there a way in the divorce decree to make her go back to her maiden name?”

Dad turned in his chair and looked at Katie and me with deep, protective respect before facing the lawyer.

“You heard them, Arthur,” Dad said firmly. “After what she put my son and daughter through, they don’t want her carrying our family name—and I want their wishes respected in the final decree.”

Mr. Vance nodded thoughtfully, tapping his gold pen against his legal pad as a shrewd veteran litigator’s smile crossed his face.

“Under Code of Virginia Section 20-121.4, the court restores a party’s maiden name as part of the final divorce decree upon her signed request or stipulation,” Mr. Vance explained, looking directly at Katie and me so we knew he was taking our request seriously. “A judge can’t force a name change in a vacuum—but under Section 20-109.1, we can make reverting to her maiden name a binding condition of the financial property settlement. Remember, she secretly ran up more than six thousand dollars on the marital credit card to book that cruise behind your father’s back, and under equitable distribution, I can petition the court to saddle her with half of that cruise debt plus your attorney’s fees. When her lawyer calls me to beg for a walk-away release from the cruise debt and a small relocation check so she can get an apartment of her own, I will tell them your father’s non-negotiable condition: she only gets the debt release and the settlement check if she signs the Section 20-121.4 stipulation in the divorce decree restoring her maiden name, Walsh, and surrendering the name Prairie on her driver’s license and Social Security card. Knowing her pride—and her wallet—she’ll sign it before the ink is dry.”

Beside me on the leather sofa, Katie let out a long, quiet breath and leaned her shoulder against mine. That evening before dinner, Dad bought three brass deadbolt kits at the hardware store, changed every lock on our front, back, and garage doors, and handed the shiny new keys to Katie and me.

Tuesday, September 4, 2001, 11:40 AM — Junior Year at Northwood High School

“We actually pulled it off, Nate—fourth-block lunch and study hall together every single day,” Katie said with a relieved smile the Tuesday after Labor Day as the two of us eased down side by side onto the bench of a quiet, sunlit corner table near the tall windows of the Northwood High School cafeteria.

Back in July, when we had given up half of our mornings to sit through high-school summer school and knock out a required academic credit early, this exact forty-five-minute sanctuary in the middle of our Junior year schedule was what we had worked for. Earlier that morning at seven-forty-five, Dad had walked into the Northwood High main office with us to hand-deliver a certified copy of the Virginia Beach judge’s custody and protective orders to the principal’s secretary, removing Brenda’s name from our emergency contact cards for good.

Yet as grateful as Katie and I were to be sitting together with our brown paper lunch bags, juice boxes, and our spiral *Quantum Basic* notebook open on the tabletop between us, getting through the first three class periods of eleventh grade had been a sobering wake-up call for our bodies.

Even without the roll of a cruise ship beneath our feet, the long linoleum hallways and concrete stairwells of Northwood High School had pushed our legs and arms to the brink before noon. Halfway up the B-Wing stairs to second-period Chemistry, my left calf had cramped and given out so suddenly that I would have gone down on the steps if Katie hadn’t grabbed my belt loop—and when she tried to pull my weight upright against the handrail, her own right wrist and forearm had trembled so violently that she dropped her binder across the landing. By the time we reached the cafeteria doors at eleven-forty, my thighs felt like lead weights and Katie’s fingers were shaking so hard that I had to help her pinch open the top of her straw wrapper.

Reaching across the table between our lunch bags, I laced my right fingers through Katie’s left hand and rested our joined hands flat on the cool laminate tabletop so neither of our wrists had to work to hold them up.

“How bad are your legs shaking right now?” I asked her quietly beneath the chatter of the cafeteria.

“From my knees down to my ankles,” Katie admitted softly, her thumb brushing against the back of my hand as she glanced down at the event-loop diagram in my notebook. “And my right shoulder still hurts from carrying my backpack down the upstairs hall. Our next scheduled checkup with Dr. Carter is next Friday afternoon after school, right?”

“Friday at three o’clock,” I nodded, squeezing her hand gently. “Dad’s picking us up right at the two o’clock dismissal bell so Dr. Carter can see how our arms and legs are doing. Whatever happens, we’ve got Dad on our side now, and we’ve got this lunch table every day. We’ll get through eleventh grade together.”

Part 2: When Borrowed Time Runs Out — The Collapse at School, The Emergency Room Escalation, & Time for Powerchairs

Date: 2001-09-14 at 13:15 America/New_York

Friday, September 14, 2001, 1:15 PM — When Our Legs Finally Gave Out at School

“Just forty-five more minutes until the two o’clock dismissal bell, Katie, and Dad’ll be waiting for us right out front in the pickup loop,” I whispered at a quarter past one on Friday afternoon as the two of us walked slowly down the quiet first-floor B-Wing hallway of Northwood High School on our way back from the guidance office.

All week long, all I knew was that Friday afternoon at three o’clock was our next scheduled checkup with Dr. Evelyn Carter. Dad had arranged his Friday schedule at the Community College of Hampton Roads so he could pick Katie and me up right when school let out at two o’clock and drive us straight over to Dr. Carter’s office for our three o’clock appointment to see how our arms and legs were doing and go over whatever test results had come back from the lab.

All we had to do was make it thirty more feet down the waxed linoleum corridor to our sixth-block classroom door.

We were holding hands between us for balance, walking close to the lockers so we could brush our free fingertips against the metal doors if our ankles wobbled, when the sensation below my knees suddenly vanished.

It wasn’t a slow cramp like on the stairwell the week before, and it wasn’t just our calves getting tired. Halfway past Room 112, it felt as though someone had reached inside our spines and pulled the electrical plug on both of our lower bodies at the exact same second.

My right knee buckled inward without an ounce of resistance. Beside me, Katie let out a sharp gasp as both of her ankles folded underneath her at the exact same instant, and before either one of us could catch the locker handles, the two of us collapsed straight down onto the hard linoleum floor.

“Nathaniel! Katie!” Mr. Henderson, our eleventh-grade U.S. History teacher, called out in alarm from his open classroom doorway ten feet ahead of us, dropping his dry-erase marker onto his podium and hurrying out into the hallway. “Are you two all right?!”

My heart was hammering against my ribs from the shock of going down so fast, and my instinct—the stubborn sixteen-year-old instinct that had kept both of us forcing our legs down hallways all week—was to get right back up before the rest of the class saw us on the floor.

“We’re okay, Mr. Henderson—just let us stand back up,” I gasped, planting my left palm flat on the cold floor while Katie braced her hands against the tiles beside me.

Straining with every muscle left in our shoulders, wrists, and thighs, Katie and I tried to push ourselves back up onto our feet.

We didn’t even make it halfway to our knees.

The moment we put weight on our legs and trembling forearms, both of our legs and arms crumpled completely out from under us a second time—sending both of us pitching forward and sideways with nothing left to break our fall.

Crack. Thud.

The right side of my forehead slammed hard against the unforgiving linoleum-over-concrete floor, sending a bright, stinging flash across my vision, and six inches away I heard the sickening thud of the left side of Katie's head striking the tiles right beside the locker base.

Before the ringing in my ears even settled, my very first instinct—and Katie's—was the exact same one we had had since the day we were born. Lying flat on the cold linoleum floor with a hot, throbbing knot rising on my forehead, I reached my right hand blindly across the six inches of tile between us, and Katie's left hand met mine in midair, our fingers locking together in a vise grip so neither of us was alone on that floor.

"Stay down! Do not try to get up again!" Mr. Henderson shouted, his voice dropping an octave in urgent alarm as he saw both of our heads strike the floor and our hands clasp together between us.

He sprinted three steps to the classroom wall intercom just inside his doorway and pressed the red emergency call button. "Main Office, get Nurse Callahan to the first-floor B-Wing hallway outside Room 112 immediately! I need a Clinic Emergency escalation right now—Nathaniel and Katie Prairie both collapsed in the hallway, their legs gave out a second time when they tried to get up, and both of them hit their heads on the floor!"

Friday, September 14, 2001, 1:18 PM — Manual C-Spine Stabilization & The Emergency Room Escalation

Within forty-five seconds, Nurse Callahan, the school's registered nurse, arrived at a dead run with her orange trauma bag, followed closely by Assistant Principal Brooks and the clinic aide.

One look at the two of us lying flat on the hard tile floor holding hands with red, swelling contusions rising on our foreheads—and Mr. Henderson's report that our arms had given out on the second collapse so nothing had cushioned our heads—was all Nurse Callahan needed to escalate the protocol straight to the Emergency Room.

"Nobody lift them and nobody let them sit up!" Nurse Callahan ordered immediately, dropping to her knees behind my head while her trained clinic aide knelt behind Katie's head. Gently but firmly, Nurse Callahan placed both of her palms along the sides of my head to hold my neck in manual inline cervical stabilization, while her aide stabilized Katie's head the exact same way so neither of us could turn or nod our necks.

"Mr. Brooks," Nurse Callahan commanded, "we have an unbroken dual head strike against concrete-backed tile plus acute bilateral lower-extremity paralysis. Under school division head-and-spine protocol, they cannot be lifted into clinic wheelchairs and they cannot go home in a passenger car until an Emergency Room CT scan clears their heads and cervical spines. Call 911 right now for Virginia Beach EMS transport to Bayside General Hospital Emergency Room, put B-Wing on a temporary Hold in Place so the hallway stays clear when the bell rings, and call their father to meet the ambulance at the ER!"

“Calling 911 and Mr. Prairie right now,” Assistant Principal Brooks said, unclipping his radio and telephone handset as Mr. Henderson closed the classroom doors along the corridor.

Down on the floor, even with Nurse Callahan’s hands cradling the sides of my head so I couldn’t turn my neck, I kept my right hand laced tightly through Katie’s left hand on the tiles between us.

“Nathaniel, Katie—keep looking straight up at the ceiling tiles so your necks stay completely still, and keep holding each other’s hands,” Nurse Callahan said calmly as she checked my pupils and then Katie’s with her penlight. “Can both of you hear me and tell me your full names?”

“Nathaniel Prairie,” I answered clearly, squeezing Katie’s fingers twice so she knew I was okay.

“Katie Prairie,” Katie answered right after me, squeezing my hand back just as tightly.

“Did either of you black out when your heads hit the floor? Do you know where you are, what day it is, and what happened right before you fell?” Nurse Callahan asked.

“No, ma’am, neither of us blacked out,” I said, my voice steady despite the throbbing ache over my right eyebrow. “It’s Friday, September fourteenth, and we’re in the B-Wing hallway at Northwood High School. Our dad was supposed to pick us up at the two o’clock dismissal bell to take us to our three o’clock appointment with Dr. Evelyn Carter to see how our arms and legs were doing—and while we were walking down the hall, our legs just gave out all at once.”

“And when we tried to push ourselves back up,” Katie added clearly from beside me, “our legs and arms crumpled again and we hit our heads.”

“Can either of you wiggle your toes or push your feet forward against Mr. Henderson’s palms?” Nurse Callahan asked.

I concentrated with everything I had, ordering my ankles and calves to move. Nothing happened. Neither of my feet moved a fraction of an inch, and neither did Katie’s.

“All right, don’t strain,” Nurse Callahan told us gently as the distant wail of sirens approached down the boulevard outside. “Your dad is already on his way to the Bayside General Emergency Room to meet you, and I had the front office call Dr. Evelyn Carter’s clinic too—she has hospital privileges at Bayside General and she’s bringing your test results straight over to the Emergency Room to meet your dad there.”

Four minutes later, four Virginia Beach EMS paramedics wheeled two ambulance stretchers through the B-Wing double doors, where Nurse Callahan handed the lead paramedic two printed clinic sheets from her clipboard.

“Both patients are sixteen-year-old fraternal twins on the autism spectrum, Glasgow Coma Scale fifteen, with an unbroken dual head strike and acute bilateral lower-extremity motor loss,” Nurse Callahan briefed the lead paramedic right beside us so I could hear every word. “Look at their hands right now—they ground themselves and prevent sensory panic by holding hands and hugging. Obviously they can’t sit

up or hug while they're in C-collars on backboards, but please keep their stretchers close enough together in the rig and at triage that they don't have to let go of each other's hands, and brief the ER Charge Nurse before you roll in."

"Copy that, Nurse—we'll keep them side by side in Squad 14 and call it in to Bayside General Triage on the radio," the lead paramedic nodded.

Working with practiced precision so our spines never bent or twisted, the paramedics fitted soft foam cervical collars around our necks, unclipped two-piece aluminum scoop stretchers that slid underneath our backs and hips from both sides on the floor, and lifted Katie and me smoothly onto the two padded gurneys—locking the two stretchers side by side in the back of the dual-patient squad rig so my right hand and Katie's left hand stayed clasped between the rails the entire ride to the hospital.

Friday, September 14, 2001, 2:10 PM — Hospital Rules, The CT Doorway, & Dr. Carter's Verdict in the ER

Because the Community College of Hampton Roads campus was only ten minutes from Bayside General Hospital, Dad actually beat our ambulance to the Emergency Room entrance by two minutes.

When the rear doors of Squad 14 swung open at the ER bay, Dad was already standing right beside the ER Charge Nurse, having briefed her himself that we were sixteen-year-old twins on the autism spectrum who grounded ourselves through physical contact—and that Dr. Evelyn Carter had already called down from her clinic across the medical plaza to let the ER team know she was bringing our neuromuscular lab packet over in person.

Even with Nurse Callahan's handoff and Dad's briefing, however, there were still real hospital rules for sixteen-year-old minors that the Emergency Room couldn't bend.

First, because Katie and I were opposite-sex sixteen-year-old minors, hospital policy required the triage team to wheel us into two separate adjacent trauma bays—Bay 3 and Bay 4—divided by a heavy fabric privacy curtain while the ER nurses checked our spines and stuck cardiac monitor leads under our shirts. While we lay flat in our rigid foam cervical collars unable to sit up or hug, the Charge Nurse compromised by leaving a six-inch gap at the bottom of the curtain between our two bays so I could reach my right hand under the curtain hem and hold onto Katie's left hand while the monitors beeped overhead.

Second—and hardest of all—was the hospital's radiation safety rule at the CT scanner.

"Mr. Prairie, I know they ground themselves by holding hands, but federal radiation rules only allow one patient inside the CT scanner room at a time," the radiology tech explained gently when the orderlies arrived at two-twenty to wheel us down the hall for our head and cervical spine scans. "We'll scan Katie first while Nathaniel's gurney waits right outside the lead glass door with you, and then we'll swap them. They'll only be apart for five minutes each."

Letting go of Katie's fingers outside the heavy lead-lined doors of the CT suite while my own neck was strapped flat in a foam collar was the longest five minutes of my life. As the sliding door closed behind Katie's gurney, my heart rate monitor began to beep faster—until Dad stepped right up beside my stretcher, took my right hand in both of his warm palms, and stood where he could see through the control-room glass.

"I'm looking right at her through the window, Nate—she's lying totally still inside the scanner ring and giving us a thumbs-up with her left hand," Dad narrated calmly, squeezing my fingers until my breathing steadied. "Ninety more seconds and she's coming right back out, and then I'll watch you through the glass while Katie waits right here."

True to his word, ten minutes later both of our CT scans were finished. By three-ten that afternoon, when the radiologist called down to confirm that neither Katie nor I had a skull fracture, concussion, or cervical spine injury, the ER trauma doctor unstrapped our foam cervical collars, the Charge Nurse pulled the dividing curtain between Bay 3 and Bay 4 all the way open, and the orderlies pushed our two hospital beds right up against each other with the inner side rails lowered.

The instant the beds locked together and the doctor raised the heads of our mattresses to forty-five degrees, Katie and I didn't just hold hands—we leaned across the narrow seam between the two hospital mattresses and wrapped both of our arms tightly around each other's shoulders in the long, deep grounding hug we had needed ever since we hit the hallway floor at school.

Seconds later, walking into the combined ER bay alongside the emergency physician was Dr. Evelyn Carter, wearing her white coat and carrying the thick manila lab folder from her clinic across the medical plaza.

"First things first—the head and cervical spine CT scans for both Nathaniel and Katie are completely clean," Dr. Carter announced with a warm, relieved smile as Katie and I eased back against our pillows with our inner hands locked together between our beds and fresh ice packs resting against the matching goose eggs on our foreheads. "Nurse Callahan followed the exact right protocol calling EMS after a dual head strike on a concrete school floor, and thank goodness neither of you suffered a fracture or intracranial bleed."

Then Dr. Carter stepped to the foot of our two ER beds and tested the reflexes and motor response in our knees, calves, and ankles.

Just like on the hallway floor outside Room 112 at Northwood High School, when she tapped our patellar tendons and asked us to lift our shins against her fingers, our lower legs didn't budge.

Dr. Carter pulled a rolling stool up beside our two beds, opened the thick manila lab folder containing the genetic sequencing and nerve-conduction studies that had arrived from Norfolk that morning, and looked at Dad, Katie, and me with deep, solemn compassion.

“David, Nathaniel, Katie,” Dr. Carter said quietly, “two and a half weeks ago, when you came to see me the Monday morning after your cruise, I told you that Nathaniel and Katie’s legs were walking on borrowed time—and that they would eventually need power wheelchairs. We had scheduled your three o’clock checkup today to review these test results and talk about transitioning to powerchairs.”

She looked straight into my eyes, and then into Katie’s.

“What happened in the B-Wing hallway at Northwood High School at one-fifteen this afternoon wasn’t a temporary spell, and it wasn’t just end-of-the-week fatigue,” Dr. Carter said gently. “Your borrowed time is up. Neither of your legs can support your body weight anymore, and from this afternoon forward, neither of you can ever try to stand or walk again—because trying to push yourselves up will only cause another collapse like the one that sent you to the Emergency Room today. It is officially time for powerchairs.”

Even though Katie and I had known in our hearts from the second we reached for each other’s hands on that linoleum floor that our walking days were over, hearing Dr. Carter say the words out loud made everything real. Beside me, Katie’s fingers tightened around mine between our two hospital beds, and I squeezed her hand right back with everything I had.

“Tell us what the test results showed, Evelyn,” Dad said steadily, standing right between our beds with one hand resting on my shoulder and the other on Katie’s. “Why did their legs give out completely today, and what does it mean for their arms?”

“When you two were toddlers,” Dr. Carter explained clearly, “your uneven balance was diagnosed as mild spastic diplegic cerebral palsy. Because mild CP is static and non-progressive—and because your mother always brushed off any new symptoms—nobody realized that your early balance issues were masking a second, genetic condition that both of you inherited as fraternal twins: a juvenile-onset progressive axonal motor neuropathy.”

Dr. Carter pointed to the nerve-conduction graphs inside the folder.

“In this condition, the longest motor nerves in the body—the ones running from the lower spine down to the feet, ankles, calves, and quadriceps—lose their electrical signal amplitude first, and the sixteen-year-old adolescent growth spurt pushes those nerves past their threshold,” Dr. Carter said. “Today at school, those lower-extremity motor nerves finally dropped below the threshold required to keep your knees locked upright. And as you both felt when you tried to push yourselves up off the hallway floor and crumpled the second time, the neuropathy is also causing progressive weakness in your shoulders, biceps, and forearms—which is why standard manual wheelchairs that you have to push with your hands are out of the question.”

“What about our fingers, Dr. Carter?” Katie asked, her voice small but brave as she held onto my hand. “Are we still going to be able to type on our computers and write *Quantum Basic* code?”

Dr. Carter’s face warmed with an immediate, reassuring smile.

“Yes, Katie—and that is the best news in your entire lab packet,” Dr. Carter answered. “As long as we stop you from straining your shoulders and wrists trying to lift your body weight or push manual wheelchair rims, your fine finger dexterity at a keyboard will remain intact for years to come. You will both be able to type, write computer code, use a mouse, and hold hands—and with a fingertip joystick on your power wheelchair armrests, you’ll be able to glide through Northwood High School all day without tiring your arms at all.”

Dr. Carter pulled three prescription and accommodation forms from her folder and signed them right on the bedside tray table.

“First,” Dr. Carter said, “I have signed an urgent hospital prescription for two SwiftChair compact, portable take-apart power wheelchairs—small-footprint motorized chairs with ten-inch drive wheels, right-hand armrest joysticks, and removable battery boxes and seats that you can break down to fit inside the trunk of your sedan, David, along with a smooth composite transfer sliding board so Nathaniel and Katie can slide horizontally from their wheelchair seats onto the back seat of the car or onto their beds without ever putting weight on their legs. Second, Hospital Physical Therapy is bringing up two loaner wheelchairs and a transfer board right now so Dad can take you home safely tonight until the custom powerchairs are delivered in two weeks. And third, here is your updated Section 504 Plan for Northwood High School: elevator keys, duplicate classroom textbooks so you never lift a heavy bag, and full-time wheelchair access starting Monday morning.”

Dad picked up the signed forms, then leaned down between our two hospital beds and wrapped one arm around Katie and one arm around me, kissing the top of Katie’s head and then mine just above our bruised foreheads.

“I was never so scared in my life as when Mr. Brooks called me and said you two were headed to the Emergency Room,” Dad whispered, his voice thick with emotion as he held us both close. “Wait until you see how fast I learn to break those two powerchairs down for the trunk of the car. Your legs may have run out of borrowed time today, but as long as the three of us have each other, nothing is going to stop you.”

Part 3: Two Compact Power Wheelchairs in the Trunk, Downsizing to Military Highway, & CVTA Route 15

Date: 2001-10-06 at 13:10 America/New_York

Saturday, October 6, 2001, 1:10 PM — Two Compact Power Wheelchairs in the Trunk & Our New House off Military Highway

“Unclip the two under-seat battery boxes first, pull the quick-release pins to lift both padded seats off their posts, fold the backrests and footrests flat, and set the two compact motorized drive bases side by side in the trunk with two inches to spare under the hinges,” Dad said with a proud grin on the first Saturday of October, wiping his brow as he demonstrated how both of our brand-new SwiftChair compact portable power wheelchairs broke down to fit inside the open trunk of our silver-blue Holt sedan.

Sitting side by side on the back bench seat of our Holt sedan with the rear passenger doors swung wide open to the concrete driveway of our new rental house and our inner hands clasped together, Katie and I watched Dad practice the disassembly routine he had timed with his wristwatch all morning.

Four days earlier, the seating clinic had delivered the two compact, take-apart power wheelchairs Dr. Carter had prescribed for us after our legs gave out for good in the hallway at Northwood High School—nimble, small-footprint power bases with ten-inch solid drive wheels, under-seat battery packs, and feather-light right-hand armrest joysticks that let us glide down the long corridors of school with a gentle nudge of one finger without ever straining our wrists or shoulders on manual hand rims. Because Dr. Carter had documented our progressive axonal motor neuropathy down to the millimeter, Dad's health insurance had covered ninety percent of the chairs.

What health insurance didn't cover, however, was a vehicle to carry them assembled.

A full-size conversion van equipped with a hydraulic wheelchair lift or fold-out side ramp cost upwards of thirty-five thousand dollars—an astronomical sum that might as well have been thirty-five million on Dad's tight budget. Between trying to finish his computer science degree at the Community College of Hampton Roads, losing Brenda's paycheck—meager as her income had been—and getting stuck with the crushing credit card debt from the seven-day Caribbean cruise that Brenda had booked behind his back, Dad was scraping by to make every dollar count.

Thankfully, because the seating clinic had ordered portable take-apart power chairs whose battery packs, seats, and drive bases separated into manageable thirty-five-pound components—and had supplied us with a smooth composite transfer sliding board that bridged the gap between the wheelchair seat and the back seat of our family Holt sedan—we could still get around by car without a lift van. Whenever we drove somewhere, Katie and I would roll our compact power chairs right up to the open rear passenger door, switch off our joysticks, flip up the inner armrest, and slide horizontally across the transfer board onto the back bench seat with Dad's steadying hands before buckling our three-point seatbelts while Dad broke both chairs down like a pit crew and loaded the bases, battery boxes, and folded seats into the trunk.

Even so, Dad had been completely honest with Katie and me around the kitchen table two weeks earlier when he opened his budget ledger.

Without a second income—and with the cruise credit card bill and legal fees hanging over our heads—we couldn't afford the mortgage on our old two-story house anymore. More importantly, even if we could have paid for it, our old house had fourteen steep wooden stairs leading up to the bedrooms and the only full bathroom—stairs that neither Katie nor I could ever climb again now that the borrowed time in our legs had run out.

So Dad had put the two-story house up for sale—using the modest equity to wipe out Brenda's cruise debt completely and fund the small walk-away settlement check that Mr. Vance had conditioned on Brenda signing the Code of Virginia Section 20-121.4 divorce stipulation reverting to her maiden name, Walsh, so that just as Katie and I had asked, she no longer carried the Prairie name—and spent every

evening for two weeks poring over rental listings, Virginia Beach school-zone boundary maps, and printed bus schedules from the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority.

What Dad found was a stroke of pure logistical genius: a small, single-story brick ranch house for rent on a quiet side street just off Military Highway near the Indian River Road intersection, right where Virginia Beach met Norfolk and Chesapeake.

First, the rent was nearly four hundred dollars a month less than our old mortgage, bringing our monthly bills comfortably inside Dad's budget while he finished school at CCHR. Second, every single room in the little house—the living room, the eat-in kitchen, the hallway bathroom with its roll-up sink and shower transfer bench, and both bedrooms—sat on one flat ground floor, with a gentle aluminum ramp Dad had bolted over the two brick front porch steps. Third, because the house sat just inside the western edge of Northwood High School's zoned attendance boundary, Katie and I didn't have to change high schools in the middle of our Junior year, and a lift-equipped Virginia Beach school bus could pick us up right at the end of our driveway every weekday morning.

And fourth—the detail Dad was proudest of as he reassembled our two compact power wheelchairs beside the open rear doors of the car, locked the seats onto their posts, and dropped the battery boxes back into place—was what ran right along the massive eight-lane corridor of US-13 (Military Highway) at the end of our block.

"Slide back into your chairs and let's head out to the corner on Military Highway before the one-twenty-five bus gets here," Dad said, closing the trunk lid of the Holt sedan, helping Katie and me slide across the transfer board from the back seat into our waiting power chairs, and holding up a yellow-highlighted paper pamphlet folded in his hand. "Since Route 15 stays strictly out on Military Highway and doesn't turn into the neighborhood streets, I want to show you two how fast we can get out to the main road without having to break your power chairs down at all."

Clicking our lap belts shut and flipping our armrests back down, Katie and I pressed the green power buttons on our armrest joysticks and hummed side by side down the smooth concrete sidewalk behind Dad. In less than three minutes, we turned the corner from our quiet residential block onto the wide sidewalk bordering Military Highway and Indian River Road, where four lanes of northbound traffic and four lanes of southbound traffic roared past a raised center median.

Saturday, October 6, 2001, 1:25 PM — Catching CVTA Route 15 on Eight-Lane Military Highway

"Look at the timetable right here under Military Hwy. & Indian River Rd.," Dad said over the steady hum of eight-lane highway traffic as the three of us stopped beside the metal bus stop post in the crisp October sunshine, unfolding the printed **CVTA Route 15 — *Naval Base Norfolk / Robert Hall Blvd.*** schedule so both Katie and I could read it.

Holding Katie's left hand with my right hand between our two compact power wheelchairs, I leaned in with my sister to follow the yellow highlighter line Dad had drawn across the grid of numbers.

“Wait a second,” Katie said, her eyes widening as she traced the columns from left to right. “It runs every thirty minutes all day Monday through Saturday?”

“Like clockwork,” Dad smiled, tapping each column with his index finger. “Going northbound up Military Highway, Route 15 stops right across the highway at Military Highway and Indian River Road at :01 and :31 past every hour from six-thirty-one in the morning until six-thirty-one at night, and then once an hour until ten-thirty-one. In exactly fourteen minutes—at :15 and :45 past the hour—it drops you right at the doors of Glenrock Mall, where you can transfer to Routes 20, 23, 25, or 27, or stay right on Route 15 past Glenrock Shopping Center, Little Creek Road, and Hampton Boulevard all the way to Naval Base Norfolk.”

“And what about going southbound on our side of the road?” I asked, looking at the lower table where Dad had highlighted two alternating rows in yellow and green.

“That’s the best part,” Dad said, pointing to the bold route note printed across the center of the timetable: *On arrival at Old Emerald Creek Rd. and Military Hwy., every other trip will alternate between Robert Hall and Emerald Creek Mall Monday through Saturday.* “Southbound buses leave Glenrock Mall at :15 and :45 past the hour and get right here to Military Highway and Indian River Road ten minutes later, at :25 and :55 past every hour. Every bus that stops here at :25 past the hour—like the 1:25 PM bus coming down the right-hand lane right now—turns onto the Emerald Creek Mall branch and puts us at the mall entrance twenty minutes later at 1:45 PM. And every bus that stops here at :55 past the hour goes straight down to Robert Hall Boulevard and Tidewater Square by :15 past the next hour.”

Right on cue, signaling across the four southbound lanes of US-13 (Military Highway) toward our curb was one of the classic forty-foot high-floor workhorses of the fleet: a 900-series Beacon V transit bus (Fleet #914) that operated alongside the agency’s high-floor MetroCoach buses. Because Tidewater Regional Transit (TRT) on the Southside and Peninsula Transit (PenTran) across the harbor had only merged two years earlier in October 1999 to form the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority (CVTA), Bus #914 was still wearing its original 1990s TRT paint scheme—a crisp white body banded with horizontal navy-blue and green stripes down its flanks—with a rectangular CVTA logo vinyl decal sticker applied right next to the front boarding doors below the *15 EMERALD CREEK MALL* destination sign.

As Bus #914 hissed to a stop parallel to the concrete curb, the bi-fold front doors swung open. Because the 900-series Beacon V was a true high-floor bus whose main passenger deck sat three full feet above the street at the top of a three-step stairwell, there was no sloped ramp. Instead, standing high up on the elevated driver’s platform, the uniformed operator pulled the parking brake knob, flipped up the two forward priority benches behind the driver’s area, and switched on the Elevate-U electro-hydraulic stairwell wheelchair lift.

“Afternoon, folks! Welcome aboard The 15,” the operator called down warmly from the elevated doorway as the three deep front steps flattened into a level horizontal steel elevator platform, telescoped outward on twin vertical hydraulic lift arms with yellow-and-black tubular side handrails, and lowered straight down to rest flat on the concrete sidewalk before dropping the yellow outer safety barrier flap flush against the curb. “Come on onto the elevator platform one at a time—I’ve got both wheelchair bays folded up and ready for you!”

Katie and I glanced at each other with identical grins. Nobody had to struggle with a car transfer, and Dad didn't have to unclip battery boxes or lift thirty-five-pound power-chair bases into a trunk. Giving Katie's hand a quick squeeze before letting go for thirty seconds, I nudged my right-hand joystick forward and rolled my compact power chair onto the flat horizontal steel platform between the two side handrails first; the outer yellow safety barrier flipped up behind my rear wheels to lock me in, the twin vertical hydraulic arms raised my chair straight up three feet in the air like an elevator to the high interior floor of Bus #914, and I backed neatly into the right-hand securement bay. Seconds later, the elevator platform lowered straight back down to the sidewalk for Katie and lifted her power chair right up to the high deck across the aisle from me before folding seamlessly back into three staircase steps so Dad could climb up into the bus and drop our fares into the farebox.

Once the operator had clicked the four-point floor straps onto both of our power-chair frames, the front doors hissed shut and Bus #914 merged back into the four southbound lanes of Military Highway.

Across the center aisle of the high-floor bus, Katie reached her left hand out over her armrest, and I reached my right hand out to meet hers, our fingers lacing together in the warm afternoon sunlight streaming through the tall transit windows.

"We don't need a thirty-five-thousand-dollar van to go wherever we want, Nate," Katie said softly over the deep diesel rumble of the Beacon V engine as we cruised south toward Emerald Creek Mall. "Between the school bus on weekdays, breaking our chairs down for the trunk of Dad's car, and Route 15 out on Military Highway at the end of our block, we've got the whole city back."

"And a house with zero stairs," I agreed, squeezing my sister's hand as Dad smiled at the two of us from the seat beside her. "We're going to be just fine."

Sixteen on Four Wheels & Finding Dates

Part 1: Navigating Northwood High on Four Wheels, Two First Dates, & Why We Ride on Saturday

Date: 2001-10-15 at 07:10 America/New_York

Monday, October 15, 2001, 7:10 AM — Rolling the "Blue Mile" & The Brass Elevator Key

"Keep your speed dial on two until we clear the Commons tiles, Nate, or the vibration is going to rattle our teeth right out of our heads," Katie said with a wry smile on Monday morning as the two of us rolled our compact SwiftChair power wheelchairs through the pinned-open double fire doors of Northwood High School.

Beneath our ten-inch solid drive wheels, the textured quarry tiles of the Northwood High Commons buzzed like a washboard before giving way to the smooth, polished linoleum of the main academic corridor everyone called the "Blue Mile."

It was the start of our second full week navigating eleventh grade on four wheels instead of two feet, and physically, the difference was like night and day.

Back in September, walking from the morning bus loop to first period had left our calves cramping, our knees trembling, and our shoulders aching from the weight of our backpacks before the first bell even rang. Now, thanks to the Section 504 Medical Mobility Plan that Dr. Carter had signed and Dad had walked into the principal's office, neither Katie nor I carried a single textbook between classes. A duplicate set of our Junior-year textbooks sat on a designated shelf in each of our classrooms, and clipped to our lanyard ID badges alongside our house keys were two shiny brass Vanguard Elevator keys issued by the school custodian.

Socially, however, showing up to your Junior year of high school in matching power wheelchairs was like dropping a boulder into the middle of a swimming pool.

As Katie and I glided side by side down the right-hand lane of the Blue Mile with our right index fingers resting lightly on our armrest joysticks, the noisy wall of lockers ahead of us reacted the exact same way it had all last week. Conversations dropped to sudden, awkward whispers as we rolled past. Kids who had known us since sixth grade either stared straight down at their sneakers as if looking at a power wheelchair might be rude, or leaped three feet out of our path against the lockers as though we were driving runaway forklifts.

When we reached the B-Wing stairwell at the end of the hall—where two hundred students were jostling up the concrete steps toward the second floor—I pulled my brass key on its retractable lanyard reel, inserted it into the keyhole beside the heavy gray door of the school's service elevator, and turned it clockwise.

With a slow mechanical clunk, the sliding metal door rattled open, releasing the familiar scent of lemon floor wax and damp mop buckets. Katie and I rolled our compact power chairs straight inside side by side, and as the door slid shut, sealing out the roar of the stairwell, Katie reached her left hand across the two inches between our armrests and laced her fingers through mine.

"Did you see Todd Jenkins jump into the water fountain alcove when we turned the corner by the trophy case?" I asked as the old hydraulic elevator groaned upward toward the second floor at roughly half a mile an hour.

"He nearly knocked his own varsity jacket off his shoulder," Katie laughed, squeezing my hand as the floor indicator light blinked from 1 to 2. "Remind me again why we used to be afraid of using this elevator?"

"Because we didn't know how nice it was to get to second period without our legs shaking," I said honestly as the elevator chimed and the door rattled open onto the upstairs landing. "See you at eleven-forty at our table?"

"Count on it," Katie smiled, giving my hand one last squeeze before we released our fingers and steered in opposite directions down the hall—Katie toward first-period U.S. History, and me toward first-period English.

Monday, October 15, 2001, 11:45 AM — Head Over Heels for Heather & Katie's Guarded Heart

"You were smiling all the way from the milk cooler to the table, Nate," Katie teased gently four hours later as the two of us parked our compact power wheelchairs side by side at the open end of our sunlit corner cafeteria table and clicked our joystick motors off. "Let me guess: Heather Collins sat next to you in second-period Computer Lab again?"

I felt my ears turn warm all the way to the tips as I set my brown paper lunch bag beside our spiral *Quantum Basic* notebook.

"She moved her chair right next to my power chair for the whole ninety-minute block," I admitted, unable to keep the grin off my face as I poked Katie's straw into her apple juice box for her and handed it across our armrests. "When everybody else in the row stepped around my wheelchair like it was radioactive, Heather didn't even blink. She showed me wallet photos of her family, helped me pick a color palette for our *Quantum Basic* menu screen, and asked if I wanted to sit with her at the computer table every day this semester."

The truth was, I wasn't just crushing on Heather Collins—at sixteen years old, I was completely, head-over-heels in love with her. From the first week of Junior year in Room 204, Heather had treated me with a warm, effortless kindness that made my heart race every time she walked through the classroom door.

Beside me, Katie took a sip of her juice box, her expression softening with genuine happiness for me before a quieter, more thoughtful look crossed her face.

"What about Ryan Miller in third-period Chemistry?" I asked, reaching my right hand across the gap between our chairs to take Katie's left hand on the laminate tabletop. "You said on Friday that he kept leaning across the lab bench to talk to you."

"He did again today," Katie said, though her voice was noticeably more reserved than mine. Ever since seventh grade—when Brandon had dumped her in the middle of the hallway and left her sobbing beneath the blue butterfly in her bedroom—Katie had kept a careful, protective wall around her heart when it came to boys. "Actually, while we were cleaning up our beakers at the accessible lab sink, Ryan asked if I wanted to go out with him to Emerald Creek Mall this weekend. And he asked if you had a girlfriend you wanted to bring along so we could make it a double date."

My breath caught in my throat. Neither Katie nor I had ever been on a real high-school date before. Before our legs gave out in September and we got our compact power wheelchairs, Katie and I had gone to both Emerald Creek Mall and Chesapeake Bay Mall all the time—with Chesapeake Bay Mall out on Lynnhaven Parkway always being our favorite "big trip" mall (which we still hadn't visited yet since getting our powerchairs), and Emerald Creek Mall becoming our favorite regular teenage hangout because we only needed to ride a single bus from Military Highway to get there.

"Wait—what did you tell him?" I asked.

"I told him I'd talk to you at lunch first," Katie said carefully, her fingers tightening around mine. "Honestly, Nate, I don't know about Ryan. He's nice enough when we're lab partners, but I can't tell if he actually likes *me* or if he just likes having

someone who balances his chemical equations for him. Still… I see the way your whole face lights up whenever you talk about Heather. And if we go together as a double date on Saturday afternoon, neither one of us has to go through our first high-school date alone."

"Why Saturday specifically?" I asked, glancing at the calendar inside my binder.

"Because I checked Dad's printed CVTA Route 15 schedule on the refrigerator this morning," Katie explained, tapping the timetable notes she had copied into the margin of our notebook. "Remember the alternating branch rule at Old Emerald Creek Road and Military Highway? Route 15 only serves Emerald Creek Mall Monday through Saturday. On Sundays, every single trip runs straight down to Robert Hall Boulevard and skips Emerald Creek Mall completely. So if we want to take the bus to the mall ourselves, it has to be on Saturday."

"Then let's do Saturday," I said earnestly, squeezing her hand so she knew my promise from seventh grade hadn't changed one bit. "I'll ask Heather in Computer Lab on Wednesday morning, and you tell Ryan we'll meet them at the Emerald Creek Mall upstairs food court at twelve-forty-five on Saturday. And Katie—if Ryan acts weird for even one second, you and I have our bus fare in our pockets and each other right beside us."

Wednesday, October 17, 2001, 10:05 AM — Two Very Different Reactions

"A Saturday afternoon double date at Emerald Creek Mall with you and Katie?" Heather Collins repeated on Wednesday morning in second-period Computer Lab, her warm hazel eyes lighting up with an immediate, genuine smile that made my chest feel weightless. "I would love to, Nate! How are you and Katie getting over to Emerald Creek?"

"We live right near Military Highway and Indian River Road now, so we're taking CVTA Route 15 at twelve-twenty-five," I explained honestly, bracing myself just in case a high-school girl thought riding the city bus on a first date was uncool. "The high-floor bus has a hydraulic wheelchair lift in the front stairwell, so Katie and I can roll our power chairs right aboard together without Dad having to break them down for the trunk of his car."

Heather didn't flinch or look embarrassed for a fraction of a second. Instead, her smile grew even warmer.

"That is so smart—my dad can drop me off at the main mall entrance at twelve-forty, and I'll ride the back glass elevator right up to the second-floor food court to meet you and Katie," Heather said brightly, reaching over to touch the sleeve of my flannel shirt. "I can't wait for Saturday, Nate."

Two hours later at Fourth-Block lunch, however, when Katie rolled up to the corner table and parked beside me, I could see immediately from the tight set of her jaw that her conversation with Ryan Miller in third-period Chemistry had gone very differently.

"Ryan agreed to meet us at twelve-forty-five on Saturday," Katie said quietly, unwrapping her sandwich and taking my right hand across the table, "but we didn't even make it out of the Chemistry lab before he got weird about two things."

“What did he say?” I asked, frowning.

“First, when I told him we were meeting at Emerald Creek Mall, Ryan puffed his chest out and said, *‘Oh, I’ll drive over to your house in my coupe and pick you up—just fold your wheelchair up and throw it in my trunk,”* Katie recounted, shaking her head in disbelief. “I tried to explain to him twice that a motorized power wheelchair with a battery box and solid drive wheels doesn’t just fold flat like an umbrella stroller, and that even if Dad disassembled it into four pieces, it wouldn’t fit inside a two-door sports coupe.”

“And what was the second thing?” I asked.

“When I told him that you and I were riding CVTA Route 15 to the mall together because we always travel as a pair,” Katie said, her blue eyes steady and guarded as she looked at me, “Ryan frowned and said, *‘Wait—you’re bringing your brother on the bus instead of riding with me? Don’t you ever go anywhere without Nate?’* I looked him straight in the eye and told him, *‘No, Ryan. Nate is my twin brother, and he comes first.’* He backed down and said he’d meet us at the food court at twelve-forty-five, but… I have a feeling Saturday is going to be a very short test for Ryan Miller.”

Part 2: Cousin Wesley, Ryan’s Escalator Exit, & Two Dates at Emerald Creek Mall

Date: 2001-10-20 at 12:45 America/New_York

Saturday, October 20, 2001, 12:45 PM — The Second-Floor Food Court & Cousin Wesley

“Nate! Katie! You guys made it right on time!” Heather Collins called out with a radiant smile at twelve-forty-five on Saturday afternoon, waiting for us on the terracotta-tile landing right outside the brushed-brass sliding doors of the freestanding early-1980s glass elevator on the main retail concourse—its warm cream-colored corner columns framing multi-pane glass and topped with a small glass pyramid cap beneath the white steel roof trusses—right where the elevator connected the first floor of the main concourse up to the second-floor food court wing of Emerald Creek Mall.

Twenty minutes earlier, Dad had walked with us out to the corner of Military Highway and Indian River Road, pressed a twenty-dollar bill into each of our hands, and waved from the sidewalk as Katie and I rode the Elevate-U hydraulic stairwell wheelchair lift aboard the 12:25 PM Saturday southbound CVTA Route 15 (Bus #914). Right on schedule at 12:45 PM, the high-floor Beacon V bus had dropped us off at the bus stop on the mall’s outer ring road, straight across the parking lot from the first-floor exterior entrance of Wellington’s, the two-story anchor department store at the end of the wing. Rolling side by side from the ring road through the ground-floor cosmetics and apparel aisles of Wellington’s into the first-floor main concourse, Katie and I had stepped right into the glass-backed scenic elevator directly in front of the department store’s mall entrance and ridden it up to the second floor.

Before I could even click my joystick speed dial down to one on the upper landing, Heather stepped straight up to my compact SwiftChair power wheelchair, leaned down without a trace of hesitation, and wrapped her arms around my shoulders in a warm hello hug that sent my heart soaring into the skylights.

“Hi, Nate,” Heather said softly against my cheek before straightening up and smiling just as warmly at my twin sister. “And hi, Katie! My dad dropped me off at the lower Wellington’s entrance and I rode the glass elevator right up here from the first-floor concourse so we could roll into the food court wing together—and whenever we go downstairs to browse the lower level, I’m riding the elevator right alongside you two.”

“Thanks for waiting for us by the elevator, Heather,” Katie said, her guarded posture relaxing noticeably at how naturally Heather included both of us and had zero problem being seen riding the mall elevator with two kids in wheelchairs.

Turning 180 degrees away from the glass elevator and the two-story interior entrance of Wellington’s behind us on the main retail concourse, the three of us rolled straight into the bustling second-floor food court wing—where the high white tented fabric canopy ceiling and skylights echoed with weekend chatter, the far exterior glass exit doors at the back of the wing opened straight out onto the graded upper section of the mall parking lot that gently sloped up to the second-floor level, and Bobby Vanguard’s 1982 synth-pop classic *“Moving Up the Escalator”* drifted down from the PA speakers above the food court escalators—just as Ryan Miller strolled over from the brass-and-glass mezzanine railing in his letterman jacket.

Unlike Heather, Ryan didn’t look thrilled to see our two compact power wheelchairs rolling side by side.

“Hey,” Ryan said, glancing down at Katie’s motorized drive wheels as we picked a four-top table positioned right on the tile concourse between the two central escalators—with the up escalator rising from the first floor on Katie’s and my side, and the down escalator descending to the first floor on Heather’s and Ryan’s side—and pulled two plastic chairs away so Katie and I could park our power chairs side by side facing Ryan and Heather. “Katie, I still don’t get why you made me meet you here instead of letting me pick you up in my car. You seriously couldn’t just fold that chair up and stick it in my trunk?”

“Ryan, I told you on Wednesday—it’s a power wheelchair,” Katie replied evenly, tapping the black battery box beneath her seat. “It has electric motors and heavy batteries. It doesn’t fold up like a beach chair, and Nate and I ride Route 15 together.”

Ryan let out a loud, skeptical sigh, slumping into his seat across from Katie as Heather and I brought back our lunch trays from Crown Burger and Annie’s Pretzels.

Halfway from the counter to the table, the progressive neuropathy weakness in my left forearm flared under the weight of the plastic food tray. My left wrist trembled, tipping my large cola cup toward the edge of the tray. Instantly—without me having to say a single word—Katie glided her power chair half a foot to her right, slid her left hand under the corner of my tray to steady it onto the table, pinched open the paper wrapper on my straw, and laced her left fingers through my right hand between our armrests while my wrist tremor settled.

Across the table, Ryan stared at our joined hands as if we had just committed a felony.

“Are you kidding me right now, Katie?” Ryan snapped, setting his burger down on its wrapper and leaning forward across the table. “First you refuse to ride in my car unless your brother comes along, and now you’re sitting here holding his hand and opening his straw while you’re supposed to be on a date with *me*? Who’s number one here—me or your brother?”

The noisy food court seemed to fade into background static around our table. Beside me, Katie didn’t flinch, and she didn’t let go of my hand.

“Nate is number one in my life, Ryan,” Katie said clearly, looking him straight in the eyes. “He is my twin brother. We’ve been through everything together, and he is always going to come first.”

Ryan scoffed, his face flushing red as he turned toward Heather next to him, clearly expecting her to back him up. “Heather, are you seeing this? Doesn’t it bother you that your date is sitting here holding his sister’s hand and acting like they’re glued together?”

Heather looked at Ryan with calm, unmistakable steel in her hazel eyes—and then reached across the tabletop to lay her right hand warmly over my left hand.

“No, Ryan, it doesn’t bother me one bit,” Heather said firmly. “In fact, I love how close Nate and Katie are.”

Ryan blinked at her. “What? Why?”

“Because my fourteen-year-old cousin Wesley—my mom’s sister’s son—is severely developmentally disabled,” Heather explained, her voice steady and proud as she looked from Ryan to Katie and me. “Wesley and I grew up together, and whenever the two of us go anywhere, I hold Wesley’s hand, I hug him, and we look out for each other the exact same way Nate and Katie do. If I ever screamed at Nate or got jealous of him for holding his twin sister’s hand and hugging her, I would be disrespecting the exact relationship I have with Wesley.”

Heather turned her gaze back to me, her eyes shining with so much warmth and affection that my throat went tight.

“I knew before I ever said yes on Wednesday that Nate and Katie travel as a pair,” Heather continued softly. “And watching the way they take care of each other only makes me love Nate more.”

Saturday, October 20, 2001, 1:20 PM — Ryan’s Escalator Exit & “Did You Bring Two Dates?”

Ryan stared from Heather to Katie and me, his ego visibly bruised beyond repair as he realized neither girl at the table was going to bend to him.

“Whatever,” Ryan muttered bitterly, shoving his plastic food-court chair back across the quarry tile and standing up. “If I wanted to play second fiddle to your twin brother and a pair of wheelchairs all afternoon, I would’ve stayed home. Have fun riding the city bus, Katie.”

Heather, Katie, and I watched in silence as Ryan snatched his jacket off the back of his chair.

Beside me, Katie kept her chin up, but I felt the slight tremor in her left hand where her fingers were still laced with mine, and I saw the hurt glistening at the corners of her blue eyes. Even though Katie had stayed guarded with Ryan all week—and even though part of her had figured from the start that this wouldn’t work—having a boy walk out on her in the middle of a crowded food court still stung.

And then Ryan did something that turned my blood to ice.

Because our table sat right between the two central escalators—with the up escalator on Katie’s and my side, the down escalator right on Heather’s and Ryan’s side, and the glass elevator back behind us—the entrance to the down escalator was to Ryan’s immediate right as he stood up from his chair. Instead of walking back toward the elevator or the upper-level parking-lot doors, Ryan turned to look directly at Katie sitting in her compact power wheelchair, took two steps to his immediate right, and stepped deliberately onto the moving metal steps of the down escalator—riding it down to the first floor in a massive, calculated show of disrespect because he knew Katie’s disability made it physically impossible for her to follow him down those stairs.

As the top of Ryan’s head sank below the second-floor floorplate on the escalator, a long, quiet breath left Katie’s lips.

“I kind of figured before we even got off the bus today that it wouldn’t work with him,” Katie admitted quietly, blinking back the moisture in her eyes as she looked down at her lap belt. “Still… taking the escalator just to rub it in that I can’t follow him was pretty low.”

“It wasn’t just low, Katie—it was disgusting, and he didn’t deserve five minutes of your time,” Heather said immediately, stepping around the corner of the table to rest a gentle, supportive hand on Katie’s shoulder while I squeezed Katie’s left hand with everything I had. “And we are *not* letting him ruin our Saturday. Come on—finish your pretzels, and let’s the three of us go walk the second floor of the mall together!”

Katie looked up at Heather in surprise, then glanced at me.

“You’re sure you don’t mind me tagging along on your date, Heather?” Katie asked softly.

“Are you kidding? You’re not tagging along—we’re a team today,” Heather smiled warmly.

Ten minutes later, after we cleared our trays, the three of us rolled out of the food court and into the wide, sunlit second-floor concourse of Emerald Creek Mall. I rolled down the center of the polished terrazzo walkway in my compact power chair, with Katie rolling right beside my left armrest holding my left hand, and Heather walking right beside my right armrest holding my right hand.

Halfway past the Oak & Iron Outfitters and The Literary Alcove upper-level windows, three guys from our Junior-year History and English classes at Northwood High School—Marcus, Devon, and Chris—came walking out of the music store carrying CD bags.

None of the three had ever had a class with Katie and me at the same time, so they had no idea Katie was my twin sister—and as their eyes landed on me rolling down the mall in my power wheelchair flanked by two pretty sixteen-year-old girls holding both of my hands, all three of them stopped dead in their tracks.

Marcus grinned from ear to ear and gave me an impressed salute.

"Whoa, Prairie—save some for the rest of us, man!" Marcus laughed, nudging Devon's elbow as they walked past. "Did you seriously bring *two* dates to Emerald Creek Mall today?!"

For one second, Heather, Katie, and I blinked at each other—and then all three of us burst out laughing so hard that every bit of the sadness Ryan had left behind vanished into the vaulted ceiling of the mall.

"Tell them yes, Nate!" Heather giggled, squeezing my right hand as Katie laughed beside us. "Let the whole eleventh grade think you're the smoothest guy at Northwood High!"

"With the two prettiest girls in Virginia Beach on either side of my chair," I grinned, looking from Katie's bright, restored smile on my left to Heather's glowing face on my right, "I'm definitely not correcting them."

Saturday, October 20, 2001, 2:40 PM — A Hug for Me, A Handshake for Katie, & Route 15 Home

We spent the next hour browsing the second-floor music and book aisles at The Literary Alcove together before riding the freestanding glass-enclosed elevator down to the first-floor main concourse at two-forty and rolling out through the first-floor entrance of Wellington's toward the ring road so Katie and I could catch the 2:48 PM northbound CVTA Route 15 bus back up Military Highway.

Just outside the automatic sliding glass doors in the crisp October sunshine, Heather's father pulled up to the pickup curb in his burgundy sedan and gave a friendly wave through the windshield. Fifty feet down the wide concrete sidewalk, the blue-and-yellow CVTA bus stop sign stood waiting for the 2:48 PM bus.

Stopping beside us on the sidewalk, Heather turned to me first. Bending down in front of my power chair, she wrapped both arms warmly around my neck and hugged me close, her cheek pressing against mine for a long, unhurried moment.

"Today was the best first date I've ever had, Nate," Heather whispered in my ear before pulling back with a bright smile. "Same computer table on Monday morning?"

"Same computer table on Monday morning," I promised, my face glowing.

Then Heather turned to Katie's power wheelchair right beside mine. Instead of giving a polite wave from a distance, Heather stepped squarely in front of my twin sister, met Katie's blue eyes with genuine warmth and respect, and extended her right hand.

"It was really great hanging out with you today, Katie," Heather said earnestly. "Next Saturday, maybe the three of us can bring my cousin Wesley along and get pretzels together."

Katie looked at Heather's outstretched hand, and a real, unguarded smile broke across my sister's face as she reached out with her right hand and shook Heather's hand warmly.

"I'd really like that, Heather," Katie said. "See you at school on Monday."

We watched from the sidewalk as Heather climbed into the front passenger seat of her father's car and waved out the window until the sedan merged onto the ring road. As soon as her dad's car turned the corner, Katie and I steered our compact power wheelchairs side by side down the sidewalk to the CVTA Route 15 bus stop and laced our inner hands together while we waited for the 2:48 PM high-floor Beacon V bus to round the loop.

"Well," I said quietly, looking over at my twin sister as the familiar white bus with its horizontal blue-and-green TRT stripes and CVTA door sticker signaled toward our curb, "one out of two first dates wasn't bad."

"Are you kidding, Nate?" Katie smiled, squeezing my hand as the bus pulled up and the operator switched on the Elevate-U hydraulic stairwell wheelchair lift. "Finding out in twenty minutes that Ryan was a jerk—and finding out that Heather loves you *and* gets us completely because of her cousin Wesley? I'd call that a hundred percent success."

Seventeen, Senior Year, & Greenway Court

Drunken New Year

Part 1: The Gas-Station Run, A Box of Dry Cereal, & Why I Never Had a Twenty-First Birthday Drink

Date: 2002-12-31 at 21:30 America/New_York

Tuesday, December 31, 2002, 9:30 PM — The Broken Ground Rules & The Gas-Station Run

"Brittany, Dad and Aunt Liz laid down the ground rules before they walked out that front door—nobody is allowed over here tonight, and there is zero alcohol allowed in this house!" I said sharply at nine-thirty on New Year's Eve, sitting in my

compact SwiftChair power wheelchair in the front hallway beside Katie's chair as our seventeen-year-old cousin Brittany pulled the front door open to the cold December night.

Tonight was supposed to be simple, quiet, and safe.

It was Tuesday, December 31, 2002—the middle of our Senior year at Northwood High School, just over three months before Katie and I would turn eighteen on April 8. Ever since the Friday afternoon in September of our Junior year when the borrowed time in our legs had finally run out in the hallway at school, both Katie and I had used our compact power wheelchairs full-time from the moment we woke up until we went to bed at night.

Because Grandma had come down with a bad winter bronchitis over Christmas and couldn't travel on the ARTS train, Dad, our Aunt Elizabeth, and our older cousin Chelsea had driven across the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel to Newport News at seven o'clock that evening to check on Grandma, drop off her prescriptions, and have a quiet New Year's Eve dinner with her before driving back after midnight. Meanwhile, our seventeen-year-old cousin Brittany—who was staying over at our house for the second half of winter break—had stayed behind in Virginia Beach with Katie and me. Before Dad and Aunt Liz left with Chelsea, they had stood right in the center of our living room and laid down the law to the three of us: the front door was to stay deadbolted, nobody was allowed inside the house, and Katie, Brittany, and I were supposed to spend New Year's Eve eating pizza, drinking sparkling apple cider, and watching the Times Square ball drop together on television.

Instead, the second Dad's Holt sedan had turned onto Military Highway, Brittany had picked up the cordless kitchen phone.

Now, standing on our aluminum front porch ramp in the porch light were five teenagers Brittany had met earlier that week—along with a tall, scruffy twenty-one-year-old guy named Derek who had just used his vertical driver's license to do a run to the corner gas station out on Military Highway, carrying two heavy plastic grocery bags clinking with glass bottles and cardboard twelve-packs.

"Oh, chill out, Nate—don't be such a pair of babies," Brittany scoffed, waving Derek and the other four kids past our wheelchairs into our small living room. "Uncle David and Aunt Liz won't be back from Grandma's in Newport News until one in the morning. We'll throw the empties in the outside trash bin before midnight and nobody will ever know unless you two snitch."

"This isn't your house, Brittany, it's ours!" Katie said firmly, her left hand reaching across our armrests to grip my right hand as Derek dumped the plastic bags onto our kitchen counter with a loud crash of bottles. "Our dad works his tail off to pay the rent on this place, and we don't want strangers drinking in our living room!"

"Well, they're already here, and Derek already spent forty bucks at the gas station," Brittany shot back, grabbing two plastic cups from the dish rack as one of her friends cranked the volume knob on our living-room stereo up until the bass rattled the window blinds. "If you two don't want to party, go play on your computers in your room and leave us alone."

Tuesday, December 31, 2002, 11:15 PM — Hiding Behind a Locked Bedroom Door

By eleven-fifteen that night, our living room had devolved into a loud, sour-smelling war zone.

Katie and I had stayed near the hallway threshold as long as we could to make sure nobody broke Dad's things, but as the gas-station bottles emptied over the next ninety minutes, Brittany's guests turned into every kind of drunk at once.

Over on the living-room sofa, one boy in a hooded sweatshirt was already passed out cold with his mouth open and an empty can rolling across the carpet beneath his sneakers, while a girl beside him was slumped sideways over the armrest, half-conscious and groaning that the room was spinning. Near the kitchen doorway, Derek and another guy in a baseball cap had turned mean and belligerent—shouting profanities inches from each other's faces and shoving kitchen chairs out of the way in an angry argument over who owed whom ten dollars for the gas-station run. And right in the middle of the rug, Brittany and her friend Jenna were completely loopy—stumbling into the coffee table, slurring every third word, and cackling at the top of their lungs as they spilled sticky soda and liquor across the floor.

For Katie and me, the smell of stale alcohol drifting down the hallway and the sound of angry, slurred shouting inside our own home hit every raw nerve left behind by our mother on the cruise ship sixteen months earlier.

When Derek slammed his palm against the kitchen wall so hard that the framed family photos in the hallway crooked on their nails, Katie looked at me with wide eyes and gripped my wrist.

"Nate, I don't want to be out here near them anymore," Katie whispered over the roar of the stereo and the shouting. "If Derek or that other guy trips over our wheelchairs while they're fighting, neither of us can stand up to get out of the way."

"Grab that unopened box of dry cereal off the lower pantry shelf so we have food for the rest of the night and don't have to come back out here," I told her immediately, snagging two cans of ginger ale on my lap tray while Katie tucked the family-size box of toasted oat cereal onto her lap. "We're locking ourselves in your room until Dad gets back."

As we backed our two compact power wheelchairs down the short hallway toward Katie's bedroom at the back corner of the house, one of Brittany's guests—a loudmouth senior from Northwood High named Tyler who had been chugging out of a plastic cup by the stereo—spotted us retreating and stumbled down the hall after us.

"Hey! Where do you two think you're rolling off to?" Tyler slurred, thrusting a red plastic cup toward my face as I steered Katie inside the bedroom ahead of me. "Come on, Prairie, stop acting like you're too good for the rave and take a drink!"

"We don't drink, Tyler—stay out of our hallway," I told him flatly.

Before Tyler could take another step, I backed my power chair across the threshold into Katie's bedroom, swung the solid wooden bedroom door shut right in his flushed, angry face, twisted the brass privacy lock until it clicked, and wedged the heavy rubber doorstop beneath the bottom gap.

On the other side of the oak panel, Tyler banged his fist twice against the door and yelled spitefully over the bass of the stereo, *"Fine, lock yourselves in a bedroom all night, you stuck-up losers! See if anybody cares!"*

For good measure, once Katie and I used our armrests to transfer onto the edge of her bed side by side beneath the framed blue butterfly print from our old house, I used my joystick to inch my fifty-pound power wheelchair right up against the inside of the doorknob like a steel roadblock.

Even through the closed door, we could still hear the muffled thudding of boots, the angry shouting from the kitchen, and the loopy, off-key shrieking from the living room.

Pulling Katie's green-and-gold quilt around both of our shoulders, I opened the top flaps of the cardboard cereal box between us so we had handfuls of dry cereal to munch on for dinner, switched the small thirteen-inch television on her dresser to the GBS New Year's Eve broadcast from Times Square with the volume turned low, and wrapped my right arm around my twin sister's shoulders while my left hand held hers.

Wednesday, January 1, 2003, 12:00 AM — Why I Never Had a Twenty-First Birthday Drink

"Ten minutes to midnight," Katie murmured, resting her blonde head against my shoulder as the crowd in Times Square cheered on the small screen and another loud crash of glass echoed from the kitchen on the other side of our locked bedroom door. "Can you believe we have to hide in a locked bedroom in our own house on New Year's Eve because Brittany couldn't follow one simple rule?"

"Dad is going to hit the roof when he pulls into the driveway," I said quietly, glancing at the two unopened cans of ginger ale we had brought into the bedroom with us on our lap trays before the party got out of hand.

For a long moment, I sat there listening to the contrast between the two sides of that bedroom door: out in the living room, kids our age were passed out on the floor, screaming at each other in drunken rage, or stumbling around out of their minds—while in here, Katie and I were safe, clear-headed, and holding onto each other.

Up until that exact night at seventeen years old—four months shy of my eighteenth birthday in April—I had always assumed that when it came to alcohol, I was just waiting until my twenty-first birthday like everybody else to have my first legal drink. I was a rule-follower by nature; I didn't break laws, so I had figured that once I turned twenty-one, I'd probably try a glass of beer or wine just to see what the big deal was.

Sitting on the edge of that bed with Katie's hand in mine, listening to Derek's slurred shouting and Brittany's loopy giggling through the drywall—and remembering the look on our mother's face on Deck 4 of the *Sunward Tropics* right before she landed in the ship's brig—something settled permanently inside my chest.

"Katie?" I said softly as the digital clock on the television screen ticked to 11:59 PM and the glittering crystal ball began its sixty-second descent down the flagpole in Times Square.

"Yeah, Nate?" Katie asked, looking up at me.

"You know how I always said I was waiting until my twenty-first birthday to have my first legal drink?" I said, popping the tabs on our two cold cans of ginger ale and handing one to my sister. "Listening to what's going on in our living room tonight—some of them passed out cold, some of them furious and trying to fight each other, some of them acting like they lost half their brains—I don't ever want to end up like that. Not even once. When we turn twenty-one, I'm not having a twenty-first birthday drink. I'm never touching the stuff for the rest of my life."

Katie looked at the can of ginger ale in her hand, then looked up into my eyes with a fierce, unmistakable pride.

"Me neither, Nate," Katie said, clinking her ginger ale can gently against mine just as *12:00 AM — HAPPY NEW YEAR 2003* flashed across the small screen and confetti snowed over Times Square. "Why would either one of us ever put something in our bodies that turns people into *that*—when we can stay sharp, write our code, and take care of each other?"

"Happy New Year, Katie," I whispered, setting my ginger ale on the nightstand and pulling my twin sister into a tight, two-armed hug under the quilt.

"Happy New Year, Twin Brother," Katie whispered back, hugging me tight while the noises in the living room finally began to stumble toward the front door—just twenty minutes before Dad's headlights swept up the driveway and Brittany's New Year's Eve privileges came to a permanent, unceremonious end.

Part 2: The Drunken New Year Lie, Heather's Bitter Goodbye, & Twin Sisters Always Stay

Date: 2003-01-06 at 08:05 America/New_York

Monday, January 6, 2003, 8:05 AM — Blindsided Outside Room 204

"Save it, Nathaniel—don't you dare roll up to my locker with that innocent smile on your face and pretend you didn't do anything wrong!" Heather Collins snapped at five minutes past eight on Monday morning, slamming her locker door shut so hard that the metal vents rattled down the second-floor hallway of Northwood High School.

My right thumb froze on the joystick of my compact SwiftChair power wheelchair, bringing my chair to an abrupt halt three feet from her locker outside Room 204.

It was Monday, January 6, 2003—the very first morning back at school after winter break. Because Heather's parents had taken her and her cousin Wesley up to the Shenandoah Valley to visit her grandparents between Christmas and New Year's Day, I hadn't seen her in person for over a week. All morning long on the CVTA Route 15 bus ride and up the school elevator with Katie, I had been grinning from ear to ear, carrying a small folded note in my jacket pocket asking Heather if she wanted to meet Katie and me at Emerald Creek Mall that coming Saturday afternoon.

Instead, as Katie rolled her power chair up beside mine in the busy hallway before first period, I found myself staring into a face I barely recognized.

The warm, gentle girl who had held my hand on the second-floor bridge of the mall, who had defended my bond with my twin sister because of how fiercely she loved her cousin Wesley, was staring down at me with hard, glassy eyes and a jaw clenched so tight her chin was trembling.

"Heather, what's wrong?" I asked, completely blindsided as my stomach dropped into my shoes. "Did something happen over break? I don't even know what you're talking about!"

"Oh, you don't know what I'm talking about?" Heather laughed—a short, jagged, bitter sound that made several students walking past us turn their heads. "Really, Nate? Look down the hall by the stairwell!"

I glanced over my shoulder toward the east stairwell. Leaning against the cinderblock wall in his varsity jacket with a smug, spiteful smirk plastered across his face was Tyler—the loudmouth senior who had stumbled down our hallway with a red plastic cup on New Year's Eve and banged his fist on Katie's bedroom door when we refused to join Brittany's drunken rave.

"Tyler was in my homeroom ten minutes ago bragging to half the senior class about the wild New Year's Eve rave at your house off Military Highway," Heather said, her voice shaking with a cold, venomous fury that cut straight through the hallway chatter. "He told everybody how you got yourself and some girl wicked drunk on gas-station liquor, locked the two of you inside a back bedroom with a chair wedged against the doorknob, and spent the whole night hooking up behind a locked door while the party went on outside!"

For two full seconds, my brain couldn't even process the sheer absurdity of what I was hearing.

"What?!" I gasped, staring at her in disbelief. "Heather, that's a complete lie! Neither one of us drank a single drop of alcohol!"

"And you know what the worst part is, Nate?" Heather cut me off, her voice cracking with bitter humiliation as angry tears welled in the corners of her eyes. "When Tyler first started laughing in homeroom about how you locked yourself in a back bedroom all night with a girl, I actually defended you! I immediately assumed you were in that room with *Katie*—because I know the two of you always stick together and look out for each other! I looked right at Tyler in front of everybody and said, *'That was his twin sister Katie, you idiot!'* And Tyler looked me dead in

the eye, laughed in my face, and told the whole room it *wasn't* Katie—that it was some blonde girl from the party who got wasted with you before you locked the door in his face!"

Beside me, Katie's blue eyes went wide with outrage.

"Heather, Tyler *only* saw the back of my blonde head from the hallway before Nate shut the door in his drunken face!" Katie spoke up immediately, rolling her power wheelchair six inches forward to put herself right alongside me. "It *was* me in that bedroom! Our cousin Brittany broke our dad's ground rules and invited strangers with alcohol into our house while our dad, our aunt, and our cousin Chelsea were in Newport News! Nate and I grabbed an unopened box of dry cereal out of the pantry so we'd have food to eat and locked ourselves in my bedroom all night just to stay safe and away from them! Tyler was furious that Nate wouldn't drink with him or join the rave—he's lying to get back at us!"

I reached into my jacket pocket with a shaking hand, desperate to make Heather hear the truth.

"Heather, please, listen to me—Katie's telling the absolute truth!" I pleaded, my chest aching as if someone had dropped a cinderblock onto my sternum. "We ate dry toasted oat cereal out of a cardboard box and drank two cans of ginger ale while watching the ball drop on a thirteen-inch TV! I literally promised Katie at midnight that I'm never even having a twenty-first birthday drink because watching Tyler and those kids act like drunken idiots disgusted me so much! You know me, Heather—how could you ever believe I would get drunk or cheat on you?"

Slowly, painfully, I realized from the cold, shuttered look on Heather's face that the damage was already done.

Sitting in front of twenty kids in homeroom while Tyler laughed in her face and told everyone her boyfriend was locked in a bedroom all night with another girl had humiliated her to the core—and once that bitter poison had taken root in her chest, no amount of truth about a cardboard box of dry cereal was going to undo it.

"Save it for somebody gullible enough to buy it, Nathaniel," Heather said coldly, stepping back from our two wheelchairs as the five-minute warning bell rang overhead. "I stuck up for you in front of everybody because I thought you were different from every other guy at this school, and you made me look like a complete fool. Don't call my house, don't wait for me at the bus loop, and don't ever talk to me again. We're done."

Before I could get another word out of my throat, Heather spun on her heel, walked briskly down the hallway past Tyler—who flashed me one last triumphant, nasty grin before disappearing into his classroom—and vanished around the corner toward the science wing.

Monday, January 6, 2003, 3:45 PM — Roles Reversed Under the Blue Butterfly

All through first period, lunch, and afternoon classes, I felt like I was moving underwater.

What hurt more than anything wasn't just that my very first relationship had ended in less than sixty seconds on a Monday morning—it was the crushing, helpless injustice of being condemned for the exact opposite of who I was. I had followed every rule my father had laid down; I had protected my twin sister from a living room full of reckless drunks; I had sworn off alcohol for the rest of my life; and yet because one angry liar wanted revenge for having a bedroom door closed in his face, the girl I had been head over heels in love with for a year and a half now hated my guts without ever knowing I was innocent.

By the time the CVTA Route 15 Beacon V bus lowered us down the Elevate-U hydraulic stairwell lift onto the sidewalk along Military Highway at three-thirty that afternoon and we rolled up the aluminum ramp into our house, the knot in my throat was so tight I could barely breathe.

Without saying a word, Katie steered her power chair ahead of me down the short hallway into her bedroom—the exact same room where we had hidden six nights earlier—and patted the edge of her mattress beneath the framed blue butterfly print on the wall.

Just like we had done on that afternoon in seventh grade when Chad had dumped Katie in the cafeteria of Bayside Middle School—except with our roles completely reversed—we locked our wheelchair brakes side by side and transferred onto the edge of her bed.

As soon as I sat down, I buried my face in my hands, my shoulders shaking as the bitter sting of Heather's final words replayed in my ears.

Beside me, Katie didn't lecture me or tell me to tough it out. Instead, she wrapped both of her arms tightly around my shoulders, pulled my head down against her shoulder, and rested her cheek against my blonde hair while her hand rubbed slow, steady circles across my back.

"It isn't fair, Katie," I choked out against the sleeve of her sweater, my voice breaking in the quiet bedroom. "I didn't even know what she was talking about when I rolled up to her locker. We were sitting on this exact bed eating dry cereal out of a box to stay away from Tyler's booze, and she thinks I betrayed her."

"I know, Nate. I was right there with you every single second," Katie whispered fiercely, holding me with every ounce of strength in her seventeen-year-old arms. "Tyler is a vindictive jerk who couldn't stand that you wouldn't act like an idiot with him, and if Heather threw away everything she knew about your character over one drunk liar's story without even listening to the two of us, then she didn't deserve my brother's heart in the first place."

I lifted my head, wiping my eyes with the back of my wrist as I looked at my twin sister.

In seventh grade, when Chad had walked out on Katie and left her crying in the middle school hallway, I had held her right under that same framed blue butterfly print and promised her that I would never leave her behind. Now, five years later at seventeen—with both of our power wheelchairs parked side by side at the foot of the bed—Katie reached out, laced the fingers of her left hand tightly through my right hand, and gave me the exact same unbreakable anchor.

“Remember what you told me in seventh grade when Chad broke my heart, Nate?” Katie said softly, her blue eyes locked onto mine. “Boyfriends and girlfriends can walk away over a rumor in a sixty-second hallway conversation. Twin Sisters never walk away. You and I know the truth about who you are, and we’ve got each other for life.”

Taking a long, steadying breath, I squeezed Katie’s hand back and leaned my head against her shoulder until the shaking in my chest finally subsided—knowing beyond a shadow of a doubt that as we headed toward high school graduation and our adult lives together, the only person in the world I would ever completely trust was sitting right beside me.

Greenway Court, Apartment A6 & The Square Closet Sanctuary

Part 1: Apartment A6 on Greenway Court, Dad’s Microwave Cart, & Across-the-Hall Neighbors

Date: 2003-07-16 at 07:40 America/New_York

Wednesday, July 16, 2003, 7:40 AM — Dad’s Rolling Cart & Our Own Set of Keys in Apartment A6

“Careful with the power cord on the toaster, Nate—tuck it through the back wire loop so it can’t snag on your armrest when you turn around by the stove,” our father said cheerfully at twenty minutes to eight on Wednesday morning, tightening the last chrome corner bolt on the two-shelf rolling utility cart he had just assembled beside our tiny kitchenette counter.

Sitting side by side in our compact SwiftChair power wheelchairs inside Apartment A6, Katie and I watched with huge grins as Dad lifted our new countertop microwave onto the top shelf of the cart, set our two-slice chrome toaster right next to it, and plugged both cords into the wall outlet above the speckled laminate counter.

“Look at the clearance on that,” Katie said happily, rolling her wheelchair forward to test the reach. Without leaning an inch off her seat cushion, she popped open the microwave door with her left hand and tapped the toaster lever with her right. “Now we still have the whole counter square above the dorm fridge free for making sandwiches!”

“That’s the whole idea,” Dad smiled, wiping his forehead with the back of his sleeve as the through-wall box air conditioner mounted into the red brick directly below our wide, three-pane white-framed rear window hummed steadily in the July heat. “When a studio kitchen only gives you a four-burner stove, a single sink, and an under-the-counter dorm refrigerator, you two need every square inch of prep space at seated height.”

We had turned eighteen on April eighth and rolled across the graduation stage of Northwood High School a month ago in June. Because our estranged mother Brenda had spent the spring calling our dad’s house in Virginia Beach and threatening to

track us down the second we turned eighteen and were no longer covered by the family-court custody order, Dad had quietly gone apartment hunting across the city line in the tree-lined West Ghent neighborhood of Norfolk.

At the beginning of July, Dad had introduced us to Dave and Deb—the husband-and-wife landlords who owned this quiet, two-story flat-roofed red-brick building on Greenway Court, where Apartments A1 through A10 sat downstairs on the first floor and Apartments B1 through B10 sat upstairs on the second floor. Even better, Dad had signed the lease and paid the rent for Apartment A6 himself so that Katie and I could finally have a safe, independent home to call our own as eighteen-year-old college freshmen.

Every detail of the building and our studio fit our daily lives like a glove. Out front, beneath the black lamppost on the grass walkway, the building's recessed glass-and-aluminum main entrance door stayed locked twenty-four hours a day and required our brass apartment key to open—meaning nobody from the street could wander into the interior hallway uninvited. Just inside the front lobby past the row of locking metal mailboxes, Dave had bolted down a short, nonslip aluminum modular ramp over the three shallow rubber-treaded lobby steps so Katie and I could roll our power wheelchairs straight up into the first-floor hallway without a bump.

Down at the very back of the first-floor hallway—directly opposite Apartment A5—our wooden door opened into Apartment A6. All twenty apartments in the building shared the exact same enlarged bedroom-style rectangular studio layout, with units on opposite sides of the hallway like Apartment A5 and Apartment A6 built as exact mirror images of each other, giving us plenty of open floor space for two wheelchairs to pivot side by side. Against the side wall stood the full-sized bed we shared and our long workstation desk holding our shared desktop computer tower and seventeen-inch CRT monitor. Along the front corner sat our small kitchenette with its stove, sink, under-the-counter dorm fridge, and Dad's brand-new microwave-and-toaster cart. Tucked off to the side were two doors: one leading into our square walk-in closet with its soft carpeted floor, and the other opening into an accessible bathroom equipped with a roll-under sink, a toilet, and a standing shower where Dad had placed a sturdy padded transfer bench and a handheld shower sprayer within easy reach.

"Alright, you two, I've got to get across the river to work before traffic backs up on Interstate 264," Dad said, picking up his tool bag and kissing the top of Katie's head before squeezing my shoulder. "Remember, keep the front lobby door latched behind you whenever you go out to catch the Route 2 bus on Hampton Boulevard, and call me tonight after you test out the microwave."

"Thank you for the cart, Dad—and for giving us our own place," I said, rolling beside Katie to walk him to the door.

"You two earned it," Dad said warmly. "Have a great morning."

Wednesday, July 16, 2003, 7:48 AM — Familiar Faces Across the Hall in Apartment A5

“Come on, Nate—let’s roll out with Dad as far as the front sidewalk while the morning air is still cool,” Katie suggested, slipping her brass Greenway Court key lanyard around her wrist. “I want to see how the cell signal is out by the grassy field across the street before we call CCHR about our fall books.”

“Good call,” I agreed, glancing at the single bar of reception on my flip phone—the thick red-brick walls of the Greenway Court building blocked half the cellular towers in West Ghent whenever we were inside Apartment A6.

I pulled our wooden apartment door open, rolled my SwiftChair out into the quiet first-floor hallway right behind Dad and Katie, and turned to pull our deadbolt shut.

At that exact second, the heavy deadbolt of Apartment A5—directly across the narrow back hallway from our door—let out a loud metallic thunk.

The door to Apartment A5 swung open, and out stepped a slender eighteen-year-old guy with reddish-blond hair, wire-rimmed glasses, and a stiff, slightly uneven gait in his legs, flanked closely by an athletic eighteen-year-old girl with a protective posture and her hand steadying his elbow.

For two full seconds, all four of us froze in the back hallway between Apartment A5 and Apartment A6.

I stared at the guy’s wire-rimmed glasses and the unmistakable way he stood shoulder-to-shoulder with the girl beside him. He stared down at our two compact SwiftChair power wheelchairs, then up at Katie’s and my matching platinum-blonde hair.

“Wait a second,” I blinked, my jaw dropping as nine years of neighborhood and school memories clicked into place at once. “Michael? Michael Ragsdale?!”

Behind his wire-rimmed glasses, Michael’s eyes went wide with genuine shock, and the tight, guarded tension in his shoulders vanished on the spot.

“Nathaniel? Katie?!” Michael said, recognizing us immediately from three doors down on Delaney Street and our childhood two-week summer camp at Virginia Dominion University—as well as the hallways of Northwood High School, where all of us had just graduated a month earlier. “You two live in A6?!”

“We just moved in at the start of the month!” Katie beamed, rolling her wheelchair half a foot closer to shake hands with Michael and with Ashley Raybourn, whom we recognized from our graduating class at Northwood High. “Our dad rented A6 for the two of us so we’d have our own place near the Route 2 bus line! Don’t tell me you two just moved into A5?!”

“We literally got the keys from Deb last night,” Ashley laughed, a huge, relieved smile breaking across her face as she looked from Katie and me to our dad. “We were just heading outside across the street to the grassy field so we could get three bars of cell service to call Michael’s mom before the moving truck gets here at nine.”

“That’s the exact reason we were rolling outside right now!” I grinned, holding up my flip phone with its lone, stubborn bar of signal. “The brick walls in the back of the building eat every cell signal alive!”

Dad chuckled warmly, shaking Michael’s and Ashley’s hands in the hallway before we all headed down the corridor together, rolled smoothly down Dave’s nonslip aluminum ramp over the three rubber-coated lobby steps, and pushed out through the locked glass-and-aluminum front entrance door into the sunny July morning.

While Dad waved goodbye from his pickup truck in the decal-controlled parking lot, Katie and I rolled across the quiet street with Michael and Ashley to the open grassy field where neighbors were walking their dogs among the slatted wooden benches. Parking our two power wheelchairs right flush against the ends of the wooden bench where Michael and Ashley sat pressed side by side, we spent the next twenty minutes catching up like old teammates—talking about how Michael’s sisters Jessica and Rachel were out in Washington State, how Katie and I were starting our freshman classes together at the Community College of Hampton Roads on the bus, and how relieved both pairs of us were to have a locked front building door and a quiet rectangular studio where nobody could bother us.

When we finally waved to Michael and Ashley as they headed off to meet Michael’s mom and the moving truck, Katie and I rolled back across Greenway Court, unlocked the glass front door with our brass key, and wheeled back into the cool, air-conditioned sanctuary of Apartment A6.

“Can you believe that, Nate?” Katie smiled as the deadbolt clicked shut behind us and the aroma of fresh toast drifted from our new rolling cart in the kitchenette. “Out of every apartment building in the entire city of Norfolk, our old neighbor from Delaney Street and VDU summer camp is right across the hall from us in A5.”

“Best across-the-hall neighbors we could ever ask for,” I agreed, parking my wheelchair beside hers at our shared computer workstation desk.

Part 2: Brenda in the Back Alley, Hiding in the Square Closet, & A Happy Year Together

Date: 2003-08-09 at 20:45 America/New_York

Saturday, August 9, 2003, 8:45 PM — Footsteps Behind the Exterior Iron Stairs & Hiding in the Square Closet

“Wait—turn the speakers down, Nate,” Katie whispered sharply at a quarter to nine on Saturday evening, her hand dropping onto my wrist over the computer mouse. “Listen.”

I clicked the mute icon on our seventeen-inch CRT monitor at the shared workstation desk, leaving only the low, steady hum of the through-wall box air conditioner mounted into the brick below our wide three-pane rear window.

Outside in the narrow first-floor back alley—right behind the black iron exterior fire-escape staircase that climbed the rear brick wall of 801 Greenway Court beside the bushes and trash bins—an angry, slurred woman’s voice echoed off the brick.

“I know their father rented them an apartment in this building!” our estranged mother Brenda’s voice rasped in the humid August dusk, followed by the crunch of her shoes on the gravel behind the iron stairs. “Stupid locked front door won’t even let a mother into the lobby to see her own eighteen-year-old kids! Katie! Nathaniel! Which window is yours?!”

My blood turned to ice water in my veins. Beside me at the computer desk, Katie’s fingers clamped around my forearm so tightly I could feel her pulse racing against my skin.

Even though we had kept the white horizontal mini-blinds tilted shut over the wide three-pane window above our through-wall air conditioner, Apartment A6 sat on the first floor at the very back of the building. If Brenda stepped two paces past the black iron exterior stairs and pressed her face against the glass beside the bushes, even the faintest glow from our desk lamp or our computer monitor would tell her immediately that Apartment A6 was ours—and she would bang on our back window and scream in the alley all night long.

“Kill the lamp and the monitor,” Katie breathed silently in my ear, her voice barely above a whisper. “If the room is pitch dark and dead silent when she looks through the blinds, she’ll think the apartment is empty.”

In less than three seconds, I reached behind the tower to flip the master rocker switch on our surge protector—plunging the CRT monitor and the desk lamp into instant darkness—while Katie clicked off the small stove hood light over the kitchenette.

Outside in the back alley, Brenda’s footsteps crunched closer toward the iron stairs, her knuckles rapping sharply against one of the rear brick window frames down the wall.

“The square closet,” Katie whispered, pointing through the shadows toward our open closet door. “Grab the sleeping bag and the pillows off the bed—if we’re inside the closet with the door closed, she won’t see a single shadow or hear our chairs even if she shines a flashlight through the window slats.”

Moving in silent, practiced twin synchronization, I pulled our soft navy-blue sleeping bag and two pillows off the full-sized bed while Katie guided us across the dark studio carpet to the doorway of our square walk-in closet. Quickly spreading the sleeping bag and pillows flat across the square carpeted floor inside the closet, Katie and I parked our two compact SwiftChair power wheelchairs side by side just outside the closet frame, switched both joystick controllers completely off so their green battery-level LEDs wouldn’t glow in the dark, and transferred smoothly down onto the closet floor.

Reaching up from inside the shared sleeping bag, I pulled the solid wooden closet door shut until the latch clicked softly into place.

Inside the square closet, the darkness was total and absolute.

Katie immediately turned on her side inside the sleeping bag, wrapped both arms tightly around my shoulders, and pulled my head against her chest while I wrapped my arms around her waist—holding each other with every ounce of steady, deep-pressure warmth we had so neither of us would tremble or make a sound.

Thirty seconds later, through the muffled layers of the closed closet door and the rear brick wall, we heard Brenda's footsteps stop right behind the exterior iron staircase outside our back window, just above our humming through-wall air conditioner.

We heard her fingernails tap twice against the exterior glass of Apartment A6. We heard her mutter a bitter curse under her breath when she saw nothing but dark, empty blinds and heard nothing over the drone of the air-conditioning compressor. Two minutes later, her footsteps retreated down the back alley toward Raleigh Avenue, and the distant slam of a car door told us she had finally given up and driven away.

Even after the alley went quiet, neither Katie nor I moved to open the closet door.

Wrapped together inside our shared sleeping bag on the carpeted floor of that small, enclosed square closet, something remarkable happened to our nineteen-thousand-rpm fight-or-flight nervous systems. Out in the open studio room, the streetlamp shadows on the blinds and the knowledge that someone could walk down the back alley always left a tiny background thread of vigilance running in our autistic brains. Inside the enclosed four walls of the square closet, zipped up together in the velvet dark with Katie's arms locked securely around me, the outside world couldn't touch us at all.

"Are you okay, Nate?" Katie whispered against my hair in the pitch dark, her hand rubbing slow, soothing circles between my shoulder blades.

"More than okay," I whispered back, letting out a long, sleepy breath as every tense muscle in my back and legs finally melted into the carpet. "It's so quiet in here, Katie. I actually feel completely safe."

"Me too," Katie murmured, resting her chin against my forehead as a soft yawn escaped her lips. "We don't have to move back out to the bed tonight if you don't want to. Let's just stay right here in our little fortress."

Resting my head against my twin sister's shoulder inside our shared sleeping bag on the square closet floor, I closed my eyes—and for the first time since moving out on our own, both of us slept nine uninterrupted hours straight through the night without waking up once.

From that August night forward, that compact square closet literally became our bedroom. Yes, we still had our full-sized bed out in the main studio apartment, kept neatly made up under its quilt—but it rarely ever got used. For both of us on the autism spectrum, sleeping cuddled up together inside our single shared sleeping bag in the snug, confined space of the closet made us feel completely secure in a way an open room never could—a habit that would stay with the two of us for the rest of our lives.

Wednesday, November 12, 2003, 5:30 PM — Dad's Microwave Cart, Shared Code, & A Happy Year in Our Studio Sanctuary

By late autumn and winter of our eighteenth year, life inside Apartment A6 on Greenway Court had settled into the happiest, most peaceful routine Katie and I had ever known.

Every morning, after waking up well-rested inside our shared sleeping bag on the carpeted floor of our square closet bedroom—while the full-sized bed out in the main studio stayed smooth and untouched—we used the padded transfer bench in our accessible shower, brushed our teeth side by side at the roll-under bathroom sink, and rolled out to our compact kitchenette. While I popped four slices of whole-wheat bread into the toaster on Dad's rolling utility cart and pulled the milk carton and butter out of the under-the-counter dorm fridge, Katie scrambled eggs on the four-burner stove, and we washed our plates and skillet in the sink the minute we finished eating.

Whenever we headed out our door and down Dave's nonslip aluminum ramp through the locked front lobby, we waved to Michael Ragsdale and his one-eyed black Lab Archie across the hall in Apartment A5 before rolling down Greenway Court and Redgate Avenue to Hampton Boulevard to catch the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority Route 2 bus into Downtown Norfolk. Side by side in the front wheelchair bays of the bus, we rode ten minutes downtown to the Martin Building at the Community College of Hampton Roads Norfolk campus for our morning lectures, grabbed hot burgers and fries upstairs at the third-floor food court of The Admiral Center on Fridays, and rode the afternoon Route 2 bus right back home to West Ghent.

In the evenings, while the radiators and the through-wall fan kept our rectangular studio cozy and warm, Katie and I parked our SwiftChairs side by side at our long workstation desk in front of our shared desktop computer. Taking turns at the keyboard while the other sister or brother read aloud from our textbooks or debugged lines of HTML and Quantum Basic code on the seventeen-inch CRT monitor, we had everything we needed under one roof: four locked walls, a full kitchen cart, our own bus passes, and each other.

The Admiral Center Bookstore & Meeting Tiffany

Part 1: Death by Cascading Style Sheets & Iced Cocoa at Chapters & Co.

Date: 2004-05-14 at 15:15 America/New_York

Friday, May 14, 2004, 3:15 PM — The Computer Books Aisle at Chapters & Co.

"Two tall iced cocoas with extra whipped cream, coming right up—go pick out the web-design book you want for the summer, Nate, and I'll meet you in the computer aisle!" Katie called out cheerfully over her shoulder, steering her compact SwiftChair power wheelchair up to the lowered marble counter of the café inside Chapters & Co. on the ground floor of The Admiral Center.

"Deal!" I grinned, turning my matching power wheelchair down the wide carpeted bookstore corridor toward the Computer & Internet shelves.

Katie and I had just turned nineteen a month earlier on April eighth, and twenty minutes ago we had walked—or rather, rolled—out of our final spring-semester exam across the street at the Downtown Norfolk campus of the Community College of Hampton Roads. Nearly a full year had passed since Dad had rented Apartment

A6 on Greenway Court for the two of us, and life in our West Ghent studio had settled into the happiest, most comfortable rhythm we had ever known. Every weekday morning, Katie and I rode the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority Route 2 bus down Hampton Boulevard to our college classes; every afternoon, we rolled home to our locked red-brick building, waved to Michael in Apartment A5 across the hall whenever we crossed paths by the lobby mailboxes, made honey-ham sandwiches beside Dad's rolling microwave cart, and spent our evenings side by side at our shared desktop computer writing HTML websites.

Braking my wheelchair between the towering oak bookshelves of the programming section, I scanned the rows of thick technical manuals until my eyes landed on a fat, eight-hundred-page paperback near the upper-middle shelf titled *Cascading Style Sheets & Dynamic Web Design*.

It sat just an inch higher than my normal seated reach. Checking to make sure my wheels were locked, I braced my left hand on my armrest pad and stretched my right arm up from my seat cushion, hooking my index finger over the top edge of the spine to slide the heavy book out.

As I tilted the paperback forward, a second copy that had been wedged crookedly beside it slipped loose from the shelf and tipped straight toward my lap.

Before I could pull my hand back to catch both volumes at once, someone stepped smoothly into the aisle beside my right wheel and caught the falling book cleanly in midair with both hands.

"Whoa—careful! Death by cascading style sheets is a terrible way to start the weekend," a warm, playful voice laughed right beside me.

I blinked and looked up. Standing next to my wheelchair was a girl who looked to be about twenty, with a heavier build, shoulder-length dark reddish-brown hair cut with neat bangs across her forehead, and black-rimmed rectangular glasses framing a bright, friendly smile. Tucking the rescued copy back onto the shelf with one hand, she held out the copy I had been reaching for with the other.

"Here you go," she said warmly, handing the heavy paperback right into my hands at chest height without a trace of awkwardness. "I saw that second one teetering on the edge from the end of the aisle."

"Thank you," I said, feeling my ears warm slightly as my social scripts scrambled to catch up. Since Heather Collins had dumped me in the hallway of Northwood High School back in January of our senior year over my cousin Brittany's New Year's Eve party rumor, I hadn't spoken to a girl my age outside of college group projects. "I didn't realize the two copies were stuck together."

"Those thick computer books are practically bricks," an older woman with a kind, maternal smile agreed as she stepped up behind the girl, carrying a bookstore shopping bag over her forearm.

"Oh, I'm Tiffany, by the way—Tiffany Sloan," the girl said, adjusting her black-rimmed glasses with a small, endearing laugh before extending her hand to shake mine. "And this is my mom, Sandra."

"I'm Nathaniel—Nate Prairie," I said, shaking Tiffany's hand and nodding politely to her mother.

Instead of turning away the way most strangers did after a polite aisle interaction, Tiffany glanced down at the cover of *Cascading Style Sheets & Dynamic Web Design* resting across my lap, and her eyes lit up behind her glasses.

“Wait—do you actually know how to build websites?” Tiffany asked, sounding genuinely impressed. “Like, writing the real code from scratch?”

Speaking about HTML and CSS was the one topic on earth that bypassed every ounce of my shyness.

“Yeah, my twin sister and I have been hand-coding HTML since we were in seventh grade at Morrison Middle School,” I said, my posture brightening immediately. “We’ve been using HTML tables for page layouts, and we’re switching everything over to CSS positioning this summer now that spring finals at CCHR are done.”

“No way!” Tiffany beamed. “I’ve been trying to put together a simple little webpage on my computer at home for weeks, and every time I try to line up a picture next to a paragraph, the whole page jumps to the bottom of the screen! I came over to this aisle looking for a beginner book, and half of them look like they’re written in ancient Greek.”

“That’s usually just an unclosed table cell tag or an image alignment attribute,” I explained eagerly, opening the paperback on my lap to a diagram of floating div containers. “Once you see how container boxes work, it’s super logical.”

At that exact moment, the quiet hum of electric wheelchair motors rounded the corner of the bookshelf, and Katie rolled into the aisle balancing a cardboard four-cup carrier on her lap with two tall plastic cups of iced cocoa topped with swirled domes of whipped cream.

“Got our celebratory cocoas, Nate—zero coffee, extra chocolate drizzle!” Katie announced happily before spotting Tiffany and Sandra standing beside my chair. “Oh! Hi!”

Out of pure lifelong habit, I braced myself for the micro-expression we saw from ninety percent of the public whenever they realized there were two of us in identical compact power wheelchairs.

Tiffany didn’t blink, stare, or take a step back. Instead, her face broke into an even wider, delighted smile.

“Katie, this is Tiffany Sloan and her mom, Sandra,” I introduced them proudly. “Tiffany just saved me from getting clobbered by a falling eight-hundred-page CSS manual. Tiffany, Sandra—this is my twin sister, Katie.”

“Hi, Katie! It is so nice to meet you!” Tiffany said, shaking Katie’s free hand with warm enthusiasm. “Nate was literally just telling me that the two of you have been coding websites together since seventh grade and just finished your freshman finals at CCHR!”

“Last exam turned in twenty minutes ago,” Katie grinned, immediately warming to Tiffany’s friendly, unhurried energy. “And knowing my brother, he was already explaining unclosed HTML tags before he even said hello.”

Tiffany laughed out loud, looking between the two of us with genuine admiration. “Are you kidding? I think it’s amazing! Wait—do you two take all your classes together too?”

“Every single one,” Katie said proudly, glancing over at me. “And we share a studio apartment over in West Ghent on Greenway Court.”

“Are you serious?! That is so cool!” Tiffany said, placing a hand over her heart. “My younger brother and I are super close too. Honestly, I always say family comes first, no matter what. When a brother and sister look out for each other the way you two do, that shows what kind of heart a person has. If a guy isn’t close with his sister, that’s a giant red flag in my book!”

Beside me, I saw Katie’s shoulders relax completely, a bright, unmistakable smile of approval lighting up her blue eyes. To both of us, hearing someone say out loud that a close brother-and-sister bond was something wonderful—rather than something strange—felt like passing the most important test in the world.

Friday, May 14, 2004, 3:35 PM — Café Chairs, A Sudden May Cloudburst, & The Umbrella over Our Joysticks

“Well, if you two aren’t in a rush to catch your bus right this second, why don’t we sit down in the café for a few minutes while you drink your iced cocoas?” Sandra suggested warmly, gesturing toward the open tables near the front windows of Chapters & Co. “Tiffany and I were just about to grab a lemonade.”

“We’d love that,” Katie said at once, looking at me for confirmation.

“Definitely,” I nodded.

We rolled back out of the computer aisle to the checkout counter so I could pay for the CSS paperback, and then headed over to a round four-top table in the bookstore café. Before Katie or I even had to ask, Tiffany stepped ahead of our wheelchairs, lifted two of the heavy wooden café chairs away from the table, and tucked them neatly against the wall so Katie and I could roll right up to the table edge side by side with plenty of elbow room.

Katie caught my eye across our armrests and gave me a subtle, approving nod. Almost nobody thought to clear two chairs from a restaurant table without making a big show out of it.

For the next forty minutes, while Tiffany and her mother sipped iced lemonades and Katie and I drank our iced cocoas, the conversation flowed without a single awkward pause. Tiffany asked Katie what her favorite classes at CCHR had been, laughed at our story about how our dad had assembled a rolling microwave-and-toaster cart in our Greenway Court kitchenette because our studio only had an under-the-counter dorm fridge, and listened with rapt attention as Katie and I took turns explaining how we formatted our shared computer desktop.

When I glanced at my watch at four-fifteen, I saw that the afternoon sky outside The Admiral Center’s glass rotunda had turned the dark slate-gray of a sudden May coastal thunderstorm.

“We should probably head up to Monticello and Charlotte so we catch the four-thirty Route 2 bus back to West Ghent before the sky opens up,” Katie said, tucking her empty cocoa cup into the trash bin beside the café exit.

“Which way is your stop?” Tiffany asked as the four of us stepped out through the mall’s sliding glass doors onto the downtown sidewalk.

“Just one block north up Monticello Avenue,” I said.

Right as our front caster wheels cleared the mall awning, the first fat drops of warm May rain began pattering against the concrete. We couldn’t load our heavy motorized SwiftChairs into a standard family minivan without a hydraulic lift, which meant the Route 2 bus was our only way home—and the one part of a power wheelchair that hated getting rained on was the electronic joystick controller mounted on the right armrest.

“Oh, don’t let the rain get on your controls!” Sandra said immediately, popping open a wide, oversized navy-blue golf umbrella from her tote bag while Tiffany pulled a second compact umbrella out of her purse.

Without hesitation, Tiffany stepped right alongside my right armrest and angled her open umbrella directly over my head and my right-hand joystick controller, while Sandra walked beside Katie’s wheelchair holding the big golf umbrella over Katie’s head and joystick.

Walking shoulder-to-wheel with us down the block to the covered glass bus shelter at Monticello and Charlotte, Tiffany kept her umbrella steady over my armrest until both of our wheelchairs were safely parked underneath the dry acrylic roof of the transit shelter.

“Thank you so much, both of you,” Katie said warmly, wiping a single raindrop off her sleeve. “Most people just sprint for their car when it starts raining.”

“What are friends for?” Tiffany smiled, shaking out her umbrella and tucking a lock of dark reddish-brown hair behind her ear as she looked down at me through her black-rimmed glasses. Reaching into her purse, she pulled out a ballpoint pen and a cardstock bookmark from Chapters & Co., scribbled her name and phone number across the back in neat handwriting, and handed it to me.

“Here’s my number, Nate,” Tiffany said softly, her cheeks turning a pretty pink. “If you and Katie aren’t busy tomorrow afternoon, maybe my mom could drop me off over at your building in West Ghent? I could bring over a big cheese pizza from Gianni’s for the three of us, and you two could show me how to fix my webpage!”

My heart did a sudden, weightless flip in my chest as I looked from the bookmark in my hand to Katie.

“Saturday pizza and HTML debugging sounds awesome to us,” Katie beamed, answering for both of us without missing a beat. “Just call Nate’s cell when you pull into the Greenway Court lot tomorrow so we can come down to the lobby and unlock the front door for you.”

Down the block, the amber destination sign of our CVTA Route 2 bus rounded the corner onto Monticello Avenue, its air brakes hissing as it pulled flush to the curb and kneeled.

“There’s our bus,” I said, slipping Tiffany’s bookmark carefully into my shirt pocket right over my heart before pulling out my flip phone so we could trade numbers.

As the bus driver deployed the front hydraulic wheelchair ramp onto the sidewalk and Katie rolled aboard first to turn into the rear securement bay, Tiffany leaned down beside my wheelchair. Wrapping both arms around my shoulders, she pulled me into a warm, remarkably firm hug—pressing her cheek against mine with a steady, comforting weight that made my whole chest glow.

“I’m really glad that book almost fell on you today, Nate,” Tiffany whispered against my ear before straightening up and waving to Katie through the open bus doors. “It was so great meeting both of you! I’ll call you tomorrow morning!”

“See you tomorrow, Tiffany! Bye, Sandra!” Katie called out from the wheelchair bay with a huge wave as I rolled up the hydraulic ramp right behind my twin sister.

As the Route 2 bus pulled away from the curb and headed toward West Ghent through the May sun-shower, Katie reached across the aisle between our two secured wheelchairs, squeezed my hand, and grinned from ear to ear.

“Did you see how she cleared those café chairs and held her umbrella right over your joystick, Nate?” Katie said, her eyes shining with genuine happiness for me. “And she wants to bring pizza over for the three of us tomorrow! I think she really, really likes you.”

Part 2: Saturday Pizza in Apartment A6 & Katie’s Wholehearted Blessing

Date: 2004-05-15 at 13:00 America/New_York

Saturday, May 15, 2004, 1:00 PM — Pizza, Floppy Disks, & HTML in Apartment A6

“She’s pulling into the parking lot right now!” I said at one o’clock on Saturday afternoon, peeking through the white mini-blinds after my flip phone rang with a single bar of signal by our window.

“Come on—let’s roll out to the front lobby together to let her in,” Katie smiled, smoothing down the hem of her royal-blue sweater as she checked our studio one last time.

We had spent the morning tidying every corner of Apartment A6 until our rectangular studio gleamed. Our full-sized bed was neatly made against the side wall, the speckled laminate counter above our under-the-counter dorm fridge was wiped spotless beside Dad’s rolling microwave-and-toaster cart, and our shared desktop computer was booted up at our long workstation desk.

Rolling down the first-floor hallway and down Dave’s nonslip aluminum ramp over the three rubber-treaded lobby steps, I unlocked the building’s 24/7 keyed glass-and-aluminum front door right as Tiffany stepped up the front walkway past the circular brick lamppost planter, carrying a steaming cardboard pizza box in both hands while her mother Sandra waved warmly to us from the driver’s window of their minivan in the parking lot.

“Hey, you two!” Tiffany beamed, stepping into the cool lobby as Sandra pulled out of the lot to run afternoon errands. “One large extra-cheese pizza and a two-liter bottle of ginger ale—Nate told me yesterday at the bookstore that the two of you don’t drink alcohol or like the taste of coffee, and that ginger ale is one of your favorite sodas with pizza, so I made sure to grab a cold bottle!”

Katie and I exchanged an instant, delighted look. Remembering a detail like our ginger-ale rule from a single conversation the day before meant everything to us.

“You remembered!” Katie said warmly as we led Tiffany up the short aluminum ramp and down the first-floor corridor to the back of the building. “Right this way—we’re in A6, right across the hall from our old neighborhood friend Michael in A5.”

When I unlocked our wooden door and held it open for Tiffany to step inside Apartment A6, she paused in the center of the carpet and looked around our studio with an appreciative smile.

“Look how nice and neat you two keep this place!” Tiffany said, setting the warm pizza box down on our kitchenette counter next to Dad’s rolling microwave cart. “Seriously, Katie, you can tell a girl who cares about organization lives here—there isn’t a single dish in the sink, and look at that microwave cart your dad put together!”

“Wait until you see the walk-in closet and the roll-under bathroom sink,” Katie said proudly, grabbing three paper plates and three plastic cups from the cabinet above our stove before pouring cold ginger ale for all three of us.

After we ate two slices of warm cheese pizza apiece, Katie washed our three plastic cups in the kitchenette sink right away—following our house rule of washing dishes as we go—and Tiffany pulled a blue three-and-a-half-inch floppy disk out of her purse.

“Okay, Professor Nate and Professor Katie,” Tiffany laughed, holding up the floppy disk as she walked over to our long computer workstation desk. “Don’t laugh at my messy code, okay? I brought my HTML file on disk so you two could show me what I did wrong.”

Because our studio didn’t have extra desk chairs—since Katie and I always sat side by side at the workstation in our compact SwiftChair power wheelchairs—Tiffany didn’t ask to sit on our bed across the room. Instead, she kneeled right down on the soft carpet between our two wheelchairs so her black-rimmed glasses were at the exact same eye level as ours while I slid her blue floppy disk into the A: drive of our desktop tower.

Opening her index.html file in a plain-text editor on our seventeen-inch CRT monitor, Katie and I spotted the bug on line forty-two at the exact same second.

“There it is,” Katie pointed at the screen with a friendly grin. “You opened a second table row right here without closing the first table cell.”

“And look what happens when we replace that nested table with two simple CSS float blocks from the book you caught for me yesterday,” I said, typing out a clean ten-line stylesheet block and hitting refresh in the browser window.

On the monitor, Tiffany's jumbled pictures and text snapped into a clean, centered two-column page layout.

"No way! You two fixed that in thirty seconds!" Tiffany gasped, clapping her hands together before turning on the carpet and wrapping one arm around my shoulders and the other arm around Katie's shoulders in a spontaneous three-way group hug. "You guys are absolute geniuses! I wish I had half the brains the two of you have."

For the rest of the afternoon, the three of us stayed right there in Apartment A6 like we had known each other for years. Tiffany listened attentively as I walked her through every CSS property in the new manual, asked Katie about the fall course schedule at the Community College of Hampton Roads, and laughed whenever Katie and I finished each other's sentences. Not once did Tiffany act impatient, not once did she try to pull me away from my twin sister, and when Sandra called at five o'clock from the parking lot out front to pick her up, Tiffany helped Katie fold up the empty pizza box before giving both Katie and me a warm goodbye hug in the hallway.

Saturday, May 15, 2004, 5:20 PM — "You Deserve Someone Who Makes You Happy, Nate"

When we rolled back up the lobby ramp after watching Sandra's minivan turn off Greenway Court and locked the deadbolt of Apartment A6 behind us, I parked my wheelchair beside our computer desk, still feeling the warm glow of Tiffany's hug in my chest.

Across the room by the kitchenette, Katie pivoted her SwiftChair around, rolled right up beside me, and took my left hand in hers.

"Well?" I asked quietly, looking into my twin sister's blue eyes—because in nineteen years of life, I had never made a single major decision without knowing what Katie thought first. "What did you think of her, Katie?"

Katie's face softened into the warmest, most genuine smile I had ever seen.

"I really like her, Nate," Katie said wholeheartedly, giving my hand a reassuring squeeze. "She brought ginger ale just for us, she sat right down on the carpet between our chairs so we were all together at the computer, and she didn't act weird for a single second about how close you and I are. After how unfair Heather was to you in high school over a rumor that wasn't even true, you deserve someone sweet and patient who makes you happy."

A huge wave of relief and excitement washed through my chest. Having a girl like Tiffany smile at me and hold my hand felt wonderful—but having my twin sister's complete, enthusiastic blessing made the whole world feel safe.

"She asked if we wanted to hang out with her again next weekend," I said, smiling back at Katie.

"Then you should call her tonight and tell her yes," Katie beamed, resting her head briefly against my shoulder the way we always did when everything in our world was right. "Everything is going to be great, Nate."

Part 3: Tiffany's Pitch for Our Own Place in Ocean View & The Promise of Brother-and-Sister Weekends

Date: 2004-08-14 at 14:30 America/New_York

Saturday, August 14, 2004, 2:30 PM — "Just One Route 1 Bus Ride Up Granby Street"

"Look at the floor plan in this rental brochure my mom picked up for us yesterday, Nate," nineteen-year-old Tiffany Sloan said warmly on a sunny Saturday afternoon in mid-August, spreading a folded one-page apartment flyer across the corner of our computer workstation desk inside Apartment A6 on Greenway Court while handing Katie and me two cold cans of orange soda from our dorm fridge. "It's a ground-floor one-bedroom apartment right by the beach at a quiet courtyard complex called Sea Breeze West on West Ocean View Avenue."

Sitting side by side in our compact SwiftChair power wheelchairs at the workstation desk, Katie and I looked down at the printed flyer together.

Three months had passed since that Friday afternoon in May when Tiffany had caught the falling CSS manual for me at Chapters & Co. inside The Admiral Center, and through the entire summer of 2004, Tiffany had been everything a nineteen-year-old guy who had never had a real girlfriend could have hoped for. Every weekend she had come over to Apartment A6 to watch movies, eat pizza with cold ginger ale or fruit juice, and sit between our wheelchairs while I worked on HTML templates. Whenever our dad David had driven down from Northern Virginia to take us out to dinner, Tiffany had been polite and respectful, and she had never once complained about how close Katie and I were.

Now, with the fall semester at the Community College of Hampton Roads approaching at the end of August, Tiffany rested her hand affectionately on my shoulder and looked from my face to Katie's with a gentle, understanding smile behind her black-rimmed glasses.

"I love coming over here to visit you two in West Ghent," Tiffany said softly, "and I know how special this studio has been for the two of you since you turned eighteen. But let's be honest—Apartment A6 is a single-room studio with one full-sized bed and no bedroom walls. Now that Nate and I have been dating all summer and getting serious, it's really hard for a boyfriend and girlfriend to have any normal couple privacy in a studio apartment with three people in one room, and my mom keeps hounding me at home about when I'm going to get my own apartment."

I looked across my armrest at Katie. For nineteen years—from our cribs in Virginia Beach to the house on Delaney Street, through the Friday afternoon at Northwood High School when our legs gave out within three hours of each other, and through every night since April eighth zipped inside our shared sleeping bag on the carpeted floor of the square walk-in closet four feet behind us—Katie and I had never once lived under separate roofs.

Seeing the hesitation tighten around my eyes and Katie's, Tiffany immediately knelt down on the carpet between our two wheelchairs, just like she had done on her very first Saturday afternoon in Apartment A6, and took one of Katie's hands and one of mine.

“Hey—look at me, both of you,” Tiffany said in her sweetest, most reassuring voice. “Nobody is talking about separating the two of you or breaking up your routine. Do you know why my mom and I picked Sea Breeze West on West Ocean View Avenue instead of looking over in Portsmouth or Chesapeake? Look at the bus stop right down at the corner of West Ocean View Avenue and Duffy’s Lane.”

Tiffany tapped her fingernail against the hand-drawn map at the bottom of the rental flyer.

“It’s right on CVTA Route 1 and Route 3,” Tiffany beamed. “That’s a single, direct one-seat bus ride straight down Granby Street and Princess Anne Road to right here in West Ghent! No transfers, no bridges, and no tunnels—just thirty-five minutes on the bus. Katie gets to have all of Apartment A6 to herself without two other people crowding her kitchenette and bathroom, Nate and I get a real one-bedroom apartment with a big green living-room sofa right by the front windows, and you two still take your classes together at CCHR during the week.”

“What about weekends?” Katie asked quietly, looking straight into Tiffany’s eyes behind her glasses. “Nate and I have spent every weekend together our whole lives.”

“And you’re still going to!” Tiffany promised without a second’s hesitation, squeezing Katie’s fingers warmly. “That’s the best part of having a real living room with a big three-cushion green sofa at Sea Breeze West! Whenever you two want a Brother-and-Sister Weekend—just the two of you hanging out, coding on Nate’s computer, and eating pizza all weekend long—Katie can hop right on the Route 1 bus on Friday or Saturday, roll straight into Apartment 3, and sleep right on the green sofa! You two won’t miss a single beat.”

Across our armrests, Katie looked at me.

I could see that my twin sister was going to miss having me right beside her every night in Apartment A6 just as much as I was going to miss her. Yet because Tiffany was smiling so warmly, holding both of our hands on the carpet, and promising up and down that West Ocean View was only one Route 1 bus ride away and that our Brother-and-Sister Weekends would always be sacred, Katie didn’t want to stand in the way of me having my first real adult relationship.

“Thirty-five minutes on Route 1 really isn’t far at all, Nate,” Katie said bravely, offering me the same supportive smile she had given me back in May. “And since Dad already paid the lease here on Apartment A6 through next spring while your disability check and Tiffany’s job cover the rent up at Sea Breeze West, we’ll see each other at CCHR during the week and have our Brother-and-Sister Weekends in Ocean View.”

“Are you sure you’ll be okay here in A6 by yourself at night, Katie?” I asked, my throat tightening slightly as I glanced toward our square walk-in closet. “Michael and Ashley are right across the hall in A5 if you ever need anything, and you can call my flip phone anytime day or night.”

“I’ll be fine, Nate,” Katie said, leaning across our armrests to hug me tight. “You found a girlfriend who understands how close we are and already planned out the bus route so we can spend weekends together. Go sign the lease—and next month in September, as soon as you two get your boxes unpacked, I’m riding the Route 1 bus up to Ocean View Station for our very first Brother-and-Sister Weekend.”

“It’s a date!” Tiffany chirped, hugging both of us around the shoulders. “Wait until you see the green sofa, Katie—you’re going to love it!”

Two weeks later, at the end of August 2004, Dad drove down from Northern Virginia with his SUV to help load my desktop tower PC, my seventeen-inch CRT monitor, and my clothes up to Apartment 3 on the ground floor of the white-painted courtyard building at Sea Breeze West on West Ocean View Avenue, while setting up a second desktop computer for Katie at the workstation desk in Apartment A6 so we could message each other every evening.

When Dad and I rolled out the keyed glass front door of the Greenway Court building that afternoon, Katie smiled and waved to me from the lobby window in her compact SwiftChair, holding up two crossed fingers—our lifelong twin signal for *see you soon*—as we counted down the days until our first Brother-and-Sister Weekend in September.

West Ocean View & Reclaiming Our Sanctuary

Ocean View Station, Dirty Old Tonomy Hill, & Five Buses from Williamsburg

Part 1: Ocean View Station, The Green Sofa Confrontation, & Speak Now or Forever Hold Your Peace

Date: 2004-09-18 at 19:30 America/New_York

Saturday, September 18, 2004, 7:30 PM — Ocean View Station & The Green Sofa Confrontation at Sea Breeze West

“This is going to be a great weekend,” I said, rolling my compact SwiftChair power wheelchair right up to the curb cut at Ocean View Station as the hydraulic front ramp of the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority Route 1 bus folded down onto the concrete and my nineteen-year-old twin sister Katie wheeled off the bus straight into my arms.

Wearing her favorite royal-blue long-sleeve V-neck sweater with black trim at the collar and cuffs and light-blue jeans, with an overnight backpack clipped to the rear frame of her matching SwiftChair, Katie threw both arms around my shoulders across our armrests and hugged me tight in the warm September evening air blowing off the Chesapeake Bay.

“I’ve missed you all week, Nate,” Katie said happily, resting her cheek against mine for a second before we released our brakes and rolled side by side down the sidewalk along West Ocean View Avenue. “Two whole days of just brother-and-sister time, coding on your computer, and no drama.”

“We’ve got the whole weekend,” I smiled, checking my watch on my left wrist as we turned past the low white two-rail fence into the small, tree-shaded courtyard of Sea Breeze West.

Our complex consisted of two low-rise early-nineteen-seventies buildings facing each other across the narrow courtyard and asphalt parking lot—the red-brick building with the script Sea Breeze West sign and the quarter-operated laundry room on one side, and our white-painted two-story courtyard building on the other, where the exterior unit doors and wide double windows were lined up side by side like an old coastal motel. My unit—Apartment 3—sat on the ground floor at the very far end of the white-painted building, furthest from the parking lot.

When I unlocked the wooden front door in the right-hand corner and rolled inside ahead of Katie, the single six-hundred-square-foot apartment opened straight into our combination living room and kitchen. Immediately to the left of the front door, directly beneath the two wide front windows covered by white horizontal mini-blinds looking out onto the courtyard, sat our bright green three-cushion sofa with an oval weathered-wood coffee table in front of it and a black cathode-ray-tube television on a two-shelf black-and-glass stand in the opposite front corner. Just beyond the oval coffee table stood a large dining table that I used as a computer desk for my desktop tower PC running Quantum OS XN Pro, looking straight ahead into the open kitchen with its olive-green base cabinets, speckled laminate prep counters, slate-blue four-burner electric stove, sink, and full-size top-freezer refrigerator.

Standing near the corner television stand in a mint-green short-sleeve graphic T-shirt, charcoal-gray pants, and black-rimmed rectangular glasses, my nineteen-year-old girlfriend Tiffany Sloan froze and stared at Katie’s wheelchair rolling through the doorway behind me.

“Wait, what?” Tiffany snarled, her voice dropping into a harsh, hostile edge behind her glasses.

I blinked, braking my chair beside the bright green sofa while Katie transferred smoothly from her SwiftChair onto the left cushion of the couch and patted the middle cushion for me to sit beside her.

“I thought we discussed this on Thursday, Tiffany,” I said, transferring onto the green sofa next to Katie as my twin sister naturally draped her right arm around my shoulders the way we had sat together our entire lives. “My sister wants to see me for the weekend.”

Tiffany shot me a venomous dirty look, her face flushing dark red behind her black-rimmed glasses as she stared at Katie’s arm around my brick-red polo shirt. It baffled me why Tiffany always acted so bitterly jealous whenever another woman—even my own fraternal twin sister—hugged me, especially when I had never once had a problem with Tiffany being close with her own brother.

“Katie is going to sleep right here on the green sofa, just like we discussed,” I added, trying to keep my voice calm and even so an argument wouldn’t start before Katie even unclipped her overnight bag.

Across the oval wooden coffee table, I could feel Katie’s shoulders tense as she watched Tiffany and me fighting yet again.

“I wanted some time with my brother, Tiffany,” Katie said firmly, looking straight across the living room at her. “You get to see him twenty-four hours a day, seven days a week. I don’t.”

“I am his girlfriend!” Tiffany snapped at the top of her lungs.

Katie’s blue eyes flashed with instant, protective fire.

“Don’t yell at me like that,” Katie retorted, transferring straight off the green sofa back into her SwiftChair in one fluid motion. Reaching across her armrest, she took me firmly by the hand and snarled, “Come on, Nate.”

Turning her head toward Tiffany by the corner television stand, Katie growled three words that echoed off the drywall from the front window blinds all the way back to the open kitchen stove:

“My brother only!”

Saturday, September 18, 2004, 7:55 PM — The Courtyard Walk & “Speak Now or Forever Hold Your Peace”

I wasn’t sure how to react—my head was spinning in complete confusion as I transferred back into my own SwiftChair and rolled out the front door of Apartment 3 right behind Katie into the cool September twilight of the Sea Breeze West courtyard.

The moment the wooden door clicked shut behind us and we rolled past the white two-rail fence toward the quiet sidewalk along West Ocean View Avenue, Katie braked her wheelchair, pivoted to face me under the streetlamp, and got straight to the point.

“Why do you stay with her, Nate?” Katie demanded.

I gave her what must have been a bewildered, defensive look, my hands tightening on my armrest pads.

“I’m your twin!” Katie said, leaning forward in her chair so her blue eyes locked directly onto mine. “I know when something’s up before you even say a word. Now please, tell me the truth. Why do you stay with her?”

“Katie, I… uh… well, I finally found someone,” I stammered in frustration, my voice cracking as the familiar ache of nineteen years of awkwardness and rejection after Heather Collins at Northwood High School knotted my chest. “A real, actual girlfriend.”

“She’s hurting you,” Katie said, her voice dropping from anger to an aching, urgent plea. “Why can’t you see it?”

“You’re just mad that I found someone!” I snapped back before I could stop myself.

Katie didn’t flinch, though I saw the hurt flash across her face under the streetlamp.

“Listen to you!” Katie replied softly, shaking her head. “I’m your sister, Nate. You shouldn’t be snapping at me like that. Your own twin sister.”

The second those words left her mouth, the defensive wall inside my chest collapsed. Hot tears leaked from my eyes and spilled down my cheeks as I realized I was blowing up at Katie—the one person on earth who had never left my side through our parents’ divorce on Delaney Street, through the September Friday in eleventh grade when our legs gave out, and through every lonely bus ride across Hampton Roads.

“It’s alright,” Katie whispered immediately, rolling her SwiftChair two inches closer and reaching across to hold my hand in both of hers. “I’m not mad at you, Nate. Not ever. But I still don’t approve of her, and I never will.”

My sister gripped my hand more tightly, her fingers warm and steady around mine while my thoughts collided inside my skull. Katie had always been there for me, yet part of my stubborn nineteen-year-old brain kept clinging to the illusion that having a girlfriend meant I had finally built a normal adult life—even if that life meant walking on eggshells around Tiffany’s temper and Tiffany’s overbearing mother every single day.

Looking straight into my tear-streaked eyes, Katie spoke in a clear, solemn voice that sounded like a sworn oath in a courtroom.

“If she ever pops the question, Nate, I am telling you right now,” Katie said, squeezing my hand so hard I could feel the pulse in her fingers. “When the minister or the judge stands up in front of the room and says, *Speak now or forever hold your peace*, I will be speaking up. I will roll my wheelchair right down the center aisle, I will look the officiant in the eye on the record, and I will tell the whole room that my autistic twin brother is being coerced, isolated from his family, and pressured into a marriage against his will so they have to stop the ceremony on the spot. It is my duty as your twin sister to protect you—and no, I never thought it would come down to this.”

It was too much for my brain to comprehend all at once. Between Tiffany screaming at us inside Apartment 3, the humiliating memory of Tiffany’s mother glaring at me, and Katie swearing on the West Ocean View sidewalk that she would literally halt a wedding ceremony under Virginia law to rescue me, my autistic sensory circuits hit total overload. I felt like my head was about to explode, and all I wanted to do was crawl into a dark, quiet closet away from the rest of the world.

Katie saw my shoulders trembling and read my silence before I could even form a sentence.

“You can’t think straight right now,” Katie whispered gently, stroking the back of my hand with her thumb. “You know I can read your mind. Please be honest with me.”

She paused for a long breath, letting the distant rumble of a Route 1 bus rolling down West Ocean View Avenue pass behind us before she plunged on.

“To tell you the truth, Nate, I do not approve of Tiffany,” Katie said quietly. “I do not like her, and I will never like her. She will never earn my respect, and I really want you to leave her. You’re not happy, and you need to get rid of her. Whenever you’re ready to see that—no matter how long it takes or how bad it gets—I’m right here.”

Part 2: Riding Route 1 Back to West Ghent, Meeting Brandon Mercer at The Admiral Center, & Taking Things Slow

Date: 2004-09-19 at 13:15 America/New_York

Sunday, September 19, 2004, 1:15 PM — The Empty Half of Apartment A6 & Rolling Over to The Admiral Center

“I haven’t slept that badly since the hospital in eleventh grade,” I muttered to myself at one-fifteen on Sunday afternoon as the hydraulic ramp of the southbound CVTA Route 1 bus folded down onto the curb in West Ghent and I rolled my compact SwiftChair down the shaded brick sidewalk toward the two-story red-brick apartment building on Greenway Court.

My stomach had been tied in a sick, heavy knot ever since eight-fifteen the night before, when Katie had refused to step another foot inside Apartment 3 at Sea Breeze West after Tiffany’s screaming outburst by the green sofa and had ridden the Saturday night Route 1 bus all the way back down Granby Street to Greenway Court by herself. All night long, lying awake on the sagging mattress in West Ocean View while Tiffany snored beside me, one sentence Katie had spoken under the courtyard streetlamp had echoed inside my skull:

I’m your sister, Nate. You shouldn’t be snapping at me like that. Your own twin sister.

The moment Tiffany left at noon on Sunday to go spend the afternoon at her mother Sandra’s house, I had rolled straight down to Ocean View Station and caught the twelve-thirty southbound Route 1 bus. I didn’t care if Tiffany got annoyed when she found out I had gone to West Ghent; I couldn’t go another hour without looking my twin sister in the eye, apologizing for snapping at her, and making sure she knew I loved her.

Because I still kept my brass Greenway Court keys on my keyring, I unlocked the building’s 24/7 keyed glass-and-aluminum front door, rolled up Dave’s nonslip aluminum ramp over the three lobby steps, and wheeled down the quiet first-floor hallway to Apartment A6 on the back right side of the building.

I knocked twice on the wooden door. “Katie? It’s Nate.”

When no one answered from inside, I used my spare key to unlock the deadbolt and pushed the door open.

Rolling three feet across the threshold into Apartment A6 stopped me cold.

For sixteen months, from the day after our eighteenth birthday until three weeks ago at the end of August, this rectangular studio had been *ours*. Now, looking around the spotless room in the quiet Sunday afternoon light filtering through the white mini-blinds above the through-wall air conditioner, the silence felt almost unbearable. The right half of our long computer workstation desk—where my desktop tower and

seventeen-inch CRT monitor had sat right beside Katie's—was completely bare except for a neatly coiled ethernet cable. Across the room, the door to our square walk-in closet stood halfway open, and on the vacuumed carpet inside, our navy-blue sleeping bag was folded into a neat square with only a single pillow resting on top of it.

A lump rose in my throat as I realized Katie had come home from Ocean View in tears the night before and had slept in that closet completely alone.

Rolling over to her workstation desk, I spotted a yellow sticky note stuck to the bottom bezel of her monitor in Katie's neat handwriting:

12:45 PM — Rolled over to the bakery café at The Admiral Center for a cup of hot chocolate and fresh air. Back by 2:30! — Katie

I locked the door of Apartment A6 behind me, rolled back out the front entrance of the Greenway Court building, and set my SwiftChair speed dial to a brisk four miles per hour down the sidewalk toward Twenty-First Street.

Sunday, September 19, 2004, 1:40 PM — Brandon Mercer Presents Himself as a Gentleman, Defends Nate, & Respects Katie's Pace

Ten minutes later, I turned my wheelchair into the wide brick pedestrian promenade of The Admiral Center.

Three storefronts down from the glass windows of Chapters & Co., where I had met Tiffany back in May, was the outdoor brick patio of the corner bakery and café. Shaded by dark-green canvas umbrellas, the patio had four wide, wheelchair-accessible wrought-iron tables along the outer walkway.

And sitting at the corner table in her compact black SwiftChair, wearing her royal-blue sweater with both hands wrapped around a steaming paper cup of hot chocolate, was Katie.

She wasn't sitting alone.

Seated across the small round table from her in a wrought-iron patio chair was a clean-cut, soft-spoken young man who looked to be about twenty-two years old, wearing a neatly pressed light-blue button-down shirt, khaki trousers, and a leather wristwatch, with short sandy-brown hair and a warm, attentive expression on his face. On the table between them sat a fresh stack of paper napkins, an unopened bottle of strawberry-kiwi flavored water beside Katie's hot chocolate, and a tall glass of apple juice in front of him.

As I rolled down the brick walkway toward their table, Katie was laughing softly at something he had just said—the first real smile I had seen on my sister's face all weekend. Then she glanced up, saw my SwiftChair rolling toward her, and her blue eyes widened.

"Nate!" Katie said, setting her cup of hot chocolate down as I braked my chair right beside hers and reached across our armrests with both hands.

“Katie, I’m so sorry about last night,” I blurted out immediately, my voice thick as I held her hands tightly in mine. “I couldn’t stay up in Ocean View another minute without coming down here on Route 1 to tell you how sorry I am for snapping at you in the courtyard. You were right—you’re my twin sister, and I never should have talked to you like that.”

Katie’s eyes softened instantly, and she leaned across our armrests to wrap both arms around my neck in a tight, forgiving hug.

“I told you last night I wasn’t mad at you, Nate,” Katie whispered against my collar before sitting back and wiping a tear from the corner of her eye with a smile. “I’m really glad you came down. I went back to A6 last night and the apartment felt so quiet this morning that I had to get out for a little while.”

She turned toward the young man in the light-blue button-down shirt, who had politely stood up a few inches and stepped back just enough during our hug to give us a respectful moment of sibling privacy before offering me a warm, friendly smile.

“Nate, this is Brandon Mercer,” Katie said, introducing us. “He’s visiting Norfolk from Williamsburg today. About twenty minutes ago, some guy in a hurry with three shopping bags cut across the patio, bumped right into my table, and knocked my entire cup of hot chocolate all over the bricks without even stopping to say excuse me. Brandon came right over with a stack of napkins to clean up the table, went inside to buy me a brand-new cup of hot chocolate and a bottle of flavored water, and asked if he could keep me company.”

Brandon leaned down slightly so he was at my eye level and extended his right hand across the table with a genuine, unhurried handshake.

“It’s really good to meet you, Nate,” Brandon said in a calm, pleasant voice. “Katie’s been telling me all about you and the classes the two of you are taking at CCHR. You two have a lot to be proud of.”

“Thank you for helping my sister out with the spilled hot chocolate, Brandon,” I said, shaking his hand and immediately noticing how natural and unforced he was around our two power wheelchairs—not staring at the joysticks, not talking down to us in a high-pitched voice the way strangers sometimes did, and sitting right back down at our level. “And I’m sorry if I interrupted you two because I needed to apologize for ruining her weekend.”

“Hey, don’t beat yourself up, man,” Brandon said warmly, holding up a hand with an understanding smile as he looked from me to Katie. “Katie was just telling me a little bit about what happened up in Ocean View last night because I asked why she looked so down when I first walked over, and I already told her five minutes ago that I knew right away it wasn’t your fault.”

I blinked in surprise. “You did?”

“Of course it wasn’t your fault,” Brandon said earnestly, nodding toward both of us. “Anyone who listens to Katie talk about you for two minutes can tell how close the two of you have been your whole lives. When a good guy moves into his first apartment with a girlfriend and she suddenly changes the rules after the lease is signed—after promising your sister she’d be welcome for the weekend—it catches you completely off guard. You didn’t want your sister hurt; you just got put on the

spot in a tiny living room and tried to keep the peace. And the fact that you rode the city bus all the way down from Ocean View today just to apologize and make sure Katie was okay proves what kind of brother you are."

Across our armrests, Katie looked at me with a warm, relieved nod, and I felt the tight band around my chest loosen for the first time since Saturday night. After how hostile and loud Tiffany had been the evening before, hearing a polite, level-headed guy from Williamsburg immediately defend me to Katie—and treat our twin bond like the most natural, admirable thing in the world—made Brandon seem like a breath of fresh air.

For the next forty-five minutes, the three of us sat together around that shaded patio table at The Admiral Center. When I pulled a cold can of ginger ale out of my backpack, Brandon mentioned that he didn't care for alcohol or coffee either and preferred apple juice, sports drinks, or hot chocolate—which made Katie and me exchange a delighted twin grin. He told us he was twenty-two years old, lived up in Williamsburg on Virginia Avenue a few blocks from the College of Charles & Anne, and worked in hospitality bookkeeping while taking business courses.

At two-thirty, Brandon glanced down at his leather wristwatch and stood up reluctantly from the wrought-iron chair.

"I promised my supervisor I'd be back up in Williamsburg by four o'clock to close out the weekend ledgers, so I'd better head back toward the bridge-tunnel before Sunday afternoon traffic backs up," Brandon said, smiling warmly down at Katie. "Katie, meeting you today was the best part of my whole week. I'd really love to show you around Williamsburg sometime soon—my apartment on Virginia Avenue is on the ground floor with zero steps, and the Williamsburg Transportation Center is right down the street with accessible CTTA buses that run all through the historic area."

Katie blushed slightly, smoothing her royal-blue sweater over her lap before looking up at Brandon with clear, honest blue eyes.

"I'd really like to see Williamsburg someday, Brandon," Katie said softly, "and thank you so much for being so kind to me today. After everything that happened yesterday, though—and with Nate and me living in separate apartments for the first time in our lives—I really want to take things slow and get to know you here in Norfolk first."

I watched Brandon's face closely to see if he would look disappointed or try to talk her out of it.

Instead, Brandon's smile only grew warmer and more respectful.

"I respect that completely, Katie," Brandon said without a trace of pressure in his voice, pulling a small business card out of his shirt pocket and writing his home and cell numbers neatly on the back before handing it to her. "Taking things slow is the smart way to do it, and I don't want you rushing into anything you aren't a hundred percent comfortable with. I love visiting Norfolk anyway—it's an easy trip down I-64 on the weekends. If it's alright with you and Nate, I'd love to come down here to Ghent next Saturday afternoon, bring you two some hot chocolate, and go completely at your pace."

“I’d really like that,” Katie smiled, slipping his card carefully into her zippered purse.

“And it was great meeting you too, Nate,” Brandon added, shaking my hand warmly again before waving goodbye and walking down the brick promenade toward the parking lot.

As soon as Brandon turned the corner past Chapters & Co., Katie rolled her SwiftChair two inches closer to mine and took my hand.

“Well?” Katie asked, echoing the exact question I had asked her inside Apartment A6 four months earlier on the afternoon she met Tiffany. “What did you think of him, Nate?”

Looking back down the sunny brick walkway where Brandon had just bought my twin sister fresh hot chocolate, defended me without hesitation, and promised to respect her boundaries and go completely at her pace, I smiled and squeezed Katie’s hand back.

“He seems like a genuinely good guy, Katie,” I said honestly. “I like how he didn’t push you at all when you told him you wanted to take things slow, and it meant a lot to me that he knew last night wasn’t my fault. Let’s roll back to A6 and spend the rest of Sunday afternoon together before I have to catch the evening Route 1 bus back to Ocean View.”

Part 3: Patience at Katie’s Pace, Winning Over Nate and Dad, & Katie’s Move to Williamsburg

Date: 2004-11-20 at 14:00 America/New_York

Saturday, November 20, 2004, 2:00 PM — Two Months at Katie’s Pace & The Decision in Apartment A6

“Look how neatly Brandon labeled all of the computer cables with masking tape before putting them in the box, Nate,” nineteen-year-old Katie said with a warm smile on the Saturday afternoon before Thanksgiving in November 2004, rolling her compact SwiftChair back from the long workstation desk inside Apartment A6 on Greenway Court so our dad David could lift her seventeen-inch CRT monitor into its padded carton.

Standing beside the desk with a roll of clear packing tape in his hand and his steaming travel mug of black coffee resting on the kitchenette counter next to three cold bottles of sports drink and orange juice, forty-six-year-old Dad looked across the room toward twenty-two-year-old Brandon Mercer, who was carefully wrapping Katie’s glass butterfly paperweight in bubble wrap on his knees.

“You’ve got a good system, Brandon,” Dad said approvingly. “Most guys your age just toss all the cords into a grocery bag and spend three days figuring out what plugs into what.”

“My dad taught me early on that if you take your time and do things carefully, nothing gets broken,” Brandon replied with that calm, polite smile that had won over our entire family since September.

Sitting in my SwiftChair beside the kitchenette counter, I watched Brandon tape the bubble wrap around Katie's paperweight and felt a complicated mixture of happiness for my twin sister and a quiet ache in my chest that she was moving forty-five miles up Interstate 64 to Williamsburg.

True to the promise he had made at The Admiral Center on that Sunday afternoon in September, Brandon hadn't rushed Katie for a single day. All through late September, October, and November, Brandon had respected Katie's wish to take things slow and get to know him right here in Norfolk. Every single Saturday and Sunday, rain or shine, he had driven down I-64 from Williamsburg to West Ghent. He brought Katie cups of hot chocolate from the bakery and cartons of chocolate milk for her dorm fridge; he carried her laundry basket down the hall and chatted warmly with our across-the-hall neighbors Michael and Ashley before Michael finished moving out of Apartment A5 earlier this month; he sat beside her wheelchair at the workstation desk while she finished her CCHR homework; and whenever Dad drove down to take us out to dinner, Brandon pulled out chairs, opened doors, and spoke with the steady, respectful courtesy of a young man who genuinely cherished my twin sister.

And during those exact same autumn months between September and November 2004, while Brandon was treating Katie like gold every weekend in Ghent, my own life up in West Ocean View at Sea Breeze West Apartment 3 had been sliding downhill so gradually that I barely knew how to explain it even to myself.

When Tiffany and I had first moved into Apartment 3 back in August, I had genuinely believed we were going to build a normal grown-up romance together—sharing the queen bed in the back bedroom, kissing goodnight, cuddling under the covers, and figuring that once we were settled in and ready, our relationship would naturally take the next step the way adult couples do when they are in love. Yet before moving out of Greenway Court, Katie and I had promised each other that neither of us would rush into anything sexual that could risk an unplanned pregnancy while we were still adjusting to living apart for the first time in our lives. And as it turned out, that waiting period had barely begun before Tiffany's warmth dried up on its own. Almost as soon as the Sea Breeze West lease was signed, the affectionate girlfriend who had held an umbrella over my joystick in the rain started turning cold and irritable whenever I came near her, leaving unwashed dishes in the sink for days at a time, banishing milk from our refrigerator, and picking jealous fights over my twin sister until sharing our bedroom felt more like walking on eggshells than being in love.

Whenever I mentioned riding the CVTA Route 1 bus down to Greenway Court on a Saturday afternoon to visit Katie, Tiffany would suddenly complain of a migraine, or her mother Sandra would show up unannounced at Apartment 3 demanding that I stay home to help reorganize the living room, or Tiffany would start a guilt-tripping argument asking why she wasn't enough company for me. Week by week, my trips down Granby Street had grown fewer and further between. Because I was too embarrassed to admit to Katie or Dad how bad the mess and the arguments at Apartment 3 had gotten, I kept telling them over the phone that I was just busy—which meant that Monday through Friday, nineteen-year-old Katie had been coming home to an empty studio apartment at the back of Greenway Court, eating dinner by herself at half of a workstation desk, and sleeping alone in the square walk-in closet where the two of us used to zip up in our shared sleeping bag together.

Once Michael vacated Apartment A5 across the hall earlier in November, leaving both back apartments on the first floor quiet at night, Brandon had seen how lonely Katie was sitting in Apartment A6 all by herself while I was stuck up in Ocean View. Two weeks ago, Brandon had sat down with Katie, Dad, and me over Sunday lunch and made the gentlest, most reasonable pitch imaginable.

Why keep paying rent on a studio apartment in West Ghent where Katie had to sit alone staring at Nate's empty half of the desk through Thanksgiving and Christmas, Brandon had asked kindly, when Katie was ready to move into his ground-floor one-bedroom apartment at 224 Virginia Avenue in Williamsburg? His apartment was completely step-free on the first floor; it was only blocks away from the College of Charles & Anne and the Williamsburg Transportation Center, where the Colonial Triangle Transit Authority buses, the Pathfinder intercity coaches, and the ARTS passenger train stopped every day; and Katie could work and commute by bus while never having to come home to an empty room again.

Because Brandon had spent the entire autumn earning every ounce of our trust—and because Katie genuinely loved how attentive and gentle he was with her—Katie had said yes, and both Dad and I had given them our blessing.

"That's the last of the kitchen cartons," Dad said, carrying the rolling microwave-and-toaster cart out toward the hallway so he could load it into the back of his pickup alongside Brandon's sedan in the front parking lot. "Brandon, let's you and me run these three boxes out to the vehicles while Nate and Katie have a few minutes before we lock up."

"You got it, Mr. Prairie," Brandon said, picking up two taped boxes of books and following Dad out into the first-floor corridor.

As soon as the wooden door of Apartment A6 clicked half-shut behind them, the studio felt cavernously quiet. Only the bare full-sized mattress, the empty workstation desk, and the open door of the empty square walk-in closet remained.

Katie released her joystick brake, rolled her SwiftChair across the vacuumed carpet right up beside mine, and took both of my hands.

"You're quiet today, Nate," Katie said softly, her blue eyes searching mine the way they always did whenever I was holding something inside. "Are you okay with me moving up to Williamsburg?"

"I want you to be happy, Katie," I said, my voice catching slightly as I squeezed her fingers. "I hated knowing you were sitting down here in A6 all by yourself every weeknight while I was up in Ocean View. Brandon has been so patient and good to you all autumn, and I know you won't be lonely up there with him. Just… remember our pact, okay? Take things at your own pace, and don't let anyone rush you into anything you aren't ready for—especially anything that could get you pregnant or put your health at risk."

"I remember, Nate, and I won't," Katie promised earnestly, squeezing my hands right back. "Brandon already knows I want to keep taking things slow even after we're sharing a bedroom, and he promised he's completely fine with just holding me and taking our time until we're settled. Besides, Williamsburg is just right up I-64 on the Peninsula. The Williamsburg Transportation Center is right down the street from Brandon's apartment on Virginia Avenue. CTTA buses run right from the station

down to Lee Hall to connect with CVTA routes in Newport News, and we still have our phones and instant messaging every single day. Promise me you'll call me whenever Tiffany is at work so we can talk just the two of us?"

"Twin's promise," I whispered against her hair, holding my sister close inside the studio apartment that had been our very first home as adults. "And if you ever need me for anything at all—day or night—you call me or come straight down to Ocean View, okay?"

"I will, Nate," Katie smiled, sitting back and wiping a tiny tear from her eyelashes as Dad and Brandon walked back down the hallway to pick up the final computer boxes. "Everything is going to be great for both of us."

Twenty minutes later, outside in the crisp November sunshine by the circular brick lamppost planter in front of the Greenway Court building, Katie transferred into the front passenger seat of Brandon's sedan while Brandon and Dad carefully folded and stowed her compact SwiftChair in the trunk.

As Brandon's car pulled out of the parking lot onto Greenway Court heading toward Interstate 64 West and Williamsburg, and I rolled down the sidewalk toward Granby Street to catch the northbound Route 1 bus back to Tiffany and Sea Breeze West Apartment 3, Katie waved to me through the passenger window with two crossed fingers pressed against the glass.

For the first time in nineteen years, my twin sister and I were living in two different cities.

Part 4: The Worst Christmas Ever: Eighteen Stops to Dirty Old Tonomy Hill, Four Days with Cousin Chelsea, & The West Main Road Shortcut Home

Date: 2004-12-24 at 15:30 America/New_York

Friday, December 24, 2004, 3:30 PM — Eighteen Stops to Dirty Old Tonomy Hill & The Worst Christmas Ever

"Another girl," twenty-year-old Tiffany retorted, with what sounded like a sharp hint of anger in her voice, as the blue-and-white Ocean State Transit Authority Route 63 bus hissed away from the curb on Dirty Old Tonomy Hill on Friday afternoon, Christmas Eve, and left the two of us in the biting Rhode Island December wind outside the weathered World War II-era public housing buildings.

"I thought I told you that all my cousins are women. There really are no men in my life," I replied from my compact SwiftChair, answering that exact question for what seemed like the millionth time while my cold fingers gripped the joystick controller.

We were in Newport, Rhode Island—my dad David's birthplace and childhood home—at the end of an exhausting overnight and daylong Pathfinder bus marathon that had left every muscle in my shoulders and back aching. Because our Aunt Elizabeth had died earlier that year from her lifelong smoking, and our grandmother had passed away not long before her, our twenty-two-year-old cousin Chelsea was facing her very first Christmas without her mother. When Dad had helped buy my Pathfinder ticket up to Rhode Island so Chelsea wouldn't spend Christmas completely alone, I had originally hoped Katie and I would make the trip together.

Instead, with Katie now living up in Williamsburg with Brandon, Tiffany had flatly refused to hear of Katie coming with us and insisted on making the multi-day holiday trip with me herself.

Getting from Norfolk to Newport by bus on Christmas Eve had been a grueling eighteen-leg haul up the Eastern Seaboard, with drivers unfolding the coach wheelchair lift for my SwiftChair at four separate transfer terminals along the way. We had started at the downtown Pathfinder station in Norfolk, rolled across the harbor to Hampton and up I-64 to the Williamsburg station, and ridden into Richmond, where we changed buses for the run north through Fredericksburg and Springfield into Washington, D.C. In Washington we changed buses a second time, riding north into Downtown Baltimore on West Fayette Street—where our driver had to exit I-95 onto I-395 and crawl through block after block of congested downtown Baltimore traffic lights—before continuing up through Newark, Delaware and Philadelphia into the crowded underground gates of the Port Authority Bus Terminal in New York City. After changing buses a third time in Manhattan, we had rolled up the Connecticut coast through Bridgeport and New Haven, passed through the steel skyline of Braxton, Rhode Island and downtown Providence, and pulled into Boston's South Station—where we changed buses a fourth time for the run south through Fall River, Massachusetts into the Newport Gateway Center, finally paying our cash fare onto the local OSTA Route 63 bus up to Tonomy Hill.

In December 2004, Tonomy Hill—which everyone in Newport called Dirty Old Tonomy Hill—was still a sprawling complex of faded, aging World War II-era defense-worker public housing apartments perched on the wind-swept ridge on the north side of town.

Before Tiffany could make another angry remark on the cracked concrete walk, the front door of the nearest World War II-era building swung open.

"Welcome to Newport!" cried a voice as I saw my cousin Chelsea hurrying down the low wooden entry ramp toward my wheelchair as fast as her struggling gait would carry her and pulling me into a tight squeeze hug. "I hope you enjoy Christmas with me," she whispered against my coat collar, her speech slurred due to her developmental disability.

A single tear leaked from the corner of her eye. Aunt Liz's heavy smoking while pregnant was the reason Chelsea had been born developmentally delayed and with severe chronic asthma that required her to keep both her regular maintenance inhaler and her rescue inhaler with her at all times—yet Aunt Liz was still her mother, and facing this first Christmas without her weighed heavily on Chelsea's heart.

"You like my boyfriend?" Tiffany asked beside us, disgusted.

"He and Katie are my only family, my only cousins," Chelsea replied excitedly, not fully comprehending the hostile meaning behind Tiffany's words. She took us into the apartment building and up the interior ramp into her living room. "You two make yourselves comfortable on the couch. I'm going to take a badly needed shower."

"She seems to really like you a lot," Tiffany groaned as soon as the bathroom door clicked shut and the water began running.

“She doesn’t understand some things about life,” I said, none too happily, braking my SwiftChair near the sofa. “She hasn’t seen me since we were younger and she’s just very excited to see me. Think about how you feel about your brother when he comes to town.”

Tiffany didn’t respond to that comparison, but our arguments went back and forth across the living room—with Tiffany’s voice rising into harsh, angry screaming—when suddenly we heard the bathroom door fly open.

Because the sound of Tiffany screaming at me through the bathroom wall was so distressing to Chelsea that she genuinely feared for my safety—deciding in an instant that protecting her cousin was far more important than her modesty—Chelsea came running out of the shower soaking wet and completely naked, dripping soapy water across the floor without a care in the world that she was standing there wearing nothing at all.

“Why are you two fighting?” she asked in a frightened, slurred voice.

Tiffany was startled by her sudden appearance in the buff, and immediately seemed angry that I wasn’t shocked at all. Keeping my eyes respectfully averted toward the hallway wall, I was remembering from childhood—like the Christmas at our house in Virginia Beach when we were nine—that our family constantly had to remind Chelsea to stay dressed, and that she sometimes ran around the house naked when she was younger without realizing she needed clothes on.

“Come on, Chelsea, let’s get you dried off and dressed,” I said calmly, rolling my SwiftChair forward, grabbing a large dry bath towel off the hall shelf, and guiding her back into the bathroom. “Tiffany doesn’t grasp that you don’t understand some things.”

Closing the bathroom door behind us and wrapping the thick towel completely around her shoulders to cover her, I added gently, “I remember when you’d run around the place naked when we were kids, Cous.”

“I wish it was just you and Katie,” she whimpered, her chest hitching with a tight asthmatic wheeze as she started to have a full emotional breakdown. After taking a shaky puff from the rescue inhaler she kept right beside the sink alongside her regular inhaler, she started holding onto me tightly, scared out of her mind by Tiffany’s screaming.

“Let’s get you dressed and try to have a good time,” I said softly, rubbing the towel over her shoulders to dry my cousin off as best as I could while keeping her completely covered so her dignity stayed in place.

Friday, December 24 – Monday, December 27, 2004 — The Christmas Eve Nightmare, Four Days Under Siege, & The West Main Road Shortcut Home

“She seems to have a crush on you,” Tiffany spat quietly right after the three of us finished Christmas Eve dinner.

“Please don’t be mean to her. There are some things she doesn’t understand,” I tried to explain again to Tiffany.

“I really don’t give a damn,” Tiffany snapped out loud. “First you have a sister and now a cousin. I’m starting to wonder where your loyalties are!”

“I don’t care when you’re close with your brother,” I replied, my temper starting to rise as Chelsea stood by the counter and started tearing up. “Now look, she’s crying! You frightened her! Look, I’m really the only family she has left along with my sister. Her mother—my aunt—died. Our grandmother died. She has no one but herself here in Newport. I’m the closest family, being in Virginia! So what if she loves me? She doesn’t understand certain concepts such as the difference between family love and girlfriend love!”

Chelsea tugged at my arm as she was heavily in tears, wheezing through her sobs as she pulled me toward her bedroom.

“Just him!” Chelsea sobbed angrily when Tiffany stood up and tried to follow us into the room. The moment my wheelchair rolled inside, Chelsea slammed the bedroom door in Tiffany’s face and turned the lock.

“She’s mean to you and she’s mean to me!” Chelsea sobbed as she reached for her inhalers on the dresser and then immediately started pulling off her clothes to get into bed, blurting out through her tears without any filter at all, “I don’t care that I’m naked. I always sleep naked!”

Keeping my eyes fixed on her tear-streaked face while I reached out and pulled the heavy bed quilt all the way up over her shoulders to keep her covered, I tried to calm my cousin down. She was an absolute emotional wreck.

“It’s Christmas Eve. Let’s try to salvage it?” I asked gently.

“Promise you will never bring her again. Only Katie! Tiffany’s mean to you and me too!” Chelsea was sobbing with very heavy tears streaming from her eyes, and there was nothing else I could get out of her.

“Chelsea, could we please try to salvage tonight?” I asked softly, wanting her to stop crying.

She didn’t respond as her crying intensified. Instead, terrified that if I rolled back out into the living room Tiffany would start screaming at me all over again, Chelsea clutched my sleeve through her tears and insisted that I transfer out of my wheelchair and climb into bed beside her—with me staying fully dressed in my jeans and sweater on top of the sheet under the edge of the quilt while she clung to my arm—so she wouldn’t have to hear Tiffany and me fight.

There was going to be no changing Chelsea’s mind: she hated my girlfriend with every fiber of her body, and my girlfriend hated her just as much.

Because our return Pathfinder tickets weren’t scheduled until Monday after Christmas, we were stuck at Tonomy Hill for three full nights—Christmas Eve, Christmas Day, and Sunday night. Every single day, whenever Chelsea hugged me or kissed my cheek the way she always had since we were little kids, Tiffany glared at her with open fury and hissed at me that my cousin had a crush on me. Because of Chelsea’s developmental disability, she genuinely didn’t understand what made family love different from romantic love; I had never once in my life stopped Chelsea from hugging or kissing me in the past, and I wasn’t about to start pushing her away now and scare my grieving cousin who simply didn’t understand how life

worked sometimes. And every single night of the visit, refusing to listen to Tiffany yell at me in the living room, Chelsea locked her bedroom door against Tiffany and made me stay in her room with her until morning—leaving Tiffany out on the living-room sofa, seething with rage.

By Monday morning, December 27, when it was finally time to head back to Virginia, the tension inside the apartment was suffocating.

Looking at our printed Pathfinder return tickets, Chelsea noticed a problem right away: our tickets started at the Newport Gateway Center on a local bus to Fall River, Massachusetts, where we were supposed to change buses for a connecting run to Providence that departed only five minutes later. Even with her developmental delays, Chelsea knew Newport transit cold—and she knew that with a driver having to unload my SwiftChair on the wheelchair lift in Fall River, a five-minute transfer window meant we would miss the connecting bus to Providence for sure.

“Don’t go down to the Gateway Center for the Fall River bus,” Chelsea told us earnestly by the front door, taking a puff of her regular morning inhaler and pointing past the World War II-era buildings toward the paved walking path that cut down the eastern slope of Tonomy Hill. “Take the walking path right over to West Main Road and catch the OSTA Route 60 bus straight to Kennedy Plaza in Providence. Then you won’t miss your New York bus.”

Giving Chelsea one last tight hug at the top of the ramp—and whispering in her ear that next time it really would be just Katie and me—I rolled down the Tonomy Hill walking path with a silent, fuming Tiffany walking beside me out to West Main Road.

Just as Chelsea had promised, the blue-and-white OSTA Route 60 bus picked us up on West Main Road, carried us north across Aquidneck Island and over the Mount Hope Bridge straight into Kennedy Plaza in downtown Providence with plenty of time to spare, and let us board our scheduled Pathfinder NYC Express right on our Newport tickets without ever setting foot in Fall River.

From Providence, the NYC Express carried us nonstop down to the Port Authority Bus Terminal in New York City, where we changed buses for the southbound run through Philadelphia and Wilmington, Delaware into Maryland. Unlike our northbound trip that had crawled through the traffic lights of Downtown Baltimore on Fayette Street, our southbound driver stayed right on I-95 and pulled into the highway-side bus bays at the Baltimore Travel Plaza on O’Donnell Street for a quick break before continuing into Washington, D.C.

In Washington we changed buses again, rolling south down I-95 through Fredericksburg into Richmond, where we made our final Pathfinder bus change for the last leg down Interstate 64 toward Hampton Roads.

An hour east of Richmond, the coach exited the interstate and pulled into the bus bays at the Williamsburg Transportation Center.

Staring out the tinted coach window at the brick station platform under the evening streetlights, my heart gave a hard, sudden thud against my ribs. Two blocks down the street from that platform, at 224 Virginia Avenue, was my twin sister Katie. Beside me in the double seat, Tiffany had her arms crossed tightly over her chest, still radiating cold fury over Chelsea and the four days in Newport.

For two full minutes while the driver stood outside by the open luggage bay, I gripped my armrests and seriously considered calling out to the driver to bring my SwiftChair out of the bay right now—getting off the bus right here in Williamsburg, rolling down Virginia Avenue to Katie's front door, and telling my twin sister the whole truth about how miserable I was.

Then the driver swung the luggage bay doors shut, climbed back up the steps, and released the air brakes. Swallowing the lump in my throat, I stayed in my seat beside Tiffany as the coach pulled out of Williamsburg, rolled through Hampton and across the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel into Downtown Norfolk, and dropped us at the Norfolk terminal—where Tiffany and I transferred in silence onto the northbound CVTA Route 1 bus back to our apartment in Ocean View.

Part 5: Five Buses from Williamsburg — The Ninety-Second Window, Crown Burger, & The Last Route 61 Across the Water

Date: 2005-11-12 at 15:38 America/New_York

Saturday, November 12, 2005, 3:38 PM — 224 Virginia Avenue, The Canadian Healthcare Lie, & The Only Arms That Felt Safe

Rain lashed against the living room window of the ground-floor apartment at 224 Virginia Avenue near the College of Charles and Anne as Brandon yanked the zipper shut on his overstuffed canvas duffel bag and dropped it onto the carpet beside the front door.

"Once we cross that river into Windsor tomorrow, all the red tape you've been whining about down here disappears," Brandon said, pacing past the front of my SwiftChair while he shoved a printed stack of internet maps into his coat pocket. "Canada has universal healthcare, Katie. Every prescription you take, every physical therapy visit, every wheelchair motor part—all of it is completely free up there. We won't need your father's insurance, and we won't need your brother meddling in our business."

I kept my eyes fixed on my canvas messenger bag resting across my lap, my hands folded tightly over the flap where my birth certificate folder, my wallet with my state identification card, my daily maintenance medication pouch, and my flip phone were tucked inside. Even at twenty years old, I knew enough about how government eligibility rules worked to know that two United States citizens cannot just roll off a tunnel bus in Ontario on a tourist pass and be handed provincial health cards. Brandon hadn't researched a single residency requirement. He was lying to himself —or lying to me—because the truth didn't matter to him once he got me across an international line where I couldn't get back.

Brandon stopped right behind my shoulders and clamped both of his heavy palms down onto the rubber push-handles of my chair, leaning over the top of my backrest so his breath brushed my ear.

"Up there, it's going to be just you and me," Brandon murmured, sliding his hands down from the handles to wrap his arms awkwardly and tightly around my shoulders from behind. "I'm going to be the one taking care of you from now on, Katie. Just me. Nobody else."

I stiffened against the backrest, holding my breath until he let go.

Even after fourteen months in Williamsburg, Brandon still had no idea how to hug me properly. He always grabbed me from above or behind while standing over my wheelchair, pressing down on my collarbone and pinning my arms against my armrests so I felt trapped in a vise. Every time his hands touched my shoulders now, my skin crawled. I didn't want him touching me anymore.

Through the rain-streaked light beside the door, I glanced at the red numbers on my digital clock radio sitting on the end table: three-thirty-eight in the afternoon.

Our northbound ARTS train wasn't scheduled to pull into the Williamsburg station until early evening, yet Brandon insisted on marching over to North Boundary Street two hours early so he could buy the multi-city rail and tunnel-bus vouchers in cash at the counter before the afternoon clerk went off shift.

As he bent down to lace up his boots by the door, a memory flashed sharp and clear behind my eyes. Two weeks earlier, when we had crossed North Boundary Street past the brick train depot, I had seen a white-and-colonial-blue Colonial Triangle Transit Authority bus idling at the north end of the station island with *NEWPORT NEWS* glowing across its front destination sign.

At the time, it had just been a passing detail on a street corner. Now, at three-thirty-eight on a freezing Saturday afternoon with Brandon slinging his duffel bag over his shoulder, that bus sign was the only lifeline left between me and the Canadian border.

There was only one man on this earth I wanted right now, and he was forty-five miles away across the harbor in West Ocean View.

My chest ached so fiercely for Nate that my throat closed up. I didn't want Canada, and I didn't want a boyfriend hovering over my wheelchair pretending to be my savior. I wanted my twin brother. I wanted to be back in a quiet, dark closet with the door shut against the world and a heavy sleeping bag zipped up around the two of us on the carpet, just like we had done in our West Ghent studio apartment whenever the noise and the fear of the outside world got too loud to bear. I wanted to curl up against Nate's chest in the pitch dark, feel his arms wrap around me at my own level without pinning me down, and breathe in the familiar, safe warmth of his cuddles—the only set of arms in the world where my nervous system ever went completely still.

"Come on, switch your drive levers to freewheel and get your hood up," Brandon ordered, pulling the apartment door open to the cold November wind and grabbing my rear push-handles again before I could even touch my joystick. "We're walking over to the depot right now so I can get the tickets printed at the window."

As my tires rolled out onto the wet sidewalk of Virginia Avenue toward North Boundary Street, I kept my left hand pressed over my messenger bag and stared straight ahead through the rain.

The second Brandon walked inside that station building to stand in line at the ticket counter, I wasn't waiting for him to come back out. I was going to find that Newport News bus, and I was going home to my brother.

Saturday, November 12, 2005, 3:55 PM — North Boundary Street, The Windsor Tickets, & The Ninety-Second Window onto the CTTA Grey Line

Cold November rain slanted sideways under the dark green overhang of the Williamsburg Transportation Center, spattering against the brick columns along North Boundary Street and soaking the knees of my jeans.

Behind my shoulders, Brandon took his hands off the rubber push-handles of my SwiftChair just long enough to reach down to my rear drive motors and flip both of my motor-brake levers into the locked park position—and then reached over my right shoulder to switch off my armrest joystick controller—parking me under the dripping eaves ten feet from the heavy wooden doors of the depot waiting room. Slung across my lap under my raincoat was my canvas messenger bag, holding my wallet with my state identification card, my birth certificate folder, my daily maintenance medication pouch, and my cell phone.

“Stay right here under the awning and don’t move an inch,” Brandon said, adjusting the strap of his overstuffed duffel bag across his chest as he glanced through the glass doors at the ARTS ticket counter inside. “The clerk has to print the multi-city rail and tunnel bus vouchers through Washington and Toledo up to Windsor manually at the window. As soon as I have the tickets in my hand, we’re rolling out to the platform for the northbound train, and by tomorrow afternoon we’ll be across the Canadian border.”

My stomach twisted so hard my throat burned. I looked down at my rain-speckled footrests so he wouldn’t see the panic in my eyes. I didn’t want to get on that train. I didn’t want to go to Michigan or Canada, and I didn’t want to spend another hour trapped in a room with a man who had spent the last fourteen months cutting me off from my dad and my twin brother.

“You hear me, Katie?” Brandon asked sharply, tapping two fingers against the top of my headrest. “Wait right here. I’ll be back in three minutes.”

He turned, pushed through the heavy brass-and-glass doors of the station house, and stepped into the queue behind two college students at the indoor ARTS ticket counter.

For five seconds, I sat frozen under the whistling wind, listening to the wet hiss of tires out on Boundary Street.

Then, forty feet to my left along the curved transit island at the north end of the brick plaza, air brakes sighed against the slick pavement.

A white-and-colonial-blue bus with Colonial Triangle Transit Authority painted across its flank pulled into the end bay beneath the bus shelter. Above its wide windshield, the amber electronic destination sign cycled through two words that made my heart slam against my ribs:

GREY LINE — NEWPORT NEWS / LEE HALL.

I didn’t have a printed Coastal Virginia Transit Authority timetable in my bag, and I had no idea what transfers it would take to get all the way across the harbor on a rainy Saturday afternoon. All I knew was the map of the Peninsula Dad and Nate and I had memorized when we were teenagers: Newport News sat straight down

Route 60 toward Hampton and the bridge-tunnel, and once you reached Lee Hall in Newport News, the blue-and-gold CVTA buses ran south into the heart of the city and across the water to Norfolk.

Through the tall multipane window of the depot waiting room, I caught a glimpse of Brandon's back. He had just stepped up to the counter, pulling his wallet out of his back pocket while the ticket agent typed into her terminal.

It was now or never. If I waited ninety more seconds, Brandon would walk back through those doors with two one-way train tickets to the Canadian border, and I might never see Nate or Dad again.

My right hand trembled as I pressed the power button on my armrest controller, saw the green battery lights flash to life, and pushed my joystick full forward.

My SwiftChair hummed across the wet brick pavers of the platform, splashes of rainwater kicking up off my front casters as I rolled straight past the station overhang toward the bus bay. Up at the front doors of the CTTA coach, the driver spotted my wheelchair coming through the rain and immediately flipped his toggle switch.

The front air suspension knelt with a loud pneumatic whoosh, and the hydraulic aluminum ramp unfolded and clanged down onto the wet concrete curb.

I didn't look back toward the station doors. I lined my front casters up with the yellow side rails, drove straight up the steep wet diamond-plate incline into the warm interior of the bus, and spun my chair around in the front vestibule to back into the forward wheelchair securement bay.

"Nasty rain out there this afternoon, sweetheart," the driver said kindly, rising from his seat to pull the four SafeLock floor straps out from their retractors and hook them onto my frame. "Where are you headed down the line?"

"All the way to the Lee Hall transfer stop in Newport News, please," I said, my voice shaking so hard I barely recognized it as I pulled a crumpled dollar bill and two quarters out of my coat pocket and pushed them into the farebox slot.

"Lee Hall it is," the driver said, clicking the lap belt across my waist and stepping back up to his seat. "Hang on tight."

He hit the switch. The hydraulic ramp folded up inside the doorway, the dual glass doors hissed shut, and the driver released the air brakes, pulling the bus out of the Williamsburg Transportation Center bay and turning left onto North Boundary Street.

As the coach accelerated past the south end of the brick station house, I looked out through the rain-streaked left window.

Right at that exact second, the heavy wooden doors of the depot swung open.

Brandon walked out onto the wet brick platform holding a yellow paper ARTS ticket jacket in his right hand. He took two steps toward the spot under the overhang where he had left me—and stopped dead in his tracks, staring at the empty patch of wet brick.

Even through the pouring rain and fifty feet of distance, I saw his head whip frantically to the left, then to the right, his mouth dropping open as he scanned the empty platform. A second later, he shoved the train tickets into his coat pocket and yanked his cell phone out of his belt clip.

Inside my canvas bag on my lap, my phone began to vibrate against my leg.

I reached into my bag, pulled out my flip phone, and stared down at the glowing outside screen as the CTTA bus turned the corner onto Lafayette Street and left the Williamsburg train station behind in the rain.

BRANDON MERCER — CALLING.

I didn't flip the phone open. Instead, I held down the side volume button to silence the ringer, let the call go unanswered to voicemail, and watched the streetlamps of Williamsburg blur past in the November dusk as the bus carried me south toward Newport News and my brother.

Saturday, November 12, 2005, 4:30 PM — Lee Hall, CVTA Route 116, & Warm Food and a Clean Restroom at Crown Burger

For thirty minutes down Pocahontas Trail alongside the freight railroad tracks, my flip phone vibrated inside my canvas bag every three minutes like a trapped hornet.

Each time the little outer screen lit up with Brandon's name, I kept my thumb pressed over the side button to mute it without opening the hinge. If I answered—even for five seconds to tell him we were finished—he would hear the diesel engine of the bus or the automated stop chime and figure out I was heading south down the Peninsula toward Newport News instead of hiding somewhere in Williamsburg.

At exactly four-thirty, the CTTA Grey Line bus pulled off Warwick Boulevard onto the shoulder at Elmhurst Drive in Lee Hall, right behind a waiting white-and-blue Coastal Virginia Transit Authority low-floor transit coach idling at the transfer shelter with *116 MALL-HALL LOOP* glowing across its headsign.

"Right on time for your CVTA connection," the Grey Line driver smiled, unclipping my four floor straps and lowering the front ramp into the drizzle. "Tell the 116 operator I held the horn for you!"

Rolling thirty feet through the rain from one ramp straight up onto the next, I dropped my fare into the CVTA farebox, asked the operator for a paper transfer slip, and backed into the forward bay as Route 116 pulled back onto Warwick Boulevard heading south.

Fifteen minutes later, at four-forty-five, the bus turned into the transfer stop at the corner of Warwick Boulevard and Denbigh Boulevard beside the Newport Crossing Shopping Center.

"If you're heading downtown toward the shipyard and the transit center, honey, Route 106 pulls in right here at five o'clock, and Route 107 comes through at five-thirty," the woman sitting across the aisle told me kindly as the driver unhooked my straps.

“Thank you, ma’am,” I said, rolling down the ramp onto the wet sidewalk.

Through the rain across the intersection, the glowing red-and-gold sign of a Crown Burger restaurant shone against the gray four-forty-five twilight. My stomach cramped so sharply I had to press my left forearm across my waist. In the chaos of Brandon spending the whole afternoon packing his duffel bag, demanding my birth certificate folder, and marching me over to North Boundary Street, I hadn’t eaten a single bite of food since a piece of toast at eight o’clock that morning—and after nearly an hour of sheer adrenaline in the cold rain, I badly needed to use a restroom.

If I caught the five o’clock Route 106 bus in fifteen minutes, I wouldn’t have time to eat or use a bathroom all the way down to the bottom of Newport News. If I skipped the five o’clock bus and caught the five-thirty Route 107 instead, I had forty-five minutes right here.

Steering my SwiftChair across the crosswalk into the warm, french-fry-scented lobby of the Crown Burger at Warwick and Denbigh, I rolled straight back to the single-user accessible restroom first.

Locking the heavy door behind me, I transferred cautiously with the wall grab bar, used the clean restroom, and washed my face with warm water and paper towels at the roll-under sink. Looking into the clean mirror above the faucet, I barely recognized the pale, rain-streaked twenty-year-old girl staring back at me—until I thought of Nate waiting across the water in Norfolk and felt the steel come back into my spine.

Rolling back out to the front counter at five minutes past five, I ordered a warm junior cheeseburger, a small order of salted fries, and a cup of tap water from the dollar menu. Parking my wheelchair at the farthest corner table where I could watch the Warwick Boulevard bus stop through the plate-glass window, I ate every crumb of the hot burger and fries while my phone buzzed twice more in my bag with silent voicemails from Brandon.

At five-twenty-four, with warm food in my stomach and my raincoat zipped up to my chin, I rolled back out to the curb at Warwick and Denbigh just as the headlights of CVTA Route 107—signed *107 DOWNTOWN / 6TH & IVY*—pulled up to the shelter right on schedule at five-thirty.

Saturday, November 12, 2005, 6:10 PM — Newport News Transit Center, The Disgusting Women’s Restroom, & The Last Route 61 of the Night

By the time Route 107 wound its way south through Hilton Village and pulled under the high canopy of the Newport News Transit Center downtown at six-ten, night had fallen completely and the November rain had intensified into a freezing coastal downpour.

“When is the next bus across the water to Norfolk?” I asked the Route 107 operator as he unclipped my tie-down hooks.

“Bay D across the island—Route 61 at six-forty-five,” the driver answered, glancing at his wristwatch. “And don’t miss it, sweetheart. On Saturday nights, that six-forty-five bus is the very last Route 61 across the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel until tomorrow morning.”

A cold shiver ran down my neck. Thirty-five minutes until the last bus of the night across the harbor—and if I missed it, I would be stranded on the Peninsula overnight on the exact same side of the water as Brandon.

Because the rain was blowing sideways under the outdoor bus bays and I wanted to make sure I didn't need a bathroom before a long cross-harbor ride through the bridge-tunnel and Norfolk, I steered my SwiftChair through the sliding doors into the indoor waiting area of the Newport News Transit Center and pushed open the heavy door to the women's restroom.

The instant the door swung open, the stench hit me like a wall, and I stopped my wheels dead on the threshold.

It was, without question, the most disgusting public restroom I had ever seen in my life.

Above the two stained porcelain sinks, the entire left half of the wall mirror had been ripped clean off the wall, leaving a jagged rectangle of bare, splintered plywood dotted with hardened round blobs of black mastic glue. Inside the accessible stall at the end of the row, the metal toilet paper dispenser had been wrenched loose from its mounting bracket and hung crookedly down the beige partition wall by a single rusty bolt, with damp, shredded wads of paper littering the wet tile floor around an unflushed toilet. Across the beige metal stall doors and the white ceramic wall tiles, layers of vulgar black marker graffiti were scrawled over rusted partition bottoms that looked as though they hadn't seen a mop or disinfectant in months.

Holding my breath so my stomach wouldn't turn over, I used the stall as fast as humanly possible without touching a single surface I didn't have to, scrubbed my hands twice with soap at the sink beneath the half-ripped plywood mirror, and backed my SwiftChair out of that bathroom into the cold night air.

How on earth, I thought to myself as I rolled out under the bus canopy to Bay D at six-thirty-five, *does a regional transit agency expect working people—let alone someone in a wheelchair—to use a transit center that looks like a condemned building?*

Ten minutes later, at six-forty-five sharp, the amber headsign of the last cross-harbor bus of the night swung into Bay D:

61 CROSSROADS — EXPRESSWAYS / DOWNTOWN NORFOLK.

When the driver folded the ramp up behind my wheelchair, strapped my frame into the bay, and pulled out of Newport News toward the interstate—stopping briefly at the Hampton Transit Center at six-fifty-seven before climbing the approach trestle of the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel—I pressed my forehead against the cool glass of the window.

Below the bus windows, the black, white-capped waves of Hampton Roads harbor churned in the storm until the coach plunged downward between the concrete portal walls into the bright, white-tiled tube of the underwater tunnel beneath the Chesapeake Bay.

As the tires hummed through the tunnel beneath the ship channel and climbed back up into the rain on the Southside at Willoughby Spit, I let out a breath I felt like I had been holding since three-fifty-five in Williamsburg.

There was a mile and a half of open water and a submerged concrete tunnel between Brandon Mercer and me now. I was back on the Norfolk side of the harbor.

Saturday, November 12, 2005, 8:00 PM — CVTA Route 1 to Duffy's Lane, Portview Avenue in the Pouring Rain, & Knocking on Nate's Door

Because the six-forty-five Saturday night trip on Route 61 was an Expressways run that terminated in Downtown Norfolk instead of continuing out to Virginia Beach, the driver let me off at the Wards Corner transfer stop at Granby Street and Little Creek Road at seven-nineteen.

For forty-one minutes between seven-nineteen and eight o'clock, there was nowhere to hide from the storm.

Parked as close as I could get against the shallow brick storefront awning at the corner of Granby and Little Creek while sheets of icy November rain blew off the passing headlights and soaked through my raincoat, my jeans, and my sneakers, I tucked my canvas messenger bag inside my jacket against my chest so my birth certificate, my medication pouch, and my cell phone stayed dry, and draped my left sleeve over my right-hand joystick controller to protect the electronics from the water.

At eight o'clock on the dot, the glowing headsign of northbound CVTA Route 1—*1 GRANBY ST / OCEAN VIEW*—splashed to a stop at the Wards Corner curb.

Shivering so hard my teeth clicked together, I rolled up the ramp for my fifth bus ride of the afternoon and evening, riding thirteen minutes straight north up Granby Street until the operator called out my stop at eight-thirteen:

"Duffy's Lane and Ocean View Avenue!"

Rolling down the ramp into the pouring dark at Duffy's Lane, I didn't wait a second. Keeping my speed dial turned all the way up and my left hand shielding my joystick from the driving rain, I cut straight across the glistening asphalt of the shopping center parking lot and turned north onto Portview Avenue.

Half a block up Portview Avenue on my right stood the white-painted two-story courtyard building of Sea Breeze West, with the black numbers *2 3 3* mounted on the front wall and the small tree-shaded courtyard opening to the right.

And right there at the near end of the courtyard walk—the very first door on my right as I turned in from Portview Avenue—glowed the porch light of Apartment 3.

At eight-twenty, soaked to the bone and trembling from head to foot after four hours and twenty minutes across five buses in the rain, I rolled my SwiftChair right up to the wooden door, raised my freezing fist, and pounded on the wood with everything I had left:

"Please let me in!"

The End of Hell & Reclaiming Apartment 3

Part 1: A Sister's Worst Nightmare, Tiffany Forces a Choice, & Scrubbing Out the Filth

Date: 2005-11-12 at 20:20 America/New_York

Saturday, November 12, 2005, 8:20 PM — A Sister's Worst Nightmare & Five Buses from Williamsburg

"Please let me in!" a voice cried out over the roar of the cold November rain hammering the courtyard pavement outside my front door.

It was just after eight-twenty on Saturday evening inside Apartment 3—the far-end ground-floor apartment of the white-painted building at Sea Breeze West, right off Portview Avenue and West Ocean View Avenue, where our door was the very first door on the right as you turned in from Portview Avenue. When the first loud knock rattled the wooden front door, my instinct had been to ignore it. West Ocean View could be a rough neighborhood after dark, and I wasn't about to open my door to a stranger on a rainy November night.

Then I heard that voice through the rain—and my heart stopped.

I recognized my fraternal twin sister's voice instantly. Braking and pivoting my compact SwiftChair power wheelchair around the oval wooden coffee table, I rolled straight up to the wide front windows above the bright green three-cushion sofa and parted two slats of the white horizontal mini-blinds to peek out into the courtyard.

There on the concrete walk under the flickering porch light, drenched to the bone in the driving rainstorm, sat twenty-year-old Katie in her compact SwiftChair.

I unlocked and threw open the wooden front door in the corner so fast the latch banged against the drywall. Rolling her wet tires across the threshold into the living room, Katie threw both arms around my neck across our armrests and sobbed against my shoulder.

"Katie—what happened?!" I asked, holding my twin sister tight as I felt her whole body trembling through her soaking-wet jacket and jeans. Cold rainwater was dripping from her blonde hair onto the green sofa cushion as she transferred out of her wet wheelchair frame onto the couch beside me.

Katie sobbed harder, shivering uncontrollably before letting out a sharp sneeze.

"Brandon lost his mind today because he wanted me to run away with him to Canada to start a new life, and when I saw my chance at the train station, I realized I had to get out of there and start riding buses home to you!" Katie cried, clutching both of my hands as her teeth chattered. "I've been riding five city buses since four o'clock this afternoon just trying to get here from Williamsburg!"

"Tiffany, please get my sis a dry bath towel," I called out toward the hallway as Katie sneezed a second time, before turning my stunned eyes back to my twin sister. "Wait—what? Run away to Canada? Katie, what are you talking about?"

“He marched me over to the Williamsburg train station on Boundary Street with my ID and birth certificate in my bag to buy one-way rail and tunnel-bus tickets through Washington and Toledo up to Windsor, Canada so I’d never see you or Dad again,” Katie sobbed, wiping her rain-soaked face with the back of her trembling hand. “He is plain off-his-rocker crazy, Nate! He locked my drive motors, switched off my joystick under the station awning, and went inside to the ticket counter thinking I wouldn’t dare move—and the second the four o’clock Colonial Triangle Grey Line bus to Lee Hall pulled into the bay, I powered my joystick back on and drove straight up the ramp! He walked back out holding the train tickets right as my bus pulled onto Boundary Street!”

Katie shuddered, her icy fingers tightening around mine as she caught her breath.

“I muted my phone every time he called and transferred at Lee Hall to the 116 down to Warwick and Denbigh, where I ducked into Crown Burger for something warm to eat and a clean restroom before catching the five-thirty 107 down to Newport News Transit Center,” Katie continued, her voice shaking. “I tried to use the women’s restroom inside the Newport News Transit Center while waiting for the tunnel bus—and Nate, half the mirror was ripped off the wall over bare plywood and black glue blobs, the toilet paper holder was hanging by one bolt, and there was graffiti and filth everywhere. I got out of there, caught the very last six-forty-five Route 61 of the night across the bridge-tunnel to Wards Corner, waited forty minutes in the pouring rain for the eight o’clock Route 1 bus to Duffy’s Lane, and rolled across the shopping center lot and half a block up Portview Avenue until I saw your door!”

I could see my sister was frightened beyond belief as Tiffany walked slowly back down the short hallway from the bathroom carrying a folded bath towel. Katie sneezed again, shivering so hard her shoulders shook.

“Do you have anything dry in your bag to change into?” I asked gently, draping the dry towel around Katie’s shoulders. “I want you to get out of those sopping-wet clothes before you catch pneumonia.”

“No,” Katie sobbed, shaking her head. “I didn’t even have time to pack a bag when I escaped—I just had to get out of there and get to you.”

“Alright, here’s what we’ll do,” I said immediately. “Take my oversized dry flannel shirt and sweatpants from my dresser so you can get out of those soaked outer clothes in the bathroom, and I’ve got my warm sleeping bag you can zip up in on the green sofa for tonight. There’s a quarter-operated laundry room right across the courtyard in the red-brick Sea Breeze West building, and I can run your wet clothes through the washer and dryer right now so you have your own clean clothes to wear in the morning.”

Standing awkwardly beside the repurposed dining table that held my desktop tower PC running Quantum OS XN Pro, Tiffany cleared her throat. “Let me go wash her clothes,” Tiffany said. “You need to comfort your sister.”

Once Katie had changed out of her drenched outer clothes into dry layers and wrapped the bath towel and my sleeping bag around herself on the green sofa, Tiffany picked up Katie’s soggy mustard-yellow shirt and jeans, grabbed the bottle of laundry soap and our roll of quarters off the laminate kitchen counter, and stepped out the front door across the rainy courtyard toward the red-brick building’s laundry room.

The moment the door closed and it was just the two of us inside the living room, Katie zipped the sleeping bag up to her collarbone, reached out, and gripped my hand with both of hers.

“I’m just so scared, Nate,” Katie sobbed, her blue eyes wide as she held onto my fingers like a lifeline. “Please don’t leave my side.”

“I’m right here, Katie—nobody is getting past that door tonight,” I promised, squeezing her hand back until a loud rumble echoed from her stomach. “You haven’t eaten anything since that stop at Warwick and Denbigh before five o’clock, have you? Would you like something to eat?”

“Please,” Katie whispered, wiping her eyes. “Some real food, please.”

I rolled twenty feet forward to the open kitchen—feeling a wave of hot embarrassment in the pit of my stomach as my wheels navigated around the cluttered piles of unemptied trash bags, greasy fast-food wrappers, and crusty dishes that Tiffany had left littering the floor and counters—and reached into the cabinet for the only clean, sealed package I could find: a box of low-fat baked potato chips.

Rolling back to the bright green sofa, I opened the box and offered a small handful of chips to my sister. Sitting up against the arm of the green sofa inside the sleeping bag, Katie ate the chips gratefully while keeping her free hand linked with mine.

“They really thought they could force me to move to Canada and cut me off from you and Dad forever,” Katie whispered, her voice still shaking from the five-bus ordeal through the rain. “Nate, do you mind if I take a hot shower? I’ve been riding five city buses all afternoon and evening trying to get here from Williamsburg. I’m hungry, I’m exhausted, I’m scared, and I’m still freezing from the rain.”

“Come on, let’s get the hot water running for you,” I said, helping Katie out of the sleeping bag and steadying her arm as we rolled down the straight right-hand hallway past the two white bi-folding doors of the closet on the left hallway wall.

At the end of the hallway—where there was no door or doorway at all, and the space opened directly to the left into the back bedroom under the through-wall air conditioner on the back exterior wall—we turned left into the bedroom toward the bathroom entrance door, which opened inward from the bedroom into the small bathroom equipped with a sink, toilet, and a bathtub fitted with steel grab bars—though to my disgust, I first had to push aside a stack of dirty kitchen pots and pans that Tiffany had bizarrely dumped inside the tub instead of washing them. After showing Katie how to adjust the hot-water faucet and making sure a fresh dry towel was within easy reach of the grab bars, I rolled back out into the living room and closed the bathroom door so she could warm up in privacy.

By the time Katie finished her hot shower and transferred back into the warm sleeping bag on the green sofa beneath the front window blinds, Tiffany had returned from across the courtyard with Katie’s freshly dried clothes folded in her arms.

Even with the warm water taking the chill out of her bones, Katie was still too traumatized to close her eyes unless she was holding my hand. Parking my SwiftChair right beside the oval wooden coffee table at the edge of the green sofa, I held my twin sister's hand for the next hour while she whispered every terrifying detail of how Brandon had tried to isolate and trap her in Williamsburg.

"I promise you're safe here tonight, Katie," I told her gently as the clock on my Quantum OS XN Pro computer monitor near the kitchen ticked toward midnight. "Since the connecting bus routes don't run on Sundays into our neighborhood in Virginia Beach, you can rest right here all day tomorrow and we'll figure everything out on Monday."

Katie pulled me into a tight hug from the sofa and wept softly against my collar. "Thank you, Nate." She let out a long, exhausted yawn, though her eyes still darted nervously toward the front window blinds.

"We really need to get some sleep—it's almost midnight, and after five buses from Williamsburg, you especially need your rest," I said softly, squeezing her hand one last time before rolling down the hallway toward the open-doorway back bedroom where the through-wall box air conditioner hummed opposite its wall-mounted temperature switch. "Tomorrow morning, we'll help you get everything sorted out."

Sunday, November 13, 2005, 8:15 AM — Dry Cereal Without Milk & Tiffany Forces a Choice in the Open Kitchen

Morning barely filtered through the white horizontal mini-blinds at the front of the apartment when the sound of muffled crying from the living room jolted me awake.

Transferring out of the queen bed into my SwiftChair in seconds, I rolled straight out of the doorless back bedroom down the hallway to the green sofa.

Katie was sitting upright inside the sleeping bag with both hands pressed over her face, sobbing uncontrollably.

"I had a nightmare," Katie cried as I rolled right up to the sofa cushion and wrapped both arms around her shoulders. "They were forcing me across the border into Canada and locking me in a room where I couldn't call you or Dad. It felt so real, Nate!"

"You're right here in Ocean View with me—Brandon can never touch you again," I said, holding my twin sister close until her breathing steadied. "Let me make you some breakfast. How does cereal sound?"

"Please," Katie said, wiping her cheeks. "And could you hand me my clothes from the chair? I want to get dressed."

I handed Katie her clean mustard-yellow short-sleeve T-shirt and blue jeans from the laundry pile, giving her privacy while she got dressed and transferred into her SwiftChair, while I rolled straight ahead into the open kitchen under the hanging amber cone pull-chain lamp—along the narrow lane of linoleum I had cleared earlier that morning by shoving the worst floor piles into black garbage bags just so both of our wheelchairs could maneuver—and took two bowls and a box of toasted oat cereal down from the counter.

When I rolled back to the oval wooden coffee table and set the two bowls down in front of us, Katie looked down at the dry cereal and blinked in surprise.

“No milk?” Katie asked.

“Tiffany claims she’s lactose intolerant,” I explained, unable to hide the weary frustration in my voice as I glanced back toward the black top-freezer refrigerator. “She says even the sight of a jug of milk in the refrigerator makes her sick, so she won’t let me keep any in the apartment.”

Katie ate her dry cereal grudgingly without saying another word about the milk—she knew me well enough to see that complaining to me about Tiffany’s rules right now was barking up the wrong tree—until she set her spoon down and looked quietly into my eyes.

“Nate,” Katie said in a low voice, “sometime today, when it’s just you and me, I want to talk.”

“What is it?” I asked.

“I want to talk to you—just you,” Katie repeated evenly, glancing toward the hallway. “Ask me again when it’s just you and me.”

Before I could answer, footsteps shuffled down the hallway from the back bedroom.

Wearing her black-rimmed rectangular glasses, her mint-green short-sleeve graphic T-shirt, and her charcoal-gray pants, Tiffany stepped out of the hallway into the open kitchen right in front of the slate-blue four-burner stove and the black top-freezer refrigerator. Stopping beneath the hanging amber cone pull-chain lamp and the olive-green upper cabinets, she folded her arms, glared at Katie and me sitting together by the oval coffee table, and spoke in a loud, accusatory sneer.

“You know, you seem to be cuddling with Katie a whole lot more than me,” Tiffany snapped. “Do you not love me?”

Beside me, Katie looked at Tiffany with pure disgust. To my twin sister, the very idea that anyone would try to force an ultimatum between a loyal twin sibling and a romantic partner—after Katie had just escaped an abusive nightmare in Williamsburg the night before—was repellent.

“Uh, excuse me?” Katie spoke up, rolling her SwiftChair two feet forward toward the open kitchen.

I knew the two of them had disliked each other ever since Tiffany ruined our brother-and-sister weekend fourteen months ago, but one rule had been carved into my soul since the day we were born: no one insults my twin sister. Watching Tiffany glare at Katie felt like that awful day in Newport News when Tiffany had disrespected our developmentally disabled cousin Chelsea all over again.

“Of course I love you, Tiffany,” I replied, rolling my chair up beside Katie’s in front of the stove, “but why can’t you accept that I love my twin sister too?”

“You really need to think about what you just said, Tiffany,” Katie said firmly, looking straight up at her. “I’m his twin sister; you’re his girlfriend. There is zero reason on earth why you should be getting jealous of me hugging my brother after what I went through yesterday.”

Tiffany’s face contorted with fury behind her black-rimmed glasses, and she lunged half a step forward in front of the slate-blue stove, screaming straight into Katie’s face:

“Don’t you talk to me like that!”

Right then and there, standing in front of that filthy kitchen counter between the slate-blue stove and the black refrigerator, every warning Katie had given me outside in the Sea Breeze West courtyard fourteen months ago clicked into focus. My girlfriend hated my twin sister, disrespected my family, and wanted me isolated in the dark—and I was never going to choose anyone who treated Katie like that.

Katie and I sat side by side in our wheelchairs, staring daggers straight back at Tiffany without giving an inch.

Seeing the look in my eyes—realizing for the first time that her temper tantrum wasn’t going to make me apologize or push Katie away—Tiffany looked at me with deep loathing and rage.

“Forget it!” Tiffany shrieked, grabbing her purse and jacket off the corner of the repurposed dining-table computer desk. “You don’t love me! Good riddance!”

“No, he doesn’t love you!” Katie snarled, wheeling forward toward the front door as Tiffany yanked it open. “Go on! Get out of here! Stay away from me, and stay away from my brother! Don’t ever come back!”

The wooden front door slammed so hard the white horizontal mini-blinds rattled against the glass.

In the sudden, ringing silence of Apartment 3, Katie turned her wheelchair toward me and spoke gently.

“You’re probably going to hate me for saying this right now, Nate, but I’m glad she’s leaving you,” Katie said softly. “If your girlfriend can’t even accept you hugging and comforting your own twin sister, then you don’t need her in your life.”

All at once, the dam inside my chest broke. Even though Katie was still raw and traumatized from her escape from Williamsburg, I started crying right alongside her as the reality registered in my twenty-year-old mind: my girlfriend had just dumped me and walked out the door.

Katie immediately rolled flush against my chair, pulled me into a deep, grounding hug across our armrests, and held the back of my head against her shoulder.

“Would you like me to stay here with you for now?” Katie whispered as she wiped the tears from my eyes and I wiped hers. “This way you won’t have to be alone.”

“Please—would you, Katie?” I asked, my voice shaking.

Katie knew how much I hated being alone. Holding both of my hands, she offered a brave little smile. “Want me to make us some lunch?”

Rolling four feet forward into the open kitchen, Katie opened the black top-freezer refrigerator and the olive-green base cabinets, then grimaced as she surveyed the crusty counters, the overflowing trash bags, and the sour smell hanging in the air.

“You know, Nate, she really is a pig,” Katie said bluntly, closing the empty refrigerator door. “I still have my paycheck money in my wallet. How about we roll down to the shopping center and grab a real hot lunch, and pick up some basic groceries while we’re out?”

“Alright, Katie,” I nodded, wiping my face. “And while we’re at the grocery store in the shopping center, you can buy a Norfolk CVTA bus pass right at the front customer-service desk.”

“Do they sell a monthly pass?” Katie asked as we rolled out the front door into the sunny Sunday courtyard.

“Fifty dollars for thirty days,” I told her as we wheeled down the sidewalk along West Ocean View Avenue. “It’s a thirty-day magnetic card, and the thirty-day clock doesn’t start ticking until the first time you swipe it in the farebox on a CVTA bus.”

Sunday, November 13, 2005, 1:00 PM — Crown Burger & The Heavy-Duty Deep Clean of Apartment 3

Twenty minutes later, after picking up Katie’s new thirty-day bus pass at the grocery store counter, the two of us sat across from each other at an accessible table inside the Ocean View Crown Burger right down West Ocean View Avenue with hot burgers, crispy fries, and two tall cups of soda in front of us.

Now that we were out of the apartment and away from the stench of Tiffany’s mess, Katie leaned forward across the table and looked me straight in the eyes.

“Now that she’s not around, Nate, I’m going to be blunt and I’m going to be completely honest with you,” Katie said evenly. “She was treating you like trash—and I know this isn’t polite to say when you just broke up, but I wanted you to leave her.”

I opened my mouth to say something, only for Katie to hold up her hand and continue.

“I know your bedroom—and mine too—have gotten a little messy with computer books or laundry at times when we were teenagers,” Katie said, her voice tight with protective anger. “But never in our entire lives have I seen you live in filth like what’s back in that apartment right now. That apartment isn’t just cluttered, Nate—it is trashed. It’s overstuffed with rotting garbage bags that haven’t been taken to the dumpster in weeks, crusty takeout containers stacked on every surface, and filthy dishes everywhere. Tiffany is a pig, and I don’t want you associating with her ever again.”

Again I tried to speak, and Katie immediately reached across the burger wrappers to take my hand so I wouldn’t misunderstand her.

“It’s not you I’m mad at, Nate,” Katie said softly. “I know how your mind works when somebody bullies you and shuts you down until you freeze up. I’m mad at her for treating my twin brother like trash. But now it’s over and done with. Welcome back to the light.”

Those four words—*welcome back to the light*—brought fresh tears welling into my eyes. With Tiffany officially my ex, the heavy, suffocating fog that had trapped me inside Apartment 3 for the last year was finally lifting, and I could see clearly that every word my twin sister was speaking was the truth.

“You’re saying…” I started, my voice choking up.

“Truth is,” Katie whispered, her own blue eyes tearing up across the table, “I never approved of Tiffany. Remember that weekend last September when I took the Route 1 bus here because I wanted a brother-and-sister weekend with you and just you?”

“Yeah,” I answered quietly, remembering how I had snapped at Katie outside in the courtyard before she swore her *Speak now or forever hold your peace* vow.

“That’s the exact day she lost every shred of my trust—when she threw a fit and insisted she wouldn’t allow the two of us to spend a weekend together,” Katie said. “I wanted a brother-and-sister weekend with my twin. I wasn’t going to bring an ex-boyfriend between us, and I never wanted a girlfriend coming between us either.”

When we rolled back down West Ocean View Avenue and returned to Apartment 3, the sight of the trashed combination living room and kitchen hit me like a physical blow. Transferring onto the bright green sofa beneath the front window blinds, I felt so emotionally drained that Katie transferred onto the cushion beside me, opened her arms, and let me rest my head in her lap while she wrapped her arms around my shoulders.

“Katie,” I whispered, staring at the worn carpet by the oval coffee table, “do you promise not to tell anyone what I’m getting ready to tell you?”

“Twin’s promise,” Katie said softly, curling her arms more tightly around me to let me know I was completely safe.

Resting my cheek against my sister’s knee, I finally let out everything I had kept locked inside my chest for a year—how Tiffany and Tiffany’s manipulative mother had coerced and guilt-tripped me from the very beginning, using affection as a weapon to separate me from my family, and how toward the end Tiffany’s mother had turned on me with open hatred while Tiffany let the apartment rot around us.

After holding me in silence for a long time and letting me cry until my chest stopped aching, Katie made her decision.

“I want to live with you, Nate,” Katie said, looking down into my eyes with steady, unbreakable resolve.

My heart leaped with relief, and I loved what she said next even more.

“We’re going to get this apartment into decent, spotless condition until your lease is up, I promise you,” Katie said, pulling me upright into a fierce hug. “We’re going to pack every single one of Tiffany’s things into separate bags by the door, and we’re

going to make Apartment 3 a real home for you and me—a place that both of us can be proud to show our friends and Dad. First question: what bus takes us from here to the Community College of Hampton Roads in Virginia Beach?"

"Thank you, Katie," I said, wiping my eyes with a real smile breaking across my face. "Tomorrow morning, we can catch the Route 1 bus that leaves Ocean View Station at thirteen minutes past the hour—it's about a ninety-minute ride down to the Virginia Beach campus. Or if you want a shorter commute, maybe you could register for classes at the Norfolk campus downtown? That's only forty-five minutes on the Downtown 1 or about an hour on the Downtown 3."

"All my friends are at the Virginia Beach campus," Katie replied without hesitation.

"Alright," I smiled. "Tomorrow morning, I'll take you on the bus down to the Beach campus and we'll register together."

"Thanks, Nate," Katie said, transferring back into her SwiftChair and rolling her sleeves up past her elbows. "Now, let's get this apartment cleaned up. Priority one: where are the heavy-duty trash bags? Anything that's garbage, throw it straight in. Anything that belongs to Tiffany, put it in a separate bag by the front door in case she and her mother come back to collect her things. You're going to hate me for how hard I push us today, because this filth won't be cleaned in five minutes—but I promise you, it will get done, and we are going to do it together."

The truth was, the deeper we dug into the apartment, the more mortified I felt. It wasn't just untidy; it was an overwhelming disaster of uncollected trash and grime that needed heavy-duty scrubbing from floor to baseboards. To keep our spirits up, Katie rolled over to the large repurposed dining table on the left side between the living room and the kitchen, woke up my seventeen-inch off-white CRT monitor and my 2004 desktop tower PC—which ran Quantum OS XN Pro and still sported the salvaged off-white three-and-a-half-inch floppy drive, CD-ROM drive, and CD-RW drive from our older desktop computer—and queued up a playlist of our favorite upbeat nineteen-eighties synth-rock and pop tracks through the desktop speakers.

For the next two hours, working side by side from our compact power wheelchairs, Katie tackled the overflowing trash around the green sofa, the oval coffee table, and the open kitchen counters while I bagged up the piles of garbage choking the back hallway and the open-doorway bedroom. Sweat poured down my forehead as I tied off bag after heavy black bag, my gag reflex kicking in half a dozen times whenever we uncovered week-old takeout containers festering at the bottom of a pile.

"Nate, come help me clean the bathroom!" Katie called out from the short hallway on the far right.

"Coming," I called back, rolling out of the doorless bedroom and turning left toward the inward-opening bathroom door.

Katie was sitting in her wheelchair just inside the bathroom doorway, staring in disbelief at the bathtub beneath the steel grab bars.

"Why on earth are all of these kitchen pots and pans stacked inside the bathtub?!" Katie demanded.

“Ask Tiffany that,” I groaned in pure disgust. “Whenever she didn’t feel like washing a pot in the kitchen sink, she just dumped it in the tub so she wouldn’t have to look at it.”

“Here is what we’re going to do,” Katie said, pinching the bridge of her nose. “Let’s haul every single one of those pots and pans out of the bathtub and stack them by the kitchen sink for now. Then we’re going to scrub this entire bathroom down together with heavy-duty cleaner from the grab bars to the tile floor. Once the bathroom is sparkling, I’ll help you go through the pots and pans to see which ones are even salvageable and which ones go straight in the dumpster.”

“Alright, Katie,” I said.

Both of us gagged out loud as we lifted the crusted, foul-smelling pots and pans out of the bathtub onto a plastic tray on our laps and ferried them back to the open kitchen.

“That old bat was absolutely disgusting,” Katie shuddered, wiping her hands with a soapy paper towel. “Let’s haul all of these tied-up trash bags out to the dumpsters behind the complex first so we can breathe, and then we’ll scrub the bathroom together.”

Rolling back into the living room and looking around at the newly cleared carpet between the bright green sofa, the oval wooden coffee table, and the Quantum OS XN Pro computer table, I realized just how deeply Katie cared about me. Tears stung my eyes again, and I braked my chair beside hers and pulled her into a grateful hug.

“Thank you, Katie,” I sobbed quietly against her shoulder. “The place is starting to look so much better already.”

“She was a pig, Nate, and you deserve to live in a clean, decent home where you feel comfortable having family and friends over,” Katie said warmly, hugging me back before tapping my armrest with a grin. “Now let’s keep rolling and finish the job, because this place is nowhere near done yet!”

Side by side, balancing the heavy black garbage bags across our footplates and armrests, we rolled out the front door of Apartment 3, wheeled down the courtyard walk past the white two-rail fence, and heaved bag after bag into the steel dumpsters behind the complex.

“Do we have any air fresheners inside?” Katie asked as we rolled back through the courtyard.

“I don’t think so,” I admitted.

By late Sunday afternoon—after hours of scrubbing the grab-bar bathtub, the bathroom sink and toilet, the olive-green kitchen cabinets, the speckled laminate prep counters, the slate-blue stove, and the inside of the black top-freezer refrigerator—Apartment 3 finally looked and smelled like a human home again.

“I actually feel like we could have company over now,” Katie said with a tired, proud sigh as she surveyed the clean living room and kitchen. “We just need to air the rooms out and pick up some air fresheners to clear out the last of that stale smell.

How about we roll straight down to the shopping center first to grab a nice dinner and some plug-in air fresheners? Then when we get back home, we can take hot showers and relax for the rest of the night."

"Yeah—after hauling all those bags to the dumpster, I'm wiped out," I smiled. "Food first."

An hour later, after celebrating with a hot dinner at the shopping center and plugging fresh linen-scented air fresheners into the outlets by the green sofa and the open kitchen, Katie and I braked our compact SwiftChairs side by side in front of the bright green three-cushion sofa beneath the white horizontal window mini-blinds, our footrests angled two inches apart and each of us holding a cold can of ginger ale.

Outside the front windows, the November night was dark and quiet, and the open top sash was letting a crisp salt breeze off the Chesapeake Bay clear the last traces of stale grease out of Apartment 3. My arms ached from hours of scrubbing countertops and baseboards, and dark circles still lingered under Katie's eyes from her four-hour-and-twenty-minute journey across five buses in the rain the night before, yet the apartment was quieter and more peaceful than it had been in fourteen months.

Katie took a slow sip from her ginger ale can, looked around at the clean walls and the wide, unobstructed turning space between the sofa and the kitchen doorway, and then looked over at me. All of a sudden, fresh tears welled up in her blue eyes and spilled down her cheeks.

"Katie?" I asked softly, rolling half a foot closer and reaching across our armrests to take her hand. "What's wrong?"

"I'm just thinking about everything that happened to the two of us over the last fourteen months," Katie wept, gripping my fingers tightly with hers as the tears streamed down her face. "Do you remember what everybody kept telling us when our lease in West Ghent was coming up last summer? How twenty-year-olds aren't supposed to just live with their twin forever? How we needed to get out there, date normal people, and have our own separate lives?"

I looked down at the condensation on my ginger ale can, thinking of fourteen months of Tiffany piling dirty pans in the bathtub, blocking my turning radius in the hallway with her junk, and slamming doors whenever Katie's name flashed on my phone.

"Yeah," I said softly. "I remember."

"Look at how badly both of us got hurt the first time in our lives we ever let people pull us apart, Nate," Katie said, her voice steady through her tears in the quiet room. "Brandon used to grab the push-handles on the back of my chair whenever he didn't like how fast I was rolling or who I was talking to. He made me feel like needing a wheelchair and taking daily medicine meant I owed him obedience for putting up with me, and yesterday he tried to drag me to Canada where I'd never see you or Dad again. And Tiffany and her mother had you trapped right here in the dark, bullying you and treating you like garbage. Last night, when I was sitting in the pouring rain at Wards Corner waiting for the Route 1 bus to bring me here, I realized the only people on this earth who have never once made us feel broken are you, me, and Dad."

My throat tightened as I watched the tears glistening on my twin sister's cheeks. All afternoon she had been the fierce, unstoppable one pushing us through bag after bag of rotting trash, and only now that the apartment was finally clean and quiet did the full weight of what both of us had survived come crashing down on her heart.

"I'm so sorry I didn't listen to you in the courtyard last September, Katie," I whispered, my own eyes stinging as I squeezed her hand. "And I'm so sorry I wasn't up there in Williamsburg to protect you from Brandon."

"We're together now—that's what matters," Katie cried softly, looking straight into my eyes as she held my hand like an unbreakable vow between our two chairs. "I'm done letting outsiders into our lives, Nate. I don't ever want a boyfriend or a husband, and I don't ever want another person moving into our home and trying to split us up or run our lives. Aside from Dad, nobody else gets inside our walls ever again. When you asked me this morning if I wanted to move in here and live with you, I didn't mean just until our next lease is up. I promise you right here and right now: we will never separate ever again."

"Neither did I—and never again," I promised her back, my throat tightening as I squeezed her fingers. "Dad is the only other person who ever gets a key to our front door. When it comes to our lives, it's you and me from here on out, Katie. Fifty-fifty on every lease, every house we ever buy, every line of code we write, and every bus we ride—for the rest of our lives."

Katie smiled through her tears, the tension of the last fourteen months finally melting out of her shoulders as she tapped her ginger ale can gently against mine.

"Just you and me, fifty-fifty for life—plus Dad," Katie whispered. "Deal."

When we rolled down the hallway into our freshly scrubbed bathroom to wash off six hours of heavy-duty cleaning, there wasn't a shred of awkwardness or a need to look away between the two of us. We had come into the world at the same hour, lost the use of our legs on the exact same Friday afternoon in eleventh grade at Northwood High School, and spent years helping each other through transfers and muscle spasms when nobody else understood how our bodies worked. Neither of us wanted an outside home-health aide or an able-bodied partner standing over us ever again, and looking at each other had never felt any different than looking in a mirror.

While I leaned forward from my SwiftChair to turn the shower valve all the way to hot until warm steam billowed across the clean bathroom tile, we peeled off our sweat-damp shirts, jeans, and underclothes right beside our chairs. I transferred onto the wide padded bath bench beneath the steel grab bars first, then reached out both hands to brace Katie's hips and ribs as she slid across from her seat cushion right against my side under the steaming spray.

As the hot water poured over both of our shoulders, Katie let out a long, relieved sigh and leaned her weight sideways against my bare shoulder while I held her steady with one arm around her waist and used the handheld showerhead with the other to warm our tired legs and feet. When Brandon had touched her in Williamsburg, he had grabbed her from above over her wheelchair backrest like a warden pinning a prisoner down; sitting pressed side by side on the transfer bench washing the last grime of the weekend off each other's skin while Katie lathered my back and I washed her hair, neither of us had to hide an inch of ourselves.

Twenty minutes later, dried off with clean bath towels while the bathroom heater ticked warmly behind us, we rolled out of the bathroom into the doorless back bedroom and stopped side by side in front of the queen bed.

We took one look at that caving-in mattress in the far corner—the bed where Tiffany and I had slept during the worst year of my life—and both of us felt the exact same wave of revulsion at the exact same second.

“I don’t want to sleep where you and Tiffany slept, Nate,” Katie said flatly, wrinkling her nose at the sagging center of the mattress. “Even if we buy brand-new sheets at the mall tomorrow so the bedroom doesn’t look like an eyesore, I do not want either of us lying on that bed tonight.”

“Me neither,” I agreed immediately. “Looking at that mattress just makes my skin crawl.”

Katie sat quiet for a moment in her wheelchair, then turned her head toward the straight carpeted hallway, where the standard-width white bi-folding doors of the hallway closet stood open on the left wall above the freshly vacuumed carpet we had cleared out that afternoon. All at once, a mischievous, brilliant spark lit up her blue eyes.

“I have a crazy idea,” Katie said.

“What’s your crazy idea?” I asked.

“What if we do just like we did back in Apartment A6 on Greenway Court, and take our sleeping bag and the pillows I was using on the green sofa last night and move them right onto the carpeted floor inside the hallway closet so the two of us can make the closet our bedroom again?” Katie asked.

The moment she said it, my whole chest relaxed. Back when we lived together in Apartment A6 on Greenway Court, our full-sized bed out in the main studio had rarely ever been used because both of us had much preferred sleeping cuddled up together inside our single shared sleeping bag in the confined space of the square closet. Because both of us are autistic, vast open rooms with drafty windows and streetlamp glare leaking through mini-blinds left our nervous systems on high alert—whereas a small, enclosed, dark space where we could tuck in together inside a single shared sleeping bag and hold each other close made us feel completely secure.

“Katie, that isn’t crazy at all—that’s genius,” I smiled.

Rolling back out to the bright green sofa in the living room, we gathered up the warm navy-blue sleeping bag and the two pillows Katie had used the night before, carried them across our laps down the carpeted hallway, and spread the sleeping bag and pillows neatly across the vacuumed carpet on the floor of the hallway closet.

When we transferred down out of our compact SwiftChairs onto the soft carpet at the closet threshold, we didn’t bother putting pajama shirts or shorts back on. Because full-time wheelchair users with lower-extremity neuromuscular paralysis have impaired circulation below the waist, tight waistbands and tangled fabric only trapped the chill against our legs—and the fastest, most natural way to keep our core temperature steady and calm our muscle spasms all night was sharing our body heat skin-to-skin inside the sleeping bag.

Climbing into the single navy-blue sleeping bag together and zipping the quilted fabric up to our shoulders, I reached up to pull the two white bi-folding closet doors completely closed until they latched, and Katie reached up to click off the overhead closet light.

Instant, velvet darkness wrapped around us from wall to wall.

“I missed sleeping right beside my twin sister,” I whispered inside the snug, pitch-dark quiet of the enclosed closet as a single tear of relief slipped from the corner of my eye onto the pillow.

Turning on our sides facing each other inside the shared sleeping bag, Katie curled her bare front tight against my chest and tucked her cool feet between my shins while I wrapped both arms securely around her bare back—holding her flush against my heartbeat at the exact same level, where nobody was hovering over a chair or caging either of us in. Within minutes, our shared warmth soaked into our legs, calming every last tremor of fight-or-flight anxiety in our autistic minds.

“You’re still shaken up from everything today, aren’t you?” Katie asked comfortingly, resting a gentle hand against my cheek as I laid my head against her shoulder.

Even in the dark, she knew me by heart.

“You just want to hold me, don’t you?” Katie whispered, wrapping both arms securely around my shoulders inside the shared sleeping bag so I wouldn’t burst into tears again. “It’s alright, Nate. Both of us went through hell this weekend, and you’re emotionally exhausted. We had a long afternoon scrubbing this whole apartment back to life—so tonight, inside our own quiet little sanctuary, just hold onto me and get some sleep.”

She leaned over and gently kissed my forehead goodnight, just like we used to do when we were kids on Delaney Street, and bundled together inside that dark, enclosed hallway closet, both of us fell fast asleep feeling completely secure.

Part 2: The 8:13 AM Bus to CCHR, All-New Queen Bedding, Dad’s Pickup Truck, & The Hallway Closet Sanctuary

Date: 2005-11-14 at 07:30 America/New_York

Monday, November 14, 2005, 7:30 AM — Real Milk in the Cereal Bowls & The 8:13 AM Route 1 Bus to CCHR

“Good morning, sleepyhead—look what’s in the bowls today,” Katie called out cheerfully from the open kitchen as I rolled my compact SwiftChair out of the doorless back bedroom down the short right-hand hallway.

Under the hanging amber cone pull-chain lamp, Katie was pouring cold, fresh white milk from a half-gallon carton we had picked up the night before into two bowls of toasted oat cereal on the speckled laminate counter.

“Real milk!” I grinned, rolling up to the oval wooden coffee table in front of the bright green sofa as Katie carried both bowls over on a tray.

“And even better news,” Katie said, setting my bowl down in front of me before parking her SwiftChair beside mine. “I called Dad at his house in Virginia Beach twenty minutes ago. He knows that you and I are living together here in Apartment 3 now, he knows Tiffany left you in that disgusting mess and that the two of us spent all day Sunday scrubbing the apartment clean, and he’s bringing his pickup truck over this afternoon to help us move my dresser and clothes in! Now, what time did you say the bus to Virginia Beach leaves?”

“Thirteen minutes past the hour,” I answered after giving my twin sister a grateful thank-you hug across our armrests. “We just roll right up West Ocean View Avenue to Ocean View Station by the Burger Arch. It’s a ninety-minute ride down to the Community College of Hampton Roads Virginia Beach Campus—and we just have to remember that the last bus leaving CCHR to bring us back here is at 5:45 PM, because buses in Virginia Beach stop running around dinnertime for some reason.”

“Today I want to get both of us registered for our CCHR classes so we’re right back on track,” Katie said, taking a spoonful of cereal with real milk. “And while we’re in Virginia Beach, I want to take the bus over to Chesapeake Bay Mall and buy brand-new bedding for the queen mattress—sheets, comforter, pillows, everything—because I don’t trust a single thread that’s currently on that bed. Which bus routes go from CCHR toward Dad’s house off Military Highway and Indian River Road?”

“Any of the routes hubbing out of CCHR—Routes 12, 25, 26, 29, 33, and 36,” I told her.

“Perfect,” Katie said. “I told Dad we’d meet him with his pickup truck after we pick up the new bedding at the mall, ride over to his house to load up my basics—my laptop, my dresser, my clothes, my clock radio, and my television and DVD player—and bring them straight back here to Ocean View.”

As soon as we finished eating breakfast, Katie picked up both of our empty cereal bowls and our spoons from the oval coffee table and rolled straight back to the kitchen sink.

“From now on, Nate, we wash as we go,” Katie declared, turning on the hot tap and scrubbing both bowls with dish soap right from her wheelchair. “This way there are never any smelly, crusted dishes lying around the sink or the bathtub ever again.”

Glancing at her wristwatch as she set the two sparkling bowls into the drying rack, Katie dried her hands on a clean dish towel. “I want us on that 8:13 AM Route 1 bus. If we catch the 8:13 at the Burger Arch, what time will we roll into CCHR?”

“Right around 9:45 AM—it’s an hour and thirty minutes end to end,” I said, watching in admiration as she finished wiping down the sink rim. “You really meant it about doing the dishes immediately!”

“We used two cereal bowls for breakfast, and washing them the second we finish takes sixty seconds,” Katie smiled, unlocking her brakes and rolling toward the front door by the white mini-blinds. “I want both of us to feel proud of how neat we’re keeping our apartment. Come on—let’s catch the 8:13!”

Ten minutes later, at the Ocean View Station bus loop near the Burger Arch, the blue-and-silver CVTA Route 1 bus knelt at the curb and lowered its hydraulic front ramp. Rolling up the ramp one behind the other, Katie swiped her brand-new fifty-

dollar thirty-day magnetic bus pass in the farebox right after mine, and the driver secured both of our compact SwiftChairs into the front wheelchair bays behind the yellow line.

Even after four years in our powerchairs, the cool damp November air had left a dull ache in my lower legs, and it felt wonderful to sit securely side by side with my twin sister as the bus rolled south down Granby Street and turned east toward Virginia Beach.

“Welcome to our oh-so-wonderful regional transit patchwork,” I joked to Katie as the Route 1 crossed the municipal line out of Norfolk into Virginia Beach. “Back in Norfolk on Route 1, no complaints at all—you can catch a bus late into the night. Cross the city line into Virginia Beach, though, and the whole bus system shuts down at dinner like nobody with a job or a wheelchair ever needs to go anywhere after six o’clock.”

“Wait until we start writing about that online,” Katie murmured, her blue eyes narrowing thoughtfully as she looked out the bus window at the narrow road shoulders without sidewalks.

At 9:45 AM sharp, the Route 1 pulled into the transit loop at the Community College of Hampton Roads Virginia Beach Campus. Rolling into the student services building together, we got in line at the registrar’s counter while I pulled out my flip phone and called Dad to let him know we had made it safely down from Ocean View on the bus and were registering for classes.

At the counter, Katie and I came up with a registration plan that gave us the best of both worlds: we signed up to take United States History together in the exact same lecture section—which knocked out our required history credits side by side—while letting each of us pursue our favorite subjects in our other classes, with me diving into computer programming and software architecture while Katie registered for early European literature.

At 11:45 AM, with our printed spring class schedules tucked safely into Katie’s backpack, we rolled out to the CCHR bus loop and boarded CVTA Route 29 up to Chesapeake Bay Mall.

“Priority one,” Katie announced as we wheeled off the Route 29 ramp into the mall entrance: “I’m starving! Let’s grab lunch at the food court first, and then we’re heading downstairs to the department store for bedding. I’m sorry, Nate, but what Tiffany left on that bed was disgusting, and I want all-new everything so you never have to be reminded of her in our bedroom again.”

After eating lunch together upstairs, we took the mall elevator down to the lower level and rolled into the home-goods department among the rows of packaged sheet sets and comforters.

“Can I help you two find anything today?” a friendly sales clerk asked, stepping over to our wheelchairs.

“Yes, please!” Katie replied brightly. “I’m moving in with my twin brother to help him get back on his feet, and I’m looking for a complete, high-quality bedding set for a queen-sized mattress. All we’re keeping is the mattress itself—we’re starting completely over from scratch, so I want new fitted and flat sheets, a warm comforter, new pillows, and new pillowcases.”

Rolling down the aisle together, Katie and I picked out a soft navy-and-slate-blue queen comforter set with crisp cotton sheets and four plush pillows that both of us loved. After Katie paid for the giant zippered bedding bags at the register, my phone buzzed with a text from Dad: he was waiting right outside the mall doors in his pickup truck.

Monday, November 14, 2005, 2:30 PM — Dad’s Pickup Truck, A Real Grocery Run, The Confrontation With Tiffany’s Van, & The Hallway Closet Sanctuary

Rolling out through the automatic glass doors into the Chesapeake Bay Mall pickup zone, we spotted our forty-seven-year-old dad standing beside the open tailgate of his pickup truck with the folding aluminum loading ramps already set in place.

“There are my two favorite college students!” Dad said warmly, hugging Katie and me tightly before helping us load the new queen bedding bags, secure our two compact SwiftChairs in the bed of the pickup truck, and settle into the back seat of the extended cab behind him.

The ride down to Dad’s single-story brick ranch off Military Highway and Indian River Road was quiet and easy, and once we arrived, Dad loaded Katie’s clothes, her wooden dresser, her television and DVD player, her digital clock radio, her laptop, and the other essentials she felt she needed into the bed of his pickup truck. Climbing back into the cab—with Dad up front in the driver’s seat and Katie and me side by side in the back—we spent the drive back across the city line into Norfolk explaining everything that had happened over the last forty-eight hours: from Brandon Mercer trying to force Katie to run away with him to Canada and Katie’s five-bus escape from Williamsburg through the Saturday night rainstorm, to Tiffany screaming at us in front of the stove and dumping me on Sunday morning, to Katie offering to move in and live with me after we spent all day Sunday scrubbing out the filth.

Listening in the driver’s seat, Dad’s knuckles turned white on the steering wheel, a deep, protective fury settling behind his glasses at what both Brandon and Tiffany had put his nineteen-year-old twins through.

When we arrived in Ocean View and Dad backed his pickup truck up to the white two-rail fence at Sea Breeze West, we quickly unloaded my sister’s things into the courtyard of Apartment 3. Looking into the newly scrubbed open kitchen, Dad turned to the two of us.

“Do you two need to go grocery shopping while I have the truck here?” Dad asked.

“That might not be a bad idea,” Katie said immediately. “She did a horrible job keeping food in the apartment, and I didn’t trust any of the food that was left. She was an absolute slob, so I threw everything out into the dumpster yesterday.”

Ten minutes later, Dad pulled into the parking lot of the neighborhood grocery store down West Ocean View Avenue, set the folding ramps against his tailgate so we could roll our two compact SwiftChairs down onto the pavement, and walked right inside through the automatic glass doors with us. In the front vestibule, Dad pulled a full-sized metal shopping cart out of the rack to push right alongside our wheelchairs so that Katie and I could keep both hands free to steer and pick out every item ourselves.

Katie was lovingly stubborn about taking charge of the grocery run for the two of us.

“I want to buy food that we like,” Katie said firmly as our wheelchairs rolled side by side toward the bright produce section with Dad pushing the cart half a step behind us. “Yes, she bought food, but she didn’t take any of your input. You know that as well as I do.”

She thought about it for a moment as her tires hummed across the polished floor, then added, “And I don’t believe she was really allergic to milk, since she ate ice cream.”

“Chocolate ice cream,” I said.

“Point being, if she could eat dairy, she could have milk,” Katie said as we rolled up to the misted produce tables. Reaching out from her wheelchair, she inspected a pyramid of crisp red apples, bagged half a dozen firm ones, and handed the bag up to Dad to set into the shopping cart. “Here—you haven’t had apples in a while.”

“What else do you want to get?” I asked.

Katie pulled out her flip phone, flipped it open, and angled the screen toward my eyes. “I made a list of what we need. I want to completely restock the apartment with you-and-me food.”

Rolling slowly along the produce tables together while Dad followed with the cart, Katie and I picked out a bunch of ripe yellow bananas for morning snacks before our bus rides to CCHR, a head of crisp green leaf lettuce and two vine-ripened tomatoes for sandwiches, a bag of baby carrots, and a five-pound mesh sack of russet potatoes that I lifted off the lower wooden bin and passed back to Dad. Each time we chose something, Dad took it from our hands with an approving nod and arranged it neatly in the basket of the cart so nothing bruised.

From produce, we rolled down the bakery aisle, where Katie reached out to grab a soft loaf of whole-wheat sandwich bread and handed it to Dad, before steering us toward the refrigerated packaged meat wall.

“Lunch meats for us, of course,” Katie said, scanning the pegs of plastic-sealed packages.

“Can we get the meat from the deli instead?” I asked.

“Sure,” Katie said, pivoting her SwiftChair around while Dad turned the shopping cart to follow us back toward the lighted glass deli counter. “What kind of meat would you like?”

“Just some ham will do,” I said as our two wheelchairs rolled up to the deli case.

“Sure, I’ll get some ham. Half a pound sound good?” Katie asked me.

“Sure,” I replied.

Looking up at the clerk behind the glass counter, Katie smiled politely. “I’ll take a half pound of thinly sliced honey ham, please.”

When the clerk handed down the warm, white-paper-wrapped parcel sealed with its printed weight label, Katie checked it with a satisfied nod and passed it back to Dad, who laid it carefully beside the bread in the top basket of the cart.

“We need to get a few more items on my list,” Katie said, glancing down at her phone screen again. “Condiments, of course, to make sandwiches, and breakfast food. Milk and cereal, of course, but I also want to get other breakfast supplies in case we want pancakes or eggs or whatnot.”

“Alright. What about dinner?” I asked.

“That’s why we’re getting meat,” Katie said as we rolled back along the fresh meat case and she eyeballed the cuts arranged on the chilled display trays. “I don’t want to get too much since it will be just you and me.”

Working together from our chairs, Katie and I picked out a smaller two-person package of lean ground beef for skillet pasta nights and a pair of boneless chicken breasts, handing both trays up to Dad to tuck into the lower rack of the shopping cart.

For the next twenty minutes, the three of us went up and down the center grocery aisles in an easy, familiar rhythm—Katie and I rolling side by side down each aisle picking out what we wanted from the middle and lower shelves, while Dad pushed the cart behind us, took each jar or box from our hands, and reached up to the top shelves whenever Katie pointed to something just above our seated reach. In the condiment and pasta aisle, we picked out squeeze bottles of yellow mustard and mayonnaise for our honey-ham sandwiches, two boxes of enriched pasta, and two jars of marinara sauce; in the soup and canned-goods aisle, we picked out cans of chicken noodle soup and green beans to stock the new pantry shelves we planned to put in the hallway closet; and in the baking aisle, Katie grabbed a box of buttermilk pancake mix and a bottle of maple syrup for lazy weekend mornings.

When we rounded the back dairy wall, I reached into the chilled case for a carton of Grade A large eggs and a pack of salted butter while Katie pulled two cold half-gallons of whole milk off the middle rack and handed them to Dad to stand upright in the cart.

Then we turned into the cereal aisle—and without saying a single word to each other, both Katie and I rolled straight to the exact same section of shelving and reached out at the exact same instant for two boxes of the toasted oat cereal we had both loved since we were kids.

Ah, the joys of being twins: we shared pretty much everything.

Dad chuckled warmly behind the handlebar of the shopping cart as Katie and I handed him the matching cereal boxes at the same time.

As we rolled out of the cereal aisle past the glass-door frozen-food cases toward the front checkout lanes, a mischievous grin spread across Katie's face.

"One last thing," Katie suggested, braking her chair beside the ice-cream doors. "Let's get ice cream, just to stick it to that old bat."

Laughing out loud, I pulled open the frosty glass door from my chair, Katie reached in to grab a tub of rich chocolate-fudge ice cream, and Dad grinned as he set it right on top of the cart.

At the front register, Dad refused to let Katie pull out her wallet, paying for our entire cart of groceries himself before pushing the loaded cart out to his pickup truck and helping us load every bag into the cab and truck bed for the two-minute drive back to Sea Breeze West.

"I want to organize everything reasonably, now that she is gone," Katie said as we rolled back toward the courtyard of Apartment 3. "I didn't like how she had everything haphazardly placed."

Before Katie could put her plan into action, we saw a familiar minivan pull into the parking lot right outside the white two-rail fence—and something in my chest told me how glad I was that Dad was right here with us.

I recognized that van from anywhere. Rolling flush against Katie's chair, I threw both arms around my twin sister, hugged her as tightly as I could, and whispered against her shoulder, "It's them. I know that van from anywhere."

Standing beside his pickup truck with Katie's wooden dresser still strapped in the bed, our dad turned around, watched Tiffany and her scowling mother step out of the minivan, and planted himself across the courtyard walk like an immovable wall.

"Get your stuff—my daughter put it all in one pile—give us your key, and leave," our father snarled in a low, iron voice that left zero room for argument. "You are no longer welcome in my family."

Neither Tiffany nor her mother dared to talk back to Dad. Avoiding our eyes, they hurried past him to the front threshold where Katie and I had stacked all of Tiffany's bags and boxes in one giant pile. Because they had only come in a minivan, they could only take what would actually fit inside a minivan. Trip after silent trip, Tiffany and her mother hauled out bag after overstuffed bag of her clothes and personal clutter, shoving them into the back cargo area and across the middle bench seat until the minivan was packed nearly to the roof. There was zero room left in their van for the queen bed or for Tiffany's bulky bedroom dresser.

When Tiffany's mother glanced at the stuffed minivan and muttered that they didn't have room for the television, the rabbit-ears antenna, and the VCR that were still sitting on top of Tiffany's dresser against the right wall of the back bedroom beneath the high-mounted through-wall air conditioner, neither Katie nor I wanted a single piece of her electronics left behind—and Dad wasn't having it either.

"You're taking that television and VCR with you right now," Dad said flatly.

Marching straight down the carpeted hallway into the doorless back bedroom, Dad stepped over to the right bedroom wall beneath the high-mounted air conditioner, yanked the power cords out of the wall outlet, unplugged the coaxial lead, lifted Tiffany's television, rabbit ears, and VCR off the top of her dresser in one load, and

carried them right out across the courtyard himself. Opening the minivan's passenger-side sliding door, Dad wedged the television, the VCR, and the folded rabbit ears firmly onto the floorboard in front of the middle seat, then held out his open palm.

Without a word, Tiffany dropped her brass apartment key into Dad's hand, climbed into the minivan beside her mother, and backed out of the Sea Breeze West parking lot for the last time in our lives.

Katie promised right away that she would comfort me whenever I needed it—which I did. As the minivan disappeared down West Ocean View Avenue, I could still see the fierce, protective anger burning in my dad's eyes: anger directed squarely at Tiffany and her mother for everything they had put me through.

Refusing to leave Tiffany's dresser inside our apartment for one more minute, Dad marched back into the bedroom, muscled Tiffany's empty dresser away from the right wall below the air conditioner, hauled it out through the straight carpeted hallway and out the front door by himself, and hoisted it into the bed of his pickup truck so he could take it straight to the landfill on his way home. Once Tiffany's dresser was out of the apartment, Dad, Katie, and I brought Katie's wooden dresser in from the pickup truck and placed it right against that exact spot on the right wall of the bedroom below the high-mounted air conditioner, setting Katie's television and her DVD player neatly on top of her dresser. Now the only piece of furniture left behind from Tiffany was the queen bed pushed into the far-left corner of the bedroom—just a box spring and an aging queen mattress whose center was noticeably caving in.

Pressing his hand against the sagging middle of the bare mattress as we stripped it down and fitted our crisp new navy-and-slate-blue sheets, comforter, and four fresh pillows from Chesapeake Bay Mall over it, Dad shook his head at how badly the springs were caving in and promised Katie and me that he would replace the queen bed for us.

As we started arranging our things inside the apartment, Katie rolled up beside me and squeezed my hand.

"You need comfort?" Katie promised gently. "I'm right here for you, and always will be."

Rolling back out to the large repurposed dining table on the far-left side of the front room—where our seventeen-inch off-white CRT monitor sat beside my 2004 desktop tower fitted with the salvaged off-white three-and-a-half-inch floppy drive, CD-ROM drive, and CD-RW drive from our older desktop computer—I turned to my sister.

"I want to redo the desktop in the front room, so that it's used for both of us," I said. "I want to get rid of any traces of her from it."

"I want to help," Katie replied, rolling her SwiftChair right up beside mine.

"What I'd like to do is set up the desktop to have user accounts for the two of us," I said.

"We have laptops," Katie said.

“I know,” I said, my eyes lighting up as the architecture took shape in my head. “Someday, what I think would be neat is to have it set up so that no matter which computer we log in from, it would have all of our data.” I paused for a moment, glancing at the glowing seventeen-inch CRT screen as I popped open my binder of Quantum OS XN Pro installation discs, then continued, “I just want to get rid of any traces of her from the desktop. Yes, I’m going to reinstall everything, starting from scratch.”

While the fresh installation formatted the desktop hard drive from scratch, Katie and I rolled down the straight right-hand hallway to put fresh bathroom supplies away in the back. Pausing beside the two white bi-folding doors of the hallway closet on the left wall—where the doors opened outward toward the solid right exterior wall—Katie looked thoughtfully at the upper space inside the closet.

“You know?” Katie said. “I think I would like to turn half of this closet into a pantry. We have our dressers for clothes, we have a few coats and whatnot that need to be hung, so there should be plenty of room to get some shelving.”

“We should look for some shelving someday,” I said, noticing how well the half closest to the kitchen would work for pantry shelves while the half closest to the bedroom held our hanging coats above the clear carpeted closet floor.

“Yeah. Meanwhile, we need to finish unloading groceries,” Katie replied as we rolled back out to the open kitchen and she started putting items away in the olive-green cabinets and the refrigerator.

After a few minutes, every last grocery item was put away in our spotless kitchen. Katie transferred onto the bright green three-cushion sofa beneath the front window blinds and allowed me to transfer over and snuggle with my head resting in her lap.

Looking up as Dad stepped back inside from tying down Tiffany’s old landfill-bound dresser in the bed of his pickup truck, Katie smiled warmly.

“Dad, I would like to get some shelving for the closet,” Katie said. “I was thinking it would be perfect for half a pantry, and the other half will be where we hang our clothes up.”

“Next time I am off,” Dad said, resting a gentle, proud hand on Katie’s shoulder and then on mine.

“Alright, Dad. Let us know,” Katie said happily. “Guess you should be heading home.”

When the front door clicked shut behind Dad and the quiet hum of our freshly formatted Quantum OS XN Pro desktop filled the clean, linen-scented living room of Apartment 3, Katie wrapped both arms around my shoulders on the green sofa, and I knew without a shadow of a doubt that the year of hell was over—and that my twin sister and I were never letting anyone tear us apart again.

Part 3: The Goyeau Street Tunnel Bus, The Federal Courthouse on Granby Street, & Protected Non-Traveling Complainant

Date: 2005-11-16 at 14:00 America/New_York

Wednesday, November 16, 2005, 2:00 PM — The Federal Courthouse on Granby Street & Special Agent Morales

By Wednesday afternoon, November 16, 2005, Katie's wooden dresser, her television and DVD player, her digital clock radio, and her laptop were all settled into their permanent places inside Apartment 3 at 233 West Ocean View Avenue, and forty-eight hours of uninterrupted sleep inside our shared sleeping bag in the dark hallway closet and warm meals at our scrubbed kitchen table had finally steadied her nervous system enough to face a badge.

At two o'clock that afternoon, Dad met Katie and me outside the brick entrance of the Walter E. Hoffman United States Courthouse and federal building on Granby Street in downtown Norfolk—right off CVTA Route 1, just a twenty-minute ride south from Duffy's Lane. Because Brandon had attempted to force a disabled woman across state and international borders using interstate rail and tunnel-bus tickets after months of coercive isolation in Williamsburg, a detective from the Williamsburg Police Department and an investigator from the United States Attorney's Office for the Eastern District of Virginia had arranged to take Katie's statement together in a quiet ground-floor conference room so she wouldn't have to travel back up the Peninsula.

Katie sat in her compact SwiftChair at the head of the long oak table with my chair locked right beside her right armrest and Dad sitting at her left shoulder. Spread out on the blotter in front of the federal investigator—Special Agent Morales—sat Katie's flip phone containing twenty-four saved voicemails from Brandon between Saturday afternoon and Sunday morning, along with the crumpled paper CVTA transfer slips from her five-bus escape through the rain.

"Take your time, Miss Prairie," Agent Morales said gently, clicking his pen open above his legal pad while the Williamsburg detective turned on a small digital tape recorder. "Start with Friday night and Saturday afternoon in Williamsburg. You mentioned on the phone that Mr. Mercer was trying to take you to Canada against your will, and that you were afraid you might have broken a law by running away from him at the train station."

Katie reached sideways and held onto my hand on the armrest between our chairs, drawing a steady breath before she spoke.

"He told me for weeks that my dad and my brother didn't really care about me, and on Friday night he printed out maps for Windsor, Ontario," Katie said, her voice quiet at first but growing clearer as she went through the exact timeline. "He demanded my birth certificate folder and my state identification card, and when we got to the Williamsburg train station on North Boundary Street on Saturday afternoon in the rain, he locked the motor-brake levers on the back of my power wheelchair and switched off my joystick under the overhang, telling me not to move while he went inside to buy two one-way train and tunnel-bus tickets to Canada. I didn't want to go to Canada, and I didn't want to be near him anymore. When I saw the Colonial Triangle Transit Authority Grey Line bus pull in with Newport News on the sign, I switched my joystick back on, drove onto the bus, and took five buses all the way home to my brother's apartment in West Ocean View."

“And normally, in a case where the victim escapes at the station before boarding the train,” the Williamsburg detective noted, leaning forward across the table, “the suspect claims it was all a misunderstanding—that he never actually bought tickets to leave the country, or that he was just planning a short weekend trip.”

“Wait until you hear the last voicemail he left on her phone at eleven-thirty Saturday night from Washington before his train headed northwest toward Pittsburgh and Toledo,” Dad said grimly, tapping the side of Katie’s flip phone on the table. “After he spent two hours marching back to the Virginia Avenue apartment in the rain thinking she was hiding there, he realized she was gone for good and that we would be coming to the police. Rather than stay in Virginia to face the law or lose the cash he had spent at the ticket window, he boarded the northbound evening train alone—furious that she left him holding two non-refundable tickets to Windsor, and swearing he was going across the Canadian border without her so American law couldn’t touch him.”

Agent Morales raised an eyebrow and pulled his heavy black agency laptop closer across the conference table.

“He actually got on that train to Michigan and tried to cross the tunnel into Ontario?” Morales asked, his fingers already flying across the keyboard to log into the federal Treasury Enforcement Communications System. “Let’s see if a Brandon Mercer crossed the Detroit-Windsor border on Sunday.”

For ten seconds, the only sound in the quiet conference room was the click of keys and the soft whir of the laptop cooling fan.

Then Agent Morales stopped typing, stared at his screen, and let out a low, astonished whistle.

“Well, I’ll be damned,” Morales said, turning the laptop screen forty-five degrees so Dad, Katie, and I could all see it from our side of the table. “Look at this timestamp from Sunday afternoon, November 13, at four-fifteen.”

The Goyeau Street Inspection Plaza, The Caged CBSA Van, & Stranded in Detroit With Thirty-Four Dollars

Katie leaned forward in her SwiftChair, her blue eyes widening as she read the federal border readout on the monitor.

“United States Customs and Border Protection, Detroit-Windsor Tunnel Plaza, East Jefferson Avenue and Randolph Street,” I read aloud beside her, tracing the lines on the screen with my eyes. “Subject Brandon Mercer returned in custody of Canada Border Services Agency enforcement van following formal refusal of entry at Windsor Goyeau Street terminal under IRPA Sections 20 and 39.”

“Wait—Canada didn’t even let him in?!” Katie gasped, her hand tightening around mine.

“Not even thirty minutes inside the building before they threw him out in disgrace,” Agent Morales said, scrolling down through the scanned attachments uploaded by the Detroit CBP supervisor on Sunday evening. “Look at the narrative filed by the Canadian Border Services officers at the Goyeau Street and Wyandotte Street East plaza, and the secondary customs report from our officers on the Detroit side.

Mr. Mercer walked off the Windsor Transit Tunnel Bus on Sunday afternoon carrying a fifty-pound canvas duffel bag after thirty hours without sleep. According to the primary officer at Podium Two, he stood out twenty feet away—sweating in the November chill, jaw clenched, eyes darting toward the ceiling cameras and the exit doors leading out to Park Street East, and his left hand hovering defensively over the yellow ARTS multi-city ticket jacket sticking out of his wet coat pocket."

Agent Morales clicked open the scanned exhibit pages one by one as the three of us leaned in to read.

"When the Canadian officer asked where he was staying in Ontario and when he was returning to Virginia, Mr. Mercer admitted he had no hotel reservation because he had planned to use your disability income once you crossed the river, and he snapped at the officer that he was going to walk over toward Wyandotte Street and catch a train toward Toronto," Morales continued, shaking his head at the screen. "Then the officer made him hand over the yellow rail and bus ticket jacket—and saw that he had paid cash in Williamsburg the afternoon before for two one-way tickets to Ontario, including a printed ADA wheelchair bay reservation for Katie Prairie, with zero return ticket to the United States. When the officer asked why he was traveling alone on a two-person wheelchair itinerary and why he was so nervous, Mr. Mercer lost his temper at the podium, barked that his girlfriend had bailed on him at the train station in Virginia, and told a Canadian border officer that as an American citizen with a birth certificate he had a legal right to cross the border."

Beside me, Dad let out a dry, disbelieving laugh. "He told a foreign border agent he had a right to enter their country?"

"Fastest way in North America to get a coded yellow referral slip slapped onto your file," Agent Morales said. "Officer Vance walked him straight into the CBSA Windsor Tunnel District Operations secondary inspection room on Park Street East right off the Goyeau Street plaza, where two Canadian officers unpacked his fifty-pound duffel bag on the steel table. Underneath twenty days of winter clothes, they found his original birth certificate, his Social Security card, his high school diploma folder, three pages of printed internet notes about relocating permanently to Ontario and signing up for provincial healthcare and social assistance, a wallet with thirty-four dollars in crumpled American bills, and a Williamsburg train station ATM receipt showing a remaining checking balance of four dollars and twelve cents."

Right there on the federal computer monitor popped up the high-resolution scan of the yellow ARTS ticket jacket purchased at 3:56 PM on Saturday, November 12—complete with the unused companion voucher reading *PRAIRIE, K. — ADA WHEELCHAIR SPACE RESERVED*—followed by the stamped Canadian refusal packet citing Sections 20 and 39 of Canada's Immigration and Refugee Protection Act for attempting to reside permanently without legal status and financial inadmissibility.

"Normally, when Transit Windsor brings an inadmissible passenger across the tunnel, Canada puts them back on the public four-fifteen tunnel bus under a Direction to Return form," Agent Morales explained, scrolling to the bottom of the Canadian superintendent's report. "Except when the Shift Superintendent told Mr. Mercer his name, photograph, and fingerprints were permanently flagged in the Canadian enforcement database and that they were sending him back to Detroit with thirty-four dollars, Mr. Mercer lunged halfway across the steel counter shouting that everything he owned was in that bag. So the superintendent canceled the bus

turnaround, locked him in the caged rear compartment of a marked CBSA enforcement van, drove him back under the Detroit River through the tunnel, and walked him straight through the steel security door of the United States Customs and Border Protection compound at East Jefferson Avenue and Randolph Street in downtown Detroit."

"And our customs officers searched him all over again?" I asked.

"Under Title 19, Section 1582 of the United States Code, every person returned from a foreign port of entry undergoes a mandatory warrantless border examination," Agent Morales nodded. "Because you were still decompressing here in Norfolk on Sunday afternoon and hadn't filed your police report yet, no Virginia warrant popped up in NCIC when Detroit CBP ran his ID. So our Detroit supervisor did the next best thing: he scanned the entire Windsor refusal file, the Ontario relocation printouts, the Williamsburg ATM receipt, and your unused wheelchair ticket stub directly into the federal Treasury Enforcement Communications System, creating a permanent, time-stamped federal evidentiary record—and then at five-thirty Sunday evening, they buzzed the steel door open and dumped him out onto the sidewalk of East Jefferson Avenue in the thirty-eight-degree Detroit rain."

Dad stared at the screen, his jaw dropping open before a slow, fierce grin broke across his face.

"He handed the federal government the entire prosecution exhibit himself," Dad said in amazement. "He rode six hundred miles to the Canadian border with Katie's wheelchair ticket in his pocket and confessed to federal border officers on both sides of the river!"

"In twenty years of federal law enforcement, I don't think I've ever seen a suspect package an interstate coercion and attempted abduction case against himself this neatly," Agent Morales agreed, printing out the twelve-page border encounter packet on the portable printer beside his briefcase. "When Detroit CBP released him off the federal plaza Sunday night with thirty-four dollars in his pocket, he didn't even have enough cash for a bus ticket back to Virginia. Two nights ago, a Detroit Police patrol unit ran his ID during a routine check outside a men's homeless shelter on Cass Avenue after he got into an argument in the intake line over his duffel bag. With this federal border file corroborating the Williamsburg charges, we'll have a felony fugitive warrant in the NCIC computer before five o'clock today, and the United States Marshals Service task force in Detroit will pick him up right at that shelter's doors tonight."

"Protected Non-Traveling Complainant (V-W, Zero Infraction)"

Agent Morales slid the freshly printed twelve-page federal packet across the oak table so Katie could see the summary page.

"He corroborated every single word of your statement to two separate border agencies, Miss Prairie," Morales added kindly, pointing to the bottom box of the printout. "And just so your mind is completely at ease—look at the bottom line of the CBP record. You are listed strictly as the protected non-traveling complainant."

Katie blinked at the bottom line of the printed federal report, her fingers tightening around my hand on the armrest as her blue eyes locked onto that four-word phrase. For someone whose autistic mind ran on strict, literal rules, an unfamiliar bureaucratic label in a federal computer wasn't comforting until every single word was defined down to the millimeter.

"Wait—what does protected non-traveling complainant mean?" Katie asked, her voice rising slightly as she looked straight across the oak table at Special Agent Morales. "Does having my name in the United States Customs and Border Protection database and the Canadian border computer mean I'm flagged? Did I break a railroad or immigration law because he put my name on a ticket to Windsor that I didn't use? If Nate and I ever want to get passports and take a train into Canada someday on our own, are the border guards going to stop me?"

Agent Morales didn't brush her question off or give her a vague wave of his hand. Seeing how rigidly she was staring at the code box on the printout, he turned the paper around, laid his pen directly underneath the line item, and broke the exact federal terminology down piece by piece.

"Let's read each word literally, Miss Prairie, because in federal law, every word on this form has an exact statutory definition," Agent Morales said calmly. "First, non-traveling means the United States and Canadian governments have officially verified that you never got on that train, never left the Commonwealth of Virginia, and never attempted to cross the international border. Because you escaped at the Williamsburg station at three-fifty-seven on Saturday afternoon, the border computers show you were six hundred miles away when Mr. Mercer showed up at the Goyeau Street plaza in Windsor with a ticket bearing your name."

Katie nodded once, her shoulders dropping half an inch, though her eyes stayed glued to the line. "And complainant?"

"Complainant is the legal word for the victim and witness who brings the criminal complaint against the offender," the Williamsburg detective explained gently from across the table. "When someone buys a ticket in your name to abduct or coerce you across state lines, your name has to appear in the evidence file as the person he targeted—the exact same way a bank's name appears in a bank robbery file. Nobody arrests the bank for getting robbed, Miss Prairie."

"And the word protected is the most important part of all," Agent Morales added, tapping the two-letter status code printed beside her name: *V-W, Zero Infraction*. "When Detroit CBP and the Canada Border Services Agency entered your name under a Protected Victim-Witness firewall, they attached a permanent legal shield to your identity in both countries' databases. That shield does two things. First, it certifies that you broke zero United States laws, zero Canadian immigration laws, and zero rail tariff rules."

"None at all?" Katie asked quietly, double-checking the rule one more time.

"Zero," Morales said firmly. "Not a felony, not a misdemeanor, not even a civil administrative warning. And second, that shield means that if you and your brother ever apply for passports and take a train or a bus across the Canadian border ten days from now or twenty years from now, the border officer scanning your passport will see a completely clean traveler profile. In fact, the only reason that protected

note exists in the system is so that if Brandon Mercer ever tries to use your name at a border crossing again, the computer alerts the officers to protect you and detain him on sight."

Beside me, Katie stared down at the printed code—*V-W, Zero Infraction*—reading it three times until the literal wording clicked permanently into place inside her head.

She let out a long, slow breath through her nose, looked over at me with her eyes finally clear, and gave my hand a single firm squeeze.

"Non-traveling victim-witness," Katie repeated softly to herself, satisfied at last. "Zero infraction. I didn't break a single rule, Nate."

"Not a single one, sis," I told her, squeezing her fingers back as Dad rested his warm hand on her shoulder. "The only person who broke the law is sitting in a shelter on Cass Avenue in Detroit waiting for the United States Marshals to put him in handcuffs."

Part 4: Thanksgiving Dinner at Dad's House, The Black Friday Closet Project, & The Secret on the Closet Floor

Date: 2005-11-24 at 13:00 America/New_York

Thursday, November 24, 2005, 1:00 PM — Thanksgiving Dinner With Dad in Virginia Beach

"Smell that roasting bird!" Dad smiled from the stove of his single-story brick ranch off Military Highway and Indian River Road as Katie and I rolled our compact SwiftChairs down the hallway into the warm, cinnamon-and-sage-scented kitchen.

It was Thursday afternoon, November 24, 2005—Thanksgiving Day—just ten days after Katie had moved into Sea Breeze West Apartment 3 with me and we had reclaimed our lives from fourteen months of isolation. Earlier that morning, Dad had driven up to West Ocean View in his pickup truck with the folding aluminum ramps to bring both of us down to his house in Virginia Beach for the holiday, and for the first time in over a year, there were no jealous partners, no screaming ultimatums, and no walking on eggshells—just our forty-seven-year-old father and his twenty-year-old twins under one roof again.

"Can we help mash the potatoes or set the table, Dad?" Katie asked, braking her wheelchair beside the kitchen counter and washing her hands at the sink.

"You can take the wooden spoon to the bowl of mashed potatoes while Nate sets the silverware and napkins around the dining table," Dad said, opening the oven door to baste the golden-brown turkey. "I made sure the two places on the long side of the table have plenty of clearance so you two can roll right up side by side."

Sitting together at Dad's dining-room table twenty minutes later—with platters of carved roast turkey, herb stuffing, creamy mashed potatoes and gravy, cranberry sauce, buttered dinner rolls, and green beans spread out between us—Dad raised his glass of iced tea and looked back and forth between Katie and me with quiet emotion in his eyes behind his glasses.

“Last Thanksgiving, our family was scattered in three different places, and I spent every week worrying sick about the two of you,” Dad said softly. “Having my son and my daughter back together at this table today—safe, enrolled in classes together, and looking out for each other the way you two always have—is the best Thanksgiving gift a father could ever ask for.”

“We’re never letting anyone split the three of us up again, Dad,” Katie said warmly, reaching over to squeeze my left hand while tapping her glass against Dad’s and mine.

Over second helpings of turkey and warm slices of pumpkin pie topped with whipped cream, Dad leaned his forearms on the table with a grin.

“By the way,” Dad said, looking at Katie, “I didn’t forget what you asked me ten days ago before I hauled that old dresser off to the landfill. I have tomorrow—Black Friday—and the whole Thanksgiving weekend off work. How about we make a weekend project out of building that half-pantry, half-coat closet in your hallway at Apartment 3?”

Katie’s face lit up immediately. “Really, Dad? You want to build it with us this weekend?”

“I already measured the standard closet depth in my head,” Dad said. “First thing tomorrow morning, we’ll pick up a set of heavy-duty white wire pantry shelves, wall standards, drywall anchors, and a sturdy half-width coat rod, and the three of us will build it right into the left wall of your hallway so you have a real pantry.”

Friday, November 25 – Saturday, November 26, 2005 — The Black Friday Closet Project & The Secret on the Carpeted Closet Floor

At nine-thirty on Black Friday morning, Dad’s pickup truck pulled into the Sea Breeze West parking lot with boxes of white vinyl-coated wire shelving, vertical mounting tracks, a heavy-duty hack saw, a level, and his cordless drill stacked neatly in the bed.

Rolling our wheelchairs down the straight right-hand hallway of Apartment 3 behind Dad as he carried his red steel toolbox inside, Katie and I watched as Dad set his level down and pulled open the two white bi-folding doors on the left wall of the hallway.

Then Dad stopped dead in his tracks.

Looking down at the carpeted floor at the bottom of the hallway closet, Dad went completely quiet.

There, stretched neatly across the entire clear carpeted floor of the closet from the kitchen end to the bedroom end, lay our navy-blue sleeping bag—unzipped and folded over like a double-wide cocoon—with two white pillows nestled side by side at the head against the back corner.

I felt my ears turn warm, and beside me, Katie bit her lower lip. In our excitement over Dad coming by to start the Black Friday shelving project, neither of us had remembered to roll up the sleeping bag and hide the two pillows before he opened the bi-fold doors.

Dad slowly turned his head to the left—looking past the open end of the hallway into the doorless back bedroom, where the queen bed sat pushed into the far-left corner under the window with its brand-new navy-and-slate-blue Chesapeake Bay Mall comforter smoothed flat, crisp, and completely untouched—and then looked back down at the two indented pillows and the shared sleeping bag on the floor of the hallway closet.

Dad knew both of us better than anyone else on earth. He knew that Katie and I are autistic. He knew that ever since we were toddlers in cribs, our deepest source of emotional regulation was hugging and holding onto each other, and he knew that whenever the world got too loud, too bright, or too overwhelming, both of us craved the pitch dark and a tight, confined space where nothing could reach us.

And looking from the pristine, unwrinkled comforter on Tiffany's caving-in queen mattress to the two well-slept pillows inside the hallway closet, our dad put the whole picture together in three seconds flat.

"Kids," Dad said in a low, gentle voice, crouching down beside the open bi-fold doors and resting a hand on the edge of the sleeping bag, "you two haven't slept on that bed in the bedroom a single night since she left, have you?"

Katie and I looked at each other across our wheelchair armrests, and then Katie looked up at Dad with honest blue eyes.

"We tried to make the bedroom look nice with the new comforter so you wouldn't worry when you came over, Dad," Katie admitted softly. "We even took two of the four pillows off the bed to put in here. Every time we roll into the bedroom at night and look at that mattress caving in down the middle, all either of us can think about is Tiffany. Neither of us wanted to sleep on Tiffany's bed."

"So the two of you have been sleeping in the hallway closet every night?" Dad asked quietly, no anger or judgment in his voice at all—only a deep, aching tenderness behind his glasses.

"Every single night since Sunday the thirteenth—just like we used to do in our square closet back on Greenway Court," I confessed, looking down at the carpeted closet floor. "Even when we had a regular bed in the main room, we barely ever used it because we always felt so much safer in the closet. When we transfer into our single shared sleeping bag together and pull the two bi-fold doors almost all the way shut, it's completely dark and snug in here, Dad. The confined space makes us feel secure, and as long as we're cuddled up holding each other inside the sleeping bag, neither of us has nightmares about Williamsburg or about Tiffany."

Dad stayed crouched beside the closet threshold for a long moment, swallowing hard as he looked at the two pillows pressed side by side in the narrow dark of the closet. I could see how much it broke his heart that his twenty-year-old son and daughter had been hurt so badly—and left with such a broken, caving-in reminder of Tiffany in their bedroom—that they had retreated into a hallway closet every night just to feel clean and safe in each other's arms.

When Dad stood back up and pulled his yellow tape measure from his belt clip, his voice was warm and steady.

“Well,” Dad said, tapping the drywall on the left half of the closet nearest the kitchen, “then we are going to engineer this closet around your sleeping spot so nobody ever takes your sanctuary away from you.”

Both Katie and I looked up in surprise. “You don’t think it’s weird that we’re sleeping in the closet, Dad?” I asked.

“Nate, you and your sister just survived fourteen months of hell, and the two of you found a way to keep each other safe and calm through the night,” Dad said firmly, resting a hand on my shoulder and then on Katie’s. “There is nothing weird about two autistic twins who love each other needing the dark, a snug space, and a hug to sleep in peace. Watch what we’re going to do.”

Pulling out his carpenter’s pencil and level, Dad marked the vertical mounting tracks on the kitchen half of the closet wall starting twenty-eight inches above the carpet—leaving the entire bottom level of the closet completely open from end to end so that even with four tiers of white wire pantry shelving mounted on the half closest to the kitchen, and a sturdy coat rod mounted high on the half closest to the bedroom for our winter jackets, the carpeted floor beneath remained a 100-percent unobstructed, full-length sleeping-bag berth for the two of us.

Across Black Friday afternoon and Saturday morning, the three of us worked together in the hallway like a well-oiled crew. From our wheelchairs, Katie and I held the spirit level against the drywall, handed Dad the steel drywall anchors, screws, and wire shelf brackets, and tested the height clearances while Dad drilled the vertical standards into the studs, snapped the four white wire pantry shelves into place on the kitchen side, and anchored the coat rod and upper shelf on the bedroom side.

By Saturday afternoon, when we rolled the boxes of toasted oat cereal, the blue boxes of enriched pasta, and the rows of canned soups and vegetables out of the cramped kitchen cabinets and arranged them neatly across the four white wire pantry shelves on the left half of the hallway closet—with our winter coats hanging on the right half and our freshly fluffed sleeping bag and two white pillows laid smoothly across the vacuumed carpet below—the hallway closet looked like it had been custom-designed from the ground up just for us.

“Half pantry closest to the kitchen, half coat closet closest to the bedroom, and our dark cuddle sanctuary right on the carpeted floor,” Katie beamed, leaning across her armrest to hug Dad around the waist as he packed his drill back into his red toolbox. “Thank you, Dad—it’s even better than I pictured it.”

“You’re welcome, sweetheart,” Dad said, kissing the top of Katie’s head and ruffling my hair as he glanced one more time toward the caving-in queen bed in the back bedroom with a quiet, determined look in his eyes. “And I promise you two—you aren’t going to be stuck with that caving-in mattress forever. As soon as I get things lined up, I’m going to make sure the two of you have a real, brand-new queen bed of your own to share.”

Part 5: The Seattle Transit Blog Inspiration & Quietly Launching Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit

Date: 2005-11-27 at 19:30 America/New_York

Sunday, November 27, 2005, 7:30 PM — The Seattle Transit Blog & A Question Across the Desk

“Look at this site I just found on OmniSearch, Katie,” I said, angling our seventeen-inch off-white CRT monitor slightly toward my twin sister’s wheelchair as the cooling fan inside my 2004 desktop tower hummed steadily on the repurposed dining table along the far-left wall of our front room. “It’s called the Seattle Transit Blog.”

Katie set her cold can of ginger ale down on a coaster beside her open laptop, released her joystick brake, and rolled her compact SwiftChair right up flush against mine so our armrests touched in front of the desk.

It was Sunday evening of Thanksgiving weekend—the night after Dad had finished anchoring the four white wire pantry shelves and the winter coat rod above our sleeping-bag sanctuary inside the hallway closet—and for the past hour, Katie and I had been spreading paper Coastal Virginia Transit Authority folding pocket timetables across the tabletop to plan our upcoming January spring-semester bus commute down to the Community College of Hampton Roads Virginia Beach Campus. Between my freshly wiped Quantum OS XN Pro desktop—now cleanly configured with separate user accounts for the two of us and zero trace of Tiffany anywhere on the hard drive—and our two laptops flanking the keyboard tray, the left corner of Apartment 3 already felt like a proper twin command center.

“What’s the Seattle Transit Blog?” Katie asked, leaning her chin on my shoulder as her blue eyes scanned the web page glowing on the CRT glass.

“It’s a website run by everyday transit riders out in Washington State who ride TAPS—the Transit Authority of the Puget Sound,” I explained, scrolling down through the front-page articles with the mouse wheel. “Instead of just complaining to themselves at bus stops, a group of regular riders, computer programmers, and wheelchair commuters started a blog where they write out actual proposals for how their regional bus and light-rail grid ought to work.”

Katie leaned closer to the monitor, reading silently beside me as I clicked from one post to the next.

On the screen, the writers at the Seattle Transit Blog were dissecting TAPS King County and Pierce County bus corridors with the exact kind of logical, map-by-map precision that made both of our autistic brains light up. One post broke down how unifying five separate county and municipal bus systems under TAPS—complete with a single regional smart card called the Cascade Card and coordinated low-floor CNG bus fleets—eliminated the penalty for riders crossing city and county lines around the water of Puget Sound. Another post mapped out how the planned TAPS Central Corridor light-rail spine from downtown Seattle toward Tukkwila and the airport would only succeed if local feeder buses were redesigned into high-frequency, clock-face transfer pulses rather than leaving riders stranded at suburban hubs after six o’clock in the evening.

Better yet, down in the comment threads below every post, dozens of daily Puget Sound riders—alongside local transit operators, mechanics, and even city planners—were trading timetable math, pointing out broken wheelchair lifts or missing sidewalk curb cuts, and debating which corridors needed fifteen-minute headways next.

Katie stayed quiet for a long moment, her gaze moving from the glowing Seattle Transit Blog header on the seventeen-inch monitor down to the crumpled stack of paper CVTA timetables spread beside our keyboard: Route 1 from Granby Street and Ocean View down to CCHR; Route 61 across the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel from Newport News and Hampton; Route 29 up to Chesapeake Bay Mall and Hilltop; Route 15 down Military Highway; and Route 12 past Dad's neighborhood off Indian River Road.

"Look at how they write this, Nate," Katie said softly, tapping her fingertip against the edge of the desk. "They aren't screaming or venting into the void. They're posting the real schedules, showing where the connections fail, and laying out constructive ideas for what their regional transit system could be if the people in charge actually listened to daily riders."

She turned her head to look straight at me, a quiet spark catching in her eyes.

"Why doesn't Hampton Roads have something like the Seattle Transit Blog for CVTA?" Katie asked.

I blinked, looking from the CRT monitor to my sister. "A transit blog for Coastal Virginia?"

"Think about it, Nate," Katie said, gesturing toward the paper timetables on our table. "Nobody knows this bus grid better than the two of us. We don't drive cars. Every single time we go to college at CCHR, or go shopping at Chesapeake Bay Mall or Emerald Creek Mall, or cross the water from the Peninsula, our wheelchairs are rolling up the front ramps of CVTA buses. Two Saturdays ago, when I fled Williamsburg in the pouring rain, it took me five buses across two transit agencies just to get from the College of Charles and Anne to your front door—and if I had missed that 6:45 PM Route 61 bus out of Newport News Transit Center, I would have been stranded on the wrong side of the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel all night long because the cross-harbor bus shuts down before seven o'clock!"

"And ten days ago, when we rode Route 1 down to the CCHR Beach Campus to register for United States History," I added, the pieces clicking together in my head, "it took ninety minutes each way on a single local bus—and the schedule book says the very last Route 1 back leaves campus at 5:45 PM. Basically the whole Virginia Beach bus grid rolls up the sidewalks at dinnertime."

"Exactly!" Katie said, sitting up straighter in her SwiftChair. "We talk about what we wish CVTA would fix every single time we're waiting at a bus shelter together. What if we quietly start our own website and start jotting those ideas down in public—just like the Seattle Transit Blog did for TAPS?"

Hand-Coding Our Template on BlogSphere: Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit

My fingers hovered over the mechanical keyboard as the technical architecture spun up in my head.

“We can do it tonight,” I said, opening a fresh browser window on Quantum OS XN Pro. “We haven’t learned server-side database programming yet to build our own dynamic content engine from scratch, and static hand-coded HTML pages alone would be a pain to update every time someone leaves a comment. But Omni Corporation’s hosted blogging service—BlogSphere—handles the post database, permalinks, RSS syndication feed, and reader comments on their servers automatically, while letting you switch into raw HTML mode to hand-code your own custom page template.”

Katie grinned, pulling her laptop closer across the dining table. “And we’ve known how to write clean HTML by hand since seventh grade at Morrison Middle School. What should we call it?”

We looked down at the teal-and-navy logo printed across the cover of the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority timetable booklets on our desk.

“What about Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit?” Katie suggested. “Simple, direct, and constructive. Anyone searching OmniSearch for CVTA or Hampton Roads bus routes will know right away that we aren’t there to tear public transit down—we’re there to share ideas for what our regional bus system could be.”

“Let’s see if the BlogSphere title is available,” I said, typing Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit into the BlogSphere registration form on the CRT monitor.

A green confirmation line appeared on the screen immediately: the blog name was available.

Side by side at our repurposed dining-table desk, Katie and I clicked through the registration screen, created our shared administrator account under both of our first names—Katie and Nate, two twenty-year-old college students and daily wheelchair transit riders living in Norfolk and commuting into Virginia Beach—and immediately opened the raw HTML template editor.

For the next hour, the only sounds in Apartment 3 were the rhythmic click of our keyboards, the gentle hum of the desktop tower’s cooling fan, and the occasional fizz of ginger ale as the two of us stripped out BlogSphere’s cluttered stock layout and hand-coded our own clean, two-column HTML and style-sheet template from scratch.

Working together the same way we had since we were twelve years old, I coded the structural HTML tables, semantic heading tags, and high-contrast style rules—using a deep coastal-navy banner, crisp white background panels, dark slate body text that was effortless to read without eye strain, and a coastal-teal accent bar—while Katie wrote the sidebar markup on her laptop and transferred the snippets over our local network folder. In the right-hand sidebar, Katie coded an About the Authors box explaining that we were twin brother and sister who used compact power wheelchairs full-time and rode CVTA buses across Norfolk, Virginia Beach, Chesapeake, Hampton, and Newport News every week, followed by a clean list of

links to official CVTA route schedules, the Colonial Triangle Transit Authority in Williamsburg, and a Blogroll section where the very first link pointed directly to the Seattle Transit Blog that had inspired us.

“Take a look at the preview,” I said, hitting Refresh on the seventeen-inch CRT monitor.

Across the top of the screen ran our clean navy-and-teal masthead:

> Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit
> A Rider-Written Blog Exploring What Public Transit Across Hampton Roads Could Be
> Written by Katie & Nate

“It looks clean, fast, and completely readable,” Katie said proudly, squeezing my shoulder. “No flashy clutter, no broken tables, and anyone on dial-up or broadband can load it in two seconds. Now let’s jot down our very first posts so the site doesn’t launch with an empty front page.”

Jotting Down Our First Posts & Planting the Seed for 2008

We didn’t issue any grand manifesto or pretend to be transportation lobbyists. We simply opened the New Post editor on BlogSphere and started jotting down the exact, practical realities we lived every time our wheels touched the pavement at a Hampton Roads bus stop—paired with the common-sense improvements we wished CVTA and our local city councils would build.

For our opening post, Katie rolled her chair right up to the center keyboard and typed out the story of what it actually took to ride public transit from the Peninsula to Southside Norfolk on a Saturday afternoon and evening—without naming Brandon or the personal nightmare she had been escaping, focusing entirely on the five-bus regional gauntlet from Williamsburg down through Lee Hall on Route 116, down Warwick Boulevard on Route 107 to Newport News Transit Center, across the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel on Route 61 to Wards Corner, and north on Route 1 to West Ocean View.

> Sunday, November 27, 2005 — Welcome to Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit: Why Does Our Cross-Harbor Lifeline Shut Down at 6:45 PM?
>
> Hampton Roads is a metropolitan region of more than one and a half million people divided by water, yet if you rely on a wheelchair and public transit to cross between the Peninsula and Southside Norfolk on a Saturday evening, the entire regional grid hangs by a single thread: the last southbound CVTA Route 61 bus leaves Newport News Transit Center at 6:45 PM (and Hampton Transit Center at 6:57 PM), and isn’t even a full route into Virginia Beach—it’s an Expressways trip that terminates in Downtown Norfolk at 7:34 PM. Miss that 6:45 PM connection because an upstream bus on Warwick Boulevard runs late, and you are stranded on the wrong side of the water until Sunday morning.
>
> Even worse, while waiting thirty-five minutes at Newport News Transit Center for that final 6:45 PM bus—or transferring through Hampton Transit Center—riders are forced to use public transit center restrooms with half-

> ripped mirrors, bare glue-stained plywood, broken toilet-paper dispensers hanging by a single bolt, and vandalized stalls. Riders who pay their fares every day deserve cross-harbor Route 61 service that runs until at least 10:00 PM or 11:00 PM seven nights a week, and transit center facilities that are kept clean, safe, and fully accessible.

As soon as Katie clicked Publish on our first entry, I opened a second draft tab so the two of us could jot down the twin Virginia Beach problems we had just run headfirst into during our Monday college-registration trip to CCHR and our rides across the Norfolk–Virginia Beach city line: the ninety-minute local bus crawl, the strict two-hour paper transfer time limit, and the glaring service cliff where buses crossed out of Norfolk into Virginia Beach.

“Look right here at the printed Route 1 and Route 25 schedule booklets, Nate,” Katie said, smoothing both folded paper timetables flat under the desk lamp while I typed. “You don’t even need an inside source at City Hall to see why Virginia Beach’s bus service hours are so terrible compared to Norfolk’s. Just look at the columns on Route 1 between Downtown Norfolk and Pembroke East. On the Norfolk side of the route—from Monticello and Charlotte up Granby Street through Wards Corner, Ocean View at Duffy’s Lane, and out to the Amphibious Base at the city border—the bus runs every fifteen minutes during weekday rush hours, every thirty minutes midday and Saturdays, and keeps running late into the night until 2:15 AM, seven days a week. Then look at what happens the exact second Route 1 crosses the city line from the Amphibious Base into Virginia Beach along Pleasure House Road, Haygood Shopping Center, and Pembroke East: most of the buses stop at the Amphibious Base and turn right back around into Norfolk! Inside Virginia Beach, Route 1 drops to once an hour, only runs during the day with the last bus leaving Pembroke East at 6:22 PM, and on the back of the brochure under Sunday, the Virginia Beach columns literally just say NO SUNDAY SERVICE in capital letters across an empty white box!”

“And look at Route 25 between Glenrock Mall and CCHR Virginia Beach Campus,” I said, tracing my finger across the weekday timetable columns. “It leaves Glenrock Mall in Norfolk every thirty minutes, rolls down to Greenwich Road and Newtown Road right at the Virginia Beach border, and every second bus literally stops at Newtown Road and turns right back around to stay in Norfolk—dropping the Virginia Beach half down Princess Anne Road to CCHR to once an hour, ending at 5:53 PM, with zero weekend service at all.”

Katie shook her head with a wry half-smile. “It reminds me of that old local political story Dad told us about Virginia Beach’s mayor, Myra Overton. Everyone knows Mayor Overton is a genuinely sweet, grandmotherly lady in person who got her political start serving on the city’s library board—and she’s been a great champion for the Central Library—but she is not so great a politician when it comes to public transit. Like the story that always goes around among bus riders: there’s no way to confirm she ever actually said it, of course, but so they say, if Mayor Overton had her way, Route 20 on Virginia Beach Boulevard would depart Downtown Norfolk, take the Boulevard out to Newtown Road, and turn right back around and stay in Norfolk—just to keep the riff-raff out!”

“Whether anyone at City Hall ever said it out loud or not, that exact Newtown Road mentality is printed right here in the CVTA schedule book,” I said, typing the Route 1 and Route 25 timetable numbers straight into our second post without naming any unconfirmed rumors, letting the black-and-white schedule columns speak for themselves. “At CCHR Virginia Beach Campus, the last Route 12 toward Military

Highway and Indian River Road leaves at 5:48 PM, the last Route 25 leaves at 5:53 PM, and if a citizen takes Route 33 down to the Virginia Beach Municipal Center to watch a 6:00 PM City Council meeting and needs to connect at CCHR to Route 12, Route 25, Route 29, or Route 36 to get home, they have to leave the Municipal Center on the 5:33 PM bus—twenty-seven minutes before the 6:00 PM City Council meeting even gavels in! And when every Virginia Beach route runs once an hour, if you ride a multi-bus loop across Virginia Beach and Norfolk—say from CCHR up Route 29 to Hilltop, across Virginia Beach Boulevard on Route 20 to Glenrock Mall, down Military Highway on Route 15, and onto Route 12 back to CCHR—your two-hour paper transfer expires before you can even board your final connecting bus, forcing you to pay a second full fare just to finish one trip."

Together, we formatted our second entry—laying out our wish list for late-evening service hours until at least ten o'clock at night on core Virginia Beach routes, timed clock-face transfer pulses at CCHR, Glenrock Mall, and Hilltop, limited-stop express trunk buses along Granby Street, Virginia Beach Boulevard, and Military Highway, continuous curb-cut sidewalks leading to concrete wheelchair boarding pads, and a regional smart-card or day-pass system modeled on what the Seattle Transit Blog documented out in the Puget Sound.

When I clicked Publish on the second post and refreshed our BlogSphere home page, both articles sat cleanly on the screen beneath our navy-and-teal header, ready for OmniSearch's web crawlers to index overnight.

Right then, of course, the visitor counter at the bottom of our sidebar read zero. Nobody in Norfolk or Virginia Beach knew our blog existed yet. We were just two twenty-year-old twins in power wheelchairs sitting side by side in a small West Ocean View apartment at nine o'clock on a Sunday night.

Katie reached across her armrest, laced her fingers through mine, and rested her head gently against my shoulder as we looked at the glowing CRT screen together.

"We don't need a crowd tonight, Nate," Katie said quietly, as if reading my mind. "The Seattle Transit Blog didn't build its readership in a single weekend either. If you and I just keep riding the buses together, studying every route map and timetable change, and jotting down two or three honest, well-researched posts every single week while we finish our degrees—think about where this site will be two or three years from now."

I looked at the calendar pinned beside our desk and did the math in my head. "In 2008, the City of Virginia Beach holds its next Mayor's Race and City Council elections."

"That's three full years of building an archive, showing up in OmniSearch results whenever anyone looks up a CVTA bus route, and building a community of riders across Hampton Roads," Katie said, her voice steady and quietly determined. "If we start putting in the work right now in 2005, then by the time the 2008 Mayor's Race in Virginia Beach comes around, Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit will already have its name out there—and maybe, for once, the people running to lead our city will actually have to pay attention to the people who ride the bus."

Back Home in Virginia Beach & The Kempsville City Council

Do Better: Ideas for CVTA & The Four-Bus Mayoral Loop

Part 1: Does the Bus Run? Calling Out CVTA's Complacency & The 2008 Regional Mayoral Challenge

Date: 2008-04-14 at 13:30 America/New_York

Thursday, April 14, 2008, 1:30 PM — The Binders at Eighteenth Street & The "Good Enough" Mentality

"Look at the open three-ring binder on the corner of the staff table, Nate," Katie whispered, leaning slightly across her SwiftChair armrest toward mine as we parked our wheelchairs at the end of the front visitor row inside the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority boardroom on Eighteenth Street in Norfolk. "That's our Tuesday post. They printed the whole thing out and highlighted the timetable chart in yellow."

I followed my sister's gaze across the polished laminate table where CVTA's senior operations staff and the appointed city council commissioners from around Hampton Roads were shuffling their agenda packets before the monthly Transportation District Commission meeting gaveled in.

Sure enough, clipped inside the deputy planning director's black binder—and photocopied into three separate packets along the commissioners' dais—were six pages printed directly from Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit, complete with the coastal-navy header and the custom PHP route-comparison tables I had coded the week before.

Two and a half years had passed since that quiet Sunday night in November 2005 when Katie and I had first launched our blog on BlogSphere from our dining-table desk at Sea Breeze West Apartment 3. In that time, our lives had moved forward together step by step. We had ridden CVTA Route 1 and Route 29 side by side through rain, summer heat, and winter wind to finish our associate degrees at the Community College of Hampton Roads. When our West Ocean View lease ended in March 2007 and Dad took his new systems engineering position up in Tysons Corner, the three of us had moved our permanent family home base up to Dad's two-story brick house on Sunset Drive in Alexandria while Katie and I spent twelve intense months living in the accessible dorms at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center in Fishersville, completing the Web Applications Developer program and mastering PHP and relational database architecture. And just last month, in March 2008, after graduating from Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center at age twenty-two, Katie and I had returned home to Hampton Roads, pooled our software earnings, and bought our own accessible single-story brick ranch at 741 Lord Nelson Drive in the Kempsville section of Virginia Beach strictly fifty-fifty—with both of our names on the deed, only Dad holding a spare key to our front door, our master walk-in closet outfitted as our enclosed sleeping sanctuary, and the narrow builder-grade fiberglass tub in our

master bathroom ripped out and replaced with a custom-built, extra-wide roll-up hydrotherapy soaking tub for two with a flush SwiftChair-height transfer deck where the two of us could soak side by side in chest-deep hundred-and-two-degree water at the end of every day.

And through every single one of those hundred and twenty-four weeks, we had never missed a post on Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit.

What had started as two twenty-year-old twins quietly jotting down what they wished their regional bus system could be had grown into the first independent transit watchdog Hampton Roads had ever seen. After we rebuilt the site in custom PHP during our final semester at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center, I had written a server-log analyzer to see where our weekday traffic was coming from. The results had made both of us sit up at our desks: every weekday morning between eight and ten o'clock, dozens of page views were coming straight from static IP blocks registered to CVTA headquarters in Norfolk, alongside municipal government networks inside the City Halls of Virginia Beach, Norfolk, Chesapeake, Portsmouth, Hampton, and Newport News.

They were reading every word we wrote. They just didn't know what to do with two twenty-two-year-old twins in power wheelchairs who refused to pat them on the back for the status quo.

When the commission chair called the brief public-comment period at the start of the one-thirty afternoon meeting—scheduled, as always, in the middle of a Thursday workday when almost no working commuter could attend—Katie released her joystick brake and rolled smoothly up to the low microphone table at the front of the room, with me rolling right up beside her holding our printed schedule audit.

"Mr. Chairman, commissioners, and CVTA staff," Katie said clearly, her voice steady and polite as every head along the horseshoe dais turned toward our two wheelchairs. "My brother Nathaniel and I are the authors of Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit. We ride CVTA buses in our power wheelchairs every week across Virginia Beach, Norfolk, Chesapeake, and the Peninsula, and we pay our regular thirty-day pass fares just like thousands of other citizens who depend on this network."

Down at the staff table, the senior service planner and the communications director exchanged an immediate, tight-lipped glance, recognizing our names at once.

"Over the past two years," Katie continued, resting her hand on the timetable charts across my lap, "we have documented why riders across Hampton Roads are being left behind—not because our region lacks the roads or the riders, but because this agency and our six member cities have settled for schedules that lock working people out. Look at your own printed Route 1 schedule between Downtown Norfolk and Pembroke East: on the Norfolk side of the line, from Downtown Norfolk through Wards Corner and Ocean View to the Amphibious Base, Route 1 runs every fifteen to thirty minutes and runs late into the night until 2:15 AM, seven days a week. The exact moment Route 1 crosses the city line into Virginia Beach toward Pleasure House Road, Haygood, and Pembroke East, most of the buses turn around at the border, service drops to once an hour, only runs during the day with the last bus leaving Pembroke East at 6:22 PM, and has no Sunday service at all. On Route 25 from Glenrock Mall to the CCHR Virginia Beach Campus, buses run every thirty minutes to Newtown Road at the city line, where half of them turn right back around into Norfolk, leaving the Virginia Beach side down Princess Anne Road to CCHR

with hourly daytime-only service that ends at 5:53 PM. At the CCHR Virginia Beach Campus hub, the last Route 12 bus back toward Military Highway and Indian River Road leaves at 5:48 PM. If a citizen rides Route 33 to the Virginia Beach Municipal Center to attend a 6:00 PM City Council meeting and needs to catch Route 12, Route 25, or Route 29 at CCHR to get home, they have to leave City Hall at 5:33 PM—twenty-seven minutes before the council meeting even starts. Across the water, the last southbound Route 61 across the Hampton Roads Bridge-Tunnel still leaves Newport News Transit Center at 6:45 PM, and riders transferring on multi-bus routes are still getting penalized with a second fare because the two-hour paper transfer expires while they wait for sixty-minute local buses."

"We aren't here to bash public transit," I added from my chair beside Katie. "We love public transit. We need public transit to live our lives. We're here because CVTA can be so much better than this—with timed evening transfer pulses at CCHR, Glenrock Mall, and Hilltop, service running until at least ten or eleven o'clock at night, clean transit center restrooms, and a modern smart-card fare system that doesn't punish two-bus commuters—if the leaders on this commission have the political willpower to fund and demand it."

The commission chair offered a polite, practiced nod as the three-minute timer beeped. "Thank you both for your comments. Staff will take your blog submissions under advisement."

Twenty minutes later, when the board recessed into the hallway outside the Eighteenth Street conference room, CVTA's senior service planner and one of the veteran municipal council commissioners walked past our wheelchairs near the water fountain. Stopping beside us with a folder tucked under his arm, the planner offered the tired, defensive half-smile of a bureaucrat who had spent fifteen years guarding an unchallenged routine.

"Look, Katie, Nate," the planner said, lowering his voice as the commissioner nodded beside him, "we read your blog every week. You two obviously put a lot of math into those PHP charts of yours. But you have to be realistic about how transit works in a region like Hampton Roads."

"Realistic about what?" Katie asked, looking straight up at him from her SwiftChair.

The commissioner shrugged his shoulders, palms turned upward in the exact gesture that summed up thirty years of regional transit policy.

"Does the bus run?" the commissioner asked rhetorically. "Yes, the bus runs. Every morning the garages roll the fleet out across all six cities. Do people get to CCHR and the malls and the shipyards during the day? Yes. Is it good enough for what our city councils budget every spring? I guess so. Nobody at City Hall is clamoring to spend millions more running buses late into the night or overhauling transfer rules when the buses are already out there running their routes."

Katie and I looked at each other as the planner and the commissioner patted the folder and walked back into the boardroom.

There it was, spoken right out loud in the hallway of Eighteenth Street: the entire institutional philosophy of the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority.

Does the bus run? Yes. Is it good enough? I guess so.

For decades, CVTA and the politicians who funded it had hidden behind that exact complacency. As long as a diesel bus rolled past a stop sign once an hour during banker's hours and the annual federal grant paperwork got signed, the agency and the six city councils treated the box as checked. Until Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit came along, nobody with the technical skills to dissect their Transportation Service Plans—and the daily lived reality of riding those buses in power wheelchairs—had ever stood up in public and told them to *do better*.

As we rolled our wheelchairs out the automatic glass doors of the Eighteenth Street headquarters toward the Granby Street bus stop to catch our ride home, Katie's jaw was set with quiet fire.

"Did you hear what that commissioner said, Nate?" Katie asked as we waited on the concrete sidewalk pad. "'Nobody at City Hall is clamoring to spend money or overhaul the routes because it's good enough.' He just admitted the truth. The problem isn't that CVTA can't be improved. Every single improvement we've written about on the blog is completely doable. The only thing missing is the political willpower from the mayors and city councils who control CVTA's purse strings and sit on that board."

"And half of those city halls are up for election this year," I said, the realization clicking into place as the low-floor CVTA bus pulled up to the curb and kneeled its front suspension.

"Every single one of them has elections in 2008," Katie said as the hydraulic ramp folded down onto the concrete and we rolled up into the front wheelchair securement bays. "And as soon as we get home to Kempsville, we are going to put their political willpower to the test in front of every voter in Hampton Roads."

Mapping the 2008 Regional Mayoral Elections & Issuing the Open Challenge

Back at our dual computer desks in the spare bedroom office of our new Kempsville house that evening, Katie and I pulled up the official 2008 Virginia State Board of Elections candidate filings across all six member cities of the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority: Virginia Beach, Chesapeake, Portsmouth, Norfolk, Hampton, and Newport News.

Sipping cold ginger ale from our glasses while my PHP editor and our browser tabs glowed side by side across our monitors, we mapped out the exact 2008 municipal calendar across the six cities.

"Look at how the 2008 mayoral calendar breaks down across the six CVTA cities," I said, pointing to the state election schedule on my screen. "Out of the six cities—Virginia Beach, Chesapeake, Portsmouth, Norfolk, Hampton, and Newport News—four of them are holding direct elections for Mayor here in 2008, while the other two are mid-term on their mayoral cycle."

Katie rolled her chair closer and read down the certified candidate lists with me.

"Norfolk and Newport News both elected their mayors to four-year terms back in May 2006, so neither Norfolk nor Newport News has a Mayor's race until May 2010—though both cities have City Council seats on the ballot next month on Tuesday, May 6, 2008," Katie noted. "Then, on that same Tuesday, May 6, 2008

spring municipal ballot, three CVTA cities are electing their Mayors: Chesapeake has an open-seat Mayor's race, Portsmouth has a contested Mayor's race, and Hampton has an open-seat Mayor's race across the water."

"And then our own city—Virginia Beach—moved its municipal elections to the fall general election ballot on Tuesday, November 4, 2008," I said, scrolling down to the Virginia Beach filings. "And look at the Virginia Beach Mayor's race: Mayor Myra Overton is running for another term after twenty years as Mayor, and she's facing three challengers in a four-way race for Mayor of Virginia Beach, right alongside the at-large and district City Council races."

Katie looked at Mayor Myra E. Overton's name on the screen and shook her head thoughtfully.

Every lifelong resident of Virginia Beach knew the paradox of Mayor Myra Overton. On a personal level, she was a genuinely sweet, gracious, grandmotherly lady who had gotten her start in civic and political life serving on the city's public library board and had championed the Central Library on Virginia Beach Boulevard for decades. If you met her at a ribbon-cutting or a neighborhood library reading, she couldn't have been nicer.

As a municipal politician overseeing transportation for the largest city in Virginia, however, her twenty-year tenure had been a disaster for anyone who rode a bus. Among daily CVTA riders, bus operators, and local political watchers, there was a famous story that had circulated for years to explain why Virginia Beach's bus service hours were so abysmal compared to Norfolk's. There was no way to confirm she had ever actually said the words out loud, of course, but as the local legend went, if Mayor Overton had her way, the Route 20 bus on Virginia Beach Boulevard would depart Downtown Norfolk, roll east down the Boulevard to Newtown Road at the city line, and turn right back around and stay in Norfolk—to keep the riff-raff out, of course.

Whether that story was literal truth or courthouse folklore, one glance at the printed Route 1 and Route 25 timetables—where frequent, late-night Norfolk buses hit the Virginia Beach border and suddenly shriveled into once-an-hour daytime-only runs that vanished after dinnertime—made it painfully obvious why everyone in Hampton Roads believed it.

Katie leaned forward, resting her forearms on the desk.

"Four mayoral elections across Hampton Roads in 2008—Chesapeake, Portsmouth, and Hampton in May, and Virginia Beach in November—plus City Council races in all six CVTA cities," Katie said. "Every single one of those candidates puts glossy photos on their campaign flyers claiming they care about regional transportation, traffic relief, working families, and citizens with disabilities. Let's see how many of them are actually willing to step out from behind a podium and ride the bus with the two of us."

Opening the PHP administrative dashboard for Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit, Katie and I drafted our landmark open letter together, carefully checking every word before publishing it to the top of the front page and sending personalized copies directly to the official campaign email addresses of every certified candidate for Mayor in Virginia Beach, Chesapeake, Portsmouth, and Hampton—as well as the City Council candidates across all six CVTA cities:

> Thursday, April 14, 2008 — An Open Invitation to the 2008 Mayoral & City Council Candidates of Hampton Roads: Come Ride the Bus With Us
>
> Whenever we speak with staff and commissioners at the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority about late-evening bus curfews, ninety-minute routes, expired two-hour paper transfers, and missing sidewalk curb cuts, we hear the same unspoken excuse: Does the bus run? Yes. Is it good enough? I guess so.
>
> For the thousands of citizens across Virginia Beach, Chesapeake, Portsmouth, Norfolk, Hampton, and Newport News who rely on CVTA buses every single day to get to college, to work, to medical appointments, and to civic meetings —including wheelchair riders like the two of us—"good enough" is not good enough. CVTA can be improved into a first-class regional transit network, and the only ingredient missing is the political willpower of the elected mayors and city councils who fund and govern it.
>
> This year, voters in four of our six CVTA cities—Chesapeake, Portsmouth, and Hampton on May 6, and Virginia Beach on November 4—will elect their next Mayor, while voters across all six cities will elect members of their City Councils. Therefore, Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit is issuing a simple, non-partisan public invitation to every candidate for Mayor in Virginia Beach, Chesapeake, Portsmouth, and Hampton, and every candidate for City Council across the region:
>
> Meet the two of us at a CVTA transit hub, leave your campaign car in the parking lot, pay the regular bus fare alongside us, and ride a real multi-bus loop on CVTA with two daily wheelchair riders. No staged press vans, no special charter buses, and no shortcuts—just the real schedules, the real transfers, and an honest conversation on camera about how we can give Hampton Roads the transit system our citizens deserve.

When I clicked Publish and dispatched the invitation emails across all four mayoral races and six cities, the comment section on Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit lit up within twenty minutes. Daily bus commuters from Ocean View to Kempsville, CCHR students, shipyard workers in Newport News and Portsmouth, and even readers who had followed us over from the Seattle Transit Blog cheered the challenge on and began forwarding the link to local newspaper reporters and campaign managers.

Then we waited to see which politicians actually had the courage to show up.

Silence Across the Region — And the One Candidate Who Said Yes

Days turned into weeks as the May 6, 2008 municipal elections in Chesapeake, Portsmouth, Hampton, Norfolk, and Newport News approached and passed.

Every morning, Katie and I sat side by side at our desks in Kempsville with our hot chocolate or cold ginger ale, checking our campaign inbox and phone messages.

From the mayoral campaigns in Chesapeake: silence. From the mayoral campaigns in Portsmouth: silence. From the mayoral campaigns in Hampton: a single three-sentence form email from a campaign aide thanking us for our "interest in regional

infrastructure" and stating that the candidate's schedule did not permit a multi-hour bus ride, followed by silence. From the incumbent City Council members and establishment candidates across Norfolk, Newport News, Chesapeake, Portsmouth, Hampton, and Virginia Beach: not a single acceptance.

Even here in Virginia Beach, as the four-way November 2008 Mayor's race heated up through the summer, the twenty-year incumbent mayor's campaign ignored our invitation completely. The wealthy banking-executive frontrunner backed by the courthouse establishment didn't reply. The veteran budget-hawk former councilman didn't accept either. And every single incumbent and establishment candidate running for the Virginia Beach City Council pretended our email didn't exist.

"They really don't care, do they, Nate?" Katie said quietly one warm afternoon at our desks, staring at the spreadsheet on my monitor where almost every single row across Chesapeake, Portsmouth, Hampton, Norfolk, Newport News, and Virginia Beach still read *No Response*. "They want the title of Mayor or City Council member, and they want to sit on regional boards and cut ribbons on highway interchanges, but not one of them is willing to spend two and a half hours riding the bus system they fund."

Just as I reached for the mouse to update our public tracker post on the blog, my email client chimed with a new incoming message.

I blinked at the sender line on the screen, then clicked it open.

"Katie," I said, sitting forward in my SwiftChair. "Look at the inbox. Someone just replied."

Katie rolled her chair right up against mine and leaned in toward the monitor.

The email wasn't from a campaign press secretary or an automated mailing list. It came directly from the fourth candidate on the ballot for Mayor of the City of Virginia Beach—Scott Tanner, a young, thirty-something political-outsider Navy veteran who wasn't part of the entrenched City Hall establishment and didn't have the backing of the big beachfront real-estate donors.

His message was four sentences long:

> From: Scott Tanner for Mayor Campaign
> To: Katie & Nate — Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit
> Subject: Re: Open Invitation to 2008 Mayoral Candidates — Come Ride the Bus With Us
>
> Katie and Nate,
> I read your blog post and your route analyses, and you're right—nobody asking to lead the largest city in Virginia should be afraid to ride the bus system our citizens depend on every day. I accept your challenge. Tell me which transit hub in Virginia Beach to meet you at, what time to be there, and which buses we're riding, and I'll leave my car in the lot and ride the whole loop with the two of you.
> — Scott

Katie stared at the screen for three seconds, and then a slow, fierce grin broke across her face as she reached over and gripped my hand.

“Out of every mayoral candidate in Chesapeake, Portsmouth, Hampton, and Virginia Beach—and every City Council candidate across all six cities—only one person had the guts to say yes,” Katie said, her blue eyes shining with determination as she pulled the folded CVTA Virginia Beach route map across our desk. “And he’s running for Mayor right here in Virginia Beach. Come on, Nate—get your video camera batteries on the charger. We’re going to meet him at the CCHR Virginia Beach Campus bus loop, and we’re going to take him on the exact four-bus circuit across Virginia Beach and Norfolk: Route 29 to Hilltop, Route 20 to Glenrock Mall, Route 15 down Military Highway, and Route 12 right back to CCHR.”

Part 2: The Four-Bus Mayoral Loop, Silenced at Eighteenth Street, & Choosing to Run for the Kempsville Seat

Date: 2008-09-16 at 14:00 America/New_York

Tuesday, September 16, 2008, 2:00 PM — Four Buses Across Two Cities & The Expired Two-Hour Transfer

“Right on time,” twenty-three-year-old Katie said, nodding toward the concrete island at the Community College of Hampton Roads Virginia Beach Campus transit hub as mayoral candidate Scott Tanner locked his sedan in the student visitor lot and walked over to our two compact SwiftChairs with a notebook tucked under his arm.

“Katie, Nate—good to meet you both in person,” Scott said, shaking Katie’s hand and then mine while I checked the microphone levels on the compact digital camcorder mounted to my wheelchair lap tray. “I brought crisp single-dollar bills and quarters just like your email said. Where does our loop start?”

“Right here on Route 29 northbound to Hilltop,” Katie said, pointing up at the approaching forty-foot low-floor bus pulling into the CCHR bus loop. “We’re going to ride a single continuous four-bus circuit across Virginia Beach and Norfolk and bring you right back to your car at this exact bus stop: Route 29 from CCHR up to Hilltop, Route 20 westbound down Virginia Beach Boulevard into Norfolk to Glenrock Mall, Route 15 southbound down Military Highway back across the city line into Virginia Beach, and Route 12 back here to CCHR.”

When the front ramp of the Route 29 bus folded down onto the concrete pad, Katie and I rolled aboard into the dual front wheelchair securement bays and swiped our thirty-day CVTA magnetic passes through the farebox. Right behind us, Scott stepped up into the vestibule, fed his base fare plus the paper transfer fee into the bill validator, and took the timestamped paper transfer slip the driver tore off the cutter bar.

“Keep an eye on the punched time at the top of that paper transfer,” I told Scott as I framed the timestamped slip in my camcorder viewfinder while the bus pulled out of CCHR onto Princess Anne Road. “It’s good for exactly two hours.”

Because Virginia Beach’s local routes ran on forty-five- to sixty-minute headways without synchronized transfer pulses, the math of the two-hour paper transfer trap unfolded right in front of my camera lens in real time.

Our first leg on Route 29 carried us northeast up First Colonial Road to the Hilltop transfer stop, where we waited twenty-five minutes on an unsheltered concrete sidewalk pad in the September sun before boarding a westbound Route 20 bus down Virginia Beach Boulevard.

Halfway down the Boulevard past Little Neck and Newtown Road, an older Hispanic gentleman carrying a canvas tool bag boarded the bus and asked the operator a confused question in Spanish about which stop connected to the Military Highway corridor. Before the operator could shake his head, Scott leaned across the aisle and answered the rider fluently in Spanish—explaining the exact stop at Glenrock Mall where they could both transfer to Route 15.

“You speak Spanish?” Katie asked with genuine respect when the rider thanked Scott warmly and sat down two rows behind our wheelchairs.

“Picked it up during my Navy deployments to South America,” Scott said simply. “Half the folks riding Route 20 work in the hospitality kitchens at the Oceanfront or the construction yards along the Boulevard. A mayor ought to be able to talk to the people who keep the city running.”

When Route 20 dropped us off at the Glenrock Mall transit hub in Norfolk, we waited another twenty-eight minutes for our third bus—a southbound Route 15 heading down Military Highway toward Virginia Beach.

By the time the Route 15 bus rolled south along Military Highway and climbed the bridge over the Eastern Branch of the Elizabeth River to cross from Norfolk back into Virginia Beach, it was four-fifteen in the afternoon. Holding my camcorder steady on my lap tray with the river glinting through the bus window behind Katie and Scott, I recorded the conversation that became the centerpiece of our video.

“We’re crossing back into Virginia Beach right now, Scott,” Katie said on camera, holding up the official printed CVTA timetables for Route 33 and Route 12. “Let’s talk about what happens if a taxpaying citizen of Virginia Beach who relies on the bus—like Nate and me, or a working parent, or a senior citizen—wants to attend a formal evening meeting of the Virginia Beach City Council down at the Municipal Center in Courthouse.”

“Formal City Council meetings gavel in at six o’clock in the evening,” Scott said, looking down at the printed schedule columns in Katie’s hand.

“Six o’clock in the evening,” Katie repeated clearly. “Now look at the Route 33 schedule serving the Virginia Beach Municipal Center. You can ride Route 33 down to City Hall in the afternoon just fine. If you live at the north end of the Oceanfront, the last northbound Route 33 all the way to Sixty-Eighth Street leaves the Municipal Center at 6:01 PM—one minute after the council meeting starts—and the 7:01 PM trip terminates early at Nineteenth Street. And if you live anywhere else in Virginia Beach and need to ride Route 33 from the Municipal Center back to the CCHR hub to catch your connecting bus home—like Route 12, Route 25, or Route 29—look at the departure times.”

Katie tapped her finger against the bottom row of the Route 33 and Route 12 timetables so my camera lens could capture the exact numbers.

“The very last Route 33 out of the Municipal Center to CCHR leaves at 6:33 PM, and by the time it reaches CCHR, every single connecting route except Route 36 has already shut down for the night,” Katie said. “Because Nate and I live in Kempsville and ride Route 12 home from CCHR toward Military Highway and Indian River Road, look at when the last Route 12 bus of the entire day departs CCHR: 5:48 PM. To catch that 5:48 PM Route 12 home from CCHR, we have to leave City Hall on the 5:33 PM Route 33 bus—twenty-seven minutes before the six o’clock City Council meeting even starts! Our last bus home literally pulls out of CCHR twelve minutes before the Mayor bangs the gavel.”

Scott stared at the two printed timetables in disbelief, looking up into my camera lens. “So if you ride the bus to a six o’clock Virginia Beach City Council meeting to speak during public comment, you’re stranded at City Hall with no way home.”

“Every single Tuesday night,” I said from behind the camera. “You cannot tell citizens that local government is open to the public when City Hall’s own bus schedule locks bus riders and wheelchair users out thirty minutes before the meeting begins.”

Twenty minutes later, when we stepped off Route 15 at Indian River Road and boarded our fourth and final bus—eastbound Route 12 back to CCHR to complete our circle—the final piece of CVTA’s broken math played out right on cue.

Katie and I rolled up the ramp and swiped our thirty-day passes. Behind us, Scott handed his paper transfer slip to the Route 12 operator.

The operator glanced at the punched holes along the top edge of the paper slip and shook his head.

“Sorry, sir—this transfer expired nineteen minutes ago,” the driver said, tapping the two-hour rule printed on the farebox. “That’ll be another full dollar-fifty fare to ride back to the college.”

Right on camera, Scott had to reach into his pocket and feed a second full fare into the box just to finish a single afternoon round-trip back to his parked car at CCHR—solely because waiting for hourly buses had eaten up more than two hours.

Thursday, November 19, 2009, 1:35 PM — Cut Off at the Eighteenth Street Microphone & Blackballed From TRAC

That night in September 2008, I edited our four-bus ride down into a crisp twelve-minute documentary video with full burned-in open captions and published it at the top of Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit.

Within a week, the video had been watched more than forty thousand times across Hampton Roads and picked up by *The Tidewater Pilot* and every television station in Norfolk and Virginia Beach. In the November 2008 election, twenty-year incumbent Mayor Myra Overton was defeated, and although the wealthy banking-executive frontrunner edged out Scott Tanner in the four-way race, the public uproar over our video forced CVTA and City Hall to promise a “comprehensive review” of bus transfers and Virginia Beach evening service hours.

Fourteen months later, however, on a gray Thursday afternoon in November 2009 inside the CVTA boardroom at 509 East Eighteenth Street in Norfolk, we learned exactly what CVTA's executive suite thought of that promise.

Katie and I had ridden three buses into Norfolk carrying a twenty-four-page PHP audit we had compiled over the autumn, documenting more than nine hundred missed transfer connections at Glenrock Mall and CCHR alongside a formal request for CVTA's raw General Transit Feed Specification schedule tables so riders could build real-time trip-planning tools. Just two weeks earlier, I had also submitted my formal application to fill one of Virginia Beach's vacant citizen seats on CVTA's Transit Riders Advisory Committee—known around the agency as TRAC.

Parked side by side in our SwiftChairs at the low public-comment table in the center of the boardroom, I was two minutes and forty seconds into reading our findings into the record while CVTA President and Chief Executive Officer Leonard Sterling and Chief Operating Officer Richard Halstead sat slouched in their high-backed leather chairs along the raised executive tier.

"—and because the outbound Route 20 and southbound Route 15 schedules at Glenrock Mall are offset by four minutes in the master dispatch table without a hold-for-transfer rule," I said clearly into the gooseneck microphone, holding up our printed PHP chart, "evening commuters transferring back into Virginia Beach are missing the final southbound bus seven nights a week—"

BZZZZT.

Before I could finish the sentence, Chief Operating Officer Richard Halstead reached forward and jabbed the master cutoff switch on the clerk's console. The red ring at the neck of my microphone went dead in the middle of my word.

"Your three minutes are expired, Mr. Prairie," CEO Leonard Sterling said flatly without looking up from his leather portfolio. "Next speaker."

"Mr. President, if staff would simply release the raw GTFS schedule files we requested under the Freedom of Information Act—" Katie spoke up from her SwiftChair beside me, her voice carrying across the quiet room even without the microphone.

"Public comment is not a question-and-answer session, Ms. Prairie," Sterling interrupted, waving a hand toward the rear doors. "The commission has a full agenda."

Fifteen minutes later, when the board recessed briefly before its closed executive session, Katie and I rolled our wheelchairs out into the tiled corridor near the drinking fountain to speak with Chief Operating Officer Richard Halstead and the agency's government-affairs director as they walked toward the coffee credenza.

"Mr. Halstead," I said politely, holding out the bound copy of our twenty-four-page schedule audit and a thumb drive containing our PHP transfer-timing script, "we brought a clean copy of the Glenrock Mall and CCHR connection data for your scheduling department, and I wanted to check on the status of my application for the Virginia Beach citizen seat on the Transit Riders Advisory Committee."

Halstead stopped, looked down his nose at the thumb drive in my hand, and didn't even reach out to take it. A thin, patronizing smirk curled the corner of his mouth.

“Look, Nate, Katie,” Halstead said, lowering his voice just enough that the reporters inside the boardroom couldn’t hear him, “let’s save everybody some time. My scheduling engineers don’t take operational direction from statistically insignificant hobbyist bloggers, and we aren’t handing over internal GTFS database files so the two of you can play armchair transit director from your living room.”

Katie’s blue eyes narrowed. “We ride your buses every single day of the week in power wheelchairs, Mr. Halstead. There is nothing ‘hobbyist’ about needing a bus that actually connects before dark.”

“And as for the Transit Riders Advisory Committee,” Halstead added smoothly, adjusting his silk tie as he turned back toward the executive suite door, “staff already forwarded our recommendations for the Virginia Beach TRAC vacancies this morning. Your name wasn’t on the list, Nate. TRAC is reserved for constructive community stakeholders—not blog agitators with a laptop.”

The heavy oak door of the executive suite clicked shut behind him.

For ten seconds, Katie and I sat side by side in the quiet hallway of 509 East Eighteenth Street, staring at that closed oak door. They had cut off my microphone at a hundred and eighty seconds, laughed at our engineering work, locked up public schedule data paid for by the taxpayers, and secretly blackballed me from a volunteer citizen advisory committee because we had dared to prove on camera that their schedules were broken.

And the final insult came four months later, in the spring of 2010, when the eleven-member Virginia Beach City Council met down at the Municipal Center to vote on the city’s annual transit contribution. Rather than holding CVTA accountable or funding the evening connecting pulse we had proposed, ten-year Kempsville District incumbent Councilman Harold Dietz led the budget motion to strip out every dime of proposed late-evening bus funding—muttering into his dais microphone at the Tuesday afternoon work session that *“almost nobody rides the bus out of Courthouse after dark anyway.”*

Sitting side by side at our dual coding desks in our house on Lord Nelson Drive that evening watching the archived City Hall webcast over cold glasses of ginger ale, Katie reached forward and clicked Pause on the video player.

“Of course nobody rides the bus out of Courthouse after dark, Councilman Dietz,” Katie said to the monitor, her voice calm and razor-sharp. “There isn’t a bus out of Courthouse after 6:33 PM! That’s like taking the ramp off a building and claiming nobody in a wheelchair ever comes inside.”

Katie turned her SwiftChair toward me, her blue eyes steady and bright.

“Leonard Sterling and Richard Halstead think they can cut off your microphone at Eighteenth Street and blackball you from TRAC because we’re just two twenty-five-year-old bloggers in wheelchairs with no vote on their budget,” Katie said. “And Harold Dietz thinks he owns the Kempsville seat on the Virginia Beach City Council for life. Well, Harold Dietz’s seat is on the ballot this November, Nate. City Council elections in Virginia are non-partisan, and we’ve owned our home right here in Kempsville for two years. What do you say we stop asking Richard Halstead and Councilman Dietz for permission—and go take his seat on the City Council?”

“Let’s do it,” I said immediately, already opening a fresh PHP project directory on my MagnaBook Pro. “If they won’t let us sit at the public-comment table for three minutes, we’ll put you up on the dais where they have to answer to you.”

The Empty Podium on WHRC TV-15, The 94.1% Landslide, & Councilwoman Prairie

Part 1: The Empty Podium on WHRC TV-15, The 8:24 PM Three-Bus Sprint Home, & The Front-Page Metro Headline

Date: 2010-10-14 at 19:28 America/New_York

Thursday, October 14, 2010, 7:28 PM — The Empty Mahogany Podium Under the WHRC Studio Lights

“Two minutes to air, Ms. Prairie,” the WHRC TV-15 floor director called out quietly, holding up two fingers beside the center studio camera inside the public-television broadcast center at 5200 Hampton Boulevard in Norfolk. “Still no sign of Councilman Dietz or his campaign manager at the front desk, so per station rules, his podium stays lit and his microphone stays open.”

Parked in my compact SwiftChair just outside the edge of the key lights next to the producer’s monitor cart, I glanced across the blue-curtained television set toward my twenty-five-year-old twin sister.

Katie sat upright and composed in her black SwiftChair behind a low, wheelchair-accessible mahogany desk that the WHRC studio crew had set up on the left side of the stage, wearing a crisp royal-blue blazer over a cream blouse with a small brass lapel microphone clipped to her collar. Six feet to her right stood the second debate position: a tall, traditional standing mahogany podium bearing a white placard that read *COUNCILMAN HAROLD DIETZ — KEMPSVILLE DISTRICT*, bathed in a bright, unforgiving pool of overhead tungsten light and completely empty.

For five months, Katie and I had poured every ounce of our energy into the non-partisan Kempsville District race. We hadn’t hired a political consultant, we hadn’t taken a single check from Oceanfront hotel developers, and we hadn’t hosted cocktail receptions. Instead, I had built a custom PHP precinct-mapping and sidewalk-canvassing engine on our home server on Lord Nelson Drive, and we had spent the spring, summer, and early autumn campaigning directly from the front wheelchair securement bays of CVTA Routes 12, 15, 20, 25, and 29 and rolling down the neighborhood sidewalks of Kempsville, Bellamy Manor, Brandon, and Larkspur with Dad driving down from Alexandria every weekend to knock on front doors that had brick steps.

Through it all, ten-year incumbent Councilman Harold Dietz had treated our campaign as if we were invisible. When Coastal Virginia Public Media had sent out the formal certified invitations in September for tonight’s live forty-five-minute Kempsville City Council debate on WHRC TV-15—broadcast right from the edge of the Virginia Dominion University campus across all of Hampton Roads—Katie had returned her signed confirmation within twenty minutes. Councilman Dietz hadn’t even bothered to reply. Because he had neither accepted nor formally

declined the invitation, WHRC's strict non-partisan broadcast rules required the studio to leave his standing podium on the stage and give the viewing public an unfiltered look at who had bothered to show up for the job.

"Ten seconds," the floor director whispered, lowering his arm toward the center camera lens. "Five, four, three…"

The red tally light atop Camera One glowed bright in the darkened studio.

"Good evening, and welcome to Coastal Virginia Public Media's live 2010 Decision coverage from our WHRC TV-15 studios on Hampton Boulevard in Norfolk," the veteran public-television moderator began in his resonant baritone. "Tonight we examine the race for the Kempsville District seat on the Virginia Beach City Council. Seated to my left is challenger Katie Prairie, a twenty-five-year-old Kempsville homeowner, software developer, and co-founder of the regional transit watchdog website Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit. To her right, as viewers at home can see, is the podium reserved for ten-year incumbent Councilman Harold Dietz. Although WHRC extended multiple invitations to Councilman Dietz's office over the past six weeks, our producers received neither an acceptance nor a decline, and his podium remains open should he arrive during tonight's broadcast. Because our non-profit public media rules require us to pose every scheduled municipal policy question to the stage, we will proceed with our full forty-five-minute forum. Ms. Prairie, the first question is yours."

Watching from beside the monitor cart with my MagnaBook Pro resting on my wheelchair lap tray, I felt a quiet surge of pride as the director punched up the wide two-shot on the studio monitors.

Every time the moderator asked a question about Kempsville stormwater drainage along Indian River Road, aging neighborhood sidewalks around Morrison Middle School and Northwood High School, small-business permitting, municipal transparency, or the city's annual transportation budget, the studio camera framed the stark visual contrast across every living room in Virginia Beach and Norfolk: on the left, a poised, razor-sharp twenty-five-year-old woman in a power wheelchair citing exact line items from the City of Virginia Beach's eight-hundred-page operating budget from memory without a single paper note on her desk; on the right, six feet of empty blue carpet and a vacant mahogany lectern where the ten-year incumbent hadn't cared enough to stand.

"Ms. Prairie, let's turn to regional transportation and your proposal for an Evening Civic Access Transit Pulse," the moderator said at the eight-minute mark before the end of the broadcast. "Critics on the current City Council have argued that extending CVTA bus service out of the Virginia Beach Municipal Center and the CCHR Virginia Beach Campus past six-thirty in the evening is an unnecessary taxpayer expense because ridership after dark is low. How do you respond?"

Katie looked straight into the glowing red camera lens.

"Saying nobody rides the bus out of the Virginia Beach Municipal Center after six-thirty at night when the last bus leaves at 6:33 PM is like taking the wheelchair ramp off City Hall and claiming nobody in a wheelchair ever comes inside," Katie said, her voice warm, clear, and unhurried. "Formal evening meetings of the Virginia Beach City Council gavel in at six o'clock. Yet if a working parent, a senior citizen, a college student, or a wheelchair user in Kempsville rides Route 33 down to City Hall and needs to connect to Route 12, Route 25, or Route 29 at the CCHR hub to

get home, the very last Route 12 bus of the day leaves CCHR at 5:48 PM—meaning a citizen has to leave City Hall at 5:33 PM, twenty-seven minutes before the Council meeting even begins. For the cost of less than one-tenth of one percent of our city budget, we can run an evening bus pulse until ten-thirty at night so working people and citizens with disabilities are never locked out of their own local government again."

At 8:14 PM on the dot, the moderator thanked Katie, signed off to the viewers across Hampton Roads, and the red tally lights on the studio cameras clicked off.

And that was when the real moment of the campaign began.

Thursday, October 14, 2010, 8:14 PM — Crossing Six Lanes of Hampton Boulevard With Reporter Greg Mercer to Catch the 8:24 PM Route 2

The instant the studio floor director called *"We're clear!"* at 8:14 PM, Katie didn't linger on the stage to bask in the applause of the camera crew.

While the audio technician unclipped the brass lapel mic from her blazer, Katie glanced down at her wristwatch, released her joystick brake, and rolled swiftly down the studio ramp toward my wheelchair as I closed my MagnaBook Pro and slipped it into my padded canvas backpack.

"Eight-fourteen, Nate," Katie said quietly as our two SwiftChairs fell into formation heading for the heavy soundproof doors of Studio A. "We have ten minutes to make the crosswalk."

Out in the bright fluorescent lobby of the WHRC broadcast center, *Tidewater Pilot* Metro politics reporter Greg Mercer—a veteran city-hall journalist in a rumpled trench coat with a spiral reporter's notebook in one hand and a digital voice recorder in the other—stepped away from the reception counter and hurried straight toward us.

"Ms. Prairie! Katie!" Greg Mercer called out, clicking the record button on his handheld recorder. "Greg Mercer with *The Tidewater Pilot*. That empty podium on live television was something else. Do you have ten minutes to sit down here in the lobby and give me a quick post-debate interview for tomorrow morning's Metro section?"

Katie glanced at the round wall clock above the WHRC glass entrance doors—8:15 PM—and looked back up at Greg with a friendly, earnest smile.

"I'd be happy to answer every question you have, Mr. Mercer," Katie said as I hit the big silver ADA push-plate to swing the front lobby doors open into the crisp October night air, "as long as you don't mind walking fast across Hampton Boulevard with us right now."

Greg blinked in surprise, tucking his pen behind his ear as he stepped out onto the concrete sidewalk beside our two powerchairs. "Across Hampton Boulevard? Sure—did your campaign staff have to park your wheelchair van over in the university lot across the street?"

Katie and I exchanged a quick twin look as we set our SwiftChair speed dials to four miles per hour and rolled briskly down the WHRC front walk toward the signalized intersection at Forty-Ninth Street and Hampton Boulevard.

“We don’t have campaign staff, Mr. Mercer,” I said as Katie pressed the pedestrian crosswalk button at the curb, “and we don’t own a wheelchair van.”

Greg Mercer looked down at our two compact powerchairs, genuinely puzzled as six lanes of heavy port and university traffic rumbled past under the amber streetlights of Hampton Boulevard.

Wait—if the two of us didn’t have a fifty-thousand-dollar wheelchair-lift van waiting in the lot, and our dad David wasn’t down from Alexandria on a Thursday night, how on earth were two twenty-five-year-old twins in power wheelchairs getting all the way from the West Side of Norfolk back to Kempsville in Virginia Beach at eight-fifteen at night?

The white *WALK* silhouette flashed on across the six-lane boulevard.

“Come on, Mr. Mercer—this light only gives twenty-two seconds,” Katie said cheerfully.

Jogging two steps to keep pace with our electric motors as we rolled straight across all six lanes of Hampton Boulevard to the opposite sidewalk, Greg held his digital recorder out toward Katie. “Wait a second—where are we going if your car isn’t over here?”

Reaching the far curb cut on the southbound side of Hampton Boulevard, Katie and I braked our SwiftChairs side by side right beneath a blue-and-white metal sign bolted to a utility pole:

CVTA BUS STOP — ROUTE 2 (HAMPTON BLVD / DOWNTOWN NORFOLK).

Greg Mercer stopped dead in his tracks on the concrete sidewalk, his mouth slightly open as he looked up at the metal bus stop sign, then down at our two power wheelchairs, and then back up Hampton Boulevard where the twin headlights of an approaching forty-foot low-floor CVTA gill-window transit bus were cresting the rise three blocks north.

“You’re taking the city bus?” Greg asked, staring at us in disbelief. “From a live television debate on Hampton Boulevard back to Virginia Beach—at eight-twenty at night?”

“Not just one city bus, Mr. Mercer—three of them,” I said, checking the glowing digital readout on my watch: 8:22 PM. “And that’s why we couldn’t stay in the WHRC lobby for ten minutes.”

“Walk me through this before that bus gets here,” Greg said rapidly, holding his voice recorder right between Katie’s chair and mine while his other hand scribbled furiously across his spiral pad under the streetlight. “What happens if you miss that bus coming down the street right now?”

“Look at the timetable math,” Katie said calmly, pointing up Hampton Boulevard as the southbound CVTA Route 2 bus signaled toward the curb with its amber destination sign glowing *2 DOWNTOWN NORFOLK*. “The WHRC debate ended at 8:14 PM. This bus pulling up right now is the 8:24 PM Route 2 southbound. We

have to catch this exact 8:24 PM bus down Hampton Boulevard to the Downtown Norfolk Transit Center, which gets us into Downtown Norfolk just before nine o'clock."

With a loud hiss of compressed air, the forty-foot Route 2 bus braked at the curb beside us and kneeled its front suspension. The folding glass doors swung open, and the warning chime beeped as the steel hydraulic wheelchair ramp unfolded onto the sidewalk concrete.

"Once we get to Downtown Norfolk Transit Center just before nine," I continued as I rolled backward up the steel ramp first to pull into the rear-facing curbside securement bay, "we have fifteen minutes to transfer onto the 9:15 PM Route 20 bus heading eastbound out Virginia Beach Boulevard."

"And that 9:15 PM Route 20 bus gets us out to the Glenrock Mall transit hub at 9:45 PM," Katie added, pausing at the bottom of the wheelchair ramp and looking back over her shoulder at Greg Mercer standing under the streetlight with his notebook and recorder. "At 9:45 PM at Glenrock Mall, Nate and I have to transfer onto the very last Route 15 bus of the night going south down Military Highway across the city line into Virginia Beach. If we had stayed in the WHRC lobby talking for ten minutes and missed this 8:24 PM bus right here on Hampton Boulevard, we would miss the 9:15 PM Route 20 in Downtown Norfolk, we would miss the last Route 15 of the night at Glenrock Mall, and the two of us would be stranded in Norfolk overnight in our wheelchairs with no way home."

Greg Mercer stared at Katie, stunned silent for two full beats as the bus driver waited patiently at the controls.

"My God," Greg breathed, his pen hovering over his pad. "You just debated for forty-five minutes on live television next to an empty podium because the incumbent didn't bother to show up, and now you're sprinting to catch a three-bus transfer chain across two cities before the system shuts down for the night."

"Mr. Mercer," Katie said simply, her blue eyes steady under the streetlight before she guided her SwiftChair smoothly up the metal ramp into the bus vestibule beside me, "improving the CVTA bus system—specifically Virginia Beach's locally funded share of the regional system—is the entire reason I'm running for City Council. Have a good night, and thank you for walking us to the stop!"

As we swiped our thirty-day CVTA passes through the farebox and locked our wheelchair brakes in the dual front bays, the hydraulic ramp folded back inside, the glass doors hissed shut, and the 8:24 PM Route 2 bus pulled away down Hampton Boulevard—leaving the veteran *Tidewater Pilot* reporter standing on the curb under the bus stop sign, staring after our taillights and scribbling in his notebook as fast as his hand could move.

Friday, October 15, 2010, 9:30 AM — Section B1 Above the Fold & All Ten Lines Lit on WHRC 89.5 FM

We made our 9:15 PM Route 20 transfer in Downtown Norfolk with eleven minutes to spare, caught the final 9:45 PM southbound Route 15 at Glenrock Mall, and rolled through the front door of our house on Lord Nelson Drive at ten-forty that night—tired, happy, and ready for a late cup of hot chocolate before bed.

At nine-thirty the next morning, while Katie and I were sitting side by side at our dual coding desks drinking cold orange juice and checking our overnight campaign emails, we heard the familiar sound of Dad's key turning in the front deadbolt.

"Morning, kids!" Dad called out, walking into our home office carrying a steaming travel mug of black coffee in one hand and a thick bundle of five freshly printed Friday morning editions of *The Tidewater Pilot* under his other arm. "I took a personal day in Tysons and drove down early so we could canvass Bellamy Manor this afternoon—and I bought out the newsstand box at the corner convenience store on my way in. Have you two seen Section B yet?"

"Not the print edition," I said as Katie and I rolled our chairs back from our desks. "Did Greg Mercer's blurb run inside the Metro pages?"

Dad let out a laugh that crinkled the corners of his eyes behind his glasses, pulled the Metro & Virginia section from the top of the bundle, and laid Section B1 flat across our desk.

It wasn't a two-paragraph blurb buried on page four.

Stretching all the way across the top of the Friday Metro front page above the fold in bold seventy-two-point black type was a banner headline written by Greg Mercer:

AN EMPTY PODIUM—AND AN 8:24 P.M. BUS TO CATCH Incumbent Dietz Skips Televised WHRC Debate; Challenger Katie Prairie Commands the Hour—Then Races Across Hampton Boulevard in Her Wheelchair to Make Last Bus Connection Home to Virginia Beach

Directly beneath the headline sat two side-by-side color photographs spanning all six columns of the page. On the left was a crisp frame captured from the WHRC TV-15 broadcast showing twenty-five-year-old Katie seated at her accessible studio desk next to Councilman Harold Dietz's brightly lit, completely empty mahogany podium. On the right was a photograph taken by a *Tidewater Pilot* photographer Greg Mercer had reached by cell phone on Hampton Boulevard—showing Katie and me rolling our black SwiftChairs up the steel hydraulic ramp of the kneeling 8:24 PM CVTA Route 2 bus under the streetlights while regular night-shift commuters looked on from the windows.

Katie and I read down the twenty-eight-inch column together in amazed silence. Greg Mercer hadn't missed a single detail: he had printed the exact 8:14 PM debate sign-off, the twenty-two-second sprint across all six lanes of Hampton Boulevard, the minute-by-minute transfer math of the 8:24 PM Route 2 to the 9:15 PM Route 20 to the final 9:45 PM Route 15 at Glenrock Mall, and Katie's parting words from the bottom of the bus ramp right in the closing box quote.

"Look at the traffic counter on our campaign server, Katie," I said, glancing up at my real-time PHP analytics monitor. "Our website hits just passed twelve thousand for the morning, and small online donations of ten and twenty-five dollars are coming in every thirty seconds from Kempsville, Bayside, and Norfolk."

At twelve-oh-six that afternoon, while the three of us were eating turkey sandwiches at the kitchen table before heading out to canvass, I clicked open the live audio stream of Coastal Virginia Public Media's non-profit public radio station, WHRC 89.5 FM, during its flagship Friday noon regional call-in program.

“Welcome back to *Tidewater Forum* on WHRC 89.5 FM, I’m Catherine Lindsey,” the host said over our desktop speakers. “Before we open the phone lines for our weekly Friday civic roundtable, I need to remind our listeners of the ground rules: as a non-profit 501(c)(3) public broadcasting organization, WHRC radio and television are strictly prohibited by federal law from endorsing or opposing any candidate for public office. However, judging by our studio switchboard over the last ten minutes, it appears half of Hampton Roads has read Greg Mercer’s front-page Metro column in this morning’s *Tidewater Pilot* about last night’s Kempsville City Council debate here in our building. All ten of our studio call-in lines are flashing right now. Let’s go first to Line One—Arthur in Kempsville, you’re on WHRC.”

“Thank you, Catherine,” an older gentleman’s voice came over the radio clearly. *“I’ve lived off Kempsville Road for thirty-four years and I voted for Harold Dietz twice in the past. Last night I tuned in to Channel 15 to watch the debate, and I sat there for forty-five minutes looking at an empty wooden podium while that young lady in the wheelchair answered every single budget and drainage question like she’d been running the city for ten years. And then I open my paper over breakfast this morning and find out she and her twin brother had to hustle across six lanes of Hampton Boulevard in the dark just to catch three buses home before CVTA locked up for the night! You don’t have to endorse anybody on the radio—the voters in Kempsville can see for ourselves who’s actually working for a living.”*

“Thank you, Arthur—let’s go to Line Two, Brenda calling from a cell phone near Glenrock Mall,” Catherine Lindsey said.

“Hi, I’m a respiratory therapist and I ride that exact Route 20 and Route 15 transfer at Glenrock Mall three nights a week,” the second caller said, her voice thick with emotion. *“I’ve seen Katie and her brother Nate in their wheelchairs on the front of the bus for years taking notes and talking to riders, and I never realized she was running for City Council until I saw the photo of them rolling up the Route 2 ramp in the paper today. For ten years City Hall has acted like those of us who ride the bus after eight o’clock at night don’t exist. Everybody on my shift at the hospital is voting for Katie Prairie on November second!”*

Line after line, for forty consecutive minutes without a single negative call, listeners from Kempsville, Bellamy Manor, Larkspur, College Park, and across Hampton Roads lit up all ten phone lines on WHRC 89.5 FM—until the host finally had to laugh on air and remind callers that the program had other regional news topics on its rundown.

Sitting at our Kempsville kitchen table with Dad grinning over his coffee mug and Katie holding my hand across our wheelchair armrests, we finished our sandwiches, loaded four hundred fresh palm cards into our canvas side-bags, and rolled out into the crisp October sunshine for the final eighteen days of sidewalk canvassing before Election Day.

Part 2: The WTGA 790 AM Disability Attack, The 94.1% Landslide, & The Eighteenth Street Reckoning

Date: 2010-10-28 at 08:15 America/New_York

Thursday, October 28, 2010, 8:15 AM — Five Days Before the Election: The Incumbent Attacks Katie's Wheelchair on WTGA 790 AM

"Turn the desktop speakers up a notch, Nate," twenty-five-year-old Katie said from her SwiftChair beside mine on the Thursday morning before the election, pausing her typing on our morning canvassing walk-sheets as the live web stream of conservative talk radio WTGA 790 AM—Tidewater Talk 790—crackled across our home office on Lord Nelson Drive. "The host just said Harold Dietz called in unscheduled."

I reached over and turned up the volume knob beside my monitor while taking a sip of cold chocolate milk.

For the past thirteen days since Greg Mercer's front-page Metro story in *The Tidewater Pilot* and the forty-minute switchboard takeover on WHRC 89.5 FM, Councilman Harold Dietz had vanished from public view—canceling two neighborhood civic-league appearances while our volunteer canvassing teams knocked on thousands of doors across Kempsville, Bellamy Manor, Brandon, and Larkspur. Now, with five days left before Tuesday's election, the ten-year incumbent had evidently decided to go live on Hampton Roads' loudest morning talk-radio microphone to try to stop the bleeding.

"We're joined on the studio line right now by Virginia Beach City Councilman Harold Dietz, representing the Kempsville District," the WTGA morning host announced. *"Councilman, folks all over the city have been talking about that empty podium over at WHRC and the front-page story in the Tidewater Pilot about your twenty-five-year-old opponent catching three buses home at eight-twenty at night. Looks like you've got a real horse race on your hands out in Kempsville."*

When Harold Dietz's voice came through the broadcast compressor, he didn't sound like a calm ten-year incumbent. He sounded tight, defensive, and rattled.

"Well, Mike, let's call that newspaper story what it was—a staged piece of political theater," Dietz snapped over the airwaves. *"The Tidewater Pilot loves a melodramatic human-interest angle, so they print a picture of my opponent rolling onto a bus at night as if riding a bus qualifies somebody to manage a one-point-seven-billion-dollar municipal corporation. Let's talk about the real world at City Hall that nobody at the newspaper wants to mention."*

Katie and I looked at each other across our wheelchair armrests, our fingers stilling on our keyboards.

"First of all," Dietz ploughed ahead, his voice rising with irritation as he went completely off script, *"if my opponent were actually elected on Tuesday, do the taxpayers of Virginia Beach have any idea what City Hall facilities would have to do to the historic mahogany City Council chamber in Building One? They would have to tear out the woodwork on the side of the raised Council dais and spend tens of thousands of taxpayer dollars building a custom structural wheelchair ramp just to get one person up to a desk! And second, let's be honest with the voters about the demands of this job. Serving on the Virginia Beach City Council isn't a hobby you do from a laptop. We sit in six-hour afternoon budget workshops followed by six-hour evening sessions that run past midnight, plus regional commission meetings all over Tidewater. Are we really supposed to pretend that a twenty-five-year-old girl in a*

wheelchair—who has to have her twin brother rolling right beside her everywhere she goes just to get through the day—has the physical stamina to handle twelve-hour days on the City Council?"

Inside our quiet home office in Kempsville, the silence lasted three full seconds.

Even over the radio broadcast, you could hear the WTGA morning host draw in a sharp, audible breath inside the Norfolk studio as he realized the incumbent councilman had just committed political suicide on live air in the largest military and veteran community on the East Coast.

"Uh—Councilman Dietz," the WTGA host cut in quickly, his tone dropping an octave as the red warning lights on his studio call screener's board began flashing like a Christmas tree, *"hang on a second there, Harold. We have eighty thousand disabled veterans and wounded warriors living right here in Virginia Beach and Norfolk who use wheelchairs every day, and federal law under the Americans with Disabilities Act requires public buildings to be accessible anyway—"*

"I'm just saying the voters deserve to know the practical reality and the cost, Mike!" Dietz insisted defensively before the host hastily took the program to a commercial break—and when the show came back from the break three minutes later, Councilman Dietz was no longer on the line.

What followed over the next forty-five minutes on WTGA 790 AM was unlike anything we had ever heard on conservative talk radio.

The host didn't take a single call defending Harold Dietz—because there weren't any. Instead, caller after caller was a furious Navy chief, a retired Marine colonel, a wounded Iraq or Afghanistan veteran from Little Creek or Naval Air Station Oceana, or a lifelong conservative Kempsville homeowner calling in to blister the incumbent for attacking a candidate's wheelchair and mocking the bond between twin siblings who had lived with a spinal-cord condition since high school.

"Mike, this is Senior Chief Petty Officer Miller calling from Bellamy Manor," a booming voice growled on Line One. *"I served twenty-four years in the Navy and I've voted Republican in every election since Ronald Reagan. My nephew lost the use of his legs in Anbar Province in 2007 and uses a power wheelchair just like Katie and Nate Prairie. For a sitting Virginia Beach City Councilman to go on the radio and complain about the cost of putting a wheelchair ramp on the City Council dais—and to insult a young woman's stamina because she uses a wheelchair and works alongside her twin brother—is the most disgraceful thing I've ever heard in this city. I walked out to my front yard five minutes ago, pulled Harold Dietz's sign out of my grass, and threw it in the trash can!"*

By noon on Friday, the fallout had turned into an avalanche. Three of Virginia Beach's largest business associations issued public statements revoking their endorsements of Councilman Dietz and clarifying that they stood for equal access for all citizens. When *The Tidewater Pilot* called our campaign phone asking for Katie's response to Dietz's radio remarks, Katie gave Greg Mercer a single, quiet two-sentence statement:

“My brother Nate and I have used power wheelchairs since our legs gave out during our junior year at Northwood High School, and we have never once asked anyone in Virginia Beach for pity. All we have ever asked for is a ramp to the table and a bus that runs late enough for working people to get home.”

On Saturday morning, October 30—seventy-two hours before the polls opened—*The Tidewater Pilot* devoted the entire top half of its Editorial & Opinion page to a special full-width spread of reader letters under the banner headline:

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR: DIETZ’S ATTACKS ON BUSES, WHEELCHAIR RAMPS CROSS THE LINE

Sitting at our kitchen table with Dad over Saturday morning pancakes and orange juice, I read three of the printed letters aloud while Katie listened beside me:

> A Ramp to the People’s Dais Is Not a “Special Favor”
> As a retired Navy Master Chief who lost both legs above the knee to an IED outside Fallujah in 2006, I nearly drove my hand-control truck off Kempsville Road on Thursday morning listening to Councilman Harold Dietz complain on WTGA 790 AM about the cost of building a wheelchair ramp up to the City Council dais for Katie Prairie. When I came home from Bethesda Naval Hospital in a wheelchair, nobody told me I lacked the “stamina” to contribute to my community. If the mahogany dais in Building 1 doesn’t have a wheelchair ramp after twenty years of the Americans with Disabilities Act, that isn’t an indictment of Katie Prairie—it is an indictment of Harold Dietz and every politician who never thought a citizen in a wheelchair belonged up there.
> — Master Chief Robert H. Callahan, USN (Ret.), Kempsville, Virginia Beach

> The 8:24 PM Bus Is Real Life, Not “Political Theater”
> Councilman Dietz claims Katie and Nate Prairie catching the 8:24 PM Route 2 bus home from the WHRC debate was a “publicity stunt.” Tell that to those of us who close the retail stores at Pembroke Mall and Glenrock Mall every night and pray our connecting Route 20 or Route 15 bus isn’t five minutes late so we aren’t stranded in the dark. Katie and Nate Prairie have ridden the bus with us in the rain and cold for five years. On Tuesday, the bus riders of Virginia Beach are going to send one of our own to City Hall.
> — Denise T. Holloway, College Park, Virginia Beach

> We Remember the Day Their Legs Gave Out at Northwood High
> Hearing Councilman Dietz mock Katie Prairie for having her twin brother Nate rolling beside her broke my heart and made my blood boil. I taught English at Northwood High School in September 2001 on the Friday afternoon when sixteen-year-old Katie and Nate’s legs gave out within three hours of each other. Every teacher in that building watched those two teenagers refuse to give up, finish high school from hospital beds and wheelchairs, earn their degrees at CCHR and Fishersville, build their own software business, and buy their own home in Kempsville. Their bond isn’t a weakness—it is the finest example of family courage in Virginia Beach.
> — Margaret L. Sterling, Retired Teacher, Bayside, Virginia Beach

When I finished reading Mrs. Sterling’s letter, Dad had to take off his glasses and wipe his eyes with his napkin, while Katie held my hand tightly across our armrests.

Tuesday, November 2, 2010, 7:19 PM — The 94.1% to 5.9% Landslide & The Four-Station Election Night Post-Mortem

At seven o'clock on the evening of Tuesday, November 2, 2010, the polls closed across the City of Virginia Beach.

We hadn't rented a hotel ballroom at the Oceanfront. Instead, Katie, Dad, and I were gathered inside our living room on Lord Nelson Drive along with sixteen of our volunteer sidewalk canvassers, CCHR students, and fellow CVTA bus riders, with platters of warm pizza and two-liter bottles of ginger ale, orange soda, and flavored water set out on the dining table and a fresh pot of black coffee brewing in the kitchen for Dad. Across the living room wall, I had connected four television monitors and my dual laptop screens to our custom PHP precinct-return engine, which scraped the live precinct-by-precinct XML data feed straight from the Virginia State Board of Elections and the Virginia Beach Voter Registrar every fifteen seconds.

At 7:08 PM, the first four Kempsville precincts reported their optical-scan tabulator tapes.

Dad leaned over my shoulder, staring at my PHP dashboard screen through his glasses. "Nate… check your parser code on Kempsville Precinct Three and Bellamy Precinct One. Is a decimal point shifted?"

"The parser checksums match the state XML feed to the single vote, Dad," I breathed, my heart hammering against my ribs as five more precincts popped onto the screen in bright green. "Look at the raw totals."

At 7:19 PM—just nineteen minutes after the polls closed—all four local television network affiliates in Hampton Roads (WCVB-TV 10 Coastal News 10, WTID-TV 3 NewsChannel 3, WVHR-TV 13 13News, and WHRC TV-15) flashed simultaneous breaking-news graphics across the bottom of their screens with a loud electronic chime:

PROJECTION — VIRGINIA BEACH CITY COUNCIL (KEMPSVILLE DISTRICT): KATIE PRAIRIE (WINNER) — 94.1% HAROLD DIETZ (INCUMBENT) — 5.9%

Inside our living room on Lord Nelson Drive, a roar went up that shook the framed blue butterfly print on the hallway wall. Dad wrapped both of his arms around Katie's shoulders and mine at the same time, his voice choked with pride, while Katie pressed her forehead against mine across our armrests with tears of pure joy shining in her blue eyes.

As the final precincts locked in over the next twenty minutes confirming the staggering 94.1% to 5.9% margin—the largest landslide defeat of a sitting incumbent in the modern history of Hampton Roads municipal politics—we unmuted the four television feeds and the radio stream to hear the stunned political analysts dissect what had just happened.

On WCVB-TV 10, Coastal News 10 anchor Don Roberts turned to Virginia Dominion University political science professor Dr. Quentin Marsh standing in front of the electronic precinct map.

“Ninety-four point one percent to five point nine percent, Dr. Marsh,” the anchor said, shaking his head at the big board. *“We have never seen numbers like this in a contested Virginia Beach City Council race. How does a ten-year incumbent get wiped out by eighty-eight points?”*

“Don, what we just witnessed tonight in Kempsville is the textbook anatomy of a catastrophic one-two political knockout,” Dr. Marsh explained, tapping the touchscreen map of Virginia Beach. *“Three weeks ago, before the WHRC debate, Harold Dietz was sitting on a comfortable eight-point incumbent lead mostly because voters didn’t know who Katie Prairie was. Then came Punch Number One on October fourteenth: Dietz didn’t even bother to RSVP to WHRC TV-15, leaving his podium empty on live television for forty-five minutes while Katie Prairie demonstrated complete command of the municipal budget—followed ten minutes later by Greg Mercer’s front-page story in the Tidewater Pilot showing Katie and her twin brother Nate sprinting across six lanes of Hampton Boulevard in their wheelchairs to catch the 8:24 PM Route 2 bus so they wouldn’t miss the last three-bus transfer chain home to Virginia Beach. We now know from campaign insiders that by the Monday after that story ran, Dietz’s internal tracking poll had crashed from an eight-point lead down to a dead heat—48.2 percent to 47.8 percent, a razor-thin four-tenths of one percent margin right inside Virginia’s automatic recount threshold—and his major Oceanfront donors threatened to freeze his final forty-thousand-dollar TV buy.”*

Across the room on WVHR-TV 13, a live 13News remote camera panned across a cavernous, completely deserted ballroom at an Oceanfront resort hotel where untouched trays of shrimp cocktail sat under heat lamps beside a silent podium banner reading *RE-ELECT COUNCILMAN DIETZ*.

“And that panic inside the Dietz camp led directly to Punch Number Two last Thursday morning on WTGA 790 AM,” the WVHR-TV 13 political reporter told the studio anchors from the empty ballroom. *“Trying to look tough for his panicked donors, Councilman Dietz went on live talk radio, mocked the Prairies’ three-bus ride home, complained about the taxpayer cost of building a wheelchair ramp up to the City Council dais in Building 1, and questioned whether a woman in a wheelchair rolling alongside her twin brother had the stamina to serve on Council. In a city filled with military families, disabled veterans, and working bus commuters, that radio call turned a 0.4 percent race into a 94 percent wipeout. The Councilman called Ms. Prairie three minutes ago to concede and left the hotel through a side kitchen door.”*

Meanwhile, on WTID-TV 3 NewsChannel 3, the tech-desk correspondent pulled up a live graphic highlighting our grassroots ground game:

“Don’t overlook the engineering behind this victory, either,” the WTID-TV 3 analyst noted. *“Katie and Nathaniel Prairie didn’t spend a dime on outside political consultants. Nathaniel Prairie wrote their custom PHP voter-turnout and precinct-mapping software himself, and look at the precinct turnout bars along the CVTA Route 12, Route 15, Route 20, and Route 36 corridors—precincts that normally see 18 percent turnout in an off-year municipal election surged by 42 percent tonight because bus riders and working families came out in droves to vote for one of their own.”*

Even over on conservative talk radio WTGA 790 AM, the evening election host sighed into his microphone as the 94.1% total scrolled across his screen: *“Folks, Harold Dietz dug his own grave right here on our morning airwaves last Thursday.*

When a twenty-five-year-old woman and her twin brother out-work you, out-debate you, ride three city buses home in the dark, and build their own software from scratch, attacking their wheelchairs in a Navy town is a guaranteed way to get sent into retirement."

January to May 2011 — The Building 1 Dais Ramp, Locking $810,000 of CVTA Perks in Escrow, & Taking Seat on the CVTA Commission

During the eight weeks between Election Night in November 2010 and Reorganization Night in January 2011, municipal carpenters and accessibility contractors went to work inside the City Council Chamber of Building 1 at the Virginia Beach Municipal Center.

Removing the steep wooden steps on the right wing of the curved mahogany City Council dais, the city constructed a permanent, gently sloped, red-carpeted wheelchair ramp bordered by polished mahogany handrails leading straight up to the Kempsville District desk, where the heavy leather swivel chair was rolled away so twenty-five-year-old Councilwoman-Elect Katie Prairie could pull her compact black SwiftChair directly up to the voting console.

On Tuesday evening, January 4, 2011, with the chamber gallery packed wall-to-wall with Kempsville neighbors, CCHR students, bus operators, and retired Master Chief Robert Callahan sitting in the front row in his own wheelchair, Katie rolled up the new mahogany dais ramp to her Kempsville District seat, inviting Dad and me onto the dais beside her solely for the ceremonial swearing-in while I held open our bound leather copy of the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia.

Neither Katie nor I believed in any religion or any god—and before the ceremony, Katie had politely notified the Clerk of the Circuit Court that under Article VI, Clause 3 of the United States Constitution, Article II, Section 7 of the Constitution of Virginia, and Section 49-9 of the Code of Virginia, she would be taking the secular constitutional affirmation on the Virginia Constitution rather than a religious oath on a Bible, omitting the optional parenthetical reference to a deity at the end.

Placing her left hand flat on the Virginia Constitution and raising her right hand, Katie repeated the constitutional affirmation of office as the newly elected Kempsville District Councilwoman in a clear, ringing voice that echoed to the back of the chamber:

"I do solemnly affirm that I will support the Constitution of the United States, and the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia, and that I will faithfully and impartially discharge all the duties incumbent upon me as a member of the Council of the City of Virginia Beach, according to the best of my ability."

As soon as the applause thundered across the chamber, Dad and I descended the ramp back to the front row of the public gallery so Councilwoman Katie Prairie could take her official seat alone at the Kempsville console on the dais.

She didn't wait six months to keep the promise she had made to Greg Mercer at the 8:24 PM bus stop on Hampton Boulevard.

Just two weeks later, on Tuesday evening, January 18, 2011, Item 9B came up on the formal Virginia Beach City Council agenda: a request from the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority for a $1.42 million mid-year supplemental municipal appropriation to cover administrative cost overruns at CVTA's Norfolk headquarters.

Stepping up to the low citizen and staff microphone podium on the chamber floor below the raised mahogany dais were two men in tailored charcoal suits whom Katie and I knew very well: CVTA President and Chief Executive Officer Leonard Sterling, and Chief Operating Officer Richard Halstead—the exact two executives who, fourteen months earlier at 509 East Eighteenth Street, had cut off my public-comment microphone at the hundred-and-eighty-second buzzer, sneered in the hallway that we were *"statistically insignificant hobbyist bloggers,"* refused to release raw GTFS schedule files, and secretly blackballed me from the Transit Riders Advisory Committee.

Now, the roles were reversed. Sterling and Halstead were standing down at the floor microphone looking up at the raised mahogany dais—where twenty-five-year-old Councilwoman Katie Prairie sat in the elected seat of power looking down at them with her finger resting beside her microphone button, while I sat as a private citizen down in the front accessible bay of the chamber floor right beside the dais ramp with the PHP line-item audit I had prepared for her open on my MagnaBook Pro.

When CEO Sterling finished his five-minute presentation asking the City Council to approve the $1.42 million check with no strings attached, the Mayor turned toward the right wing of the dais.

"Councilwoman Prairie," the Mayor said, "you have the floor."

Katie pressed her white microphone button. The green indicator ring lit up—and this time, Richard Halstead didn't have a cutoff switch.

"Thank you, Mr. Mayor," Katie said, her voice calm, polite, and surgical as every camera in Building 1 zoomed in on her desk. "Mr. Sterling, Mr. Halstead, before the voters of Kempsville elected me to this Council by a margin of ninety-four point one percent, the two of you cut off my brother Nate's microphone at Eighteenth Street and told us in the hallway that CVTA doesn't take operational direction from 'hobbyist bloggers.' Now that you are asking the taxpayers of Virginia Beach for an extra one point four two million dollars, my brother and I have gone through every single line of your general ledger."

Down at the podium, Richard Halstead swallowed hard, a bead of sweat glistening at his temple under the television lights.

"Out of the one point four two million dollars you are requesting tonight," Katie continued, reading directly from the PHP audit sheet on her desk, "six hundred and ten thousand dollars goes toward fuel and frontline bus operator wages, which I fully support. The remaining eight hundred and ten thousand dollars, however, is earmarked for executive retention bonuses, out-of-state conference travel, fleet take-home sedans for senior staff, and proprietary scheduling consultant contracts. Meanwhile, here in Virginia Beach, the last Route 12 bus out of the CCHR hub still leaves at 5:48 PM, locking citizens out of our 6:00 PM Council meetings, and your agency still refuses to publish its raw General Transit Feed Specification database tables for the public."

Katie held up a two-page printed budget amendment she had drafted with the City Attorney that morning from our audit notes.

“Therefore, Mr. Mayor,” Katie announced, “I move an amendment to Item 9B: the City of Virginia Beach will release the six hundred and ten thousand dollars for bus operators and fuel tonight, and we will lock the remaining eight hundred and ten thousand dollars of executive overhead in a restricted municipal escrow account. Not one penny of that eight hundred and ten thousand dollars will be released by the City Treasurer until CVTA meets two mandatory conditions: first, publishing its complete, unredacted GTFS schedule database online under an open public license within thirty days; and second, implementing the Evening Civic Access Transit Pulse—extending Route 33 out of the Virginia Beach Municipal Center until 10:30 PM on Council nights and operating a synchronized 9:00 PM and 10:00 PM evening connecting pulse for Routes 12, 25, 29, and 36 at the CCHR Virginia Beach Campus hub.”

“Second!” called out At-Large Councilman Ronald Villa from the other side of the dais with a broad grin.

When the electronic voting board on the chamber wall chimed ten seconds later, all eleven lights glowed green: 11–0.

And the reckoning wasn’t quite finished. Immediately after the budget vote, the Mayor called up Item 9C—the resolution appointing Virginia Beach’s new municipal representatives to the governing board of the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority, the Transportation District Commission, to fill the seat vacated by former Councilman Harold Dietz.

By a second unanimous 11–0 vote, the Virginia Beach City Council appointed Councilwoman Katie Prairie as a voting Commissioner of the Coastal Virginia Transit Authority.

Nine days later, on the fourth Thursday of January 2011, while every other city council commissioner from across Hampton Roads drove into Norfolk and parked in the reserved VIP lot behind 509 East Eighteenth Street, CVTA’s newest governing Commissioner arrived the exact same way she and I had always traveled: by riding a three-bus chain on CVTA—boarding Route 15 northbound on Military Highway, transferring to Route 20 westbound at Glenrock Mall into Downtown Norfolk, and riding Route 1 up Granby Street to Eighteenth Street while paying our regular fare.

When Katie and I rolled our SwiftChairs through the double doors of the Eighteenth Street boardroom, I parked at the front accessible citizen-advisor table while Commissioner Katie Prairie rolled straight up onto the raised Commissioners’ horseshoe dais—right past Chief Operating Officer Richard Halstead’s chair. Under New Business, the very first official action Commissioner Katie Prairie took from the dais was exercising her unilateral prerogative as a Virginia Beach Commissioner to make a citizen appointment to the Transit Riders Advisory Committee.

“Pursuant to Section 4.2 of the Commission bylaws,” Katie said clearly into her Commissioner’s microphone while looking straight across the table at Richard Halstead, “as a voting Commissioner for the City of Virginia Beach, I hereby appoint Nathaniel Prairie to the Virginia Beach citizen seat on the Transit Riders Advisory Committee, effective immediately.”

By May 2011, CVTA had published its complete open GTFS schedule feed and launched the permanent Evening Civic Access Transit Pulse across Virginia Beach. For the first time in the history of our city, any citizen who rode a public bus or used a wheelchair could attend a six o'clock City Council meeting, speak at the public microphone, and ride a CVTA bus safely home afterward.

And on every single Tuesday night when the Virginia Beach City Council adjourned at nine-thirty, Councilwoman Katie Prairie rolled down the mahogany dais ramp in Building 1 to meet me at the front of the gallery, and the two of us rolled out to the Municipal Center bus shelter alongside the citizens who had come to watch the meeting, swiped our thirty-day CVTA passes, and rode the 9:45 PM Route 33 and Route 12 pulse right back home to Kempsville.

The Gentlewoman from Virginia Beach: The House of Delegates

Stopped at the Third-Floor Gallery, Seated by Delegate Ronald Villa, & Winning the 85th District

Part 1: Stopped at the Third-Floor Gallery by Capitol Police, Seated on the House Floor Near Delegate Ronald Villa, & The Spark to Run

Date: 2012-02-09 at 11:35 America/New_York

Thursday, February 9, 2012, 11:35 AM — Stopped Outside the Third-Floor Public Viewing Gallery by Capitol Police

"The public viewing gallery for the House of Delegates should be right around this corner on the left, Nate," twenty-six-year-old Katie said as the brass doors of the small historic passenger elevator slid open on the third floor of the Virginia State Capitol.

Side by side, we guided our compact SwiftChairs out of the narrow elevator cab onto the polished heart-pine floorboards of the third-floor balcony corridor.

It was a cold Thursday morning in February 2012, midway through the winter session of the Virginia General Assembly and thirteen months into Katie's term representing the Kempsville District on the Virginia Beach City Council. Earlier that morning at nine o'clock, after riding up from Hampton Roads to testify both as a Virginia Beach City Councilwoman and as co-founder of Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit, Katie and I had presented our evening ridership numbers and bus-stop accessibility data to a House Transportation subcommittee down in the General Assembly Building—urging the state legislature not to slash the state transit operating funds that matched our new evening bus service in Virginia Beach. Since

our afternoon train back home didn't leave until four o'clock, we had rolled through the underground Capitol tunnel hoping to sit in the public viewing gallery and watch the full House of Delegates convene at noon.

Ahead of us, a line of schoolteachers, college students, and day-trippers was filing past the velvet rope into the steeply tiered wooden benches of the third-floor House Public Gallery.

Before our front casters reached the doorway, however, a uniformed Virginia Division of Capitol Police lieutenant standing beside the gallery entrance stepped gently into the center of the corridor and held up a gloved hand.

"Good morning, folks—hold up just a second for me," the Capitol Police lieutenant said, his tone polite but firm as he looked down at our two power wheelchairs.

Katie and I braked our SwiftChairs together. "Good morning, Lieutenant," Katie said calmly. "We already cleared the security screening downstairs at the visitor entrance. We're just heading into the public viewing gallery to watch the noon House session."

"Yes, ma'am, I see your visitor stickers," the lieutenant replied, glancing toward the narrow gallery threshold and then back at our heavy powerchairs with genuine concern on his face. "I'm very sorry, folks, but we can't bring wheelchairs into the third-floor public viewing gallery."

My eyebrows drew together. "Is there not a level space at the top of the gallery aisle?"

"It's not the floor space inside the doorway, sir—it's emergency evacuation safety," the Capitol Police lieutenant explained earnestly, gesturing back toward the small retrofit elevator we had just ridden up and the steep, winding eighteenth-century stairwell at the end of the hall. "Thomas Jefferson designed this building in 1788. If a fire alarm goes off or we have to order an emergency evacuation of the Capitol while the House is in session, that passenger elevator automatically locks out and recalls to the ground floor. From this third-floor gallery, the only way out of the building is down three flights of steep, narrow historic stairs. My officers have no safe way to carry power wheelchairs down three stories of stairs in an emergency, and I can't put the two of you in a position where we couldn't get you out of the building safely."

Katie and I looked at each other across our armrests. Having spent more than ten years navigating every flavor of architectural barrier in Virginia, both of us could tell immediately that the Capitol Police officer wasn't trying to brush us off—he was looking at a genuine life-safety trap in a two-hundred-year-old building and taking his duty seriously.

"So there's nowhere in the State Capitol where a citizen in a wheelchair is allowed to watch their own House of Delegates vote?" Katie asked quietly, not angry at the officer, but with that familiar, steady look in her blue eyes whenever she ran into a systemic wall.

"I didn't say that, ma'am," the Capitol Police lieutenant said with a reassuring half-smile, reaching up to unclip the microphone of his shoulder radio. "Give me two minutes right here by the elevator. I'm going to walk downstairs and speak directly to the Sergeant-at-Arms and House Leadership to explain that we have a member of

the public in a wheelchair and her companion upstairs who came to watch the House session, and that Capitol Police have emergency-egress safety concerns with the third-floor gallery. Let me see what Leadership can do."

We parked our SwiftChairs beside the marble bust in the third-floor elevator vestibule and waited while the ten-minute warning bell for the noon floor session chimed overhead.

Four minutes later, the brass indicator needle above the third-floor elevator swung upward. The doors slid open, and the Capitol Police lieutenant stepped out alongside a tall gentleman in a dark three-piece suit wearing the silver badge of the Sergeant-at-Arms of the Virginia House of Delegates.

"Councilwoman Prairie and Mr. Prairie?" the Sergeant-at-Arms asked warmly.

"Yes, sir," I said.

"The Lieutenant just spoke with me and the Speaker's office about the safety concern up here on the third floor," the Sergeant-at-Arms said, holding out two heavy cream-colored cards stamped in gold leaf with the seal of the Commonwealth. "House Leadership does not want any Virginian turned away from watching the people's House in session because of a wheelchair. By order of the Speaker, you and one ADA companion—or in your case, both of you together—have been granted a rare honor today. If you'll ride the elevator down to the first floor with me, we're going to seat you right on the Floor of the Virginia House of Delegates."

Katie's blue eyes widened slightly as she looked across at me, and we rolled our wheelchairs straight back into the elevator cab beside the Sergeant-at-Arms.

Thursday, February 9, 2012, 11:52 AM — Seated on the House Floor Near Virginia Beach Delegate Ronald Villa & The Spark

When the elevator doors opened on the first floor, the marble rotunda corridor outside the House Chamber was packed three-deep with corporate lobbyists, reporters, and political staffers pressed against the brass velvet rope.

Under the rules of the House of Delegates, members of the general public and registered lobbyists were strictly barred from crossing that threshold onto the Chamber floor during session. Yet as the Sergeant-at-Arms stepped out of the elevator ahead of our two wheelchairs, the doorkeepers immediately unhooked the velvet rope and swung open the tall mahogany double doors.

"Make way, please—honored guests of the House coming through to the Floor," the Sergeant-at-Arms announced.

Thirty-five lobbyists in thousand-dollar suits parted in stunned silence as two twenty-six-year-old twins from Virginia Beach rolled their compact black SwiftChairs straight across the threshold onto the lush green carpet of the Virginia House of Delegates Chamber.

Rolling inside at floor level felt completely different from looking at photographs of the chamber. High above us rose the cream-and-gold coffered ceiling and the glittering crystal chandeliers; directly ahead stood the Speaker's elevated marble rostrum and the twin electronic voting boards listing all one hundred Delegates in

alphabetical order. And instead of staring down at the tops of lawmakers' heads from a distant third-floor balcony, we were rolling right past the curved rows of polished mahogany desks where the elected representatives of the Commonwealth sat.

"Right over here on the outer right aisle, folks," the Sergeant-at-Arms whispered kindly, guiding our two wheelchairs to a wide, level carpeted bay near the rear row of desks on the first floor—twenty feet from an emergency ground-level exit door. "I figured two folks from Virginia Beach would feel right at home sitting next to one of your hometown Delegates."

At the mahogany desk immediately beside our wheelchair bay, a dark-haired Delegate in a crisp navy suit—with a brass nameplate on his desk reading *MR. VILLA — VIRGINIA BEACH (21ST DISTRICT)*—turned around in his leather swivel chair to see who was being seated beside him.

The instant his eyes landed on our two wheelchairs, Delegate Ronald Villa broke into a huge, genuine grin and stood right up to shake our hands.

"Katie! Nate!" Delegate Villa said warmly, clasping Katie's right hand and then reaching across to shake mine. "What a surprise! How did the two of you manage to score floor seats in the House of Delegates?"

"We tried to go upstairs to the third-floor public viewing gallery, Delegate Villa," I explained with a grin, "and Capitol Police stopped us because they were worried about how they'd evacuate our wheelchairs down three flights of stairs in an emergency. They talked to House Leadership, and the Sergeant-at-Arms brought us down here to sit next to you."

"Well, I couldn't ask for better company on my aisle!" Delegate Villa laughed, gesturing toward the two neighboring delegates seated to his left. "Hey, guys, let me introduce you to Virginia Beach City Councilwoman Katie Prairie from Kempsville and her twin brother Nathaniel. Long before Katie won her Kempsville Council seat, the two of them started the Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit blog. Back when I was serving At-Large on the Virginia Beach City Council before I was elected to the House, I was actively fighting to get more covered bus shelters built for our bus riders so working folks and seniors wouldn't be standing out in the pouring rain along Kempsville Road, Princess Anne Road, and Holland Road. Every time city staff claimed we didn't know which bus stops needed shelters the most, Katie and Nate had already ridden every route in their wheelchairs and published the exact stop-by-stop boarding numbers and sidewalk photos on their website!"

The two neighboring delegates smiled and shook our hands across our lap trays as the noon bell rang and the Speaker rapped his wooden gavel to call the House of Delegates to order.

For the next hour and fifteen minutes, Katie and I sat side by side in our SwiftChairs right on the green carpet of the House Floor beside Delegate Ronald Villa's desk.

Whenever a bill came up on the electronic calendar board, Delegate Villa leaned over his desk armrest between votes to whisper a quick, friendly explanation of the parliamentary procedure—pointing out how the white request-to-speak buttons worked on the desk consoles, how committee chairmen signaled floor amendments, and how the red and green lights on the big wall boards tallied the yeas and nays in real time. Even though he sat on the Republican side of the aisle and knew our transit blog frequently called out state and local leaders in both parties when public

transit got shortchanged, Delegate Villa treated us with the warm, unpretentious respect of a former At-Large City Councilman who genuinely cared about the bus riders in his city.

Then, at twelve-forty-five, the budget amendment Katie and I had testified for at nine o'clock that morning came up on the floor—a measure to restore four million dollars in state operating assistance for local public bus systems across Hampton Roads, Richmond, and Northern Virginia.

Sitting right on the House Floor, Katie and I watched the big electronic voting board on the front wall as the bell chimed and the red and green lights blinked on beside each lawmaker's name.

Right next to us, Delegate Ronald Villa reached forward and pressed his green *YEA* button to support the transit funds for Hampton Roads.

Across the chamber, however, the incumbent Delegate representing our own Eighty-Fifth House District back home in Kempsville—Delegate Richard Tatum, who had ignored three straight emails Katie had sent him asking for a ten-minute meeting to coordinate state matching funds for Virginia Beach's new evening bus routes—didn't even look up from his cell phone as he reached over and slapped his red *NAY* button, helping defeat the transit amendment by six votes.

I turned my head slightly to look at my twin sister.

Katie wasn't looking at the floor carpet anymore. Sitting upright in her compact SwiftChair on the floor of the Virginia House of Delegates, her blue eyes were locked onto the mahogany desks and the big electronic voting board at the front of the room. For the first time in her life, the Virginia General Assembly wasn't a distant, abstract institution behind a television glass screen or three stories below a balcony rail. She was sitting right on the Floor. She could see the buttons on the desks. She could hear how the bills were debated. And she could see firsthand that while she had fought for a full year on the Virginia Beach City Council to get evening buses running out of the Municipal Center, the Eighty-Fifth District's own State Delegate up here in Richmond was voting to starve those very same buses of state matching funds.

When the House recessed at one-fifteen and Delegate Villa shook our hands again before heading off to his afternoon committee meeting—promising to keep working with us on bus shelters and regional transit back home in Virginia Beach—Katie and I rolled out the tall mahogany double doors of the House Chamber into the first-floor marble corridor.

As we rode the elevator down toward the underground Capitol tunnel, Katie reached across our wheelchair armrests and took my right hand in a grip so steady and electric that I felt it all the way to my shoulders.

"Nate," Katie whispered as the elevator doors closed around just the two of us.

"Yeah, Katie?" I asked, looking straight into her eyes.

"Being stopped at the third-floor viewing gallery by Capitol Police and brought down to sit on the House Floor beside Delegate Villa today was the best thing that ever could have happened to us," Katie said, her voice quiet and ringing with unmistakable purpose. "Did you see how ordinary those mahogany desks are when

you're sitting right next to them on the green carpet? Just like on City Council back home, all it takes to make room for a power wheelchair at one of those desks is pulling out a single wooden swivel chair."

My breath caught in my chest as I realized what my twin sister was saying.

"Richard Tatum didn't even look up from his phone when he voted against our buses today," Katie continued, squeezing my fingers tightly. "We proved on the Virginia Beach City Council that when you put a bus rider in a wheelchair at the table, you can change the schedules for the entire city. But as long as politicians in Richmond keep cutting state transit funds and blocking disability Medicaid waivers, local City Councils are fighting with one hand tied behind their backs. The next House of Delegates election is in November 2013. Let's go home, talk it over with Dad, and map out how we win the Eighty-Fifth District seat."

Part 2: Telling Dad at Our Kempsville Kitchen Table, The 125-Signature Ballot Petition at CCHR, & Winning the Eighty-Fifth House District

Date: 2012-11-23 at 18:30 America/New_York

Friday, November 23, 2012, 6:30 PM — Brainstorming with Dad Around the Kempsville Kitchen Table

"Dad," twenty-seven-year-old Katie said after the three of us had finished our Friday evening Thanksgiving leftovers and I had set three fresh glasses of ice-cold ginger ale down on the oak kitchen table of our house on Lord Nelson Drive in Kempsville, "Nate and I have a big decision we want to talk through with you before the end of the year."

Sitting across the table from our two compact SwiftChairs in his flannel shirt, our fifty-four-year-old dad set his glass down, adjusted his eyeglasses, and looked from Katie's face to mine with a knowing fatherly smile.

"Wait—let me guess," Dad said warmly. "The last time the two of you gave me that exact synchronized twin look across this table was back in 2010 right before Katie told me she was going to run against Harold Dietz for the Kempsville seat on the Virginia Beach City Council. Who rattled your cage this time?"

"Delegate Richard Tatum," Katie answered without missing a beat, sliding my MagnaBook Pro laptop across the table so Dad could see the newly redistricted map of the Eighty-Fifth House District glowing on the screen. "Back in February, when Nate and I rode up to Richmond to testify for state public-transit matching funds, Capitol Police stopped us at the third-floor viewing gallery over emergency-evacuation concerns and House Leadership brought us down to sit right on the Floor of the House of Delegates next to Ron Villa's desk. We sat twenty feet away from Richard Tatum and watched him slap his red Nay button against Hampton Roads bus funding without even looking up from his cell phone."

"And after serving two years on the Virginia Beach City Council," I added, tapping the boundary lines on the laptop screen, "we've seen firsthand that almost everything we're trying to fix locally—dedicated regional funding for CVTA, clearing the state developmental-disability Medicaid waiver waitlist for Virginia

families raising adults like our cousin Chelsea up in Newport, Rhode Island, and enforcing real accessibility rules—is controlled up in Richmond by the General Assembly. Look at the new decennial map for the Eighty-Fifth House District, Dad: it covers Kempsville, Bellamy Manor, Brandon, and Larkspur, right around Fairlawn Recreation Center on Marlborough Drive. Eighty-five percent of the precincts in the Eighty-Fifth House District are the exact same Kempsville neighborhoods that elected Katie to City Council in 2010."

Dad leaned over the table, studying the precinct map carefully before looking back up at Katie.

"I know my daughter, and I know that once the two of you set your minds to something, nobody in Virginia is going to stop you," Dad said proudly, though his voice turned serious and practical as he switched into systems-engineer problem-solving mode. "So let's brainstorm this right now from start to finish before the calendar flips to 2013. Walk me through every step between tonight and swearing-in day in January 2014. First question: Virginia Beach City Council is non-partisan under state law. If you run for the Virginia House of Delegates against Richard Tatum next November, you have to declare a party ballot line. How are you filing?"

"I'm running as a Democrat—Katie Prairie, D-Virginia Beach," Katie said without a second's hesitation. "City Council elections are non-partisan by law, so party labels weren't on the ballot in 2010, but you, Nate, and I have been Democrats our entire lives. Nate and I grew up in a Democratic household watching you vote for the Democratic ticket in every election, Dad. Back when we were teenagers in high school, we would have gladly voted for the Democratic candidates right alongside you if we'd been old enough to cast a ballot, and the three of us have voted Democrat in every single local, state, and federal election since the day Nate and I turned eighteen. Ron Villa has always been fair to us on bus shelters from the Republican side because he came up through City Council, but the House majority caucus in Richmond just spent the whole 2012 session cutting public transit, blocking healthcare expansion, and starving disability services. If I'm going up to Richmond to fight for working families, bus riders, and disabled Virginians, I'm running proudly under the party banner the three of us have always believed in."

"Damn right," Dad nodded with a proud grin, pulling a yellow legal pad and a ballpoint pen toward his elbow. "The three of us have never hidden what we stand for. Second question: what happens to your Kempsville seat on the Virginia Beach City Council during the campaign—and what happens to your software business here at home if you win?"

"Under Virginia law, a sitting City Council member does not have to resign her municipal seat just to run for the General Assembly," I explained, opening the Code of Virginia tab I had bookmarked in our browser. "Katie's four-year City Council term runs through 2014, and the House of Delegates election is in November 2013. That means Katie keeps representing Kempsville on the Virginia Beach City Council through the entire 2013 campaign so our neighbors never lose their vote at City Hall. Once she wins the House seat in November 2013, she'll serve through the final December 2013 Council meeting and then formally resign her City Council seat effective December 31, 2013—right before taking her oath in the House of Delegates on the second Wednesday in January 2014."

"And because the Virginia General Assembly is a part-time citizen legislature," Katie added, "session only runs for sixty days in even-numbered years and forty-five days in odd-numbered years during January and February. Ten months out of every

year, Nate and I stay right here in our house on Lord Nelson Drive running our software business and riding CVTA buses around the district. For January and February, we'll rent a one-bedroom accessible apartment right on a JRTC bus route in Richmond."

Dad wrote *Jan–Feb: 60/45-day Winter Session (Richmond Bus Route Apt)* at the top of his legal pad, then tapped his pen below it.

"Alright—now walk me through the official election-law timeline under Title 24.2 of the Code of Virginia," Dad said. "What paperwork has to be filed between January 1, 2013 and the ballot deadline so Tatum's lawyers can't try to knock you off the ballot on a technicality?"

I rotated the second browser tab toward Dad, where Katie and I had already built a step-by-step statutory checklist.

"Step one happens on January 2, 2013," I said. "We file Katie's Statement of Organization with the Virginia State Board of Elections in the COMET campaign finance system, register *Katie Prairie for Delegate*, and open a dedicated campaign checking account at our credit union within ten days. Under state law, every candidate committee has to designate an official Campaign Treasurer who lives in Virginia. Katie and I want me to serve as Campaign Manager and Chief Technology Officer—and we want to know if you'll serve as our official Campaign Treasurer, Dad."

Dad's chest swelled visibly behind his glasses. "Try and stop me. I balanced our household books down to the penny when I was putting myself through CCHR after the divorce—I'll make sure every campaign finance report we file with Richmond reconciles to the cent. What's step two?"

"Step two is ballot qualification between January 2 and the late-March primary filing deadline," Katie said, pointing to the four official State Board of Elections forms we had downloaded:

"To qualify for the June Democratic Primary ballot in a House of Delegates district," Katie explained, "a candidate has to file four things before five o'clock on the March filing deadline: first, the Certificate of Candidate Qualification under Section 24.2-501 certifying that I'm a qualified voter and resident of the Eighty-Fifth House District; second, the Declaration of Candidacy under Section 24.2-520 along with the party primary filing fee paid to the Virginia Beach Treasurer; third, the General Assembly Statement of Economic Interests under Section 30-111 disclosing our fifty-fifty software company and our house here in Kempsville; and fourth—the most important part—the Petition of Qualified Voters under Section 24.2-506."

"How many valid voter signatures does the Code of Virginia require for a House of Delegates candidate?" Dad asked, poised with his pen.

"The statute requires a minimum of one hundred and twenty-five signatures from qualified, registered voters residing inside the Eighty-Fifth House District, witnessed by a circulator who signs the affidavit on the back of each legal-sized petition sheet before a notary public," I said. "Professional campaigns sometimes get sloppy and turn in two hundred signatures, and then get disqualified when fifty of the signers turn out to live across the street in the Eighty-First or Twenty-First District. So we aren't turning in one hundred and twenty-five signatures. We're going to collect four hundred verified Eighty-Fifth District signatures—and before a single voter signs

our clipboard, I'm going to look up their street address live on my laptop against the official Eighty-Fifth District registered-voter file so we have a one-hundred-percent validity rate."

"And where are we collecting those four hundred signatures?" Dad asked with a grin, already guessing the answer.

"Right at the CCHR Virginia Beach Campus bus transfer loop, along the Kempsville Road and Princess Anne Road bus stops, and out on the neighborhood sidewalks every Saturday morning in January and February," Katie smiled, reaching across our armrests to take my hand while extending her other hand across the table to Dad. "No paid petition mercenaries from out of town. Just the three of us."

Dad placed his large, warm hand over both of ours in the center of the kitchen table.

"Then on Saturday, January fifth, I'm driving down from Alexandria with three legal-sized clipboards and a box of black pens," Dad said. "Let's put a bus rider in the House of Delegates."

January to December 2013 — 412 Signatures at CCHR, Canvassing the 85th District, & Passing the Baton on City Council

On the first Saturday morning of January 2013, right after Katie and I filed her Statement of Organization with Dad listed as Treasurer, the three of us set up at the edge of the concrete passenger island at the CCHR Virginia Beach Campus bus loop.

Every time a CVTA Route 12, Route 25, Route 29, or Route 33 bus pulled into the college transfer hub, dozens of Kempsville residents stepped off the doors and recognized Katie immediately as the twenty-seven-year-old City Councilwoman in the black SwiftChair who had fought to keep their evening buses running until ten-thirty at night.

"Councilwoman Prairie! Are those petitions to run for State Delegate against Richard Tatum?" a CCHR nursing instructor asked excitedly on our very first morning, spotting the legal-sized State Board of Elections sheets clipped to Katie's lap tray. "Give me a pen right now—and wait two seconds while I call my husband and my daughter over from the Route 12 shelter so they can sign too!"

With Dad standing beside our wheelchairs holding the extra clipboards and signing the circulator affidavits in front of a mobile notary at the end of each afternoon, and with me verifying every signer's address and precinct number on my laptop on the spot, we didn't just hit the statutory minimum of one hundred and twenty-five signatures—by the end of February, we had collected four hundred and twelve verified signatures from registered Eighty-Fifth District voters.

When the five-o'clock primary filing deadline closed on the last Thursday of March 2013, not a single Democratic challenger had filed against a popular sitting Kempsville City Councilwoman who had turned in four hundred and twelve bulletproof grassroots signatures. The Virginia State Board of Elections officially certified Katie as the Democratic Nominee for the Eighty-Fifth House District without the expense of a June primary.

Two days later, a pair of sleek political consultants from Richmond rode down I-64 and asked to meet us at a restaurant near Pembroke Commons. Spreading glossy brochures across the table, they informed Katie that to run a "serious" House of Delegates campaign in Virginia Beach, she needed to pay their firm a forty-thousand-dollar retainer to lease the state party's voter-targeting software, hire an out-of-state direct-mail agency, and host high-dollar donor receptions at Oceanfront hotels.

Katie and I listened politely, took a sip of our ginger ales, and turned their entire forty-thousand-dollar sales pitch down flat.

"My brother and I are professional software engineers," Katie told the stunned consultants before we rolled out to catch our bus home. "Nate already wrote our custom PHP precinct-mapping and voter-turnout engine for my 2010 City Council victory, and it runs faster, cleaner, and with better precinct math than anything on K Street. Every dollar small donors give our campaign is going straight into printing accessible literature and reaching voters in Kempsville—not paying commissions to Richmond consultants."

From April through November 2013, the three of us ran the most disciplined grassroots campaign the Eighty-Fifth District had ever seen.

Every weekday after our software client work and Katie's City Council duties, Katie and I rode CVTA buses across the district and rolled down the residential sidewalks of Kempsville, Bellamy Manor, Brandon, and Larkspur. Whenever a house had two or three brick steps up to the front porch, Dad—who drove down from Alexandria every Friday night through Sunday evening, joined during the weekdays by a dozen volunteer CCHR students and fellow bus riders—walked up the steps to knock on the door while Katie and I parked our SwiftChairs right at the bottom of the front walk so the homeowner could step out onto the porch and talk directly with Katie eye-to-eye.

By mid-October, internal polling showed that Katie had erased Delegate Richard Tatum's twelve-point incumbent cushion.

Panicking during the final ten days of the race, Tatum's Richmond campaign consultants dropped a glossy, full-color attack mailer into every mailbox in Kempsville showing a photograph of the steps of the State Capitol with the headline: *THE GENERAL ASSEMBLY MOVES FAST—CAN KATIE PRAIRIE KEEP UP?* Inside, the mailer sneered that Katie "doesn't even hold a driver's license" and claimed that two twenty-eight-year-old twins who rode the city bus would be "out of their depth in Richmond."

The backlash across Virginia Beach was instantaneous.

Disabled veterans from Naval Air Station Oceana and Little Creek, parents of special-needs children at Morrison Middle School and Northwood High School, senior citizens along Kempsville Road, and hundreds of commuters who rode the evening buses Katie had championed on City Council flooded the local newspaper letters page and local television broadcasts with outrage. Even former At-Large City Councilman and sitting Republican Delegate Ronald Villa over in the neighboring Twenty-First District told a Norfolk newspaper reporter on the record, *"Anyone who thinks Katie and Nate Prairie can't keep up at the State Capitol has never watched those two work a transportation budget."*

On Election Night—Tuesday, November 5, 2013—sitting side by side with Dad at our kitchen table on Lord Nelson Drive tracking the eighteen precincts of the Eighty-Fifth House District on my PHP dashboard, we watched the final returns lock in at 8:15 PM:

Katie Prairie (D): 54.4% — Richard Tatum (R, Incumbent): 45.6%.

At twenty-eight years old, my twin sister was officially Delegate-Elect Katie Prairie of the Eighty-Fifth House District.

Over the next eight weeks of November and December 2013, we completed every statutory transition step between Election Night and Opening Day:

First, on the Wednesday and Thursday after the election, the three-member Virginia Beach Electoral Board met at the Municipal Center to conduct the official canvass of precinct returns, transmitting the certified abstract up to the Virginia State Board of Elections in Richmond under Code of Virginia Section 24.2-675 so the Secretary of the Board could mail Katie her official, gold-sealed Certificate of Election.

Second, during the first week of December, we traveled up to Richmond for the one-day House Clerk's administrative intake—receiving Katie's office assignment in Room 518 on the fifth floor of the General Assembly Building—and met via video conference with attorneys at the Division of Legislative Services to draft and pre-file her first three legislative bills on regional transit funding, developmental-disability Medicaid waiver slots, and statewide ADA building enforcement ahead of the December pre-filing deadline.

Third, on the third Tuesday evening of December 2013, Katie rolled up the permanent ramp to the Virginia Beach City Council dais at the Municipal Center one last time. After casting her final municipal votes and thanking the people of Kempsville for three unforgettable years of service on City Council, Katie formally submitted her resignation from the non-partisan Kempsville Council seat effective at 11:59 PM on December 31, 2013—welcoming her newly elected Kempsville Council successor, Councilwoman Amelia Thornton, so she would never hold dual municipal and state legislative office when her House term began.

When Katie and I rolled out of the Municipal Center at nine-thirty that December night and boarded the 9:45 PM CVTA Route 33 bus that she had fought to create, the driver saluted her from behind the wheel.

"Next stop for you two is the State Capitol up in Richmond, Delegate-Elect Prairie!" the driver beamed.

"Only for forty-five and sixty days every winter," Katie smiled, holding my hand across the center aisle between our two wheelchair bays as the bus rolled toward CCHR. "And on Friday, January third, Nate and I are moving into an apartment right on West Broad Street so we can ride the Richmond city bus to the Capitol too."

Freshman Session on West Broad Street & Riding JRTC Route 6 to the Capitol

Part 1: The West Broad Street Loft, Unpacking Our Shared Queen Bed, & Weekend Reconnaissance on JRTC Route 6

Date: 2014-01-03 at 14:15 America/New_York

Friday, January 3, 2014, 2:15 PM — Five Days Ahead of Opening Day at the Broad & Boulevard Lofts

“I still apologize that we only had a one-bedroom accessible apartment left on the ground floor for the legislative session, Delegate Prairie,” the property manager of the Broad & Boulevard Lofts said nervously as he held open the wide oak door of Apartment 104 and handed twenty-eight-year-old Katie two brass keys and a pair of electronic lobby fobs. “When the General Assembly convenes every January, the two-bedroom corporate units book up months in advance. If you and your brother need us to roll a folding cot into the living room—”

“No cot needed at all, Mr. Henderson, thank you,” Katie said with a warm, reassuring smile from her compact black SwiftChair as she rolled smoothly across the threshold ahead of me and our fifty-five-year-old dad. “A one-bedroom apartment with one queen bed is actually the exact layout my brother and I asked for.”

Behind us, pushing a wheeled bellhop cart loaded with our two dark-blue comforter bags from home, our dual laptop stands, and two plastic crates of kitchen staples that he had driven down I-95 from Alexandria in the bed of his pickup truck to meet our morning ARTS train from Norfolk, Dad chuckled softly at the property manager’s polite blink of surprise.

Once Mr. Henderson wished us a good winter in Richmond and stepped back out into the wide brick-and-timber hallway, I clicked the deadbolt shut and looked around our new sixty-day winter sanctuary.

It was Friday, January 3, 2014—five full days before the Virginia General Assembly would gavel in at noon on Wednesday, January 8 for Katie’s very first session representing the Eighty-Fifth House District back home in Kempsville and Virginia Beach.

When Katie had flipped the Eighty-Fifth District seat two months earlier in November 2013—running on the exact public-transit, disability-access, and working-family platform we had spent the previous eight years championing on Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit—party staffers in Richmond had automatically sent us brochures for upscale high-rise apartments down in Shockoe Slip and luxury suites near the downtown hotels where veteran lawmakers stayed during the winter session.

Katie and I had taken one look at the transit map of Richmond and turned every single one of those downtown hotel brochures down.

Instead, we had chosen Apartment 104 inside the Broad & Boulevard Lofts—a renovated brick warehouse building on West Broad Street right near Boulevard at the edge of Scott's Addition and the Museum District. The building had a flush concrete entrance off the wide West Broad Street sidewalk with zero steps, blue ADA push-button automatic doors, forty-two-inch interior doorways, low-pile commercial carpet, and a roll-in bathroom with steel grab bars. Even better, thirty feet outside the front lobby glass stood a blue-and-white bus stop sign for the James River Transit Company—Richmond's public bus network, universally known across the capital region as the JRTC Transit System.

"Come look at this view out the living room windows, Nate," Katie called out, rolling her SwiftChair across the open floor plan toward the two tall industrial sash windows facing south over West Broad Street.

I rolled up beside her left armrest while Dad carried our bedding bags into the bedroom. Right below our first-floor windowsill, a blue-and-white forty-foot JRTC Stalwart low-floor transit bus with an amber LED destination sign reading *6 BROAD STREET — DOWNTOWN / CAPITOL* glided past the curb.

"Four separate JRTC trunk routes converge right along this stretch of West Broad Street," I said, resting my hand over Katie's fingers on her armrest as we watched a westbound bus pass in the opposite lane thirty seconds later. "Route 6 runs straight down Broad Street past the Science Museum and Central Virginia University to Ninth and Broad at Capitol Square in eleven minutes, and straight west to the shops and grocery store at Oak Lawn in ten minutes."

"And arriving five days early gives us all of Saturday and Sunday to learn the bus routes, test every transfer stop, and get our routine locked down before Monday morning's New Member Orientation even starts," Katie said, letting out a quiet, contented breath as her shoulders relaxed.

Because both of us were autistic, walking cold into an unfamiliar city and a brand-new legislative building on the same morning would have been a recipe for sensory overload. Coming up to Richmond five days ahead of Wednesday's Opening Day gavel wasn't a vacation; it was how Katie and I mapped our perimeter so that by the time the session bell rang, every doorway, curb cut, bus stop, and timetable between our bed and the House Floor felt completely predictable.

We rolled into the bedroom to help Dad finish unpacking.

Although the apartment came furnished with a solid oak queen bedframe, a firm mattress, and two nightstands, Katie and I never slept well under stiff, bleach-scented corporate rental linens. Dad had already stripped off the rental bedspread and folded it onto the top closet shelf, and together the three of us spread out our own familiar cotton sheets, our heavy navy-blue winter comforter, and our four pillows from our shared bedroom back home in Kempsville.

"There," Katie said happily, smoothing the corner of our comforter from her wheelchair while I plugged our dual powerchair chargers into the wall outlet at the foot of the bed. "Now it smells like home."

Out in the front room, Dad helped us push the rectangular oak dining table right up in front of the tall windows overlooking West Broad Street. Within forty minutes, we had our two MagnaBook Pro laptops, our dual twenty-four-inch external monitors, our hardware firewall router, and our portable video-capture encoder cabled neatly across the tabletop.

Before Dad headed back out to his pickup truck at five-thirty to beat the Friday evening traffic north up I-95 to his house on Sunset Drive in Alexandria, he stood by the front door and pulled both of us into a long, tight hug across our wheelchair armrests.

“If anybody at that Capitol gives my daughter or my son a hard time next week, you call me,” Dad said fiercely, kissing the top of Katie’s blonde head and clapping my shoulder.

“We’ll be fine, Dad,” Katie smiled, hugging him back as I squeezed his forearm. “We’ve got each other, we’ve got our laptops, and we’ve got a bus stop thirty feet from the front door.”

That Friday night, after eating a quiet supper of toasted cheese sandwiches and tomato soup at our window table while watching the headlights and blue-and-white JRTC buses roll down West Broad Street, Katie and I transferred out of our SwiftChairs onto the edge of our shared queen bed. Pulling our familiar Kempsville comforter up to our chins in the dark, we curled up facing each other with Katie’s forehead resting against my collarbone and her fingers laced tightly through mine—safe inside our new Richmond perimeter.

Saturday & Sunday, January 4–5, 2014 — Buying Regular 30-Day JRTC Passes & Mapping the Broad Street Spine

At nine o’clock on Saturday morning, bundled up in our matching winter parkas, knit gloves, and wool scarves with our canvas backpacks hooked behind our wheelchair headrests, Katie and I rolled out the automatic glass doors of the Broad & Boulevard Lofts to the West Broad Street bus stop.

The January air was crisp and clear at thirty-six degrees. Three minutes after we braked our SwiftChairs on the concrete waiting pad alongside a Central Virginia University nursing student and two restaurant cooks heading downtown for the Saturday lunch shift, an eastbound JRTC Route 6 Stalwart low-floor bus pulled smoothly to the curb.

The air brakes hissed, and as the front doors folded open and the front air suspension dropped four inches toward the sidewalk, the bus’s external automated voice annunciator spoke through the doorway speaker in its crisp, unmistakable cadence—announcing the route once as the doors opened before switching to the safety warnings as the stainless-steel front flip-ramp folded out onto the concrete:

“Route 6. Downtown. Welcome aboard JRTC!”

“Caution: bus is kneeling! Caution: lift is deploying!”

“Morning, folks! Watch your roll coming aboard,” the JRTC operator called out cheerfully, reaching down to flip up the two bench seats over the front left and right wheelchair securement bays.

“Good morning!” Katie said brightly as she rolled up the gentle slope of the low-floor ramp first and backed her SwiftChair deftly into the curbside wheelchair bay, while I rolled right up behind her into the street-side bay across the narrow aisle.

“Caution: lift is stowing!” the automated voice announced as the stainless-steel ramp folded back into the front threshold step with a solid clank.

After the operator clicked the four-point retractable floor straps onto our wheelchair frames and returned to his seat, Katie and I each reached forward to the farebox beside the steering column and fed crisp dollar bills into the bill validator to pay our standard one-dollar-and-fifty-cent base fares like any other rider in Richmond.

“Where are you two headed this cold Saturday morning?” the operator asked as he pulled the forty-foot bus back into the eastbound lane of West Broad Street.

“Ninth and Broad first so we can walk over to the JRTC customer service window and buy our thirty-day unlimited magnetic swipe passes for the winter,” Katie replied, holding my hand across the center aisle between our two wheelchair bays. “We’re staying right back there at Broad and Boulevard through the middle of March.”

“Well, you picked the best bus line in the city of Richmond to live on,” the driver said with a proud grin in his wide rearview mirror. “Between the 6, the 1, the 2, and the 3, you won’t ever wait more than ten minutes on Broad Street from six in the morning till midnight.”

As the bus rolled straight east down the wide six-lane boulevard—passing the domed neoclassical rotunda of the Science Museum of Virginia in the old Broad Street Union Station, the brick dormitories and classrooms of Central Virginia University around Monroe Park, and the historic storefronts of the Arts District—I had my pocket notebook open on my lap tray, logging the exact travel times and stop spacing while the interior automated voice announced every single cross street we passed, whether there was a bus stop on that block or not:

“Robinson Street.”

“Mulberry Street.”

“Allison Street.”

“Meadow Street.”

“Lombardy Street.”

“Belvidere Street.”

“Listen to the onboard GPS annunciator, Katie,” I murmured with an appreciative grin as the voice called out *“First Street”*, *“Second Street”*, *“Third Street”* in steady sequence down the straight Broad Street corridor. “It announces every single cross street along the route even when it isn’t a bus stop—and whenever a JRTC bus

completes a turn, it announces both streets on the corner. For a blind rider or someone visiting Richmond for the first time, you always know down to the exact block where you are."

"Eighth Street. Ninth Street."

Eleven minutes after boarding outside our apartment, the bus pulled up to the curb at Ninth and Broad Street—directly across from the tall granite tower of the General Assembly Building and the wrought-iron gates of Capitol Square.

"Caution: bus is kneeling! Caution: lift is deploying!"

After thanking the driver and rolling down the front ramp onto the brick sidewalk at Ninth and Broad, Katie and I stopped by the downtown transit ticket counter, paid sixty dollars apiece out of our own checking account for two standard thirty-day unlimited JRTC magnetic swipe passes, and spent the next three hours testing the entire downtown pedestrian and transit grid in our powerchairs.

We rolled down the Ninth Street hill to Ninth and Main to time the bus transfer down to Richmond Main Street Station in Shockoe Bottom—listening at the intersection corner as a turning bus announced externally to the crosswalk, *"Caution! Bus is turning right. Pedestrians, look both ways!"* followed inside by both street names as it straightened out onto Main Street. We tested the exterior brick ramps leading into Capitol Square and located the ground-level accessible entrance on the north terrace of Thomas Jefferson's historic white-columned State Capitol. We checked the elevator lobby inside the General Assembly Building at Ninth and Broad, noting exactly how many minutes it took to roll from the Route 6 bus stop curb into the building, clear the security magnetometer, and ride up to the fifth-floor legislative offices.

Then, at one-thirty in the afternoon, we rolled back out to the westbound bus shelter at Ninth and Broad. When the outbound bus pulled up to the curb and the front doors folded open, the automated voice announced once across the sidewalk:

"Route 6. Oak Lawn. Welcome aboard JRTC!"

"Caution: bus is kneeling! Caution: lift is deploying!"

Rolling aboard, we swiped our new thirty-day JRTC magnetic passes through the farebox reader with a clean electronic *beep* and rode Route 6 all the way past our apartment building out West Broad Street to the Oak Lawn transfer center.

Rolling down the wide sidewalk of the open-air Oak Lawn shopping plaza, we went straight into the Market Square supermarket. With an insulated canvas grocery carrier clipped to the rear frame of each of our SwiftChairs and two hand baskets resting on our lap trays, Katie and I spent an hour picking out two weeks' worth of breakfast cereal, milk, whole-wheat bread, sliced turkey, pasta, fresh apples, and three twelve-packs of ginger ale.

By four o'clock Saturday afternoon, we had ridden JRTC Route 6 ten blocks back east to our apartment stop at Broad and Boulevard, unloaded our groceries into our kitchen cabinets, and spent Sunday afternoon sitting side by side at our front window table writing a two-thousand-word weekend dispatch for Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit:

> *What Hampton Roads Can Learn from Richmond's Broad Street Trunk Line: How JRTC Uses a Straight Six-Mile Spine to Deliver Ten-Minute Service*

By Sunday night, we knew every bus stop, every curb cut, and every timetable along Broad Street by heart. We were ready for Monday morning.

Part 2: Gold License Plates vs. JRTC Route 6, Turning Down the Parking Deck Pass, & The 60-Inch ADA Restroom Showdown

Date: 2014-01-06 at 08:15 America/New_York

Monday, January 6, 2014, 8:15 AM — The First Time Richmond Politicians See a Delegate Roll Off the City Bus

At eight-fifteen on Monday morning—forty-eight hours before the 2014 General Assembly would formally convene—the intersection of Ninth and Broad Street outside the General Assembly Building looked like a luxury auto dealership convention.

All along the curb leading toward the private legislative parking deck at Seventh and Marshall, gleaming black luxury sedans and massive chrome-trimmed SUVs idled in a bumper-to-bumper line. Nearly every bumper bore a special gold-embossed state license plate reading *VIRGINIA — HOUSE OF DELEGATES* or *VIRGINIA — SENATE*, stamped with the lawmaker's low seniority number. On the wide brick sidewalk flanking the bronze revolving doors of the General Assembly Building, groups of veteran Delegates, State Senators in tailored wool overcoats, and high-priced corporate lobbyists stood clutching leather briefcases and paper coffee cups from the downtown luxury hotels, trading back-slaps and committee gossip in the cold morning sunshine.

None of them paid the slightest attention to the public JRTC bus stop sign planted at the curb thirty feet from the General Assembly Building's accessible side doors—where half a dozen state clerical workers and hospital aides were waiting to step off the morning bus.

With a low rumble of its diesel engine and a crisp hiss of air brakes, our eastbound blue-and-white JRTC Route 6 Broad Street bus pulled up to the Ninth and Broad curb stop after calling out *"Eighth Street"* and *"Ninth Street"* inside the cabin.

As the front doors folded open, the external automated voice rang out across the sidewalk:

"Route 6. Downtown. Welcome aboard JRTC!"

"Caution: bus is kneeling! Caution: lift is deploying!"

Inside the front vestibule, where Katie and I had just ridden the eleven-minute trip down from Broad and Boulevard after swiping our regular sixty-dollar monthly passes at the farebox, the operator unhooked our floor straps as the stainless-steel wheelchair ramp settled onto the brick sidewalk.

"Have a great first week at the Capitol, Katie and Nate!" the operator called out warmly over his shoulder. "Show 'em how we do things on Route 6!"

“Thank you, Marcus! See you at five-thirty this evening!” Katie called back cheerfully.

Wearing a tailored royal-blue wool blazer over a crisp white blouse—with the small gold seal of the Virginia House of Delegates pinned to her left lapel and her leather legislative portfolio resting on her lap tray—twenty-eight-year-old Freshman Delegate Katie Prairie eased her joystick forward and rolled her compact black SwiftChair briskly down the city bus ramp onto the Ninth and Broad sidewalk.

Three seconds later, wearing my charcoal wool jacket with both of our MagnaBook Pro laptops strapped securely across my lap tray, I rolled my matching SwiftChair down the bus ramp right behind my twin sister.

“Caution: lift is stowing!” the automated voice announced behind us as the bus ramp folded back up with a hydraulic *clank* and the blue-and-white JRTC bus pulled away into the Broad Street traffic.

Outside the General Assembly Building doors, the morning chatter stopped dead.

Six veteran Delegates, two senior State Senators who had just stepped out of a town car, and a circle of corporate telecommunications lobbyists standing beside the granite columns all froze in their tracks. Three of the lobbyists literally lowered their coffee cups halfway from their mouths, staring from the retreating tailpipe of the city transit bus to the gold House of Delegates member pin gleaming on the lapel of Katie’s blazer as our two power wheelchairs rolled side by side toward the entrance.

One of the veteran lawmakers—a silver-haired, five-term Delegate from Northern Virginia who sat on the House Transportation Committee and still had his gold-plated SUV keys dangling from his gloved fingers—took two steps across the brick sidewalk and blinked down at us in utter bewilderment.

“Excuse me—Delegate-Elect Prairie?” he stammered, glancing back over his shoulder toward the empty bus stop curb as if checking for a hidden camera crew. “From the Eighty-Fifth District in Virginia Beach?”

“Good morning, Delegate!” Katie said brightly, braking her SwiftChair beside mine to shake his hand. “And this is my twin brother, business partner, and volunteer data strategist, Nathaniel Prairie.”

“Did—did the two of you just get off the *city bus*?” the veteran Delegate asked, his voice loud enough that a dozen other lawmakers and lobbyists turned their heads to listen. “Don’t you have a handicap van or a legislative driver? The Clerk’s office reserves oversized accessible spaces on the ground level of the Seventh Street legislative parking deck for members!”

Katie exchanged a quick, amused twin look with me before looking back up at him with complete, unbothered sincerity.

“Why on earth would we drive a car in downtown traffic when JRTC Route 6 picks us up thirty feet outside our apartment on West Broad Street every ten minutes and drops us right here at the front door of the General Assembly Building?” Katie asked smoothly. “A thirty-day unlimited JRTC bus pass costs sixty dollars at the ticket window, the low-floor ramp takes ten seconds to deploy, and my brother and I get to

spend our eleven-minute commute talking with the regular working people of Richmond who ride the bus every day. That's how we commute back home on CVTA in Virginia Beach and Norfolk too."

Around the entrance plaza, several lobbyists exchanged stunned glances—realizing at once that the twenty-eight-year-old software developer from Virginia Beach who had just unseated an incumbent by campaigning from her power wheelchair on public buses wasn't doing it as a campaign-season photo op. She actually lived it every single day.

Five minutes later, when we rolled inside the warm marble lobby of the General Assembly Building and checked in at the Clerk's administrative orientation table, the facilities coordinator smiled and slid a thick manila packet across the counter toward Katie's lap tray.

"Welcome to Richmond, Delegate Prairie," the coordinator said, holding up a plastic windshield RFID transponder alongside a DMV application form for special official *HOUSE OF DELEGATES* license plates. "Because both you and your brother use power wheelchairs, we went ahead and blocked off two contiguous van-accessible spaces right next to the basement tunnel elevator in the General Assembly Parking Deck. Here is your garage transponder and your legislative license-plate form."

Katie gently pushed the plastic garage transponder and the *HOUSE OF DELEGATES* license-plate application right back across the counter.

"Thank you so much for thinking of us," Katie said kindly, "but neither Nate nor I can drive due to our medical restrictions, and neither of us owns a car—so there isn't any vehicle to put House of Delegates license plates on. Whenever anyone does drive us in a private vehicle, the only person we want behind the wheel is our dad in his own truck, and as a State Delegate I'm thankfully not the President of the United States being forced to ride around in an armored Secret Service limousine. We bought our thirty-day JRTC bus passes on Saturday and we're riding Route 6 down Broad Street every morning and evening. Please reassign those two ground-floor parking spaces to Capitol custodians or building maintenance staff who have to drive in before dawn—they deserve a close parking spot a whole lot more than we do."

The orientation clerk stared at the returned garage transponder on the table as if nobody in the four-hundred-year history of the Virginia General Assembly had ever voluntarily given back a reserved downtown parking pass.

Monday Afternoon & Tuesday, January 6–7, 2014 — The Steel Tape Measure & The 60-Inch ADA Restroom Showdown

While Katie didn't care one bit about a VIP parking space or a gold license plate, we discovered at one-thirty that Monday afternoon what she *was* willing to go to war over before her first session even gaveled in.

After spending the morning getting our legislative network credentials, setting up Katie's new fifth-floor office in Room 518 of the General Assembly Building, and eating a quick lunch in the basement cafeteria, Katie and I rode the elevator down to

the underground concourse tunnel and rolled up into the first floor of the historic State Capitol to inspect the accessible desk that the Clerk's staff had modified for her at the end of the minority aisle on the House Floor.

The desk itself on the green carpet of the House Chamber was fine—they had removed the standard mahogany swivel chair so Katie's compact SwiftChair could roll straight under the writing surface within easy reach of the gooseneck microphone and the electronic voting buttons.

The problem came ten minutes later, when we rolled out into the first-floor marble corridor near the House cloakroom and Katie went to use the nearest ladies' restroom while I rolled toward the men's room next door.

Less than thirty seconds after Katie pushed her way past the heavy, spring-loaded solid-oak outer door of the women's restroom—which didn't even have a blue ADA automatic push-button opener on the wall—she backed right back out into the corridor with her jaw set and a familiar flash of storm-cloud steel in her blue eyes.

At the exact same moment, I backed my SwiftChair out of the men's restroom entrance twenty feet down the hall.

"How bad is the women's side?" I asked, rolling quickly up beside her.

"Go look inside the doorway while it's empty, Nate," Katie said tightly, reaching into the side pocket of my backpack and pulling out the twenty-five-foot retractable steel tape measure we always carried for site audits. "It's the exact same fake 'retrofitted' stall they have up on the fifth floor near our office."

I checked that the restroom was unoccupied and looked inside the entrance as Katie pulled out the yellow steel tape blade and measured the end stall.

Whoever had signed off on the restroom renovation twenty years earlier had clearly never sat in a wheelchair a day in their life. They had simply bolted two chrome grab bars onto the tile wall of a forty-two-inch-wide stall at the end of a narrow forty-inch aisle and hung an *ACCESSIBLE* plaque on a stall door that swung *inward* toward the porcelain toilet bowl.

When Katie rolled her compact SwiftChair inside the stall frame, her front footrests stopped two inches short of the toilet bowl while the rear battery casing of her wheelchair still stuck eight inches out past the door jamb—making it physically impossible to pull the inward-swinging stall door closed behind her. To use the restroom at all, any wheelchair user would either have to leave the stall door wide open to the entire room or take two separate elevators down through the underground tunnel to a single unisex medical restroom in the far basement corner of the complex—a twenty-minute round trip that would cause a sitting Delegate to miss roll-call floor votes.

"Forty-two inches wide by fifty-four inches deep, with an inward-swinging door and zero sixty-inch turning circle," I said, writing the exact measurements into my notebook while Katie snapped the steel tape measure back into its casing. "That fails federal ADA Accessibility Guidelines Section 4.17.3 on three separate counts."

“And there are plenty of extra square feet at the end of both restroom rows if they simply shift the outer laminate partition twelve inches toward the dead vanity corner and reverse the hinges so the stall door swings outward,” Katie said, her voice calm, quiet, and utterly immovable. “Come on, Nate. Let’s go pay a visit to the Department of General Services Facilities Director before two-thirty.”

Ten minutes later, Katie and I rolled our two SwiftChairs side by side into the Capitol Facilities Management suite on the lower level.

When the Deputy Director for Capitol Facilities came out to the reception counter in his gray suit, he offered Katie the indulgent, patronizing smile of a career bureaucrat who assumed a twenty-eight-year-old freshman in the minority party could be brushed off with paperwork jargon.

“Delegate-Elect Prairie, we appreciate your feedback,” the Deputy Director said smoothly, folding his hands across his stomach, “and I assure you that accessibility upgrades are part of our long-term Master Capitol Complex Modernization Plan. However, modifying restroom partitions and installing motorized door actuators in the General Assembly Building and the Capitol requires an architectural engineering review, historical preservation sign-off, and a capital-outlay work order. Realistically, we can put that in the queue for the summer interim after the session adjourns in March.”

Katie didn’t raise her voice by a single decibel. Instead, she set our steel tape measure down on the counter with a crisp *clack* and looked straight up into his eyes from her SwiftChair.

“Let me explain what is actually going to happen between now and Wednesday at twelve o’clock noon,” Katie said evenly. “The partitions on the fifth floor of the General Assembly Building and in the first-floor corridor restrooms outside the House Chamber aren’t Thomas Jefferson’s historic plaster—they’re standard bolt-together powder-coated steel commercial bathroom dividers installed in the nineteen-nineties. Under federal ADA Accessibility Guidelines Section 4.17.3, a standard wheelchair toilet stall is required by federal law to provide a minimum sixty-inch clear width and a stall door that clears the turning envelope. Right now, a sitting member of the Virginia House of Delegates cannot close the bathroom stall door in her own workplace.”

The Deputy Director shifted his weight uncomfortably. “Delegate Prairie, our carpenter and electrical shops are completely booked with pre-session podium setups—”

“At twelve o’clock noon on Wednesday, every television network camera in the Commonwealth of Virginia is going to be rolling live in the House Chamber for Opening Day,” Katie continued without blinking, her left hand resting on my wrist across our wheelchair armrests. “If the fifth-floor restrooms and the first-floor House corridor restrooms do not have outward-swinging stall doors, a full sixty-inch turning clearance, and working ADA push-button outer door openers by five o’clock tomorrow afternoon, my very first act as a sworn Delegate on Wednesday will be rising on a point of personal privilege on live statewide television—and inviting the Speaker of the House and the entire Capitol press corps to follow me out into the hallway with their cameras so the voters of Virginia can watch a female Delegate in a power wheelchair get wedged halfway out of an illegal forty-two-inch bathroom stall door because Facilities told her to wait until March.”

The silence in the Facilities office was absolute.

Behind the reception glass, two maintenance supervisors who had been listening over their clipboards traded a wide-eyed look. The Deputy Director's face went pale as he pictured the six-o'clock Wednesday evening news showing a newly sworn twenty-eight-year-old Delegate in a wheelchair stuck in an open bathroom stall door while trying to cast her first floor votes.

"I—let me call the carpentry foreman and the electrical shop chief right now," the Deputy Director said quickly, reaching for his desk telephone. "We have heavy-duty commercial partition brackets and two power-door actuator kits in the maintenance warehouse off Fourteenth Street."

"Thank you," Katie said politely, picking our steel tape measure back up off the counter. "Nate and I will be working in Room 518 until five o'clock today and all day tomorrow. Feel free to ask us to test the turning radius with our chairs before your crew bolts the brackets down."

By four o'clock on Tuesday afternoon—twenty hours before the Opening Day gavel—the carpentry and electrical crews had shifted the end partitions fourteen inches into the dead alcove space, reversed the heavy chrome hinges so the stall doors swung cleanly outward with interior loop pulls, and mounted blue wireless ADA push-button door openers outside both the women's and men's restrooms on the fifth floor and outside the House Chamber.

When the head carpenter asked Katie and me to test the finished stalls at four-fifteen on Tuesday, Katie rolled her SwiftChair effortlessly inside, spun a full three-hundred-and-sixty-degree circle without her footrests touching a single wall, pulled the outward-swinging door shut with the interior D-ring handle, and rolled back out to shake every carpenter and electrician's hand in person.

"Nobody should ever have to beg for the right to close a bathroom door in privacy," Katie told me quietly as we rolled out the front entrance of the General Assembly Building at five o'clock that Tuesday evening to catch our westbound JRTC Route 6 bus back to Broad and Boulevard.

On Wednesday morning, January 8, 2014, when the blue-and-white JRTC Route 6 bus kneeled at the curb of Ninth and Broad at ten-thirty ahead of the noon Opening Day swearing-in ceremony—with Dad waiting proudly for us on the brick sidewalk outside the Capitol gate in his best navy suit—none of the veteran politicians or lobbyists by the entrance looked surprised anymore when the front wheelchair ramp folded down.

Inside the House of Delegates Chamber at twelve o'clock noon, while Dad and I stood beside Katie's modified desk on the first-floor chamber carpet, the Clerk of the House called the freshman class forward to take the constitutional oath of office under Article II, Section 7 of the Constitution of Virginia.

Just as she had done when she was sworn onto the Virginia Beach City Council three years earlier, Katie didn't reach for a Bible, and she didn't pretend to believe in a religion or a god that neither of us believed in. Instead, exercising her explicit constitutional right under Article VI, Clause 3 of the United States Constitution, Article II, Section 7 of the Constitution of Virginia, and Section 49-9 of the Code of Virginia to affirm rather than swear—and to omit the optional parenthetical religious phrase at the end—Katie placed her left palm squarely on the gold-stamped cover of

the Virginia Constitution resting across my lap tray between our two wheelchairs, raised her right hand toward the Speaker's rostrum, and spoke her constitutional affirmation as the sole elected Delegate for the Eighty-Fifth District in a clear, ringing voice:

"I do solemnly affirm that I will support the Constitution of the United States, and the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia, and that I will faithfully and impartially discharge all the duties incumbent upon me as a member of the House of Delegates, according to the best of my ability."

Across the center aisle, three senior opposition delegates immediately craned their necks, whispering indignantly to a political blogger in the front press row that the new twenty-eight-year-old Democrat from Virginia Beach had placed her hand on a copy of the state Constitution instead of a Bible, said "affirm" instead of "swear," and left out "so help me God." By five o'clock that evening, conservative talk-radio hosts in Richmond and Tidewater—along with the televangelist commentators on *The 777 Circle* broadcasting out of the Covenant Broadcasting Network studios right off Indian River Road back home in Virginia Beach—were already having a field day over it, only for Katie to tell a Capitol corridor reporter with a calm, unbothered smile as we rolled out to catch our evening bus:

"Have the commentators complaining on television actually read the Constitution of the United States or the Constitution of Virginia? Article VI, Clause 3 of the United States Constitution states in plain English that all state legislators shall be bound by Oath or Affirmation to support the Constitution, and that no religious test shall ever be required as a qualification to any office or public trust. And if you open Article II, Section 7 of the Constitution of Virginia—the exact document I placed my left hand on today—the words 'or affirm' and 'so help me God' are printed in parentheses specifically because Virginia law guarantees every non-religious citizen the right to make a solemn secular affirmation. I wasn't elected to be anybody's pastor, and my left hand belongs on the exact Constitution I just affirmed to the people of Virginia Beach that I would defend."

Delegate Katie Prairie of Virginia Beach and her twin brother Nate had arrived in Richmond on the city bus, paid their regular fare, watched Katie affirm her constitutional oath of office on the Constitution of Virginia without bowing to a religious test, and made it crystal clear from Day One that the people's House belonged to everyone.

House Bill 663 & Live on Meet the Nation

Part 1: Line 18, Seated by Delegate Ronald Villa on the Floor, & A Question Across the Chamber

Date: 2016-02-04 at 11:35 America/New_York

Thursday, February 4, 2016, 11:35 AM — The Capitol Tunnel & Splitting Up at the Chamber Doors

"Look at Line 18 on Page 1 again, Nate," my twin sister Katie said, tapping her yellow highlighter against the two-page bill printout resting on her lap tray as our compact SwiftChairs rolled side by side down the long underground concourse

tunnel connecting the General Assembly Building to the historic Virginia State Capitol. "'Anatomical sex means the physical condition of being male or female, which is determined by a person's anatomy.' Not a birth certificate, not a driver's license, and not how someone lives their daily life—strictly their physical anatomy. And then look at Line 54 on Page 2: 'Any person who willfully and knowingly violates this section shall be liable for a civil penalty of not more than fifty dollars,' enforced by a law enforcement officer's summons."

"I read it three times while I was setting up the daily calendar script this morning," I replied, steering my wheelchair smoothly beside hers past the subterranean security desk as the fifteen-minute warning bell for the noon floor session chimed from the bronze wall speakers overhead. "Delegate Cobb and Delegate Marsh put it straight onto today's Second Reading floor calendar. They think everybody on the Floor is going to treat it like a routine committee bill and wave it through before lunch."

It was thirty-year-old Katie's second two-year term representing the Eighty-Fifth House District back home in Kempsville and Virginia Beach, and she sat in a thirty-four-seat Democratic minority facing a sixty-six-seat Republican supermajority. Every day the General Assembly was in session during January and February, the two of us operated by the exact same synchronized routine we had followed since her freshman session in 2014: we woke up in our accessible one-bedroom winter-session apartment at the Broad & Boulevard Lofts on West Broad Street, went over every bill on the daily House calendar line by statutory line the exact same way we audited PHP code or Coastal Virginia Transit Authority bus schedules, and rode the eastbound JRTC Route 6 bus straight down Broad Street to Ninth and Broad before the noon gavel.

We rode the subterranean elevator up into the historic Capitol and rolled out onto the first-floor marble corridor just outside the tall mahogany double doors of the House Chamber. Lobbyists, school groups, and legislative aides were hurrying past the white marble columns as the ten-minute bell sounded.

At the velvet brass rope flanking the Chamber entrance—where the Sergeant-at-Arms staff checked member pins—Katie braked her SwiftChair and turned toward me.

Ever since our very first visit to the State Capitol back in February 2011—when Capitol Police had stopped us outside the third-floor public viewing gallery because the small historic elevator locked out during fire alarms and there was no safe way to evacuate a wheelchair down three flights of eighteenth-century stairs—House Leadership and the Sergeant-at-Arms had maintained a standing ADA floor pass for me (and any visiting constituent in a wheelchair plus one companion) to watch the daily session from a level wheelchair bay inside the first-floor House Chamber itself, right along the outer right aisle beside our fellow Virginia Beach lawmaker, Delegate Ronald Villa of the Twenty-First District.

"Are you set to plug into the floor feed over by Ron's desk?" Katie asked, reaching across our armrests to give my right hand our familiar twin squeeze.

"All set," I said, patting the padded laptop bag strapped across my lap tray where my MagnaBook Pro and my digital stream-capture rig were tucked alongside our daily legislative binder. "I'll have the chamber stream hooked into my laptop before the Speaker bangs the gavel so I can record and caption your remarks for the constituent archive."

“Wait until Delegate Cobb finishes his floor pitch on House Bill 663,” Katie said, her blue eyes steady and focused as she tucked the highlighted two-page printout under her left wrist on the lap tray. “I’m going to ask the Speaker to let me put one direct operational question to him on the record.”

“Give him hell, Delegate Prairie,” I whispered with a small smile.

“See you at the center doors when we recess,” Katie said warmly.

Releasing my hand, my twin sister eased her joystick forward, nodded to the doorkeeper holding open the left-hand mahogany door, and rolled her compact black power wheelchair across the green carpet toward her modified accessible desk at the end of the far left minority aisle.

I flashed my gold-stamped ADA floor pass to the Sergeant-at-Arms assistant at the right-hand doorway and rolled quietly inside to the designated wheelchair bay along the outer right aisle, twenty feet from the ground-level emergency exit.

Right beside my bay, seated at his mahogany desk bearing the brass nameplate *MR. VILLA — VIRGINIA BEACH (21ST DISTRICT)*, Delegate Ronald Villa looked up from his leather binder and gave me a warm, familiar nod.

“Morning, Nate,” Delegate Villa whispered, reaching over to shake my hand just as he had done the very first day the Sergeant-at-Arms had brought Katie and me onto the Floor back in 2011. “How’s the Route 6 bus running down Broad Street this morning?”

“Right on the ten-minute headway, Delegate Villa,” I whispered back with a smile as I flipped down my lap tray, opened my laptop, plugged my headphones into the assistive-listening audio jack at the side rail, and launched my digital capture software hooked into the chamber’s fixed legislative webcast camera.

Looking across the wide expanse of green carpet under the tall cream-and-gold coffered ceiling and crystal chandeliers of the House Chamber, I had a clear, floor-level view of the Speaker’s high marble rostrum at the front of the room, the Clerk’s well, the red-and-green electronic voting boards flanking the front wall, and Katie sitting upright in her compact SwiftChair at her accessible desk across the chamber on the minority aisle, her yellow-highlighted copy of House Bill 663 resting squarely in front of her desk microphone.

Thursday, February 4, 2016, 12:18 PM — Watching Across the House Floor as Katie Challenges the Patron

At twelve o’clock noon on the dot, the Speaker of the House rapped his wooden gavel against the rostrum block.

Up in the third-floor public gallery overhanging the rear wall—where two dozen college students from Virginia Dominion University and Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute, a handful of off-duty teachers, and several parents sat along the wooden benches—and down across the hundred mahogany desks on the Floor, everyone fell silent for the opening prayer, the Pledge of Allegiance, and the routine morning leaves of absence.

By 12:18 PM, the House had moved into the Second Reading calendar of bills reported out of committee. Half the Delegates on the floor were leaning back in their leather swivel chairs chatting with deskmates or flipping through binders while the Clerk read bill titles in a rapid, monotone cadence.

“House Bill 663, a bill to amend the Code of Virginia relating to single-gender public restrooms and facilities in buildings owned or leased by the Commonwealth, public institutions of higher education, and local school divisions; civil penalty. Patron, Delegate Cobb.”

From my wheelchair bay beside the outer right aisle, I clicked the red Record button on my laptop capture window and checked my audio level meters. Right in front of me, I saw Delegate Ronald Villa—a pragmatic coastal Virginia Beach Republican who cared about bus shelters, military families, and Oceanfront tourism, not culture-war stunts—let out a quiet sigh and rub his forehead as the bill was called.

Three rows ahead on the majority side of the House Floor, Delegate Martin Cobb—with his chief co-patron, Delegate Robert Marsh, seated two desks over—stood up behind his mahogany desk, buttoned his navy suit jacket, and leaned into his silver gooseneck microphone.

“Mr. Speaker and members of the House,” Delegate Cobb’s voice echoed across the chamber and came cleanly through my floor headphones, “House Bill 663 is a simple, common-sense measure to protect personal privacy and public safety across the Commonwealth of Virginia. This legislation directs the Department of General Services, every public institution of higher education, and every local school board to ensure that every single-gender public restroom, locker room, and shower facility in any public building or school is used exclusively by individuals whose anatomical sex matches the designated gender on the door—backed by a fifty-dollar civil penalty enforceable by law enforcement summons. I hope it will be the pleasure of the House to engross the bill and advance it to its third reading.”

Across the chamber at the end of the minority aisle, I saw Katie press the white request-to-speak button on her desk console and raise her right hand into the air.

Up on the high marble rostrum, the Speaker glanced down toward the left aisle.

“For what purpose does the gentlewoman from Virginia Beach, Delegate Prairie, rise?” the Speaker asked into his microphone.

Across the green carpet, Katie flipped the toggle switch at the base of her desk microphone so the green indicator ring illuminated, and lifted the two printed pages of House Bill 663 in her right hand.

“Mr. Speaker, to see if the gentleman from Spotsylvania will yield for a question on the bill,” Katie’s voice rang out crisp and clear across the chamber.

“Does the gentleman from Spotsylvania yield to the gentlewoman from Virginia Beach?” the Speaker asked.

Standing at his desk across the center aisle, Delegate Cobb gave a brief, stiff nod. “I yield for a question, Mr. Speaker.”

“The gentleman yields,” the Speaker said.

From my wheelchair on the far side of the floor, I watched my twin sister look straight across the House Chamber at the bill's patron.

"Thank you, Mr. Speaker," Katie said. "Look with me for a moment at the exact text printed in House Bill 663, Delegate Cobb. My brother and I write computer software for a living, and when you write code—or when you write a state law—definitions determine how an instruction actually executes in the real world. Unlike bills that reference a birth certificate or a state identification card, your Line 18 on Page 1 explicitly defines anatomical sex as 'the physical condition of being male or female, which is determined by a person's anatomy.' Not their driver's license. Not how they are dressed. Their physical anatomy. And then on Page 2, Line 54, you mandate that a law enforcement officer issue a fifty-dollar civil summons at the restroom door based on that physical anatomy."

Across the floor around me, the background murmur of side conversations suddenly died down. Delegates who had been thumbing through their afternoon calendars looked up from their desks.

"The language of the bill speaks for itself, Mr. Speaker," Delegate Cobb replied stiffly into his desk microphone. "Restrooms in state buildings, public colleges, and public schools will be restricted strictly by anatomical sex, and law enforcement officers are authorized to issue a fifty-dollar civil summons to anyone who enters a restroom that does not match their anatomical sex."

Over at her accessible desk, Katie released her joystick brake half an inch, rolling her compact SwiftChair flush against the mahogany desk edge as she held the two printed pages of House Bill 663 high in the air. Across the chamber, I could hear the raw, unmistakable fire rising in my sister's voice.

"Mr. Speaker, when the people of Kempsville and Virginia Beach first elected me to serve in this House of Delegates two years ago," Katie declared, her voice echoing off the marble walls of the Capitol chamber, "I had to fight the facilities bureaucracy in this very Capitol complex just to get an ADA-compliant restroom stall wide enough for my power wheelchair to turn around in and close the door in privacy! Every single day of my life since I was sixteen years old, I have known what it feels like to have strangers stare at my body and treat a basic human necessity like using a public restroom as a public spectacle. And now the gentleman comes onto the Floor of this House with House Bill 663 and tells the women and girls of Virginia that the state government is going to police 'anatomical sex' at the door of every ladies' room from Virginia Beach to Blacksburg for a fifty-dollar fine!"

Up in the third-floor public gallery above us, the college students and parents leaned forward over the brass balcony rail, holding their breath. Down on the House Floor, you could have heard a pin drop.

"So I ask the gentleman from Spotsylvania—right here on the Floor of the Virginia House of Delegates!" Katie demanded, shaking the printed pages of House Bill 663 across the aisle. "How, exactly, is a police officer or a state building inspector standing outside a restroom door at the Community College of Hampton Roads, or Virginia Dominion University, or right outside in this State Capitol corridor supposed to verify a citizen's 'physical anatomy' before writing your fifty-dollar ticket? Why on earth should I—or any woman or girl in the Commonwealth of Virginia—have to pull my pants down for a government official or a police officer to prove I have female parts just to use the ladies' room?!"

An audible gasp swept across the chamber, followed half a second later by a sudden burst of applause from the visitors up in the third-floor gallery benches and several sharp “Hear, hear!” calls from the minority desks down on the Floor. Right beside my wheelchair on the Republican side of the floor, Delegate Ronald Villa winced, shook his head at Cobb’s bill, and exchanged an unmistakable *she’s got him dead to rights* look with his seatmate.

Bam! Bam!

“The House will be in order!” the Speaker barked from the rostrum, pounding his wooden gavel twice as he looked up toward the third-floor balcony. “The guests in the public gallery are reminded that demonstrations of approval or disapproval are strictly prohibited by the rules of the House!”

Out on the majority aisle of the House Floor, Delegate Martin Cobb stood completely frozen behind his desk microphone for four full seconds, his face turning beet-red under the chamber chandeliers as he looked from Katie’s power wheelchair to the uneasy, downward stares of his own party colleagues around him.

“I—Mr. Speaker, the bill does not—nobody is suggesting—” Delegate Cobb stammered into his microphone, shuffling his folder on his desk without answering the question.

“Mr. Speaker, that is literally what the words printed on Page 1 and Page 2 of House Bill 663 require!” Katie replied from her SwiftChair, her voice steady, clear, and unflinching across the silent chamber. “Transgender women are women, transgender men are men, and every citizen in this Commonwealth deserves basic human dignity and privacy without politicians stationing bathroom police at the door to inspect people’s anatomy. No woman or girl in Virginia should ever have to pull her pants down to prove she has female parts just to use a public restroom!”

At the front row of the center aisle, the House Majority Leader quickly stood up at his desk, exchanging a tense look with the Speaker before glancing back at a flustered Delegate Cobb.

“Mr. Speaker,” the Majority Leader said briskly into his microphone, “I move that House Bill 663 be passed by for the day.”

“Without objection, House Bill 663 is passed by for the day,” the Speaker announced immediately, rapping his gavel once and hurrying straight ahead. “The Clerk will read the next bill on the calendar.”

Thursday, February 4, 2016, 12:35 PM — Archiving the 95-Second Clip & Rolling Back Through the Tunnel

In my wheelchair bay beside Delegate Villa’s desk, I clicked the Stop button on my capture window and exhaled a quiet breath.

Delegate Villa leaned slightly toward my armrest and whispered out of the corner of his mouth, “Your sister just drove a freight truck straight through the middle of that bill, Nate.”

I gave him a quiet grin and looked down at the timeline bar on my laptop screen while the Clerk moved on to a routine highway-naming bill. Checking the timestamp on the video file I had just recorded from the chamber feed, I saw that the entire floor exchange between Katie and Delegate Cobb ran ninety-five seconds.

Just like I did whenever Katie spoke on a bill on the House Floor, I opened Quantum Code right there on my lap tray, typed out a verbatim, frame-accurate WebVTT closed-caption file for the ninety-five-second video, burned high-contrast open captions along the bottom of the frame so constituents watching on mute could read every word, and uploaded the clip to Katie's legislative website archive, StreamTube, and The Grid at 12:35 PM with a standard archival heading:

> Delegate Katie Prairie (D-Virginia Beach) Questions HB 663 Patron on the House Floor Regarding "Anatomical Sex" Restroom Enforcement (Feb. 4, 2016)

Twenty-five minutes later, at one o'clock, the House adjourned its Thursday floor session so members could grab lunch before afternoon committee work.

I unplugged my audio cable from the side rail, packed my laptop and capture rig back into my bag, shook Delegate Villa's hand, and rolled out the right-hand chamber doorway into the first-floor marble corridor just as Katie came rolling out the left-hand doorway in her SwiftChair.

"Hey," I said, rolling right up beside her and reaching out to take her left hand. "The ninety-five-second floor clip is captioned and archived on your constituent page. Delegate Cobb didn't have a single word to say when you asked him how a police officer is supposed to verify Line 18 at the door—and even Ron Villa over on my aisle said you drove a truck straight through the middle of that bill."

"Good," Katie sighed, squeezing my fingers as we turned our wheelchairs side by side toward the elevator down to the underground Capitol tunnel. "Even if the majority brings it right back up on Monday and tries to ram it through on a party-line vote, at least we put the truth about that bill squarely on the permanent House record. Come on—let's go grab a sandwich in the basement cafeteria before our two o'clock constituent meetings."

Part 2: The Speakerphone Exclusive, Two Meltdowns in Room 518, & The 6:05 AM Train to Meet the Nation

Date: 2016-02-04 at 18:00 America/New_York

Thursday, February 4, 2016, 6:00 PM — The Evening News in Richmond and Norfolk

"Hand me the pepper shaker, Nate," Katie said at six o'clock that Thursday evening, setting two warm plates of baked chicken and rice down on the dining table of Apartment 104 at the Broad & Boulevard Lofts on West Broad Street after we had ridden the 5:35 PM westbound JRTC Route 6 bus home from Ninth and Broad. "And turn on the television so we can see the weather forecast for the weekend."

We had spent the entire afternoon from two until five-thirty back in Katie's fifth-floor office in Room 518 of the General Assembly Building, meeting with special-education parents from Virginia Beach and reviewing coastal flooding amendments with our legislative aide, with both of our laptops closed during the meetings.

Picking up the remote control from the corner of the table, I clicked on the wall-mounted television—tuned first to the Richmond local six-o'clock news broadcast, with my laptop open beside my glass of ginger ale streaming our hometown six-o'clock broadcast from Norfolk so we could keep up with Hampton Roads news while we were in Richmond for the winter session.

I barely had time to set the remote down before both my twin sister and I froze with our forks halfway to our mouths.

On the television screen on the wall—and simultaneously on the Norfolk local news stream playing on my laptop—was the exact ninety-five-second video clip I had captured from my wheelchair bay on the House Floor at lunchtime.

"—and our top story from the State Capitol tonight," the Richmond evening anchor announced over the footage of Katie sitting upright in her compact SwiftChair on the House Floor holding up the two printed pages of House Bill 663, *"a fiery floor exchange in the House of Delegates this afternoon over House Bill 663, the controversial bathroom bill restricting public restrooms by 'anatomical sex,' after Virginia Beach Delegate Katie Prairie brought the House Chamber to a standstill with a single question for the bill's patron."*

Before our eyes, both the Richmond station and the Norfolk station aired the floor clip in full—every word of Katie asking Delegate Martin Cobb why she, or any woman or girl in the Commonwealth of Virginia, should have to pull her pants down for a government official or a police officer to prove she had female parts just to use the ladies' room, followed by the four seconds of Delegate Cobb standing frozen and beet-red behind his desk microphone before the Majority Leader hurriedly passed the bill by for the day.

Katie stared at the television screen, her blue eyes wide. "Nate… they're playing the whole floor clip on the six-o'clock news. In Richmond and back home in Norfolk."

I reached over and woke my laptop browser window, refreshing the server dashboard for Katie's legislative archive and The Grid.

My jaw dropped.

"Katie, look at the traffic logs," I said, turning the laptop screen toward her wheelchair. "The Capitol beat reporters from the Richmond and Norfolk papers embedded your captioned clip on their blogs at two-thirty this afternoon while we were in constituent meetings. Because the open captions were burned right into the video frame, thousands of office workers and college students at Virginia Dominion University, CCHR, and Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute watched it on their phones during the afternoon and shared it across the state. That's how the assignment desks at the Richmond and Norfolk TV stations grabbed it for the six-o'clock news!"

Friday, February 5, 2016, 9:15 AM — The Speakerphone Call on Line One, Two Twin Meltdowns, & The Majority Leader's Nephew

The black multi-line telephone on Katie's desk in our fifth-floor General Assembly Building office rang once on Line One at nine-fifteen on Friday morning, and Katie reached over from her SwiftChair to press the speakerphone button, expecting it to be a retired shipyard worker from Kempsville calling to report a missed CVTA bus connection on Princess Anne Road.

"Delegate Katie Prairie's office, this is Katie speaking," she said, keeping one hand resting on her open municipal transit binder while I sat right beside her left wheel with my silver MagnaBook Pro laptop open on the side table.

There was a brief, startled pause on the other end of the speakerphone. "Oh! Good morning, Delegate Prairie. I honestly didn't expect you to pick up your own main line. My name is Arthur Vance, and I'm a producer for Meet the Nation at GBS News up here in Washington. I hope I'm not catching you at a bad time?"

Katie blinked, glancing sideways at me in surprise. To the two of us, Meet the Nation was the quiet Sunday morning news program our dad David used to put on the living room television in Virginia Beach while the three of us ate scrambled eggs and toast together.

"Not at all, Mr. Vance," Katie said politely. "My brother Nate and I were just looking over some bus shelter amendments. How can I help you?"

"Well, Delegate, David Vance and our editorial team here in Washington watched your exchange on the House Floor yesterday afternoon over House Bill 663," Mr. Vance said warmly, his voice remarkably courteous and unhurried. "You raised some serious constitutional questions about how a law like that could ever be enforced in public buildings without violating the Fourth Amendment. David would be honored if you would join him this Sunday morning at nine o'clock for a quiet, one-on-one conversation to walk through the text of the bill—if you'd be willing to make it a Sunday morning exclusive with Meet the Nation."

Katie's shoulders visibly relaxed in her SwiftChair. After answering questions from the local Richmond and Norfolk newspaper reporters the evening before, the word exclusive sounded like a wonderful relief to her: it meant she would only have to put on a stiff blazer, sit under bright lights, state the literal facts of House Bill 663 one time, and then go straight back to our apartment in Richmond without having to repeat the exact same sentences to anyone else.

"Do you mean if I talk to Mr. Vance at nine o'clock on Sunday morning, I only have to tell the story one time and nobody else will ask me to repeat it all afternoon?" Katie asked literally.

On the speakerphone, Arthur Vance let out a soft, warm laugh. "That is the exact agreement, Delegate Prairie. Just you and David Vance one-on-one at nine o'clock sharp, zero cross-talk, and you're completely done by nine-twenty. We would be happy to send a car down to your address in Richmond at five-thirty Sunday morning to drive you up Interstate 95—"

"Oh, you don't need to waste money on a car, Mr. Vance," Katie said right away. "My brother Nate and I always ride public transit and pay our own regular fare, and a car would just get stuck in traffic on the 14th Street Bridge anyway. The suburban

Staples Mill station doesn't have Sunday bus service yet, so we'll take the early JRTC bus down Broad Street to Richmond Main Street Station, ride the six-oh-five ARTS Northeast Regional train up to Alexandria, and use our blue SmartPass cards from our family trips with our dad to take the Capital Transit Yellow Line across the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge into Washington. We'll be at your studio desk by eight-thirty—and then we can catch the eleven-twelve train out of Alexandria with the connecting ARTS Thruway shuttle back to Main Street Station so I can get back to our apartment and out of my dress blazer by two o'clock."

"You two are taking a city bus, an intercity train, and the Yellow Line subway across the Potomac?" Mr. Vance asked, sounding genuinely charmed. "Well, whatever makes you most comfortable, Delegate. We'll have two security passes waiting for you and your brother at the Washington bureau front desk at eight-thirty Sunday morning. Thank you so much for giving us your word."

"Thank you for being so polite, Mr. Vance," Katie said, and pressed the button to end the call.

Only as the speakerphone clicked off at nine-twenty-two did Katie and I look down at the plastic telephone console on her desk.

While we had been talking cleanly on Line One for the last four minutes, the little red hold lights on Line Two, Line Three, Line Four, and Line Five had all started blinking furiously at the exact same time, though the ringer had been automatically muted while the speakerphone was active.

Before I could even ask Katie why the whole console was lit up like a Christmas tree, our office door flew open. Katie's twenty-four-year-old legislative aide stumbled in carrying a thick stack of pink paper message slips, followed two seconds later by Greg, the Communications Director for the Virginia House Democratic Caucus, who was holding two vibrating cell phones in his hands and breathing like he had just sprinted all the way up the stairs from the third floor.

"Katie! Do not touch that phone until I clear a schedule!" Greg gasped, leaning over the front edge of her desk. "Capitol Sunday is holding on Line Two, This Sunday is on Line Three, Inside Politics is on Line Four, and the cable networks are blowing up my cell phone! They all want to book you for Sunday morning! We can set up a full Sunday morning sweep right now—four television shows back-to-back from eight in the morning until noon—"

"Oh, no thank you," Katie said calmly, shaking her head. "I would hate sitting in a stiff blazer repeating the exact same story four times in a row. Besides, I already promised Mr. Vance on Line One that I would only talk to Meet the Nation."

The room went dead silent.

Greg stared down at Katie, then over at my wheelchair, his mouth opening and closing without a sound.

"You… you answered your own phone and promised an exclusive to Meet the Nation without talking to me first?" he whispered, his face flushing red.

I looked up from my laptop keyboard, confused by his sudden anger. “Mr. Vance called while we were looking at CVTA bus stops. He was the first one to ask, he was very polite to Katie, and he told her that if she goes on at nine o’clock, she only has to explain the bill once and then we can catch the eleven-twelve train out of Alexandria and come home.”

“Yeah,” Katie agreed simply. “Why would I want to go on four television shows on a Sunday morning when I can explain the statute once at nine o’clock and be back in our apartment in sweatpants by two in the afternoon?”

Greg slowly lowered both of his ringing cell phones to his sides, staring at the two of us with his jaw clenched. “I have to go tell the other three networks you’re off the board,” he muttered tightly, backing out of our office doorway into the outer reception room.

As he pulled the heavy oak door behind him, the latch didn’t quite catch, leaving a two-inch gap between the frame and the jamb.

Through that crack, Katie and I heard every single word as Greg snatched up the blinking phones at the legislative aide’s desk in the outer room and started barking into the handsets back-to-back.

“Look, Sarah, I’m telling you, I can’t put her on Capitol Sunday!” we heard him shout into Line Two, his voice loud and exasperated. “She’s a backbench delegate from Virginia Beach who has never dealt with national press in her life! She picked up her own main office line five minutes ago before my staff could even get up the stairs and promised an exclusive to Meet the Nation! She had no idea what she was doing!”

Beside me, Katie’s hands froze on the edges of her transit binder.

Out in the reception room, Greg slammed down Line Two, punched Line Three, and started all over again. “No, I’m not freezing This Sunday out on purpose! Delegate Prairie doesn’t know how Washington booking rules work—she literally answered her own phone and gave away a Sunday morning exclusive without clearing it with Caucus Communications or the Minority Leader’s office! Now I have to go down to the third floor and explain to leadership and the entire Democratic Caucus what just happened!”

The outer hall door banged shut as he hurried down the corridor toward the stairs.

Inside Room 518, the silence felt suffocating.

I looked over at my twin sister, and my stomach dropped right through the floor. Katie’s fingers were trembling violently against the yellow highlighter in her lap, her breathing was coming in shallow, rapid gasps, and every trace of color had drained out of her face.

For two autistic twins who had spent our whole lives relying on literal written rules to survive, there was no phrase on earth more terrifying than unwritten rules. Whenever someone in authority started shouting about protocols that weren’t printed in any handbook—about failing to clear things with leadership or breaking rules nobody had ever told us existed—it sent every alarm bell in our nervous systems screaming at once.

“Nate…” Katie whispered, her voice shaking so badly she could barely get my name out as her chest began to heave. “Did I just break a House rule? Was I not allowed to talk to Mr. Vance on the telephone without asking the Caucus first?”

“I—I don’t know, sis,” I stammered, and the raw panic in my own voice immediately set off a feedback loop between the two of us. My own hands were shaking so hard on the keyboard of my laptop that I could barely click open the PDF of the Rules of the Virginia House of Delegates, my eyes darting frantically down the table of contents for anything about national television interviews or caucus clearance while Katie’s breathing grew faster and louder beside me. “It’s not in the written standing rules on my laptop, Katie, I swear it isn’t, but the way Greg just ran downstairs to report you to the Minority Leader…”

Katie burst into tears, a full-blown autistic meltdown overtaking her as she buried her face in both hands and began sobbing and shaking from head to toe.

“What if they kick me out of the Caucus, Nate?!” Katie cried, gasping for air between sobs as her whole body trembled in her wheelchair. “What if I broke an ethics rule and they expel me from the House of Delegates?! All the voters in Virginia Beach trusted me, and Dad was so proud of us, and I ruined everything just because I answered the telephone!”

Seeing my twin sister in a full autistic meltdown—and spiraling straight into a sympathetic meltdown of my own as the terrifying thought seized my chest that Katie was really about to be kicked out of the House of Delegates because neither of us understood some secret Richmond rule—I released the electromagnetic brakes of my SwiftChair with a trembling hand, wheeled myself flush against the side of her chair, and wrapped both of my arms around her shoulders, hugging her as tight as I could across our armrests.

Katie pressed her wet face into the shoulder of my charcoal suit jacket, sobbing uncontrollably against my lapel while my own tears spilled hot down my cheeks. I held onto my sister with everything I had, resting my chin against the top of her blonde hair while my chest shook right alongside hers and my heart hammered at a hundred and thirty beats a minute, staring in terror at the office doorway and waiting for the Sergeant-at-Arms or the Minority Leader to walk in and tell us her career was over.

Three minutes later, brisk footsteps echoed down the fifth-floor hallway.

The office door swung open, and in walked the House Minority Leader himself, with Greg trailing half a step behind him.

As I clutched Katie tighter against my chest, trembling from head to toe and bracing for the blow, the Minority Leader took one look at the two of us huddled together in our power wheelchairs—Katie sobbing into my shoulder in full meltdown, and me crying and shaking right along with her like I was trying to shield my twin sister from an oncoming train—and stopped dead in his tracks.

“Whoa, whoa, hold on a second,” the Minority Leader said softly, the color draining from his own face as he realized what had happened. He spun on his heel and shot a furious glare at the communications director—“Step outside in the hall, Greg. Right now”—before walking quietly into our office and pulling the wooden guest chair over in front of our footrests so he was sitting at eye level with us.

Katie lifted her tear-stained face an inch off my shoulder, gasping for breath and wiping furiously at her red eyes with the back of her trembling wrist as she tried to sit up in her chair.

“Mr. Leader, I am so sorry,” Katie choked out through her tears, her whole frame still shaking against my arms. “I didn’t know there was a rule that a delegate wasn’t allowed to answer Line One or agree to talk to a television show without asking you first! When Mr. Vance asked for an exclusive, I only said yes because we used to watch that show with our dad over breakfast and I thought it meant I could tell the story one time and come home on the eleven-twelve train! Please don’t kick me out of the House of Delegates—I’ll call him back right now and cancel it!”

“Please don’t expel her, sir,” I pleaded, my own voice cracking as my hands shook on Katie’s shoulders. “I searched the whole House Manual on my laptop and we didn’t know—”

The Minority Leader stared at Katie and me, and his face softened with deep, unmistakable remorse.

“Expel her? Kicked out of the House?” he repeated gently, holding up both hands palm-out in a calm, steady gesture. “Katie, Nate—look at me. Take a slow breath, both of you. You are not getting kicked out of the House of Delegates, you are not getting kicked out of the Democratic Caucus, and you did not break a single rule. Not a written rule, and not an unwritten rule.”

My grip on Katie’s shoulders loosened by half an inch as I blinked through my tears at him. “We… we didn’t? Then why was Greg yelling in the outer office that Katie had no idea what she was doing and that he had to report what she did to you and the whole Caucus?”

“Because Greg is a hyperactive press staffer who treats every five minutes like a four-alarm fire, and he had no business talking like that outside your door,” the Minority Leader said firmly. He leaned forward, resting his elbows on his knees as he looked straight into Katie’s wet blue eyes. “Katie, you are the constitutional officer elected by the voters of Virginia Beach. Not Greg, and not me. Nobody in this building owns your voice, and you never need permission from a single soul in Richmond to answer your own telephone or accept an interview.”

Katie swallowed hard, letting out a long, shuddering breath as her hand still clutched my jacket lapel. “Then… why did he say I had no idea what I did by saying yes to Meet the Nation?”

A warm, reassuring smile broke across the Minority Leader’s face. “Because neither of you saw what happened to your floor video overnight, did you? Katie, after the local stations in Richmond and Norfolk aired your question on the six-o’clock news last night, the national news desks in Washington and New York picked it up. Your ninety-five-second floor clip crossed ten million views across the United States before sunrise this morning.”

Both Katie and I froze in our wheelchairs, staring at him with wide, tear-reddened eyes. “Ten million?” I whispered.

“Ten million and climbing,” the Minority Leader nodded warmly. “And what you did on the telephone five minutes ago without even trying, Katie, is the single biggest triumph our Caucus has had in a decade. Meet the Nation isn’t just a Sunday

morning show—it is the most prestigious public affairs broadcast in the United States. Members of Congress in Washington spend ten years lobbying just to get invited onto that set. Every President, every U.S. Senator, every Governor, and every Fortune 500 CEO in America watches Meet the Nation at nine o'clock on Sunday morning. Usually, when a state lawmaker goes viral on a Thursday, the networks try to stick them in a noisy three-minute cable panel at the back of the hour. Because you picked up your own phone and politely agreed to give Arthur Vance an exclusive so you only had to tell your story once, he gave a Virginia Beach delegate the solo nine o'clock A-Block lead at the very top of the broadcast."

I blinked, looking from the Minority Leader over to Katie, whose violent trembling was finally starting to slow against my arm.

"Wait," I whispered, the crushing vise around my ribs finally beginning to loosen. "So when Greg told the other delegates down on the third floor what Katie did…"

"We were cheering, Nate!" the Minority Leader laughed gently, reaching into his breast pocket and handing Katie a clean, folded white handkerchief. "The only people upset this morning are the booking producers at the other three networks who called three minutes too late—and that's their problem, not yours. Give me sixty seconds to deal with Greg in the hallway."

He stood up, stepped out into the fifth-floor corridor, and pulled our heavy oak door firmly shut behind him—though through the solid wood, the marble acoustics of the hallway still carried the low, blistering lash of his voice as he backed the communications director up against the wall by the stairwell.

"Have you lost your absolute mind, Greg?!" we heard the Minority Leader snap in the corridor. "Do you have any idea what you just did in there? Both of those twins are on the autism spectrum, they take every word you say completely literally, and when you stood in her outer office yelling into the phone that she broke booking rules and failed to clear an interview with leadership, you threw both of them into a full panic thinking she was about to be expelled from the House of Delegates!"

"Sir, I wasn't trying to scare them, I was just trying to manage the Sunday network requests—" Greg stammered weakly in the hall.

"You work for the members of this Caucus, Greg—the members do not work for you!" the Minority Leader barked. "Delegate Prairie's name was on the ballot in Virginia Beach, not yours. She just single-handedly handed us our biggest floor victory of the session yesterday afternoon, and she doesn't need your permission to pick up her own telephone! Before noon today, you are going to walk back in here, look both Delegate Prairie and Nate in the eye, and apologize for acting like a lunatic outside her door. Do I make myself clear?"

"Yes, sir," Greg muttered, his footsteps retreating fast down the marble stairs.

Before the Minority Leader could turn back toward our door, the brass elevator doors down the hall chimed open. Measured footsteps approached down the corridor carpet, and a second, deeper voice spoke up—one with a calm Southside Virginia drawl that both Katie and I recognized from the front desk of the Republican aisle on the House Floor.

It was the House Majority Leader.

“Everything alright up here on the fifth floor, Tom?” the Republican Majority Leader asked quietly outside our door. “My clerk came down from the committee room a minute ago and said your press director was raising a ruckus outside Delegate Prairie’s office and had those two kids in tears.”

“I just handled Greg,” the Minority Leader sighed in the hallway. “Katie answered her own main line at nine-fifteen and gave Meet the Nation a Sunday morning exclusive, and Greg went into a staffer meltdown in her reception room shouting about unwritten rules and reporting her to leadership. Sent both Katie and Nate into an absolute tailspin thinking she was about to be kicked out of the House.”

Out in the corridor, the Republican Majority Leader let out a low, disgusted breath.

Ten seconds later, a polite two-knuckle knock sounded on our office door. When I called out softly to come in, both the Democratic Minority Leader and the Republican Majority Leader stepped inside Room 518 together.

Katie and I were still parked flush side by side, my right wheel touching her left wheel, my left arm still wrapped around her shoulders, and Katie holding the white handkerchief in her lap. Seeing the two most powerful floor leaders from both parties standing in our office at the same time made both of us sit up straight in our SwiftChairs.

“Morning, Delegate Prairie. Morning, Nate,” the Republican Majority Leader said gently, taking off his reading glasses and tucking them into his breast pocket so there was nothing formal or adversarial about his posture. “I hope you two don’t mind me stepping in for a minute with Tom.”

“Good morning, Mr. Majority Leader,” Katie said quietly, her voice steady again even though her eyes and mine were still red and damp around the edges.

“Tom just filled me in on the commotion out in the hallway,” the Majority Leader said, looking warmly at both of us. “Now, you and I sit on opposite sides of that green carpet downstairs, Delegate, and lord knows you gave my side of the aisle a rough afternoon yesterday on House Bill 663. We’re going to disagree on plenty of votes while you’re in Richmond. But my thirteen-year-old nephew is on the autism spectrum—he’s actually in the eighth grade in middle school and serving right downstairs on the House Floor this session in his navy blazer as a House Page, learning about state government for the very first time—and I know firsthand how overwhelming it is when folks in a building like this start shouting about unwritten rules that aren’t in the handbook.”

Katie blinked in surprise, looking from the Majority Leader over to me as the last of the tension finally drained out of our shoulders. We had seen the thirteen- and fourteen-year-old middle-school House Pages hurrying across the green chamber carpet in their navy blazers every afternoon carrying bill copies and messages for Delegates, and knowing that one of those middle-school Pages was the Majority Leader’s own autistic nephew changed the entire feeling in the room.

“When my nephew started his first week as a Page in January, I gave him one piece of advice, and it’s the only rule you and Nate ever need to know in this building,” the Majority Leader continued, pointing a finger toward the floor beneath our wheels. “Every single unwritten rule you hear a staffer or a lobbyist talk about in the hallways of Richmond is completely made up. The only rules that govern a member

of the Virginia House of Delegates are the Constitution of Virginia and the printed Manual of the House on your desk—and I know for a fact you two have already read every page of both."

"Twice," I admitted quietly, a small, relieved smile finally tugging at the corner of my mouth.

"I figured as much," the Majority Leader chuckled softly. "And let me tell you something else, Delegate. Do you know how many sitting Governors and U.S. Senators would give their right arm to get invited onto the opening A-Block of Meet the Nation for a one-on-one exclusive with David Vance? Whenever some overcaffeinated press staffer starts hollering because you answered your own phone instead of playing Washington media games, you two didn't do a doggone thing wrong—he did. In fact, between you, me, and Tom, half my own caucus wishes the gentleman from Spotsylvania had asked you two to proofread his bill before he embarrassed the whole Commonwealth on television yesterday."

Across from him, the Democratic Minority Leader laughed out loud, and for the first time since nine-twenty that morning, Katie let out a genuine, relieved laugh too, wiping the last trace of tears from her cheek.

"And just so we're clear on the bipartisan record," the Majority Leader added with a kindly wink as he turned toward the door, "if you two are taking the six-oh-five train out of Main Street Station on Sunday morning to go talk to David Vance in Washington, don't let anyone in this building bother you all weekend. Safe travels up the tracks, Delegate—and I'll see both of you at noon on Monday when we strike House Bill 663 off the calendar for good."

As the two floor leaders stepped back out into the corridor together, Katie looked over at me across our touching armrests, the color finally returning to her cheeks as she reached out and laced her fingers tightly through mine.

"Okay," Katie breathed softly, resting her forehead against my shoulder for one quiet second before picking up her yellow highlighter again. "No unwritten rules. Just the Constitution of Virginia, the House Manual, and the six-oh-five train out of Main Street Station."

"And two Business Class wheelchair bays with our names on them," I said, pulling our bank card out of my wallet and clicking the confirmation button on my laptop screen to reserve the only two integrated wheeled-mobility spaces on Sunday morning's ARTS Northeast Regional Train 164 from Richmond Main Street Station to Alexandria, along with the eleven-twelve southbound return on Train 143 and its connecting ARTS Thruway 8443 shuttle—paying full regular fare out of our own pockets just like we always did.

Saturday, February 6, 2016, 11:15 PM — The Studio 8H Tip-Off & The "Anatomical Verification Checkpoint" Cold Open

Because our Sunday morning alarm was set for four-thirty so we could catch the early JRTC Route 6 bus down Broad Street to Main Street Station, Katie and I planned to turn in early on Saturday night.

By eleven-fifteen on Saturday evening inside Apartment 104 at the Broad & Boulevard Lofts, our royal-blue and charcoal blazers and pressed slacks were already laid out for the morning, our reloadable blue plastic SmartPass cards for Capital Transit were tucked into our wallets, and our two SwiftChairs were parked side by side near the bedroom wall outlet. I was just reaching for the remote control on the table to shut off the living room television when Katie's cell phone buzzed once, then twice, then five times in rapid succession.

Katie picked it up from her lap tray and blinked at the stack of incoming text messages from three different Capitol beat reporters and the Minority Leader's chief of staff.

"What's going on?" I asked, pausing with my thumb over the power button on the remote. "Did Delegate Cobb pull the bill already?"

"No," Katie said slowly, reading the messages off the glowing screen. "A producer in New York just tipped off the Richmond press corps about the eleven-thirty dress rehearsal in Studio 8H. On the exact same GBS television network where I'm appearing tomorrow morning, their late-night comedy broadcast just scrapped its planned Washington cold open. Everyone is telling us to leave the television on right now because House Bill 663 is the star of the eleven-thirty cold open."

I stared at my sister for two seconds, then burst out laughing and backed my SwiftChair right up beside hers in front of the television. "Well, four hours of sleep and a ninety-minute train ride to Alexandria is plenty. Let's watch!"

Five minutes later, at eleven-thirty sharp, the network chime rang out and the broadcast faded up on a painted replica of a Virginia State Capitol hallway in New York.

Right beside a mahogany door marked *LADIES ROOM* stood a cast member wearing a khaki state trooper uniform with an oversized foam campaign hat, a clipboard, and a yellow carpenter's tape measure clipped to his belt, sitting behind a folding card table with a hand-painted poster board sign reading:

> COMMONWEALTH OF VIRGINIA
> ANATOMICAL VERIFICATION CHECKPOINT
> HAVE YOUR BIRTH CERTIFICATE OR FIFTY DOLLARS READY

Beside the folding table stood a second cast member wearing a gray hairpiece and a rumpled navy suit with an oversized name badge reading *DELEGATE FROM SPOTSYLVANIA*.

"Good evening, fellow Virginians!" the actor playing the Spotsylvania delegate declared earnestly into the camera, dabbing sweat off his forehead with a pocket handkerchief while the New York studio audience immediately started laughing. "Now, I know a lot of folks in the news media got the wrong impression this week when Delegate Katie Prairie asked me on the House Floor how my new bathroom bill, House Bill 663, is actually going to work. People are saying, 'Wait a minute, is the Commonwealth of Virginia really going to make women pull their pants down for a government official just to use the ladies' room at Virginia Dominion University or the Community College of Hampton Roads?' And I am here tonight to assure every tourist, college student, and business owner in America that we have worked out a totally normal, non-creepy system!"

He gestured proudly toward the actor in the state trooper uniform, who blew a silver referee whistle as a female cast member carrying a shopping bag walked up to the restroom door.

“Hold it right there, ma’am!” the fake trooper barked, flipping open his clipboard. “Before you enter this state-owned facility to wash your hands, pursuant to House Bill 663, I need to verify your physical anatomy for the Virginia Literary Fund! Did you bring your original hospital birth certificate with the raised county seal?”

“To go to the bathroom at the DMV?” the woman asked, blinking in disbelief. “No! Why would I carry my birth certificate in my purse?”

The fake trooper gasped and looked over at the Spotsylvania delegate. “Uh-oh, Delegate! No birth certificate in the hallway! What’s Step Two in Line 18 of your bill?”

The actor playing the Spotsylvania delegate froze, his eyes going wide under the studio lights as he pulled a twenty-foot-long accordion scroll of paper out of his suit pocket and squinted at it in panic.

“Well—uh—hang on, let me check Line 18!” he stammered, his face turning beet-red as the audience howled. “We don’t—nobody is suggesting we look! Wait—Officer, just ask her a trick question only a biological woman from Virginia would know! Ask her what shade of autumn cardigan she’s wearing!”

“Actually, Delegate,” the woman said dryly, pulling a crisp fifty-dollar bill out of her wallet and slapping it onto the card table, “if the options in Spotsylvania County are handing a state trooper my birth certificate, answering questions about my pants, or paying fifty bucks to buy schoolbooks for the Virginia Literary Fund, here’s fifty dollars—because clearly Spotsylvania County needs all the schoolbooks it can get!”

The studio audience erupted into cheers and applause as the actor playing the delegate stared helplessly into the camera lens for four silent seconds—mimicking Delegate Martin Cobb’s exact four-second freeze-frame from Thursday afternoon’s House Floor broadcast—before dropping into the folding chair behind the card table and muttering, “I pass the bill by for the day, Mr. Speaker—and Live from New York, it’s Saturday Night!”

In our living room on West Broad Street, I was laughing so hard my shoulders shook, while Katie sat staring at the opening saxophone montage with both hands pressed over her warm cheeks.

“And in nine hours,” I grinned, clicking off the television so we could climb into our shared sleeping bag sanctuary for four hours of sleep before the alarm, “you get to take the train up to Washington and finish that bill off for good.”

Sunday, February 7, 2016, 6:05 AM to 2:05 PM — Train 164 from Main Street Station, The Charles R. Fenwick Bridge, & Live on Meet the Nation

At five-fifteen on Sunday morning, while the rest of Richmond was still fast asleep in the February dark, Katie and I rolled out onto West Broad Street in our winter coats over our broadcast suits, caught the early Sunday morning eastbound JRTC Route 6 bus down the hill into Shockoe Bottom, and took the station elevator up to the historic train shed at Richmond Main Street Station.

At six-oh-five on the dot, the bright headlamp of ARTS Northeast Regional Train 164 swung around the curve from the Peninsula Subdivision and glided alongside the high-level platform. We rolled side by side into the warm Business Class car at the rear of the consist, engaged the electromagnetic brakes of our SwiftChairs inside the two integrated mobility bays we had reserved on Friday morning, and traded the February chill for the quiet hum of the floorboard heaters. Ten minutes north of the station, I rolled up to the café counter at the end of the car and came back carrying two cold cans of ginger ale—included complimentary with our Business Class tickets—and set one in Katie's cupholder.

For the next hour and forty minutes, as the winter sun rose pale pink and gold over the Rappahannock River at Fredericksburg and the Potomac creeks along Quantico, nobody asked Katie about House Bill 663, nobody shoved a microphone in her face, and nobody recognized us. We were just Katie and Nate again, riding the rails together the way we loved best.

At seven-fifty sharp, Train 164 pulled to a stop at Alexandria Union Station beneath the white stone spire of the George Washington Masonic Memorial.

Rather than staying onboard for the slow twenty-eight-minute crawl through the freight switches into Washington Union Station, we detrained onto the brick platform at Alexandria with the station attendant's portable lift, followed the flat brick walkway a hundred and fifty feet straight into the King Street–Old Town Capital Transit station, and pulled our blue plastic SmartPass cards out of our wallets—the exact same reloadable farecards we had carried on weekend family trips to Washington with Dad when we were growing up in Virginia Beach.

We tapped our SmartPass cards against the circular target pads on the wide accessible faregate, rode the elevator up to the island platform, and rolled straight onto a waiting northbound Yellow Line train.

Twelve minutes later, just past the Pentagon tunnel portal, our silver railcar burst out into the bright morning sunlight high above the Potomac River on the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge.

Directly to our right across the shimmering gray water, the northbound highway lanes of Interstate 395 on the 14th Street Bridge were backed up for half a mile behind an early-morning fender bender and a highway maintenance truck—the exact traffic jam a network limousine would have been stuck idling in right then. Out here on the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge, our Yellow Line train flew across the river at fifty miles an hour with a clear view of the white marble dome of the Jefferson Memorial and the Washington Monument rising against the crisp Sunday sky.

“Told you the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge beats the 14th Street Bridge every single time,” I said, grinning across the aisle of the railcar as we glided smoothly into the L’Enfant Plaza portal in downtown Washington.

“Every single time,” Katie agreed, tapping her SmartPass card out at the transfer station as we headed up to the GBS News Washington bureau with twenty-five minutes to spare.

When we rolled through the security glass of the Washington broadcast bureau at eight-thirty-five, Arthur Vance nearly dropped his coffee mug when he realized Katie had actually come all the way from Richmond on a city bus, a Business Class intercity train, and a Yellow Line subway car across the Potomac without a single staffer or chauffeur in tow.

Inside the main studio, the floor crew had cleared away the standard swivel guest chair and projected a high-resolution panorama of Thomas Jefferson’s white-columned Virginia State Capitol across the curved LED wall directly behind Katie’s tape mark, while the large flat-screen studio monitor to the side glowed blue with the program banner reading *MEET THE NATION — DEL. KATIE PRAIRIE*. When a well-meaning stage manager asked if Camera One should crop the frame tight around Katie’s shoulders so viewers wouldn’t focus on her wheelchair, Katie shook her head politely and rested her hand on her joystick armrest.

“Keep the frame wide enough to show my chair, please,” Katie told him warmly. “A lot of people watching across the country this morning have never seen a legislator in a power wheelchair on a Sunday morning show, and I don’t hide who I am.”

Five minutes before air, the floor director clipped the miniature broadcast microphone to the lapel of Katie’s royal-blue blazer and fitted the clear plastic IFB earpiece into her right ear, then guided me to my spot right beside the studio confidence monitor just outside the wide camera lens—completely out of the broadcast frame so there was zero confusion about who held the constitutional office, yet close enough that Katie had a clear, unobstructed sightline to me the entire time.

Underneath the glowing *MEET THE NATION — DEL. KATIE PRAIRIE* studio monitor, I engaged the electromagnetic brakes of my SwiftChair and opened my silver MagnaBook Pro across my lap tray. On my screen sat the exact statutory text of House Bill 663 alongside a list of the fourteen Fortune 500 corporate headquarters located in the Commonwealth of Virginia.

“Thirty seconds to live, Delegate,” the stage manager called out softly as the iconic brass orchestra fanfare of Meet the Nation echoed through the studio monitors.

Katie rested her right hand calmly near her joystick controller and her left hand on her armrest, looking briefly over at me. I gave my twin sister a steady nod from behind my laptop screen.

The red tally light atop Camera One flared bright red.

“If it’s Sunday, it’s Meet the Nation,” moderator David Vance’s voice resonated across the studio and into millions of living rooms from coast to coast. “Joining us live in our Washington studio this morning—after riding the early morning train up from Richmond Main Street Station and the Yellow Line across the Potomac—is Virginia Delegate Katie Prairie of Virginia Beach, whose blistering ninety-five-

second exchange on the floor of the Virginia House of Delegates over House Bill 663 has been viewed more than twelve million times since Thursday afternoon, and was even immortalized last night in the cold open on late-night television. Delegate Prairie, welcome to Meet the Nation."

"Good morning, David," Katie said evenly, keeping her eyes focused straight into the glass lens of Camera One. "Thank you for having me—and the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge was wide open all the way across the river."

"Delegate, let's start with that moment on the House Floor on Thursday," Vance said, as the broadcast aired the ninety-five-second floor clip side by side with our live studio feed. "You held up the printed text of House Bill 663 and asked the bill's patron why you, or any woman or girl in the Commonwealth of Virginia, should have to pull her pants down for a government official or a police officer just to use the ladies' room at a community college, a public university, or the State Capitol. Critics on the other side of the aisle claim you were being deliberately theatrical to embarrass the majority. Did you plan that line to go viral?"

"Not at all, David," Katie replied, her voice calm, clear, and completely literal. "Anyone who knows my twin brother Nate and me back home in Virginia Beach and Norfolk knows I don't do political theater. We write computer software for a living, and when a bill is placed on our desks in the House of Delegates, my job as a constitutional officer is to read every single word literally—because the courts and the police have to enforce the literal words we put into the Code of Virginia, not whatever talking point a politician gives at a press conference afterward."

Out of the corner of her eye, Katie glanced toward my chair as I tapped the touchpad of my laptop beside the studio monitor.

"And when you read Line 18 on Page 1 and Line 54 on Page 2 of House Bill 663 side by side," Katie continued smoothly, "the bill applies to every public building, public school, and public college campus owned or leased by the Commonwealth. It defines compliance not by an identification card or how someone lives their daily life, but strictly by what it calls 'a person's anatomy,' and it authorizes any law enforcement officer to issue a fifty-dollar civil summons for the Literary Fund. As someone who has used a power wheelchair full-time since I was sixteen years old—and who had to pull out a steel tape measure before my freshman session just to get an ADA-compliant restroom stall wide enough to close the door in privacy inside our own State Capitol complex—I asked the gentleman from Spotsylvania that question on Thursday because I wanted a literal, legal answer to a basic Fourth Amendment problem: since police officers standing in the hallway of the State Capitol, Virginia Dominion University, or the Community College of Hampton Roads do not carry a filing cabinet of citizens' birth certificates, how can an officer prove a citizen's physical anatomy in General District Court without conducting an invasive physical search?"

"And as millions of Americans saw on Thursday—and again in parody last night in New York—the patron couldn't answer you," Vance noted. "Instead, the Majority Leader had to pass the bill by for the day. What are you hearing from Virginia's business community and House leadership ahead of tomorrow's noon session?"

"What I can tell you is that employers, universities, and families across Hampton Roads, Richmond, and Northern Virginia are deeply alarmed," Katie said clearly. "Virginia is home to the largest naval base in the world at Norfolk, major shipbuilding and port facilities, world-class public universities like Commonwealth

Polytechnic Institute and Virginia Dominion University, and fourteen Fortune 500 corporate headquarters. Transgender women are women, transgender men are men, and none of those employers—and none of the working families I represent in Virginia Beach—sent us to Richmond to waste taxpayer money turning police officers into fifty-dollar bathroom inspectors or turning our Commonwealth into a national punchline. We have coastal flooding to mitigate, public transit systems to expand, disability Medicaid waitlists to clear, and classrooms to fund."

"One final question before we let you go, Delegate Prairie," Vance said, his tone warming with genuine respect. "A lot of viewers across the country are meeting you for the very first time this weekend. You entered public life after fighting to fix public transit schedules in Hampton Roads, and now you've single-handedly brought one of the most controversial bills in the country to a dead halt. Do you have your sights set on higher office down the road—perhaps the State Senate or even here in Washington?"

Just off-camera beneath the studio monitor, I smiled faintly above my laptop keyboard.

"Right now, David, my only focus is noon tomorrow in the building right behind me," Katie said, gesturing slightly toward the glowing image of the Virginia State Capitol behind her SwiftChair, "and catching the eleven-twelve ARTS train out of Alexandria with my brother so we can get back to Richmond this afternoon. Once we make sure House Bill 663 is permanently laid on the table where it belongs, I have transportation and accessibility amendments to pass for the people of Virginia Beach."

"Delegate Katie Prairie of Virginia Beach, thank you for joining us this morning," Vance said.

By nine-eighteen, the red tally light atop Camera One clicked off and the floor director unclipped the miniature microphone from the lapel of Katie's royal-blue blazer.

Arthur Vance walked out onto the studio floor holding his cell phone with wide eyes alongside two fresh mugs from the green room. "Delegate Prairie, our control room phones are already lighting up from Capitol Hill to Richmond, and the Associated Wire just put out an urgent alert from the Virginia State Capitol—House leadership just announced they are sending House Bill 663 back to the General Laws subcommittee tomorrow morning to strike it from the docket before the noon floor gavel even falls! You're welcome to relax in the hospitality suite as long as you like, and whenever you're ready to head back to Virginia, our driver can bring the town car around."

"Thank you, Mr. Vance, but we really do have that eleven-twelve train to catch at Alexandria," Katie said politely, handing her clear plastic earpiece back to the audio technician.

She had been sitting upright in that stiff royal-blue broadcast blazer, button-down collar, and tailored dress slacks since four-forty-five in the morning on four hours of sleep, and under the hot studio lights her sensory limit was nearly maxed out. Waiting around until three-thirty-eight in the afternoon for the direct one-seat Peninsula train back to Main Street Station would have meant spending four more hours trapped in formal interview clothes.

At nine-twenty-five sharp, I closed my silver laptop, tucked it into my bag, and rolled out the front doors of the Washington bureau right beside my sister.

We rolled straight back to the Capital Transit station, tapped our blue SmartPass cards at the wide accessible gate, and rode a southbound Yellow Line train right back out into the bright morning sun across the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge. By ten-fifteen, we rolled off the King Street–Old Town platform, crossed the brick plaza to the bakery opposite Alexandria Station to grab two hot egg-and-cheese croissants for the road, and boarded the Business Class car of southbound ARTS Northeast Regional Train 143 at eleven-twelve on the dot.

As the train glided south past Quantico and Fredericksburg, Katie's cell phone buzzed nonstop inside her bag with texts from delegates, reporters, and national political producers. She didn't answer a single one. She leaned her head back against her headrest, sipped her cold ginger ale from the café car, and watched the winter pine trees blur past the window while I held her hand across the aisle.

At one-oh-two in the afternoon, Train 143 pulled to a stop at the suburban Staples Mill station in Henrico County.

Waiting right outside the station doors in the reserved charter lane was the white lift-equipped ARTS Thruway 8443 connecting motorcoach with *RICHMOND MAIN STREET* glowing on its amber destination sign. Because our Business Class tickets were booked through to Main Street, the driver already had the hydraulic wheelchair lift unfolded and waiting on the curb before we even rolled through the sliding glass doors.

In less than ten minutes, the driver secured both of our SwiftChairs into the floor tracks of the coach, raised the lift, and pulled straight out onto Interstate 64 East toward downtown. By one-thirty-five, the Thruway shuttle dropped us right beneath the historic clock tower at Richmond Main Street Station, where we caught the Sunday afternoon westbound JRTC Route 6 bus straight up Broad Street to Boulevard.

At five minutes past two—while the political panels in Washington and the Governor's staff in Richmond were still replaying her nine o'clock interview on every screen—I unlocked the front door of Apartment 104 at the Broad & Boulevard Lofts.

Katie rolled straight into the bedroom, unbuttoned that stiff royal-blue television blazer, hung it up in the closet, and traded her starched collar and dress slacks for her softest gray cotton sweatshirt and fleece sweatpants. Five minutes later, after I had ditched my charcoal suit and tie for an old Virginia Beach t-shirt and athletic pants, we parked our SwiftChairs side by side near the living room window overlooking West Broad Street, kicked up our footrests, and enjoyed the quietest Sunday afternoon in Richmond.

The next morning, Monday, February 8, just before the noon floor session convened at the Capitol, the House majority recommitted House Bill 663 back to the General Laws subcommittee room downstairs to dispose of it without forcing their members to cast a recorded roll-call vote on the Floor.

With television cameras crammed shoulder-to-shoulder along the side walls, the subcommittee chairman called House Bill 663 up and didn't even allow debate.

“Is there a motion to lay House Bill 663 on the table?” the chairman asked briskly.

“So moved,” a majority member muttered without looking up from his desk.

“All in favor of laying the bill on the table say aye—all opposed say no—the ayes have it, and House Bill 663 is laid on the table!” the chairman announced in a single breath, banging his gavel to kill his own party’s bathroom bill on an unrecorded voice vote before anyone could demand a roll call.

Standing by the lectern as his bill died in nine seconds flat—alongside an equally furious Delegate Robert Marsh, who was already muttering under his breath that he would bring his own “Physical Privacy Act” back next session—Delegate Martin Cobb glared down the dais at his own party’s members, gathered up his folders, and snapped into the open air as he stormed out the door:

“I’m going to pray that you all get courage!”

At the accessible end of the room, Katie watched the bill’s patron stomp out into the hallway, turned her head toward my wheelchair, and gave me the quietest, proudest twin smile in the world as we reached across our armrests and squeezed each other’s hand.

Across the Rotunda: The Senate of Virginia

Watching Senator Ward Kill Our Bills Across the Rotunda & The 250-Signature Petition

Watching Senator Ward Kill Our Bills Across the Rotunda, Brainstorming the 7th Senate District with Dad, & The 250-Signature Rule

Date: 2018-02-22 at 15:10 America/New_York

Thursday, February 22, 2018, 3:10 PM — The Graveyard Across the Capitol Rotunda

“House Bill 412, patroned by Delegate Prairie of Virginia Beach, relating to dedicated regional public-transit operating assistance and Priority-One developmental-disability Medicaid waiver slots,” the committee clerk read aloud inside the crowded Senate Finance subcommittee room on the afternoon after the mid-session crossover deadline.

Parked side by side in our compact SwiftChairs in front of the witness table—with a dozen CVTA bus riders and three mothers of developmentally disabled adults from Virginia Beach and Norfolk sitting nervously behind us after riding the morning train up to Richmond—thirty-two-year-old Katie and I looked up at the raised mahogany dais of the Senate of Virginia.

It had taken Katie four years of relentless, brick-by-brick legislative work in the hundred-member House of Delegates to get House Bill 412 across the Capitol Rotunda. After winning re-election in 2015 and 2017—and after the 2017 wave brought our side within a single seat of parity in the House—Katie had worked across the aisle with coastal moderates like our Virginia Beach colleague Delegate Ronald Villa to pass House Bill 412 off the House Floor by a bipartisan sixty-two-to-thirty-eight vote. The bill did two things our constituents in Hampton Roads desperately needed: it dedicated a permanent stream of regional transportation revenue to expand evening and Sunday CVTA and JRTC bus service, and it funded fifteen hundred new Priority-One developmental-disability Medicaid waiver slots so Virginia adults with developmental disabilities—people just like our cousin Chelsea up in Newport, Rhode Island—wouldn't sit on an emergency waiting list for ten years when their parents grew old.

Now the bill had crossed the rotunda to the forty-member Senate of Virginia, where Republicans held a narrow twenty-one-to-nineteen majority.

And sitting right in the center chair behind the subcommittee gavel was our own hometown State Senator—twenty-year incumbent Senator Franklin Ward of the Seventh Senate District in Virginia Beach.

"Delegate Prairie, you have two minutes to present your bill," Senator Ward said smoothly, barely looking up from his leather folio as he checked his gold wristwatch.

Katie rolled her SwiftChair flush to the witness microphone and laid out the exact fiscal math of House Bill 412 in ninety seconds—showing how every dollar was already paid for without raising a single tax on working families, and gesturing behind us toward the Virginia Beach parents and bus commuters who had taken a vacation day from work just to testify.

Senator Ward didn't ask a single question about the math, and he didn't call a single citizen witness from the sign-up sheet.

"Thank you, Delegate Prairie, we all know how fond you and your brother are of buses," Senator Ward said with a dismissive wave of his hand. "Unfortunately, this subcommittee has other highway priorities for Hampton Roads this afternoon. Do I hear a motion to pass House Bill 412 by indefinitely?"

"So moved," a majority senator muttered beside him.

"All in favor say aye—opposed no—the ayes have it, and House Bill 412 is passed by indefinitely," Senator Ward announced, rapping his wooden gavel once to kill the bill for the year before the mothers in the back row could even stand up from their chairs. "Next bill on the docket."

Behind us, one of the mothers from Kempsville—whose twenty-nine-year-old nonverbal son had been waiting six years for a disability support waiver—let out a quiet, heartbroken breath and lowered her printed testimony back into her purse.

Katie didn't yell or pound the witness table. She turned her SwiftChair around, rolled back to the visitor rows with me right beside her, and spent ten minutes holding the hands of every parent and bus rider who had traveled up from Hampton Roads, promising them on her word of honor that she wasn't done fighting for them.

Twenty minutes later, after we had walked the families down to the Ninth and Main bus stop to catch their ride to Main Street Station, Katie and I rolled back into the center of the historic Capitol Rotunda on the second floor.

In the quiet marble rotunda directly beneath Thomas Jefferson's dome, the tall mahogany entrance doors of the House of Delegates Chamber stood to our south, while the mahogany doors of the Senate of Virginia Chamber stood directly opposite to our north.

Katie braked her SwiftChair right in the center of the black-and-white marble floor between the two chambers and stared at the closed doors of the Senate of Virginia.

"Four years, Nate," Katie said quietly, her voice vibrating with focused steel as she reached across our armrests to grip my right hand. "We spent four years building a bipartisan coalition in a hundred-member House of Delegates to pass that bill, and our own State Senator from Virginia Beach killed it in ninety seconds across the rotunda without even letting our constituents speak."

"Because in a bicameral legislature, passing a bill through the House is only half the equation," I said, squeezing her fingers back. "As long as Franklin Ward holds a committee gavel in a twenty-one-to-nineteen Senate, he can bury every single transit bill and disability-waiver bill we pass."

Katie's blue eyes stayed locked on the north doors of the Senate Chamber.

"The Seventh Senate District covers western and central Virginia Beach and eastern Norfolk," Katie said slowly. "Every single precinct of our Eighty-Fifth House District in Kempsville sits right inside the heart of Franklin Ward's Seventh Senate District. And next year—November 2019—all forty seats in the Senate of Virginia are on the ballot."

I looked at my twin sister, feeling the exact same electric charge I had felt in the Capitol elevator six years earlier.

"Let's finish out this session," I whispered, "and when we get home to Kempsville, let's sit down with Dad."

Saturday, November 10, 2018, 5:00 PM — Brainstorming the Jump to the State Senate Around Our Kempsville Table

"Walk me through the difference between being a State Delegate and being a State Senator," our sixty-year-old dad said that autumn as the three of us sat around our oak kitchen table on Lord Nelson Drive with three tall glasses of ginger ale and my MagnaBook Pro open to the map of the Seventh Senate District of Virginia. "You're already in state politics in Richmond, Katie, and the voters of the Eighty-Fifth

House District have elected you three times in a row by bigger margins every election. If a constituent on the Route 12 bus asks you tomorrow morning why you're jumping from the House of Delegates to run for the Senate of Virginia, what's the answer?"

"Three reasons, Dad," thirty-three-year-old Katie answered, holding up three fingers from her SwiftChair armrest.

"First," Katie said, "is what happened to House Bill 412 in February. The Virginia General Assembly has two chambers. In the hundred-member House of Delegates, I'm one vote out of a hundred, and even when we build a bipartisan coalition and pass a bill through the House, it has to cross the rotunda and pass the forty-member Senate of Virginia. Right now, the Senate is split twenty-one to nineteen, and our own State Senator here in the Seventh District—Franklin Ward—uses his seniority on Senate Finance and Transportation to kill regional public-transit funding, developmental-disability Medicaid waivers, and minimum-wage increases before they ever reach the Senate Floor. If I stay in the House, we can keep passing bills every February and watching Senator Ward throw them in the trash can every March."

"Second," I said, tapping the legislative math chart I had coded on my laptop screen, "look at the structural difference between the two chambers. In the House of Delegates, there are a hundred members and everyone runs for re-election every two years. In the Senate of Virginia, there are only forty members, and they serve four-year terms. One State Senator represents two and a half times the voting weight of a Delegate. Even bigger: because the Senate is split twenty-one to nineteen right now, flipping just two Senate seats next November flips the entire Senate of Virginia into a Democratic majority. And under the Senate's seniority and caucus rules, if Katie wins the Seventh Senate District and we win the majority, she won't just be one voice at the end of a committee table—she'll be handed the gavel as Chair of a standing Senate committee and sit on Senate Transportation and Finance."

"And third," Katie said, tracing the boundary lines of the Seventh Senate District across my screen from Kempsville and Bellamy Manor up past CCHR, Princess Anne Road, Pembroke Commons, Bayside, and across Newtown Road into eastern Norfolk, "look at who lives in the Seventh Senate District. A House of Delegates district has about eighty thousand residents. A Virginia Senate district has two hundred thousand residents—equivalent to two and a half House districts combined. Every single neighborhood I already represent in the Eighty-Fifth House District is right here inside the Seventh Senate District, alongside the exact CCHR, Pembroke, Newtown Road, and Military Highway bus corridors Nate and I have ridden and written about since 2005."

Dad leaned back in his chair, nodding slowly as he took in the whole picture.

"And what about your current seat in the Eighty-Fifth House District?" Dad asked. "Do you have to resign from the House of Delegates early to run for the State Senate?"

"Not a single day early," I replied. "In Virginia, every twenty-year cycle aligns so that in 2019, all one hundred seats in the House of Delegates and all forty seats in the Senate of Virginia are up for election on the exact same Tuesday—November 5, 2019. Katie serves every single day of her current two-year House term through the 2019 legislative session and all the way to January 2020. Instead of filing for re-election to the Eighty-Fifth House District ballot next spring, she files for the

Seventh Senate District ballot—and Andre Askew, who has worked right alongside us in Kempsville for the past four years, is ready to run for Katie's Eighty-Fifth House seat so our district stays in good hands."

Dad pulled his familiar yellow legal pad and black pen across the kitchen table—the exact same routine the three of us had followed in 2010 for City Council and in 2012 for the House of Delegates.

"Alright, Mr. Campaign Manager and Mr. Treasurer," Dad said with a grin, writing *Katie Prairie for Virginia Senate — 7th District (2019)* across the top line. "Since we're already registered in the State Board of Elections system from Katie's House races, what changes legally under Title 24.2 of the Code of Virginia when a sitting Delegate files for the State Senate?"

"Four main things," I said, opening our 2019 statutory checklist:

"First, right after the 2019 winter session adjourns in late February, we file an amended Statement of Organization in COMET transitioning our campaign committee to *Katie Prairie for Virginia Senate*, keeping you as official Campaign Treasurer and me as Campaign Manager and Chief Technology Officer. Second, Katie files her Certificate of Candidate Qualification under Section 24.2-501, her Declaration of Candidacy under Section 24.2-520, and her updated General Assembly Statement of Economic Interests. Third, because the Seventh Senate District spans two localities—both the City of Virginia Beach and the eastern precincts of the City of Norfolk—our ballot qualification paperwork and primary filing fee get verified across both cities' voter registrars under the State Board of Elections."

"And fourth," Katie added with a determined smile, "the voter petition signature threshold doubles. Under Code of Virginia Section 24.2-506, a House of Delegates candidate needs one hundred and twenty-five qualified voter signatures, while a candidate for the Senate of Virginia is required by law to turn in at least two hundred and fifty signatures of qualified voters registered inside the Seventh Senate District."

"In 2013 we needed one hundred and twenty-five and collected four hundred and twelve," Dad said, tapping his pen decisively against the legal pad. "So for a two-hundred-and-fifty-signature State Senate requirement across two hundred thousand people in Virginia Beach and Norfolk, we're collecting at least eight hundred verified signatures."

"Eight hundred it is," I smiled, reaching across the table to clasp Dad's hand and Katie's hand together.

Spring 2019 — Senator Ward Ducks the Race & Collecting 824 Signatures Along Route 20 and Route 25

In late February 2019, twenty-four hours after the forty-five-day winter legislative session adjourned in Richmond, Katie stood at the CCHR Virginia Beach Campus bus transfer loop flanked by me, Dad, and forty daily bus commuters and disability advocates to formally announce her candidacy for the Seventh Senate District of Virginia.

Three weeks later, after seeing our first internal poll and watching volunteers line up four-deep around our wheelchairs at the Pembroke Commons, Glenrock Mall, and CCHR bus stops to sign Katie's nominating petitions, twenty-year incumbent State Senator Franklin Ward stunned the Capitol press corps by announcing his sudden retirement rather than face Delegate Katie Prairie on the November ballot.

Instead, the majority party establishment poured over a million dollars in corporate PAC money behind Senator Ward's handpicked successor—a wealthy commercial real-estate attorney who immediately attacked Katie's regional transit plan as a "socialist giveaway to inner-city buses."

With Dad walking beside our SwiftChairs every weekend holding the legal-sized petition clipboards and signing the circulator affidavits before a notary, and with me checking every signer's street address across both the Virginia Beach and Norfolk voter rolls on my laptop, we turned in eight hundred and twenty-four verified voter signatures to the State Board of Elections in March 2019—more than triple the two-hundred-and-fifty-signature statutory requirement—qualifying Katie unopposed as the Democratic Nominee for the Seventh Senate District.

Flipping the Seventh Senate District, The Mahogany Senate Ramp, & Madam Chair

Flipping the Seventh Senate District, Custom-Milling the Mahogany Senate Ramp, & Swearing In as Madam Chair

Date: 2019-11-05 at 19:30 America/New_York

Tuesday, November 5, 2019, 7:30 PM — Winning the Seventh Senate District & Flipping the Senate of Virginia

"Norfolk precincts around Newtown Road and Glenrock just uploaded to the State Board of Elections server," I called out at seven-thirty on Election Night—Tuesday, November 5, 2019—as my custom PHP precinct-aggregation script refreshed on my laptop screen inside our packed campaign headquarters off Kempsville Road. "And here come the early-vote and seven-o'clock precinct totals from CCHR, Bellamy Manor, Brandon, Pembroke, and the polling place over by Fairlawn Recreation Center on Marlborough Drive!"

Sitting right beside my left armrest in her compact SwiftChair, thirty-four-year-old Katie leaned in while Dad stood behind our two wheelchairs with his hand resting proudly on my shoulder.

Unlike our first House race six years earlier—when we had watched eighteen Kempsville precincts around our kitchen table—the Seventh Senate District spanned fifty-four precincts across western and central Virginia Beach and eastern Norfolk. For seven straight months from April through November, Katie, Dad, and I had ridden every CVTA bus route connecting the two cities—Route 1, Route 12, Route 15, Route 20, Route 25, Route 29, and Route 33—canvassing thousands of doors from Kempsville and Larkspur all the way north to Bayside and west across Newtown Road into Norfolk.

And because voters across Virginia Beach and Norfolk remembered Delegate Katie Prairie as the lawmaker who had stood up to the bathroom-bill bullies on Meet the Nation in 2016 and fought every single winter for their buses, schools, and disability waivers, the corporate attack mailers against her hadn't stood a chance.

"Look at the margin in Kempsville and around CCHR, Katie," I said, my voice catching as the green rows populated down my screen at 7:54 PM. "You're carrying your home Eighty-Fifth House precincts by twenty-two points—Andre Askew just won your House seat right on your coattails—and you're winning the Bayside, Pembroke, and eastern Norfolk precincts by eleven points!"

Ten minutes later, at 8:04 PM, the statewide television monitors mounted above the headquarters room chimed in unison.

First came the Seventh Senate District projection:

PROJECTED WINNER — 7TH SENATE DISTRICT: DEL. KATIE PRAIRIE (D-VIRGINIA BEACH) ELECTED TO THE SENATE OF VIRGINIA (55.8% – 44.2%).

And eighteen minutes after that, a roar went up across the room that rattled the storefront windows when the statewide banner flashed across the bottom of the screen:

BREAKING NEWS: DEMOCRATS FLIP CONTROL OF BOTH THE SENATE OF VIRGINIA AND THE VIRGINIA HOUSE OF DELEGATES.

Katie turned her head toward me, her eyes bright with tears as she threw her arms around my neck across our wheelchair armrests while Dad wrapped both of us in a bear hug from behind.

"No more watching our bills die across the rotunda, Nate," Katie whispered against my shoulder. "Our caucus isn't in the minority anymore. Come January, I hold a committee gavel."

December 2019 to Wednesday, January 8, 2020 — The Custom-Milled Mahogany Ramp & Swearing In as Madam Chair

In the weeks between Election Night and the January 2020 Opening Day of the General Assembly, the transition from the House of Delegates to the Senate of Virginia looked very different from our first arrival in Richmond six years earlier.

After the Electoral Boards of the City of Virginia Beach and the City of Norfolk completed their official multi-locality canvass and the Virginia State Board of Elections transmitted Katie's gold-sealed Certificate of Election as Senator-Elect for the Seventh Senatorial District under Code of Virginia Section 24.2-675, Katie received a phone call at our home in Kempsville on the first Monday of December.

It wasn't from a mid-level facilities bureaucrat telling her to wait until March. It was from William, the veteran Clerk of the Senate of Virginia, calling personally alongside the newly elected Senate Majority Leader.

"Senator-Elect Prairie," the Clerk said warmly on speakerphone across our desk, "in the two-hundred-and-forty-year history of the Senate of Virginia, you are the very first State Senator ever elected to sit in our chamber in a wheelchair—and the

Majority Caucus has just designated you to serve as Chair of the Senate Committee on Rehabilitation and Social Services, as well as a senior member of Senate Transportation and Senate Finance. I want you and Nathaniel to ride up to the Capitol this week so our master architectural woodworkers can measure your SwiftChair in person. When you roll into the Senate of Virginia on January eighth, everything in our chamber is going to look like Thomas Jefferson built it for you himself."

Three days later, when Katie and I rode the morning ARTS train and the JRTC Route 6 bus up to Capitol Square and rolled into the second-floor Senate wing, the Clerk of the Senate was waiting for us with the Capitol's master cabinetmakers and historic preservation carpenters.

Inside the neoclassical Office of the Clerk of the Senate—where tall white marble Ionic columns framed the floor-to-ceiling volumes of the Virginia Acts of Assembly—the carpenters were already constructing a lowered, wheelchair-accessible section of the polished mahogany reception counter so Senator Katie Prairie could sign official Senate parchments and pre-file bills at eye level with me parked right beside her.

And inside the Senate of Virginia Chamber itself, under the tall arched windows and the crimson carpet of the forty-member upper house, the Clerk led us up to the front aisle where the senior committee chairs sat.

Not only had the cabinetmakers modified the front-aisle mahogany desk for the Chair of Rehabilitation and Social Services so Katie's compact SwiftChair rolled smoothly underneath the desktop without a single obstruction, they had also designed a permanent, custom-milled solid-mahogany wheelchair ramp leading directly up to the Clerk's well and the Senate dais—complete with matching turned mahogany balusters and brass handrails stained to the exact eighteenth-century patina of the chamber's historic woodwork.

"Look at the grain on that mahogany, Katie," I murmured as Katie tested the gentle one-in-twelve slope of the new Senate ramp in her SwiftChair and rolled effortlessly up to the Clerk's well. "Anyone looking down from the Senate gallery is going to assume that ramp has been part of this Capitol for two hundred years."

"And it's staying here for the next two hundred years," the Clerk of the Senate smiled.

On Opening Day—Wednesday, January 8, 2020, at twelve o'clock noon—after we had unpacked our familiar winter-session sanctuary at Apartment 104 of the Broad & Boulevard Lofts on West Broad Street the weekend before and ridden the eastbound JRTC Route 6 bus down to Ninth and Broad, thirty-four-year-old Katie rolled down the center aisle of the Senate of Virginia in her compact SwiftChair.

Because the second-floor Senate Chamber had a level ground-accessible entrance off the Capitol elevator lobby and allowed a Senator's immediate family onto the floor specifically for the Opening Day swearing-in ceremony, Dad sat beaming in his best suit in the front row of the Senatorial family section while I rolled my SwiftChair right up beside Katie's desk holding our bound leather copy of the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia.

Up on the high marble rostrum, the Lieutenant Governor of Virginia—serving under the state constitution as President of the Senate—called the forty Senators-Elect forward to take the constitutional oath of office under Article II, Section 7 of the Constitution of Virginia.

Rolling smoothly up the newly installed custom-milled mahogany ramp to the front well with me right beside her left armrest as her ceremonial guest, Katie didn't reach for a Bible while the opposition senators across the carpet held leather Bibles angled toward the press gallery cameras. Neither Katie nor I believed in any religion or any god, and just as she had done on the Virginia Beach City Council and in the House of Delegates, Katie placed her left palm squarely on the gold-stamped cover of the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia resting across my hands, raised her right hand toward the rostrum, and spoke the secular constitutional affirmation under Article II, Section 7 of the Constitution of Virginia and Section 49-9 of the Code of Virginia—omitting the optional parenthetical religious phrase at the end:

"I do solemnly affirm that I will support the Constitution of the United States, and the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia, and that I will faithfully and impartially discharge all the duties incumbent upon me as a member of the Senate of Virginia, according to the best of my ability."

Ten minutes later, after I rolled back out to the accessible viewing bay to watch the formal floor proceedings alongside Dad, the Clerk read the standing committee assignments for the 2020 session and handed Senator Katie Prairie the polished wooden gavel as Madam Chair of the Senate Committee on Rehabilitation and Social Services—sitting right across the chamber from the exact seats where Senator Franklin Ward and his allies had killed her transit and disability bills twenty-two months earlier.

And just as we knew they would, the Republican caucus, right-wing cable networks, and evangelical media had an absolute field day over both what was resting under Katie's left hand and the four words she had deliberately left out of her oath.

Before the Senate had even gaveled out of its Opening Day ceremonial session at two-thirty that afternoon, an opposition party operative up in the press gallery had blasted out a zoomed-in video clip of Katie's left hand resting on the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia instead of a Bible while she said "I do solemnly affirm" and stopped at "according to the best of my ability" without saying "so help me God." Within forty-five minutes, the opposition party's state committee had sent out a breathless statewide fundraising email accusing the newly minted committee chair from Virginia Beach of "refusing to touch a Holy Bible or say 'So help me God' on the floor of Thomas Jefferson's Capitol." Conservative talk-radio switchboards from Richmond to Tidewater were melting down, right-wing cable pundits on Beacon News and LibertyMax were running red "WAR ON FAITH IN VIRGINIA" banners across the bottom of the screen, and back home in Virginia Beach—just five minutes down Indian River Road from our house in Kempsville—the televangelist hosts of *The 777 Circle* on the Covenant Broadcasting Network were interrupting their afternoon broadcast to warn viewers that their own hometown State Senator had "defied the sacred oath precedent set by George Washington in 1789."

When Katie, Dad, and I rolled out of the mahogany doors of the Senate Chamber into the Capitol Rotunda at two-forty-five, camera crews from Beacon News, LibertyMax, and the Covenant Broadcasting Network were waiting in ambush beside Thomas Jefferson's marble statue.

"Senator Prairie! Senator Prairie!" the Beacon News correspondent called out, thrusting a microphone toward Katie's lap tray alongside a reporter holding a Covenant Broadcasting Network mic flag while two opposition state senators lingered behind the marble columns to watch the ambush. "The Republican state chairman and the hosts of *The 777 Circle* back in your own district in Virginia Beach just condemned you for refusing to place your hand on a Holy Bible and refusing to say 'So help me God' during your Senate swearing-in today! Why did you break the precedent that President George Washington set at the founding of our country?"

Katie braked her SwiftChair on the black-and-white marble tiles beneath Thomas Jefferson's statue, looked straight into the cluster of television lenses without a flicker of hesitation, and picked up the leather-bound volume off my lap tray so the gold seal of the Commonwealth gleamed under the camera lights.

"First of all, I would gladly encourage the hosts of *The 777 Circle* down on Indian River Road—and my Republican colleagues hiding behind those marble columns—to actually read the Constitution of the United States, the Constitution of Virginia, and a basic history book," Katie answered, her voice calm, crisp, and loud enough to echo across the entire Capitol Rotunda. "Let's start with the law. Article VI, Clause 3 of the United States Constitution states in black and white that all state legislators shall be bound by Oath or Affirmation to support the Constitution, and that no religious test shall ever be required as a qualification to any office or public trust under the United States. And right here in Article II, Section 7 of the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia—the exact document I placed my left hand on today—the framers put the words 'or affirm' and 'so help me God' inside parentheses, paired with Section 49-9 of the Code of Virginia, specifically so citizens who do not subscribe to a religion can make a solemn, binding secular affirmation without being subjected to an unconstitutional religious test."

The Covenant Broadcasting Network reporter opened his mouth to interrupt—"But George Washington himself added 'So help me God' in 1789—"

"No, he didn't—and historians debunked that myth decades ago," Katie cut in smoothly, her literal, encyclopedic memory firing on all cylinders as the cameras rolled live. "Even the Presidential Oath written by the Founders in Article II, Section 1, Clause 8 of the United States Constitution does not contain the words 'So help me God.' Not a single eyewitness, diary, newspaper, or foreign diplomat standing at Federal Hall in New York on April 30, 1789 recorded George Washington adding 'So help me God' to his oath. That story was invented out of thin air sixty-five years later in an 1854 book written by Rufus Wilmot Griswold, who wasn't even born when Washington was alive, and the first President confirmed by contemporary historical records to have said those words was Chester A. Arthur in 1881. And look at whose marble statue we are standing under right now: Thomas Jefferson, who wrote the Virginia Statute for Religious Freedom right here in Richmond declaring that our civil rights have no dependence on our religious opinions."

Behind the marble columns, the two opposition senators suddenly found something very interesting to look at on their shoes as Katie lowered the Constitution back onto my lap tray and added one final, unbothered smile for the cameras:

“In the Seventh Senate District across Virginia Beach and Norfolk, I represent Christians, Jews, Muslims, Hindus, Buddhists, and non-religious citizens like my brother and me alike. I wasn’t elected to be anybody’s pastor, and Virginia is a constitutional republic, not a theocracy. My legal obligation as a State Senator is to the Constitution of the United States and the Constitution of Virginia—and if the pundits screaming on Beacon News, LibertyMax, and *The 777 Circle* spent half as much time reading the Constitution as they spend inventing phony history lessons about George Washington, maybe they’d know what Article VI actually says. Now if you’ll excuse my brother, my dad, and me, we have a Route 6 bus to catch on Broad Street and a committee docket to gavel in tomorrow morning.”

The Senator from Virginia

Election Night, The Decision Desk Call, & The Referendum Mandate

Part 1: Polls Close at Seven, The 8:42 PM Decision Desk Call, & Victory in Virginia Beach

Date: 2026-11-03 at 19:00 America/New_York

Tuesday, November 3, 2026, 7:00 PM — Polls Close & The PHP Precinct Dashboard in Virginia Beach

“Seven o’clock on the dot—polls are officially closed across the Commonwealth of Virginia,” our sixty-eight-year-old dad said, setting three tall paper cups of ice-cold ginger ale down on the folding table beside my MagnaBook Pro inside the quiet green room behind the Virginia Beach convention ballroom. “How fast is the State Board of Elections JSON endpoint pushing the early-vote abstracts tonight, Nate?”

“Refreshing every fifteen seconds, Dad,” I replied, tapping a keyboard shortcut to refresh the custom PHP precinct-aggregation dashboard I had coded on my laptop while Katie rolled her compact silver-and-black SwiftChair power wheelchair flush against my left armrest and laced her fingers through mine.

Through the closed double doors at the end of the carpeted hallway, we could already hear six hundred supporters packing the ballroom floor—Coastal Virginia Transit Authority bus drivers still wearing their navy uniform jackets after finishing their afternoon shifts, community college students from CCHR, shipyard mechanics from Newport News, and nearly two dozen fellow wheelchair users who had ridden the evening bus pulse in from across Hampton Roads because they knew our campaign had picked a venue right on a regular bus line with a permanent, wide stage ramp.

Looking at the clean, color-coded precinct tables rendering on my laptop screen, Katie let out a quiet breath and rested her temple against my shoulder for two seconds.

Twenty-nine years had passed since the autumn of 1997, when Katie and I were twelve-year-old seventh graders at Morrison Middle School learning how to write raw HTML tags by hand in a plain text editor. Back then, watching his two autistic twelve-year-old twins stay up past supper building multi-page HTML websites from scratch had lit a fire under our dad—inspiring him to enroll at the Community College of Hampton Roads so he could earn his computer science degree and build a better life for the three of us. Four years later, during the summer and autumn of 2001—the year of our ill-fated Caribbean cruise on the *Sunward Tropics* and the September Friday when the borrowed time in our legs finally ran out—Katie and I had sat side by side reading Dad's mylar-wrapped *Quantum Basic 5.0* library textbooks cover to cover so we could learn *Quantum Basic 6.0* right alongside him. And from March 2007 to March 2008, the two of us had lived in the dorms at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center in Fishersville in the Web Applications Developer course, mastering PHP and database architecture right before buying our home in Kempsville fifty-fifty, filming our twenty-three-year-old *Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit* four-bus mayoral loop in 2008, and building websites and desktop applications for the next eighteen years.

Every single line of code running our statewide U.S. Senate campaign's turnout model tonight had been written by the two of us at our own desks—without a single K Street data consultant or Washington party contractor touching our servers.

"First batch of Hampton Roads and Richmond early-vote precincts just dropped," I said at 7:18 PM as the green table rows populated down my screen. "Katie, look at Virginia Beach, Norfolk, and Chesapeake. You're outrunning the 2024 baseline by nine points in Kempsville and eleven points along the Military Highway Route 15 corridor."

"What about the Peninsula and the Shenandoah Valley?" Katie asked, leaning closer as her blue eyes tracked the numbers line by line.

"Newport News around Peninsula Commons Mall just came in at seventy-one percent for you, Williamsburg is running fourteen points ahead of projections, and Augusta County right around Fishersville and Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center is giving us the highest Democratic margin in twenty years," I said, my voice catching as the next wave of JSON packets streamed in from the New River Valley. "And look at Montgomery County and Christiansburg—the student and faculty precincts around Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute just reported. You're carrying Blacksburg and Christiansburg by thirty-eight points."

Dad adjusted his glasses, leaning over our shoulders as he looked at the four wall-mounted television monitors tuned to Global News Network, GBS News, Beacon News, and the statewide public television desk.

"Remember back in May when Senator Martin Warren's chief of staff told the newspapers that two software developers in wheelchairs riding public buses could never beat the party establishment's handpicked nominee in the June primary?" Dad asked with a quiet, wry smile.

“They thought politics belonged to the people who wrote the biggest checks at Washington cocktail parties,” Katie said softly, squeezing my hand across our wheelchair armrests. “They forgot that the people riding the bus vote too.”

Tuesday, November 3, 2026, 8:42 PM — The Decision Desk Call & Three Constitutional Amendments Pass

At twenty minutes past eight, the raw precinct feeds from Northern Virginia—Alexandria, Arlington, Fairfax, and Prince William County—flooded into our PHP database all at once.

I watched the statewide mathematical regression curve on my terminal window cross the ninety-nine-point-nine percent confidence threshold before any television anchor on the wall monitors even opened their mouth.

“Nate?” Katie whispered, seeing my fingers freeze over my mechanical keyboard.

I turned my head and looked straight into my forty-one-year-old twin sister’s blue eyes.

“He can’t catch you, Katie,” I said softly, my throat tightening. “Even if he won seventy percent of every remaining uncounted precinct west of Interstate 81, our leads in Hampton Roads, Richmond, the CPI corridor, and Alexandria are mathematically insurmountable. You just won the United States Senate seat.”

Ten seconds later, at 8:42 PM Eastern Standard Time, a sharp orchestral chime rang out simultaneously from all four television monitors on the green room wall.

On the center screen, the red-and-blue map of Virginia flashed bright gold as the banner across the bottom of the broadcast changed in bold white letters:

GNN DECISION DESK — PROJECTED WINNER: STATE SEN. KATIE PRAIRIE (D-VIRGINIA) ELECTED TO THE UNITED STATES SENATE.

Right beside it, the GBS Evening Report, Beacon News, and the Associated Wire flashed the exact same call within five seconds of one another.

Outside in the main ballroom, a roar went up so loud it rattled the framed pictures on the green room drywall—six hundred voices cheering, stomping, and chanting Katie’s name while air horns and applause echoed down the corridor.

Inside our quiet room, Katie didn’t look at the television screens first. She turned her wheelchair slightly toward me, threw both arms around my neck across our armrests, and buried her face against my shoulder while Dad wrapped both of his arms around the two of us from behind.

“We did it, Nate,” Katie whispered against my collar, her voice thick with tears. “From the Route 15 bus stop on Military Highway all the way to the United States Senate.”

“Every single mile together, Senator,” I whispered back, holding my twin sister tight while Dad kissed the top of her blonde hair and wiped his eyes behind his glasses.

When Katie sat back and wiped her cheeks with the back of her hand, she looked back at my MagnaBook Pro screen, where the three statewide ballot referendums and the local city question were finishing their final tallies.

“Tell me about the three Constitutional Amendments, Nate,” Katie said immediately. “Did all three pass?”

“Every single one of them just crossed the projection threshold with statewide YES majorities,” I told her, pointing to the three green confirmation banners at the bottom of our PHP dashboard. “Question 1—the Right to Reproductive Freedom Amendment—just passed by twelve points. Question 2—the Marriage Equality Amendment repealing the old 2006 ban and locking affirmative marriage rights into the Constitution of Virginia—passed by fifteen points. And Question 3—automatic Restoration of Voting Rights upon completion of a prison term—just passed by nine points. Everything you co-patroned and voted for across the 2025 and 2026 General Assembly sessions in Richmond is officially part of the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia.”

Katie closed her eyes for a heartbeat, nodding with deep, quiet satisfaction. “Then every single oath I ever swore on the Constitution of Virginia was worth it.”

“Wait—what’s that red banner on the local municipal tab at the bottom?” Dad asked, pointing toward the lower right corner of my screen.

I scrolled down two inches to the local municipal referendum tally—the one-percent local retail sales tax dedicated strictly to public school construction and major facility modernization, which the General Assembly had authorized cities and counties to put before their voters tonight. Remembering the aging classrooms and accessibility hurdles at Northwood High School when our legs gave out in September 2001, Katie and I had both campaigned hard for a YES vote and marked YES on our own ballots in Kempsville.

“The local one-percent school construction sales tax referendum failed,” I said quietly, reading the certified precinct totals across the city. “The NO vote carried fifty-four to forty-six. Between grocery inflation and utility bills, working families just didn’t have the stomach for another one-percent sales tax at the cash register.”

Katie stared at the red NO tally for a long moment, her jaw setting with that familiar, unshakeable resolve I had known since we were children.

“I respect the voters’ decision—working families are stretched thin right now, and nobody likes paying higher sales tax,” Katie said evenly. “But the roofs on our public schools still leak, and disabled kids in wheelchairs still get stuck behind broken school elevators. If local taxpayers can’t shoulder that burden through a sales tax, then my job in the United States Senate starting in January is to bring federal school infrastructure and IDEA modernization grants straight home to Virginia.”

Tuesday, November 3, 2026, 9:15 PM — The Ramp to the Podium & A Toast With Three Glasses of Ginger Ale

At five minutes past nine, Katie’s smartphone vibrated on the table beside her cup of ginger ale.

It was the Republican nominee calling from his hotel suite in Henrico County to concede the race. The call lasted less than ninety seconds—stiff, formal, and clipped—and when Katie thanked him politely and tapped the red end-call button, the ballroom coordinator knocked on our door with a wide grin.

"Senator-Elect Prairie?" the coordinator beamed. "The crowd out there hasn't stopped chanting for thirty minutes. Are you three ready?"

"All three of us," Katie said, checking that the small gold Seal of Virginia pin was straight on her royal-blue blazer lapel before reaching her left hand across to take mine.

As the double doors swung open and the spotlight beams swept across the base of the wide, gently sloped aluminum stage ramp, Katie and I nudged our right thumbs forward on our SwiftChair joysticks and rolled side by side up onto the ballroom stage with Dad walking proudly on his own two feet right beside Katie's chair.

Above our heads, a shower of blue and gold paper confetti drifted down under the stage lights while the giant projection screen behind us blazed with the GNN Decision Desk banner proclaiming Katie Prairie the newest United States Senator from Virginia.

Looking out across the cheering sea of faces—seeing the CVTA bus operators waving their caps in the front row, the CCHR students holding handmade signs, and the kids in power wheelchairs lined up along the accessible front aisle looking up at a United States Senator whose chair looked just like theirs—Katie squeezed my hand tightly in front of the cameras before rolling two feet forward to the lowered podium microphone.

"Eighteen years ago, my twin brother Nate and I sat at the bus loop at the Community College of Hampton Roads waiting to see if a single candidate for local office would ride four buses across Virginia Beach with us," Katie's voice rang out clear and steady across the ballroom speakers. "We learned that day that if working people, transit riders, and disabled Virginians couldn't even catch a bus home from a six o'clock City Council meeting before the last Route 12 left CCHR at 5:48 PM, nobody was going to hand us a seat at the table—we were going to have to roll up the ramp and build that table ourselves! Tonight, you proved that the Commonwealth of Virginia doesn't belong to billionaire donors or Washington party gatekeepers. You enshrined reproductive freedom, marriage equality, and voting rights directly into the Constitution of Virginia, and on January third, Nate, Dad, and I are taking the morning train up from Norfolk to bring your voices straight to the floor of the United States Senate!"

An hour later, after shaking every hand along the front Rope Line without a single drop of champagne anywhere near our stage, the three of us sat together in the quiet green room while the crew coiled the microphone cables outside.

Raising our three paper cups of ice-cold ginger ale—the exact same toast we had kept since New Year's Eve when we were seventeen years old, and the only drink compatible with the daily maintenance medication that kept all three of us alive—Dad, Katie, and I tapped our rims together in the center of the room.

"To the Senator from Virginia," Dad said softly.

“To the three of us,” Katie replied, smiling across at Dad and me. “Now let’s go home to Kempsville and get some sleep—because tomorrow morning the real work starts.”

Part 2: The Morning After in Kempsville, The School Tax Referendum, & Jess’s Open Letter on The Grid

Date: 2026-11-04 at 08:30 America/New_York

Wednesday, November 4, 2026, 8:30 AM — Kempsville Morning, Morning Medications, & The Failed School Construction Referendum

“Pills first before anybody touches a keyboard or answers a press call,” Dad said cheerfully at eight-thirty on Wednesday morning, setting the fresh glass carafe of dark-roast coffee down beside the three amber prescription bottles lined up on the roll-under oak breakfast table of our Kempsville kitchen.

Sunlight streamed through the white-trimmed kitchen window onto the hardwood floor of the Virginia Beach house that Katie and I owned fifty-fifty—the house we had bought with the income from our PHP websites and desktop software, where both of our names sat side by side on the City of Virginia Beach deed, and where we were registered to vote. On the warm cream wall right behind our breakfast table hung the framed watercolor print of a blue butterfly that had watched over our sibling sanctuary since childhood.

Wearing a soft lavender fleece zip pullover instead of her Senatorial suit jacket, forty-one-year-old United States Senator-Elect Katie Prairie unscrewed her amber pill bottle, tapped her morning maintenance tablet into her palm, and washed it down with half a glass of ice-cold ginger ale right as Dad and I took ours.

Across the bottom of every one of our three prescription bottles sat the bright red pharmacy auxiliary warning label reminding us that mixing the medication with alcohol or tobacco carried a known side effect of death. Even if Katie and I hadn’t already sworn off alcohol for life behind a locked bedroom door during our cousin Brittany’s drunken New Year’s Eve party back on December 31, 2002, those three amber bottles meant that on the morning after winning a United States Senate seat, our kitchen smelled like toasted bagels, hot black coffee, and cold ginger ale—with zero hangovers in sight.

As Dad stood beside the table pouring fresh black coffee into his ceramic mug while Katie and I had our cold glasses of ginger ale in front of us—since neither of us had ever liked the taste of coffee—Katie reached her right hand across the table corner to hold my left hand while we looked together at the screen of our open MagnaBook Pro laptop.

“I just pushed your official morning-after statement on the local one-percent school construction sales tax referendum to our press feed,” I told her, glancing over the clean HTML markup before hitting publish.

On the screen sat the exact words Katie had dictated five minutes after rolling out of our bedroom:

I respect the voters' decision at the ballot box—working families are stretched thin, and nobody likes paying higher sales tax. But the roofs on our public schools still leak, and disabled students still face broken elevators. If local taxpayers can't shoulder that burden through a sales tax, then my job in the United States Senate is to bring federal infrastructure dollars home to Virginia so our kids have safe, modern, accessible schools without squeezing local families.

"The Republican campaign committee already put out a press release at eight o'clock claiming voters repudiated 'tax-and-spend Katie Prairie' because you voted YES on the school referendum," Dad noted, taking a sip from his coffee mug.

"Let them spin all they want, Dad," Katie replied calmly. "We just won the United States Senate race by nine points and passed all three Virginia Constitutional Amendments on the exact same ballot. Telling the truth about why I voted YES—and promising to fight for federal school modernization grants so local homeowners and grocery shoppers don't get squeezed—is why voters trust us in the first place."

Wednesday, November 4, 2026, 9:45 AM — Jess's Open Letter on The Grid & The Ironclad Prenup Mandate

At quarter to ten, while I was checking the morning analytics on our shared network of websites and monitoring the post-election commentary across The Grid, a text post shared by thousands of grassroots Virginia and national voters caught my eye at the top of our feed.

"Katie," I said, sliding the MagnaBook Pro two inches closer to the center of the table so she could read the screen clearly. "Look at this open letter to the national party that's going viral on The Grid this morning. Somebody named Jess posted it an hour ago, and forty thousand people have already shared it."

Katie leaned forward in her SwiftChair, her eyes moving down the paragraphs on the screen. After the third sentence, she began reading the post aloud across our kitchen table in a quiet, electric voice:

"She says: *Recognize that we did this largely despite the Establishment Dems, not because of them… Take the words 'compromise' and 'working with our friends across the aisle' out of your vocabulary. If the last ten years have taught us anything, it's that we have no friends across the aisle. This is what an actual referendum looks like. Use it. Don't just glue what they broke back together. Re-envision it. Re-engineer it. Don't try to take us back to where we were; take us where we always promised we could be.*"

Dad stopped by the counter with the coffee carafe in his hand, listening intently as Katie kept reading down the screen:

"*Codify all of it. Act like you're headed into your second marriage after a messy divorce and you're writing a pre-nup. Make it iron-clad. Irrefutable. Include every last detail down to who gets the coffee filters. I mean All of it. Release the trafficker files. If you or your friends or colleagues or benefactors are in them, too bad. You abuse children, you're done. That's how this works now. Prove that 'no' means 'no' again. That includes the 'no' in the sentence 'No one is above the law.'*"

Katie's fingertips tightened around the edge of the oak table as she read the final paragraphs aloud:

"*Remember that DEI stands for Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion and then DEI the crap out of the Capitol. No apologies, no excuses. The people leading this country should look like the country they serve, not the billionaires who own them. Trust that they will continue to play dirty. That when, come January, the repercussions of their so-called 'big beautiful bill' begin to rain down on the folks who were bamboozled into thinking that it would somehow make their lives better, they will blame you. Without logic, without rhyme nor reason, they will say it's your fault that their bill is hurting people. They will lie. Because that is what they do. Get ahead of it. Be proactive. Educate. Call out the lies. Bring receipts. Take questions, hold press conferences and town halls… And then get to work. Do EVERYTHING that we sent you there to do. All of it. Shy away from nothing. Blinders on, elbows out, unshakable principles leading the way.*"

For ten full seconds after Katie finished reading, the kitchen was completely quiet except for the morning birds outside in our Kempsville oak trees.

"I have no idea who Jess is," Katie said slowly, looking from the laptop screen up at Dad and me with a fire in her blue eyes that reminded me of the afternoon in January 2016 when she took the microphone in the House General Laws Subcommittee in Richmond and obliterated the bathroom bill in three minutes flat. "But she just wrote my entire six-year Senate playbook."

"Every single word of it," I agreed, opening a fresh Markdown document in Quantum Code right beside our browser window to save the text. "Look at what she said about not just gluing what they broke back together, but re-engineering it and codifying it like a prenup before a second marriage after a messy divorce—down to who gets the coffee filters. That is literally how we write software, Katie. Unwritten Washington 'norms' and gentlemen's agreements are just unpatched security vulnerabilities waiting for a bad actor to exploit."

"And as Virginia's new United States Senator, I am going to patch every single one of them into black-letter federal statute," Katie said firmly. "Because federal anti-nepotism law under Title 5, Section 3110 of the United States Code bars a Member of Congress from putting a sibling on a paid government payroll—and because neither of us would ever want you answering to a government bureaucracy anyway—you're staying a private citizen, earning our living through our fifty-fifty software business, and sitting right beside me in Dirksen as my unpaid chief data strategist while I hold the Senate seat and cast the votes on the floor. The national party establishment tried to block my candidacy in the June primary because they wanted a polite corporate insider who wouldn't rock the boat. I won this Senate seat despite them, not because of them. When we take the train up to Washington on January third, I am not going up there to water down my bills to appease bullies who voted to strip healthcare and disability rights from people on the bus."

She tapped her finger on the table beside her glass of ginger ale, counting off her Senatorial mandate right across our kitchen table.

"I will sponsor bills to codify reproductive freedom, marriage equality, voting rights, wheelchair right-to-repair, and repealing the SSI and Medicaid disability marriage penalty down to the last statutory comma—down to who gets the coffee filters," Katie declared. "I will use my vote in the Senate to demand the full, unredacted release of the federal child-trafficking files, and I don't care whose billionaire

donors or political friends are named in them—you abuse children, you're done, and no one is above the law. I will put Diversity, Equity, Inclusion, and Accessibility at the front door of my Senate office so Capitol Hill looks like the working people, transit riders, wheelchair users, and neurodivergent thinkers I was elected to serve. And before the delayed January fallout of the opposition's prior 'big beautiful bill' hits working families and they try to lie and blame us for their own law, you and I are going to build a live public receipts dashboard in PHP and ride local public transit to town halls across every corner of Virginia to show voters the exact roll-call votes and effective dates."

Dad smiled proudly, setting his coffee mug down on the counter. "Blinders on, elbows out?"

"Blinders on, elbows out, Dad," Katie grinned, squeezing my hand across our armrests. "Now let's look at the sixty-day transition calendar between today and January third—because we've got an orientation in Washington next week, a State Board of Elections certification on December seventh, a official Senate website vendor to audit, and a State Senate seat in Richmond I have to formally resign before we can board that five o'clock morning train to Alexandria."

The Minified ZIP File, The Raw HTML Takedown, & Resigning from Richmond

Part 1: The Minified ZIP Trick, Barely Commented Code, & The Live WCAG Takedown

Date: 2026-12-11 at 10:00 America/New_York

Friday, December 11, 2026, 10:00 AM — Static MagnaPad Slides & The Minified ZIP Trick in Dirksen

"You don't need to worry your head about the technical weeds, Senator-Elect—our engineering team in Rosslyn handles all the magic behind the curtain! Just tell us if you like this shade of Senate navy blue on the banner!"

Sitting across the polished mahogany conference table in our temporary transition suite in the Dirksen Senate Office Building, Bradford Vance—the Senior Account Director for Capitol Digital Solutions, one of the beltway IT contractors approved by the Office of the Senate Sergeant at Arms to build official United States Senate constituent websites—beamed with patronizing self-satisfaction as he tapped a static PDF slide deck on his MagnaPad tablet. Beside him sat his junior project manager, Evan, while a black triangular conference speakerphone sat in the center of the table with their lead developers dialed in live from their Rosslyn office across the Potomac.

Four days earlier, on Monday, December 7, the Virginia State Board of Elections had met in Richmond under Code of Virginia Section 24.2-679 to formally certify the November 3 general election results, and the Governor had transmitted Katie's signed Certificate of Election to the Secretary of the United States Senate.

Now, on Friday morning, Katie and I had ridden the morning ARTS train up from Norfolk, detrained on the mobile lift at Alexandria to drop our overnight bags at Dad's two-story brick house on Sunset Drive—where our newly installed interior vertical platform wheelchair lift was already humming smoothly between the first floor and our upstairs three-desk office in Bedroom 4—and taken the Capital Transit Yellow Line across the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge into the District for our ten o'clock website sign-off meeting.

Under United States Senate Internet Services rules, a Senator's official government constituent website had to be strictly separated from our campaign website, which Katie and I had coded ourselves in PHP, and hosted inside the Sergeant at Arms environment using an approved vendor template.

Watching Bradford talk down to my forty-one-year-old twin sister in the exact overly bright, sing-song voice that non-technical consultants often used when they saw two adults sitting in compact SwiftChair power wheelchairs, I didn't say a word. I just kept my hands resting lightly beside my closed MagnaBook Pro and waited for Katie to lower the boom.

"I don't approve websites from static PDF pictures on a MagnaPad, Bradford," Katie said evenly, folding her hands in the lap of her royal-blue blazer without even glancing at his tablet screen. "Before I put my name on a federal domain that sixty thousand disabled veterans, blind commuters, and working families across Virginia are going to use to request constituent casework, my brother Nate and I want to audit the raw HTML, CSS, and JavaScript source code. Please have your build team on the speakerphone drop the staging repository onto our transition VLAN share folder right now."

Bradford blinked twice, his rehearsed sales smile flickering as he exchanged an amused glance with Evan. Clearly, he assumed some twenty-two-year-old campaign intern had fed the incoming Senator a technical buzzword to sound tough.

"Well, Senator-Elect, normally congressional offices just sign the design approval form and let our certified engineers handle the code," Bradford chuckled condescendingly, leaning toward the triangular speakerphone in the center of the table. "Trevor, are you and the build team hearing this in Rosslyn? The Senator-Elect wants to see a copy of the code before she signs off. Go ahead and drop a ZIP file of the build into her transition share drive so we can check that box."

Over the speakerphone, we heard a muffled snicker from the Rosslyn engineering bullpen—the unmistakable sound of developers who thought a United States Senator wouldn't know an HTML tag from a spreadsheet macro—followed by Trevor's voice:

"Sure thing, Brad. Give me ten seconds… alright, I just dropped *prairie-senate-prod-bundle.zip* into the Dirksen transition share folder for her."

Friday, December 11, 2026, 10:15 AM — "Why Is a U.S. Senator Speaking Our Exact Engineering Language?"

Katie and I opened the unbranded matte-aluminum lids of our two MagnaBook Pro laptops at the exact same second.

Without touching a mouse, I mounted the local Senate transition VLAN share in my MagnaOS terminal, unzipped *prairie-senate-prod-bundle.zip* into our shared workspace, and pushed the extracted directory straight across our local peer link to Katie's machine.

Beside me, Katie hit Command and Space, launched Quantum Code—QCode—and opened the extracted folder across two vertical editor panes.

Bradford's patronizing smile vanished the instant he saw the dark syntax-highlighted IDE panes snap open across both of our screens. "Wait… is that Quantum Code?"

Neither Katie nor I answered him, because both of us were staring at the three files Trevor had packed into the ZIP archive: *index.min.html*, *styles.min.css*, and *app.min.js*.

Every single file had been run through an aggressive production minifier. All line breaks, indentation, and whitespace had been stripped out, crushing thousands of lines of code into a single continuous horizontal wall of characters, with every JavaScript variable and function mangled into single-letter identifiers without a single source map in the directory.

Sitting in her SwiftChair, Katie's blue eyes narrowed to ice. She leaned six inches forward toward the black triangular speakerphone in the center of the mahogany table.

"Trevor," Katie said, her voice cutting through the speakerphone mesh with razor-sharp precision. "Did your build team seriously just send a United States Senator-Elect a webpack-minified production bundle with stripped whitespace, mangled single-letter AST identifiers, concatenated CSS rules, and zero source maps because you thought I wouldn't know the difference between compiled build artifacts and raw source code?"

Across the table, Bradford's jaw literally dropped open.

Over the speakerphone, the muffled background chatter in the Rosslyn engineering bullpen stopped dead. For four full seconds, the only sound coming through the speaker was stunned, ragged breathing.

"Uh… wait—who is this speaking?" Trevor stammered over the line, completely bewildered. "Brad, did the Senator-Elect bring an outside DevOps engineer from the Sergeant at Arms office into the room?"

"No, Trevor, this is Senator-Elect Katie Prairie speaking to you, and my twin brother Nate is sitting right beside me with the exact same minified garbage open in Quantum Code," Katie snapped. "I didn't ask for your minified production output. I asked for your raw, unminified source repository—the actual human-readable HTML templates, uncompiled stylesheets, and unminified JavaScript controllers before your bundler strips the tree. Drop the raw unminified repository into the VLAN folder in the next sixty seconds, or I am calling the Senate Sergeant at Arms contract officer to cancel your task order before lunch."

"Yes, ma'am—right away, Senator-Elect! Exporting the raw source branch right now!" Trevor blurted out over the speakerphone, his voice pitching up an octave as frantic keyboard clacking echoed from Rosslyn.

Across the mahogany table, a bead of sweat rolled down Bradford Vance's temple as he stared in utter disbelief at a forty-one-year-old Senator in a power wheelchair who had just dismantled his lead engineer in fluent full-stack developer shop talk.

Friday, December 11, 2026, 10:25 AM — Twin Fury Over Barely Commented Code & Every WCAG Failure in the Book

Forty seconds later, a new archive—*prairie-senate-raw-src.zip*—appeared in the network share.

I extracted the raw source tree in terminal, opened *header.html*, *casework-form.html*, *styles.css*, and *nav-controller.js* across my Quantum Code workspace, and glanced over at Katie as she opened the exact same files on her MagnaBook Pro.

The longer the two of us scrolled down those unminified files, the hotter our faces burned. Within two minutes, both Katie and I were flat-out furious.

"Nate, look at *nav-controller.js* and *casework-form.html*," Katie said, her voice vibrating with the cold, surgical fury of a senior software architect who had just uncovered fraud. "There are almost no code comments in this entire repository!"

"Four thousand two hundred lines of unminified HTML, CSS, and JavaScript, and I just ran a grep across the whole source tree," I said angrily, leaning toward the speakerphone so Trevor and his entire Rosslyn team could hear every word. "You have exactly three inline comment lines in the entire project—and one of them on line eighty-four of *nav-controller.js* literally says *TODO: fix keyboard trap later* dated four years ago! There isn't a single architectural block comment at the top of your files, zero function docblocks explaining your state logic, and zero inline comments documenting your DOM event listeners. How is any developer supposed to maintain taxpayer-funded code that isn't even commented?!"

"And the reason you tried to hide it behind a minified ZIP file is even worse," Katie said, pointing her finger straight at her laptop screen while Bradford and Evan shrank back into their leather chairs across the table. "This website as written fails almost every single WCAG accessibility pointer there is!"

Over the speakerphone, Trevor tried to stammer a defense: "S-Senator-Elect, I assure you our template passed our internal visual QA check—"

"Don't you dare talk to me about a visual QA check when I am looking at your raw DOM tree line by line!" Katie fired back. "Let's start at the top of *header.html*. You have no skip-navigation link anywhere in the header, which violates WCAG 2.4.1 Bypass Blocks and forces every keyboard and switch user to tab through forty-two navigation links on every single page load. Your heading hierarchy jumps straight from an H1 banner title to an H4 subheader because your designer used heading tags for font sizing instead of semantic structure, violating WCAG 1.3.1 Info and Relationships. And look at line forty-seven of *header.html*!"

Katie read the offending markup aloud like a prosecutor reading an indictment into the federal record:

"You wrapped the entire *Help With a Federal Agency* constituent dropdown menu inside nested generic div tags with an inline *onclick* attribute—zero semantic button element, zero *aria-expanded* state, zero *aria-controls* binding, and no *tabindex*! Do

you know what that means? It means a blind veteran using a screen reader, or a quadriplegic Virginian navigating with a Sip-and-Puff switch or a keyboard Tab key, cannot even open the menu to ask their United States Senator for help with the VA!"

"And look at line one hundred twelve of *styles.css*," I added fiercely, scrolling my right-hand pane down the stylesheet. "Somebody on your team wrote a global wildcard rule setting focus outlines to *none* with an *!important* flag across the entire website! You literally stripped the visible keyboard focus ring off every link and form control on the page—a blatant violation of WCAG 2.4.7 Focus Visible and federal Section 508 law!"

"Wait until you hear what happens on *casework-form.html* at line two hundred four," Katie said grimly.

That page was the Federal Casework Privacy Act Release Form—the most important page on any Senator's website, where disabled constituents, seniors, and military families submit requests for help with delayed Social Security checks, Medicare power-wheelchair prior authorizations, and veterans' benefits.

"Instead of associating explicit HTML label elements with your form inputs using a *for* attribute, your developers just typed instructions into light-gray *placeholder* attributes colored hex 999999 on a white background—a 2.6-to-1 contrast ratio that fails WCAG 1.4.3 Contrast Minimum AND fails WCAG 3.3.2 Labels or Instructions," Katie said. "And because you stripped the labels, listen to what a blind constituent actually hears when they try to fill out your form."

Katie pressed Command and F5 on her MagnaBook Pro keyboard to turn on MagnaVoice—the built-in MagnaOS screen reader—turned her laptop speakers up to maximum volume right beside the conference speakerphone, and hit the Tab key four times.

Across the mahogany table and straight through the open speakerphone line into the Rosslyn engineering bullpen, the synthesized MagnaVoice voice echoed in the dead-silent room:

"Edit text, blank. Edit text, blank. Image, hero-banner-final-v3.jpg. Unlabeled button."

Nobody on the other side of the table or on the speakerphone dared to breathe.

Katie pressed Command and F5 to silence MagnaVoice and looked straight across the table at Bradford before addressing the speakerphone.

"S-Senator-Elect…" Trevor whispered over the speakerphone, sounding completely shell-shocked. "How on earth do you and your brother know how to audit raw unminified HTML, CSS specificity, DOM accessibility trees, and WCAG pointers like senior software engineers?"

"Because my brother Nate and I learned how to write raw HTML in seventh grade at Morrison Middle School back in 1997—which is what inspired our dad to go back to school at the Community College of Hampton Roads to earn his computer science degree," Katie said, her voice ringing with every year of our lives. "We learned Quantum Basic 6.0 alongside our dad in 2001, we attended Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center in Fishersville from March 2007 to March 2008 in the Web Applications Developer course where we mastered PHP, and we have spent the last eighteen years

building and maintaining production websites and desktop applications from these two wheelchairs! Did your company actually sign a federal VPAT certifying to the Senate Sergeant at Arms that this uncommented, inaccessible garbage complies with Section 508 of the Rehabilitation Act, or did you just assume a Senator in a wheelchair wouldn't know how to read your source code?"

Bradford swallowed hard, wiping his forehead with a linen handkerchief. "Senator-Elect, I… we will assign a remediation sprint immediately—"

"You don't need to assign a remediation sprint, because Nate and I don't trust your team to write clean code without supervision," Katie said, her fingers already flying across her mechanical laptop keyboard in tandem with mine. "Sit quietly for twenty-five minutes while we show you how professional Web Applications Developers write and document accessible code."

For the next twenty-five minutes, while Bradford and Evan sat frozen in their suits and the entire Rosslyn engineering bullpen watched our live screen-share in humbled silence, Katie and I refactored their core templates in Quantum Code. We replaced every non-semantic div dropdown with proper semantic HTML5 nav and button elements bound to clean ARIA state toggles, restored high-contrast focus-visible rings, bound explicit label elements and 4.5-to-1 contrast tokens to every single input on the constituent casework form, and padded the top of every file and every single logic block with comprehensive architectural block comments and inline WCAG explanations so any future developer could read and maintain it.

At 10:55 AM, I committed our changes to a clean Git patch file—*wcag-508-and-documentation-fixes.diff*—and pushed it straight back into the Rosslyn staging repository.

"Merge our pull request, apply that exact commenting and WCAG 2.2 AA standard to every remaining subpage in the repository, and have the unminified branch ready for our second inspection by Monday at noon," Katie told the speakerphone as she closed the lid of her MagnaBook Pro.

By the time Katie and I unlocked our wheelchair brakes and rolled out into the Dirksen corridor toward the Capital Transit elevator, word was already ripping through every IT vendor and Senate chief of staff on Capitol Hill: *Whatever you do, never send minified code, uncommented spaghetti, or a fake accessibility report to Senator Prairie's office—she and her brother will demand your raw unminified repo, open it in Quantum Code, and debug you live on speakerphone.*

Part 2: Article IV Section 4, Hand-Delivering Her Resignation in Richmond, & The Writ of Special Election

Date: 2026-12-15 at 14:00 America/New_York

Tuesday, December 15, 2026, 2:00 PM — The Clerk's Office of the Senate of Virginia & The Dual-Office Holding Ban

"It feels strange holding this envelope in my hand after twelve years in Capitol Square, Nate," Katie said quietly as our two compact SwiftChair power wheelchairs rolled side by side down the polished black-and-white marble corridor of the Virginia State Capitol in Richmond toward the mahogany doors of the Office of the Clerk of the Senate of Virginia.

Resting across my sister's lap on top of her leather portfolio was a heavy cream-parchment letter embossed with the gold seal of the Senate of Virginia and signed in her crisp blue fountain-pen script.

Under Article IV, Section 4 of the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia—as well as Code of Virginia Section 2.2-2800 and the Incompatibility Clause of Article I, Section 6 of the Constitution of the United States—no person holding any office under the United States government is permitted to hold a seat in either house of the Virginia General Assembly. Even more importantly to Katie, the 2027 Session of the Virginia General Assembly was scheduled to gavel in at noon on the second Wednesday in January—Wednesday, January 13, 2027, just ten days after her federal swearing-in in Washington.

If Katie had waited until January 3 to vacate her State Senate seat, the citizens of Virginia Beach and Chesapeake in her district would have been left with an empty chair on the floor of the Senate of Virginia during the opening weeks of the legislative session. By formally submitting her resignation today, on Tuesday, December 15, 2026, she was giving the Lieutenant Governor and the Governor of Virginia the legal window required under the Code of Virginia to immediately issue a Writ of Special Election for early January so her successor could be elected and seated on Opening Day in Richmond.

When we rolled through the tall wooden doorway into the neoclassical Clerk's Office—where white marble Ionic columns framed the floor-to-ceiling bookshelves of Virginia Acts of Assembly dating back to Thomas Jefferson's design—the gray-haired Clerk of the Senate stepped out from behind his high podium and walked straight over to the lowered, wheelchair-accessible mahogany counter that had been built during Katie's very first term in the upper chamber.

"Madam Chair," the Clerk said softly, his voice thick with genuine affection as he looked from Katie to me beside the blue Flag of the Commonwealth of Virginia. "Or I suppose in nineteen days I have to start calling you Senator Prairie of the United States Senate."

"In this building, William, you can just call me Katie," my sister smiled warmly, lifting the gold-sealed cream parchment letter from her lap and extending it across the accessible mahogany counter. "Pursuant to Article IV, Section 4 of the Constitution of Virginia, here is my formal signed letter resigning my seat in the Senate of Virginia, together with the duplicate copy for the Lieutenant Governor so the Writ of Special Election can be issued this afternoon."

With a respectful bow of his head, the Clerk accepted the parchment letter in both hands, stamped the official time and date of receipt onto the ledger copy, and handed the stamped receipt back across the counter to Katie.

“Twelve years between the House of Delegates and the Senate of Virginia, Katie,” the Clerk said, resting his hand over the signed parchment. “When you and Nate first rolled through the Bell Tower entrance in January of 2014, half the historic committee rooms in this Capitol complex didn’t even have flush thresholds or accessible turning radiuses, and nobody in Richmond thought a first-term Delegate from Virginia Beach could force a subcommittee to table its own bill with a single three-minute speech. This Capitol is a vastly fairer, more accessible house of the people because the two of you were here.”

“And we’re holding you to keeping every single ramp and every single late-night transit grant intact while we’re up in Washington, William,” Katie said, her blue eyes shining as she shook his hand across the mahogany counter.

Tuesday, December 15, 2026, 3:15 PM — One Last Roll Down the Senate Ramp & The Bus to Main Street Station

After leaving the Clerk’s Office, Katie and I took the elevator to the second floor and rolled quietly into the empty gallery aisle of the Senate of Virginia Chamber.

The afternoon December sunlight slanted through the tall arched windows across the crimson carpet and the forty mahogany desks of the upper chamber. Up at the front aisle, right beside the Committee on Rehabilitation and Social Services chair desk that Katie had occupied since January 2020, sat the permanent, custom-milled mahogany wheelchair ramp leading up to the Clerk’s well and the dais—installed so seamlessly into the historic woodwork that any visitor looking down from the Capitol gallery would assume it had always been there.

Sitting beside my sister in the quiet chamber, I reached across our armrests and took her left hand.

“Look at that ramp, Katie,” I said softly. “First the Virginia Beach City Council chamber at the Municipal Center in 2011. Then the House of Delegates subcommittees in 2014. Then the Senate of Virginia in 2020. And last month the carpenters in Washington finished widening your aisle and building the permanent ramp on the floor of the United States Senate.”

Katie looked at the mahogany ramp in front of her old desk, then turned her head to smile at me.

“Every time we had to fight for a ramp, Nate, people in suits acted like we were asking for a personal favor,” Katie said quietly. “We weren’t building those ramps just for me. We were building them so the next kid in a SwiftChair who rides a bus to a field trip at the Virginia State Capitol—or the United States Capitol—never has to sit at the bottom of a staircase wondering if the law belongs to them too.”

Twenty minutes later, after carrying the last cardboard banker’s box from her constituent office—holding nothing more than our framed copy of the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia and our twin blue hot-chocolate mugs—out the accessible basement entrance onto Bank Street, we didn’t call a state pool car or a limousine.

Just as we had done every winter session in Richmond for twelve years, United States Senator-Elect Katie Prairie and I rolled our two compact SwiftChairs half a block down the brick sidewalk to the regular JRTC public transit bus stop at Ninth

and Main, waited alongside the four o'clock state office clerks and hospital workers, rolled up the front bus ramp into the dual wheelchair bays, and tapped our fare cards for the seven-minute ride down the hill to Richmond Main Street Station to catch the evening ARTS train home to Norfolk.

First Train from Norfolk & Swearing In on the Constitution

Part 1: Three Business Class Tickets for Free Café Car Drinks & The Mobile Lift at Alexandria

Date: 2027-01-03 at 05:00 America/New_York

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 5:00 AM — Norfolk Station & Three Business Class Tickets for Free Café Car Drinks

"Make sure you keep your receipt folded in your wallet, Katie—that Business Class barcode gets the three of us unlimited free ginger ale and hot coffee out of the Café Car all the way up to Alexandria," our sixty-eight-year-old dad said with a grin at five o'clock in the morning, holding his leather garment bag in one hand as the uniformed ARTS station attendant finished cranking our second compact SwiftChair power wheelchair up the yellow mobile lift into the warm stainless-steel vestibule at Norfolk Station.

Outside on the low-level brick platform beside Harbor Park, the January predawn wind off the Elizabeth River was cold enough to turn our breath into white plumes under the station lamps. Inside the front end of the combined ARTS Business Class and Café Car, the air smelled like fresh-brewed dark roast coffee, warm baseboard heat, and polished vinyl headrests.

It was Sunday, January 3, 2027—Opening Day of the One Hundred Twentieth Congress of the United States. In exactly seven hours, at twelve o'clock noon in the Chamber of the United States Senate in Washington, D.C., my forty-one-year-old twin sister was going to raise her right hand and be sworn in as the newest United States Senator from the Commonwealth of Virginia.

Four days earlier, on Wednesday afternoon, a polite young protocol liaison from the Office of the Senate Sergeant at Arms had called our transition office in Virginia Beach to ask which flight Senator-Elect Katie Prairie was taking into Reagan National Airport, or whether Capitol Police needed to stage a black SUV motorcade at the VIP circular drive outside Washington Union Station.

Katie had looked across her desk at me, smiled, and given the young man the unvarnished truth.

"Neither," my sister had told him over the speakerphone. *"My brother Nate, my dad, and I are taking the first morning ARTS Northeast Regional train out of Norfolk at five o'clock in the morning."*

Because almost nobody inside the Washington beltway bubble could imagine a newly elected United States Senator navigating rail and subway transfers in a power wheelchair without a dozen handlers, every single person in the Sergeant at Arms

office—along with two dozen national television producers who caught wind of her travel plans—had automatically assumed she meant she was riding the train all the way to the end of the line at Washington Union Station.

They didn't know our dad, and they definitely didn't know Katie and me.

Two weeks after Election Night, when Dad had sat down at his kitchen table with his reading glasses on to book our rail tickets for Swearing-In Day on his own credit card, he hadn't booked us to Washington Union Station at all. He had purchased three regular passenger Business Class tickets from Norfolk to Alexandria—station code ALX—on the first train of the morning.

And as Katie and I locked the brakes of our two compact silver-and-black SwiftChair power wheelchairs side by side in the dual accessible bays at the front of the Business Class cabin while Dad hung her pressed royal-blue Senatorial suit bag on the luggage hook, neither one of us was thinking about VIP motorcades.

"First things first before we even cross the river into Suffolk," Katie said, her blue eyes crinkling with the exact same delight she had worn at sixteen on the aft deck of the *Sunward Tropics* with her souvenir soda tumbler as she held up her paper Business Class ticket stub. "Nate, are we getting our free Café Car ginger ales right now, or are we waiting until the conductor scans our tickets?"

"The Café Car attendant just rolled the security grille up on the counter thirty feet behind us," I replied, reaching across the gap between our armrests to squeeze my twin sister's hand as the diesel locomotive gave two low horn blasts and the train glided smoothly away from the Norfolk platform into the dark winter morning. "Let's go get our free ginger ales and Dad's black coffee right now so we get our money's worth before Petersburg."

Besides the promise Katie and I had made to each other behind a locked bedroom door on New Year's Eve when we were seventeen years old, all three of us—Katie, Dad, and I—took a daily prescription maintenance medication where mixing the drug with alcohol or tobacco carried a known, lethal side effect of death. Back in Richmond, and now in Washington, where lobbyists and senior lawmakers loved to clink glasses of expensive cabernet or pass around celebratory cigars in back rooms, that warning label on our pill bottles was our favorite conversational shield: nobody at a Capitol Hill reception ever tried to push a second glass of wine or a cocktail on a Senator after she cheerfully informed them that the known side effect of mixing it with her daily medication was dying on their carpet. For the three of us, cold ginger ale and hot black coffee from the ARTS Café Car were the only celebratory drinks we would ever need.

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 9:12 AM — Detraining on the Mobile Lift at Alexandria Union Station

"Next stop, Alexandria—ALX!" the conductor announced over the passenger intercom at ten minutes past nine as our Northeast Regional train slowed past the brick rowhouses and bare winter trees of Northern Virginia. "Passengers detraining at Alexandria, please step toward the vestibule doors. After Alexandria, our final stop will be Washington Union Station in approximately twenty-five minutes."

Up and down the aisle of the Business Class car, several lobbyists and congressional staffers in wool overcoats barely glanced up from their laptops, assuming every person dressed in a suit on a Sunday morning was staying aboard all the way into the cavernous concourse of Washington Union Station.

When Katie and I unlocked our wheelchair brakes, tucked our second round of complimentary Café Car paper cups into our armrest cupholders, and rolled toward the forward vestibule door with Dad walking right behind us carrying his garment bag as the train brakes hissed to a stop beside the low-level red-brick platform of Alexandria Union Station, two passengers in the front row did a sudden double-take over the rims of their coffee cups.

“Wait a second,” a woman in a camel wool coat whispered to her husband as the stainless-steel door slid open to the crisp forty-degree Virginia morning sunlight. “Isn’t that Senator-Elect Katie Prairie? Why on earth is she getting off here at Alexandria instead of riding into Union Station?”

Katie heard every word, and as she glanced back at me over her shoulder, the two of us shared a quiet, unmistakable twin grin.

There were two reasons we were getting off at Alexandria, and every single person who actually lived on the rails and buses of Virginia understood both of them by heart.

First, for two autistic forty-one-year-olds who had spent our entire lives managing sensory noise so we could stay sharp for the work that mattered, Washington Union Station was an echoing, cavernous sensory ambush—twenty tracks of screeching steel flanges under a vaulted ceiling, booming public-address announcements bouncing off marble columns, and a slow, twenty-five-minute train crawl across the Long Bridge and through the dark First Street Tunnel before you even reached the platform.

Here at Alexandria Union Station, right beneath the grassy slope of Shooter’s Hill and the stepped stone tower of the George Washington Masonic National Memorial, the 1905 Federal Revival red-brick depot was small, open-air, quiet, and calm.

Because Alexandria had a low-level red-brick platform rather than a high-level concrete deck, a uniformed ARTS station attendant was already waiting right beside the track, wheeling the yellow-and-silver portable ARTS Mobile Lift flush against the open Business Class doorway.

I rolled onto the steel platform of the mobile lift first. With a smooth hydraulic hum, the attendant lowered me three feet down from the train vestibule onto the herringbone red bricks of the Alexandria platform, where I backed clear and parked beside Dad, who had already walked down the vestibule steps onto the bricks.

Then the attendant raised the lift platform back up to the open doorway for the new junior Senator from Virginia.

Standing in the open doorway between our ARTS Business Class coach and the adjacent ARTS Café Car, the attendant held the yellow safety rail steady as Katie steered her compact SwiftChair onto the elevated metal platform, her royal-blue Senatorial blazer gleaming beneath her open navy wool winter coat. Down on the

red-brick platform, three morning commuters in winter jackets and knit caps stopped dead in their tracks, their eyes widening in disbelief as they recognized the woman descending on the hand-operated station lift.

“Morning, folks!” Katie called out warmly from the lift platform as the attendant lowered her smoothly down to the bricks beside my chair. “Beautiful morning for a train ride up from Norfolk, isn’t it?”

“Senator-Elect Prairie!” a commuter in a puffy down jacket stammered, pulling his smartphone out of his pocket with a huge grin as Katie rolled off the yellow ramp lip onto the red-brick platform right beside me. “Are you taking the train to your own swearing-in?!”

“Every single week the Senate is in session,” Katie replied cheerfully, reaching her left hand across the gap between our two wheelchairs to lace her fingers through mine while she held her plastic CapitalPass transit card ready in her right hand. “And my brother Nate and our dad wouldn’t miss the first ride for the world.”

As the ARTS train sounded its horn and pulled away northward toward the Potomac River—carrying twenty empty seats toward the television cameras and black government SUVs waiting in vain for us at Washington Union Station—Katie and I rolled side by side down the sunlit red-brick platform of Alexandria Union Station with Dad walking right beside us, leaving the railroad depot behind and following the outdoor brick pedestrian walkway over to the completely separate entrance of King Street–Old Town Metro Station.

Part 2: The Yellow Line Over the Fenwick Bridge, The Full-Chair Portrait, & Swearing In on the Constitution

Date: 2027-01-03 at 09:25 America/New_York

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 9:25 AM — King Street–Old Town & The Yellow Line Over the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge

“Excuse me—Senator-Elect Prairie!” a young man in a navy wool overcoat with a congressional staff ID lanyard around his neck called out as Katie and I rolled out of the platform elevator with Dad walking right beside us onto the elevated concrete island platform at King Street–Old Town Station. “If you’re heading to the Capitol for noon, don’t get on that train—that’s a Yellow Line train! The Blue Line on the other track goes straight to Capitol South without having to transfer!”

Katie and I looked at each other across our wheelchair armrests and laughed—the exact laugh of two people who had spent twenty-five years memorizing every route map, transfer pulse, and rail bridge from Coastal Virginia Transit Authority Route 15 on Military Highway to the Washington metropolitan grid.

“Sure, you can take the Blue Line straight through to Capitol South,” Katie told the young staffer warmly as the silver Capital Transit Yellow Line train glided up to the platform edge and its pneumatic doors chimed open level with the concrete sill. “If you want to take the long way all the way around through Crystal City, Rosslyn, and Foggy Bottom! We’re taking the Yellow Line straight across the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge to L’Enfant Plaza and hopping the Blue Line two stops to Capitol South. Come on—you’ll beat your Blue Line train to the Hill by twelve minutes!”

Blinking in surprise as he did the mental map calculation, the staffer grinned and stepped into the Yellow Line car right behind Dad as Katie and I rolled our two SwiftChairs into the center wheelchair bays.

Nine minutes later, right after our train sped past Reagan National Airport and the Pentagon, the tunnel walls fell away and our Yellow Line car burst out into the brilliant January morning sunlight high above the Potomac River on the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge.

Through the wide glass window beside our wheelchairs, the entire skyline of the capital opened up across the sparkling water: the white marble colonnade of the Jefferson Memorial in the foreground, the towering obelisk of the Washington Monument to the left, and straight ahead on Jenkins Hill, the cast-iron dome of the United States Capitol gleaming against the clear blue winter sky.

Right inside the middle of that span over the river, Katie's phone buzzed inside her coat pocket.

She glanced at the caller ID—*Office of the Senate Sergeant at Arms*—and tapped the speaker button just loud enough for Dad and me to hear over the rhythmic click of the welded rail joints beneath the bridge.

"Senator-Elect Prairie?" the protocol liaison's voice came through the speaker, breathless and slightly panicked. "Ma'am, I'm standing here with the Capitol Police detail and the press pool at Gate D inside Washington Union Station! The five o'clock ARTS train from Norfolk just pulled onto the track two minutes ago, and the conductor told us you got off the train back in Virginia! Are you alright? Do we need to send a car down the George Washington Parkway to pick you up?"

"Put your SUVs back in the garage, Marcus—we're completely fine," Katie said, her voice calm and ringing with good humor as our Yellow Line train glided off the north end of the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge and dove into the tunnel beneath Seventh Street toward L'Enfant Plaza. "Washington Union Station is way too loud and crowded for my brother and me, and the ARTS train takes twenty-five minutes just to crawl from Alexandria into the terminal. We got off on the mobile lift at Alexandria, walked over to King Street–Old Town, and rode the Yellow Line across the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge. We're pulling into the lower level at L'Enfant Plaza right now to catch the Blue Line two stops to Capitol South—we'll see you at the First Street entrance in ten minutes!"

When she tapped the screen to end the call, our dad chuckled, shaking his head as he braced one hand on the stainless-steel grab pole beside us.

"You two just outran a Capitol Police motorcade and twenty television vans on a three-dollar CapitalPass card," Dad said proudly.

"And we're going to keep doing it for the next six years, Dad," Katie said, looking from Dad to me as the doors opened at L'Enfant Plaza and we rolled smoothly out onto the lower-level platform toward the elevator up to the Blue Line track. "When we started *Ideas for Coastal Virginia Transit* back in 2008 and realized we couldn't even stay past five-thirty at the Virginia Beach Municipal Center for a six o'clock City Council meeting because the last Route 12 left CCHR at 5:48 PM, I promised myself I would never turn into one of those politicians who only sees Virginia through the tinted window of a town car. Every single time I visit constituents anywhere in the Commonwealth as their United States Senator—whether it's CVTA

back home in Hampton Roads, Blue Ridge Transit down at CPI in Blacksburg, or Capital Transit up here in Northern Virginia—we are riding that community's public transit system as part of the visit."

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 10:45 AM — "Nobody Crops My Powerchair Out of My Senate Portrait"

Fifteen minutes after our Blue Line train let us off at Capitol South and we rode the street elevator up to the sunny sidewalk at First and C Streets Southeast, Katie and I rolled through the bronze doors of the Russell Senate Office Building with Dad walking alongside us and headed up to the third-floor corner suite overlooking the Capitol grounds for Katie's official Senate photograph.

Inside the high-ceilinged room with its dark mahogany wainscot paneling and classical cream pilasters, the official Senate historical photographer had already positioned the United States Flag with its gold fringe to the left of the tall arched window and the deep blue Flag of the Commonwealth of Virginia to the right, framing the white dome of the Capitol in the morning light directly behind the center mark on the marble floor.

As Katie unbuttoned her heavy winter wool coat and handed it to Dad—revealing her tailored royal-blue Senatorial suit blazer with the small gold circular United States Senate pin gleaming on her left lapel—she steered her compact SwiftChair onto the tape mark between the two flags and rested her right hand naturally on her joystick controller.

Behind the studio umbrella lights, the photographer squinted through the viewfinder of his camera and immediately reached for the crank on his heavy aluminum tripod, raising the lens higher and zooming the barrel inward.

"Alright, Senator-Elect, let's bring the frame in nice and tight from the mid-chest up so we match the standard head-and-shoulders portraits down the corridor," the photographer said briskly. "If you could just fold your hands slightly higher near your lapel so the armrests don't—"

"Stop right there, please," Katie said—not unkindly, but with the unmistakable, quiet authority that had once silenced committee rooms in Richmond and bullies in the hallways of Northwood High School.

The photographer's hand froze on the zoom ring.

"Lower the tripod back down and step back six feet so the entire wheelchair is in the frame from my head down to the wheels and the footplate," Katie instructed him, sitting tall and poised between the two flags. "My twin brother Nate and I have rolled in these compact SwiftChairs from the moment we woke up until we went to bed since the third Friday of September in 2001 when we were sixteen years old. I didn't hide my wheelchair when I knocked on doors for Virginia Beach City Council, I didn't hide it in the House of Delegates or the Senate of Virginia, and nobody is cropping my powerchair out of my United States Senate portrait."

From the doorway beside Dad, I watched the photographer blink once, nod with genuine respect, lower his tripod to waist height, and step back across the marble floor until every inch of my sister's silver-and-black SwiftChair was framed proudly between the Stars and Stripes and the Seal of Virginia.

When the studio strobes flashed against the mahogany walls and Katie smiled straight into the lens with her right hand resting on her joystick controller, my throat tightened with a pride so fierce I could barely swallow.

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 12:00 PM — Swearing In on the Constitution of the United States of America

At two minutes before twelve o'clock noon—after riding the subterranean United States Capitol Subway together beneath Constitution Avenue—Dad and I took our places at the front brass railing of the Senate Family Gallery directly above the floor of the United States Senate Chamber.

Looking down from the gallery bay where my wheelchair brakes were locked beside Dad's polished dress shoes, I could see the entire semicircle of one hundred mahogany desks arranged across the blue carpet below us. On the far aisle of the Democratic side, the Sergeant at Arms carpenters had already modified Senator Katie Prairie's assigned mahogany desk—widening the aisle clearance and removing the fixed chair base so her compact SwiftChair rolled seamlessly beneath the desktop.

At precisely 12:00 PM, the heavy ivory gavel came down on the marble rostrum, calling the One Hundred Twentieth Congress of the United States to order.

As the Reading Clerk began calling the Newly Elected Senators forward to the well in alphabetical groups of four—*"Ms. Prairie of Virginia…"*—Dad reached over and gripped my shoulder with a steady, calloused hand.

In the span of three heartbeats, forty-one years of our lives flashed behind my eyes: two nine-year-old twins whispering our *Journey to the Sunlit Valley* cartoon password before unlocking the front door after school; two twelve-year-olds wearing matching maroon shirts on Twins' Day when a sixth-grade boy broke my sister's heart; two sixteen-year-olds learning in Dr. Carter's exam room that the borrowed time in our legs was almost gone; two seventeen-year-olds wedging a fifty-pound power wheelchair against the inside of a locked bedroom door on New Year's Eve while we ate dry toasted oat cereal out of a cardboard box to stay safe from a house full of drunks; and two twenty-three-year-olds holding a camcorder on a CVTA Route 15 bus crossing the Elizabeth River as we exposed why working people couldn't even catch a bus home from a six o'clock City Council meeting.

Down on the blue carpet of the Senate Chamber, Katie didn't need stairs. She nudged her right thumb forward on her joystick, rolled her compact SwiftChair smoothly down the newly installed permanent ramp along the chamber aisle into the well of the Senate, and raised her right hand toward the rostrum.

Fifteen minutes later, as the applause from the galleries echoed through the Capitol corridors, the elevator doors brought Dad and me down to the historic Old Senate Chamber for the individual ceremonial swearing-in with the Vice President of the United States.

Every time Katie had ever taken an oath of office back home in Virginia—first on the Virginia Beach City Council, then in the Virginia House of Delegates, and then in the Senate of Virginia in Richmond—she had famously refused to pretend to believe in a religion or a god that neither she nor I believed in, insisting instead on making a solemn secular affirmation on a bound copy of the Constitution of the Commonwealth of Virginia without saying "So help me God."

To my sister's clear, literal, fiercely principled mind, Article VI, Clause 3 of the United States Constitution explicitly guaranteed that Senators were bound by Oath or Affirmation and prohibited any religious test for public office—meaning her left hand belonged on the exact secular Constitution she was promising to defend, and not a single word of religious theater belonged in her mouth.

Now, as Dad and I positioned ourselves right beside her in the center of the crimson-and-gold Old Senate Chamber while the Vice President stepped up with the oath card, I held out the thick, gold-stamped navy leather volume Dad had bought for her at the National Archives gift shop that morning: *The Constitution of the United States of America*.

Having been notified in advance by our transition counsel under Article VI, Clause 3 of the Constitution, Title 5, Section 3331, and Title 1, Section 1 of the United States Code that Senator Prairie would be taking the secular affirmation of office without the optional religious phrase, the Vice President looked down at the card as Katie placed her left palm squarely on the gold lettering of *We the People* and raised her right hand high.

"Do you solemnly affirm that you will support and defend the Constitution of the United States against all enemies, foreign and domestic; that you will bear true faith and allegiance to the same; that you take this obligation freely, without any mental reservation or purpose of evasion; and that you will well and faithfully discharge the duties of the office on which you are about to enter?" the Vice President asked.

Katie's voice rang out clear, steady, and unshakeable across the historic chamber:

"I do solemnly affirm."

As the shutters of the Senate photographers clicked in a rapid burst of white light and the Vice President shook her hand—"Congratulations, Senator Prairie"—Katie turned her head toward me first.

Right there on the floor of the Old Senate Chamber, with the Constitution of the United States resting between our two compact power wheelchairs and our father's hands resting proudly on both of our shoulders, United States Senator Katie Prairie slipped her left hand across our armrests and laced her fingers tightly through mine.

Twenty minutes later, when the three of us rolled out onto the East Front plaza of the Capitol toward the Capital South Metro entrance, a wall of national television cameras from Beacon News, LibertyMax, and Virginia Beach's own evangelical flagship program *The 777 Circle* on the Covenant Broadcasting Network came rushing across the flagstones—breathlessly demanding to know why the new junior Senator from Virginia had affirmed her oath on the Constitution instead of a Christian Bible and omitted "So help me God" on national television.

Katie didn't roll past them. She stopped her SwiftChair right in front of the live satellite microphones, rested her hand on the navy leather cover of the United States Constitution on my lap tray, and smiled brightly into the lenses.

"I'm glad you asked, because it sounds like Beacon News, LibertyMax, and the folks at *The 777 Circle* back home on Indian River Road in Virginia Beach still haven't read the document I'm holding in my hand," Katie said clearly into the live network feeds. "Article VI, Clause 3 of the Constitution of the United States says that all Senators shall be bound by Oath or Affirmation to support this Constitution, and that no religious test shall ever be required as a qualification to any office or public trust under the United States. Even the Presidential Oath written by the Founders in Article II, Section 1, Clause 8 says 'swear or affirm' and does not contain the words 'So help me God.' And before anyone on cable television repeats the myth that President George Washington added 'So help me God' in 1789—historians debunked that fable decades ago. Zero eyewitnesses at Federal Hall in 1789 recorded Washington saying it; a writer named Rufus Wilmot Griswold made it up sixty-five years later in an 1854 book, and no President is recorded saying it until Chester A. Arthur in 1881. I affirmed my oath on the Constitution of the United States because the Constitution is the supreme law of the land—and my brother, my dad, and I are going to spend every single day of this term defending it."

With the cable correspondents left speechless behind us on the Capitol plaza, Katie turned her SwiftChair toward the sidewalk curb cut, gave my hand a warm squeeze between our chairs, and rolled side by side with Dad and me toward the Metro elevator—proving to the entire country what the two of us had known since the day we were born: twin brothers and twin sisters never leave each other behind.

Part 3: The First Invite to Cocktails, A Known Side Effect of Death, & Home to Sunset Drive

Date: 2027-01-03 at 16:30 America/New_York

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 4:30 PM — The First Invite to Cocktails & "A Known Side Effect of Death"

"There she is—the newest Senator from the Commonwealth of Virginia!" Senator Arthur Harrington, the silver-haired senior chairman of the Appropriations Committee, boomed warmly across the gilded chandeliers and marble fireplace of the Mansfield Room just off the Senate floor. "Katie, bring your brother and your father over here! Waiter—three flutes of the French champagne for Senator Prairie and her family, and then we're heading downstairs to my hideaway office for twenty-year single-malt scotch and celebratory cigars on the West Front terrace!"

A tuxedoed catering steward immediately stepped between our two compact SwiftChairs with a polished silver tray balanced on his palm, lowering three crystal flutes of bubbling gold champagne toward Katie, Dad, and me.

Across the crowded reception room, half a dozen senior Senators and committee chairs raised their wine glasses and crystal tumblers, waiting for the freshman Senator from Virginia to take a flute and join the oldest social ritual on Capitol Hill.

Sitting beside my sister in my powerchair, I didn't even have to glance at her to know what both of us were remembering beneath the polite clink of Capitol crystal: the sour stench of gin on our mother's breath on the boat deck of the *Sunward*

Tropics in August 2001; the bass-heavy thump of our cousin Brittany's drunken New Year's Eve party rattling the walls of our brick ranch off Military Highway on December 31, 2002; and two seventeen-year-old twins wedging a fifty-pound wheelchair frame against the inside of a locked bedroom door while we ate dry toasted oat cereal out of a cardboard box, clinked two cold cans of ginger ale together at midnight, and swore we would never touch a drop of alcohol for the rest of our lives.

In a room full of powerful Washington politicians, however, a personal promise made at age seventeen was the kind of thing back-slapping colleagues always tried to talk you into breaking *"just this once."*

Fortunately for the three of us, biology and pharmacology had given Katie, Dad, and me an answer that no Senator in the United States Capitol could ever argue with.

Katie raised her left hand—calm, poised, and completely unbothered—stopping the waiter's silver tray six inches above her armrest.

"Thank you so much, Arthur, and thank you, sir, but please keep the champagne on the tray," Katie said clearly enough for the entire circle of Senators to hear. "My twin brother Nate, my father David, and I can't touch a single drop of alcohol—or go anywhere near cigar smoke or tobacco—for medical reasons."

Senator Harrington's genial smile paused mid-toast as he lowered his crystal tumbler half an inch. "Oh—nothing serious, I hope?"

"All three of us take daily prescription medication where mixing it with alcohol or tobacco has a known side effect of death," Katie replied with matter-of-fact serenity, her blue eyes steady and bright beneath the crystal chandelier.

Across the circle of velvet ropes and gilded mirrors, the silence was instantaneous.

Two committee chairs instinctively took a half-step back with their wine glasses, and Senator Harrington's eyes widened before he immediately gestured for the waiter to pull the champagne tray away.

"Good Lord—say no more, Katie!" Senator Harrington said quickly, waving a second steward over from the refreshment bar across the room. "No alcohol and no cigars anywhere near you three—I'll make sure the whip's office and the cloakroom staff know that permanently! What can we get for you, Nate, and David right now?"

"Three glasses of ice-cold ginger ale would be wonderful, Arthur," Dad said with a warm, easy smile, resting his hand on the back of Katie's powerchair. "That's been the Prairie family toast for twenty-four years."

Thirty seconds later, when the steward returned with three tall highball glasses filled with crushed ice and golden ginger ale, Senator Harrington and the surrounding Senators raised their glasses right alongside ours.

As Katie, Dad, and I clinked our three glasses of ginger ale together in the center of the United States Capitol, Katie caught my eye across our armrests with the smallest, most triumphant glint of amusement. In a single sentence, my twin sister had just permanently exempted all three of us from every late-night Washington cocktail hour, wine-soaked donor reception, and smoke-filled backroom on Capitol Hill for the next six years.

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 6:15 PM — Across the Potomac & Through the King Street Tunnel to Sunset Drive

At quarter past six that evening, while the winter sky over the National Mall deepened to indigo and the other newly sworn-in Senators climbed into waiting black town cars bound for Georgetown townhouses or Capitol Hill condominiums, Katie and I rolled out of the Capitol South elevator with Dad walking right beside us, our CapitalPass cards in hand.

Riding the Blue Line two stops to L'Enfant Plaza and transferring up to the southbound Yellow Line platform took less than ten minutes. As our silver Yellow Line train glided back out onto the Charles R. Fenwick Bridge high above the dark, glass-smooth waters of the Potomac River, the illuminated white dome of the Capitol receded behind us and the lights of Alexandria rose ahead on the Virginia shore.

"How does it feel, Senator?" I asked quietly over the hum of the traction motors as the train banked south past Reagan National Airport toward Old Town. "Leaving the District behind on your very first night?"

"Like I can finally breathe," Katie said, leaning her head back against her wheelchair headrest and letting out a long, contented sigh as the Yellow Line glided onto the elevated platform at King Street–Old Town Station. "Washington is where I work, Nate. Virginia is who we are."

Exiting the station street elevator into the crisp thirty-eight-degree night air, Katie and I rolled past the glowing destination signs of the King Street Station bus loop—where BOLT and Capital Transit buses were idling at the sawtooth curbs—and turned west along the wide, flat concrete sidewalk of King Street with Dad walking alongside us.

Immediately ahead of us stood the heavy dark-green steel girders and white-painted concrete retaining walls of the King Street railroad underpass, carrying the elevated tracks of both Alexandria Union Station and the King Street–Old Town Metro directly over the street.

As Katie and I guided our two SwiftChairs side by side along the sidewalk beneath the short railroad bridge with Dad walking at our side and emerged into the quiet residential glow on the west side of the tunnel, Dad's two-story Alexandria house rose right on the left where Sunset Drive met the hill.

It was a classic two-story red-brick Virginia house with black louvered shutters framing the multi-pane sash windows, two manicured round boxwood shrubs flanking a white columned front portico topped with a small white Chippendale railing, and a broad green lawn bordered by a shade tree just steps from the railroad overpass. Looking straight back over my shoulder from the front walkway, I could see the illuminated canopy of King Street–Old Town Metro Station and the upper-level rail embankment of Alexandria Union Station right across the bridge.

Back home in Hampton Roads, Katie and I owned our primary residence fifty-fifty in the Kempsville section of Virginia Beach—the house where we claimed legal residency, where we were registered to vote, and where we paid our property taxes to the City of Virginia Beach. Dad, however, had owned this house on Sunset Drive long before Katie ever ran for the Virginia Beach City Council in 2010. The house was one hundred percent paid off and titled one hundred percent in Dad's name,

giving Katie and me a permanent family roof in Northern Virginia whenever the Senate was in session so she could take the train into Washington for day trips and truthfully say she slept in the Commonwealth of Virginia every single night. Even better, we never had to publish a street number for reporters or curiosity-seekers—to everyone who knew us, it was simply Dad's house on Sunset Drive, tucked right on the other side of the tunnel with buses and trains at our doorstep.

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 7:30 PM — The Vertical Platform Lift & Coding in Bedroom 4

"Home sweet Virginia," Dad said as he unlocked the white front door beneath the columned portico and held it open for Katie and me to roll inside over the flush threshold ramp.

When the three of us had worked with our Alexandria contractor that autumn to adapt the two-story Sunset Drive house for two full-time powerchair users, we had designed every square foot around both our accessibility needs and our privacy.

Here at the front of the first floor, directly behind the shuttered windows facing the sidewalk and the street, sat a traditional Colonial living room and dining room with a central hallway leading back to an accessible kitchen with roll-under countertops and a curbless roll-in bathroom. Anyone walking past the house on the street at night saw only warm table lamps, bookshelves, and a dining room table through the front windows.

Right alongside the central staircase in the hallway stood the engineering centerpiece that made a two-story historic brick house work for Katie and me: a quiet, enclosed through-floor residential vertical platform wheelchair lift linking the first floor directly to the second-floor landing.

After the three of us heated up bowls of chicken noodle soup and toasted sourdough bread in the kitchen for supper—and took our evening prescription tablets with three tall glasses of cold water—Katie rolled her SwiftChair to the hall lift gate and pressed the illuminated call button.

"Come on, Nate," Katie said, grinning over her shoulder even after sixteen hours awake since our 4:00 AM alarm in Virginia Beach. "Before we turn in, we still have to push the January 3rd schema update to our shared site network—and I want to test the new build in Quantum Studio 2026 while the night ARTS train rolls past the window."

While Dad walked up the central carpeted staircase to meet us on the upper landing, Katie and I rode the vertical platform lift one at a time up through the ceiling opening to the second-floor hallway and rolled past the three upstairs doors that completed our four-bedroom layout.

The first door on the left was Bedroom 2: officially designated as my bedroom whenever congressional staffers, plumbers, or visitors ever saw the upstairs floor plan, completely furnished with a neatly made full-sized bed, a cherrywood dresser, and a nightstand lamp—even though that bed went completely untouched every single night.

Across the hall was Bedroom 3, Dad's upstairs bedroom with his full-sized bed and reading chair.

And at the east end of the upstairs hallway, with two wide sash windows looking directly out over the shade tree and the steel railroad bridge toward the glowing platforms of King Street–Old Town and Alexandria Union Station, was Bedroom 4: our three-desk family office.

Having already changed out of her royal-blue Senate blazer into her favorite soft navy fleece pullover, the newly sworn-in United States Senator from Virginia rolled her powerchair right up to her dual-monitor workstation beside mine, while Dad settled into his ergonomic chair at the third desk in the corner to check his Monday morning remote-work queue.

For the next two hours, the only sounds in that warm upstairs room were the familiar, rhythmic click of three mechanical keyboards, the soft hum of our desktop towers, and the occasional distant rumble of a Capital Transit Yellow Line train or an ARTS locomotive gliding across the King Street bridge outside our window.

Side by side at our desks—just as we had coded together since learning HTML in seventh grade at Morrison Middle School in 1997, studying Dad's *Quantum Basic 6.0* textbooks with him in 2001, and mastering PHP in the Web Applications Developer course at Roosevelt Rehabilitation Center from March 2007 to March 2008—Katie and I had Quantum Studio 2026, Quantum Code, and our PHP backend templates open across our monitors, maintaining and deploying updates to the network of websites and desktop applications that the two of us shared.

"Look at line two hundred fourteen in the router controller, Nate," Katie said happily, pointing at her screen as a northbound ARTS train whistled softly across the elevated embankment beyond the glass. "Five hours ago I was holding my hand on the Constitution of the United States in the Old Senate Chamber, and right now I'm fixing a trailing array comma in PHP with my twin brother. Tell me any other Senator on Capitol Hill is having a better Sunday night than this."

"Not a single one of them, Katie," I laughed, compiling the build in Quantum Studio 2026 and watching the green deployment checkmarks light up across our shared server dashboard.

Sunday, January 3, 2027, 10:30 PM — The Private Ground-Floor Back Bedroom Sanctuary

At ten-thirty, Dad shut down his remote-work laptop at the third desk, stood up with a gentle stretch, and kissed the top of Katie's head before resting a warm hand on my shoulder.

"Goodnight, Senator. Goodnight, Nate," Dad said softly from the doorway of Bedroom 3 across the upstairs hall. "Sleep well, you two."

"Goodnight, Dad—love you," Katie and I said together.

One after the other, my sister and I took the interior vertical platform lift back down to the quiet first floor and rolled past the darkened front living room toward the rear of the house.

Tucked into the private back corner of the ground floor—looking out only onto our high-fenced backyard garden and tall evergreens behind drawn blackout curtains—was the Master Bedroom.

Officially, on paper, this ground-floor suite was Katie's bedroom, while Bedroom 2 upstairs was mine. We had deliberately chosen this room at the very back of the ground floor so that no passerby, reporter, or neighbor walking along the front sidewalk could ever peer through a street-facing window to see two forty-one-year-old opposite-gender twins sharing a bed.

Inside our quiet back-room sanctuary, however, there were no cameras, no Senate galleries, and no outsiders who needed an explanation for why the two halves of the same soul slept safest together. Even though the ground-floor suite had a queen-sized bed beneath the framed watercolor print of two blue butterflies we had carried with us from our bedroom off Military Highway, most nights—especially after a loud, bright, overstimulating day on Capitol Hill—we bypassed the open bed in favor of the deep, carpeted walk-in closet along the interior wall of the master suite, where we kept our single shared navy-blue sleeping bag and two pillows laid out on the floor.

Rolling our two compact SwiftChairs up to the threshold of the master walk-in closet, Katie and I plugged our magnetic charger leads into our joystick ports until both battery indicators glowed steady amber in the dim light.

Moving with the practiced upper-body coordination of twenty-five years in wheelchairs, we shed our clothes beside our chairs so our body heat could keep our lower-extremity circulation warm without tangled fabric, transferred down onto the soft carpet inside the walk-in closet, and zipped our shared sleeping bag up to our shoulders before pulling the closet door nearly shut to seal ourselves in quiet, velvet darkness.

Outside in the night, a late-night southbound train glided quietly over the King Street bridge just beyond the trees—heading south through Virginia toward Richmond and Norfolk along the exact steel rails that tied our whole life together.

Inside the warm cocoon of our shared sleeping bag in the dark closet, United States Senator Katie Prairie curled close against my chest, found my hand in the dark, and laced her fingers through mine.

"Goodnight, Nate," she whispered against my shoulder.

"Goodnight, Katie," I whispered back, holding my twin sister close as we drifted off to sleep in our sanctuary on Sunset Drive.

The Norfolk Carrier Leak, Suite 756 at Timberline Shopping Center, & Three Convictions in the Senate

Part 1: The South Lawn Tirade, The Norfolk Carrier Leak, & Why the Order of the Trials Matters

Date: 2027-03-18 at 10:15 America/New_York

Thursday, March 18, 2027, 10:15 AM — "He Thinks He's Brandon Mercer" & The No Vote at Eleven-Fifteen

Inside Room 511 of the Dirksen Senate Office Building, the wall-mounted television was tuned to a live morning press availability on the South Lawn of the White House, where President Garrett Thorne was shouting over the helicopter rotor wash at a cluster of reporters.

"You want to know why my nominee for Deputy Secretary of Transportation is still stalled in committee?" Thorne barked into the microphones, jabbing a thick finger toward Capitol Hill. "Because Broken Katie Prairie—a nasty, bitter little cripple who can't even walk up the steps of the Capitol without taxpayers building her a ramp—is running a personal vendetta from her wheelchair! Look at her! She's slow, she has no stamina, forty-one years old, never married, couldn't keep a real man when she was twenty, still living in her father's house in Alexandria with her crippled twin brother writing little computer spreadsheets for her! She's defective, folks—physically and mentally defective—and the Senate Commerce Committee shouldn't be held hostage by a spinster on wheels!"

Across the private office, Katie's paid legislative director, Sarah, reached for the remote control to mute the screen, her face pale with anger.

"Leave the volume up, Sarah," Katie said calmly from behind her custom-height mahogany Senator's desk, not even looking up from the red-tabbed confirmation binder open across her lap.

Parked in my compact SwiftChair right beside my twin sister's left armrest, I didn't flinch either. My fingers didn't even pause on the mechanical keyboard of my MagnaBook Pro as I finished compiling the final cross-referenced PHP table of wire transfers between Thorne Global Holdings, an offshore maritime logistics shell company, and the nominee's former shipping lobby firm.

Because federal anti-nepotism law under Title 5, Section 3110 of the United States Code barred a Member of Congress from hiring a sibling onto a paid government payroll, I didn't take a single dime of taxpayer salary. I was a private citizen, earning our living through the fifty-fifty software business Katie and I had built from our wheelchairs, and serving in Dirksen Room 511 as my sister's unpaid chief data strategist—while Katie alone held the constitutional office of United States Senator from Virginia, chaired her subcommittee on the dais, and cast the official votes on the floor.

"He thinks he's Brandon Mercer," I said quietly, turning my laptop screen ten degrees toward Katie's SwiftChair so she could read the bottom wire-transfer totals. "He thinks if he stands over the back of our chairs and screams loud enough about how broken we are, we're going to flinch."

"Brandon found out twenty-one years ago what happens when you try to corner us, and so will Garrett Thorne," Katie said, closing the confirmation binder with a sharp snap and unlocking her wheel brakes. "What time is the floor roll call on his nominee, Sarah?"

"Eleven-fifteen," Sarah answered, holding the office door open for our two wheelchairs. "And Speaker Clara Morales's office just called from the other side of the Capitol Rotunda. The House Judiciary and Armed Services investigative

committees have completed their subpoena report on Secretary of Defense Bret Halverson, Vice President Julian Vance, and President Thorne. They are voting on the Articles of Impeachment next week."

"Good," Katie said, steering her SwiftChair out into the marble corridor of Dirksen with me rolling in lockstep beside her left wheel toward the Capitol subway. "Then at eleven-fifteen, President Thorne gets my No vote on his nominee—and as soon as Chief Justice Jonathan Sterling swears in the Senate for their trials, all three of them get my Guilty vote too."

The 2025 Warning from Richmond & Secretary of Defense Bret Halverson's Norfolk Carrier Leak

As our subway car glided through the subterranean tunnel between the Dirksen building and the Capitol, both Katie and I thought back two years earlier to January of 2025.

Back in that winter of 2025, Katie had still been serving as a State Senator in the Senate of Virginia in Richmond—living with me at Apartment 104 of the Broad & Boulevard Lofts on West Broad Street—when newly inaugurated President Garrett Thorne, backed by a Republican trifecta controlling the White House, the House of Representatives, and a fifty-three-to-forty-seven Senate majority, nominated Bret Halverson to serve as United States Secretary of Defense.

Before Thorne plucked him off television to run the Pentagon, Halverson had spent a decade hosting *Patriot Watch Weekend* on the Liberty First Network—a slick, hair-sprayed weekend cable talk show where he ranted about "woke generals," mocked disabled service members and ADA wheelchair accessibility standards as "weakness," and hawked survivalist supplements and gold coins during commercial breaks. In 2024, Halverson had gone on the Liberty First Network and sneered that military bases shouldn't waste taxpayer money on "wheelchair ramps for bureaucrats."

For anyone representing Hampton Roads—home to Naval Station Norfolk, the largest naval base on earth, alongside Naval Air Station Oceana, Joint Expeditionary Base Little Creek, Newport News Shipbuilding, and tens of thousands of active-duty sailors and military families—putting a cable television talk-show host in charge of three million service members and an eight-hundred-and-fifty-billion-dollar defense budget was an insult to every sailor in uniform.

Because Katie was still a State Senator in Richmond in January 2025 and hadn't yet run for the United States Senate, she didn't have a confirmation vote in Washington. Instead, she and I had stayed up past midnight in our West Broad Street apartment compiling a fourteen-page forensic dossier on Halverson's financial conflicts and erratic record. The next morning, State Senator Katie Prairie had rolled to the well of the Senate of Virginia in Richmond, publicly urged both of Virginia's United States Senators to vote No on Halverson's confirmation, and sent our dossier straight up Interstate 95 to Capitol Hill.

Virginia's retiring senior U.S. Senator had read Katie's letter into the *Congressional Record* and voted No alongside Virginia's other Senator, just as she had urged. Yet because Thorne's party controlled the chamber in January 2025, the majority conference had rammed Halverson's confirmation through on a razor-thin fifty-fifty

tie broken by Vice President Julian Vance. That weekend, Secretary Halverson had gone back on his old cable network for a victory lap, laughing with his former co-hosts about *"that little wheelchair state senator down in Richmond who thought she could stop the Pentagon."*

It hadn't taken two years for every single warning Katie had issued from Richmond to come true—and when the November 2026 midterm wave swept a two-hundred-and-fifty-three-seat Democratic majority into the House of Representatives, flipped the Senate to a fifty-four-seat majority, and sent United States Senator Katie Prairie of Virginia to Washington in January 2027, the chickens came home to roost.

Within sixty days of the One Hundred Twentieth Congress taking power in January 2027, joint House and Senate subpoenas uncovered a staggering dual crime at the top of the administration:

First, Secretary of Defense Bret Halverson had used an unsecured commercial messaging app on his personal cell phone—on a group chat that included Vice President Julian Vance, two of Halverson's old cable-news producers, and a foreign-linked shipping broker—to text classified Fifth Fleet deployment schedules and transit coordinates for an aircraft carrier strike group homeported right at Naval Station Norfolk, putting six thousand Hampton Roads sailors in mortal danger.

Second, when I wrote a custom PHP financial cross-indexing script in Dirksen Room 511 to audit the subpoenaed Pentagon logistics ledgers against Treasury wire records, the data proved beyond a shadow of a doubt that Halverson had fired the Department of Defense Inspector General to cover up four hundred million dollars in no-bid Naval Station Norfolk fleet-supply contracts steered to an offshore shell fund co-owned by Thorne Global Holdings—using Domestic Emoluments and national-security tariff waivers personally signed by both Vice President Julian Vance and President Garrett Thorne.

Thursday Afternoon, March 25, 2027 — Why the Vice President Must Be Convicted Before the President

One week later, on Thursday afternoon, March 25, 2027—minutes after the United States House of Representatives voted two hundred and sixty-eight to one hundred and sixty-seven to impeach Secretary of Defense Bret Halverson, Vice President Julian Vance, and President Garrett Thorne for high crimes and misdemeanors—Speaker of the House Clara Morales and the House impeachment managers met with Katie and the Senate leadership inside the Capitol while I sat beside Katie's wheelchair with our constitutional succession timeline open on my laptop.

"Alexander Hamilton wrote in *Federalist Number 65* that impeachment is designed for those offenses which proceed from the misconduct of public men, or, in other words, from the abuse or violation of some public trust," Katie said evenly around the conference table. "And Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. reminded this country that the time is always right to do what is right. All three of these men betrayed the sailors of Naval Station Norfolk and sold out the public trust for four hundred million dollars in offshore kickbacks. None of them—not Thorne, not Vance, and not Halverson—can be allowed to remain in power."

“Which brings us to the exact sequence of the three Senate trials,” Speaker Clara Morales said, looking across the table at Katie and the Senate Majority Leader. “Because under Article II, Section 1, Clause 6 of the Constitution and Section 1 of the Twenty-Fifth Amendment, the order in which the Senate calls the final roll determines who becomes President of the United States.”

Katie nodded, tapping the statutory flow chart I had coded on my screen.

“If the Senate convicts and removes President Garrett Thorne first,” Katie explained with crystal-clear constitutional precision, “then the exact microsecond Chief Justice Sterling bangs his gavel on the sixty-seventh Guilty vote, Vice President Julian Vance—the man who broke the tie to put Bret Halverson in the Pentagon and co-signed the offshore Norfolk contract waivers—automatically ascends to the Presidency. Even if we impeached him the next day, he would already be sitting in the Oval Office with the pardon pen in his hand.”

“Whereas if we try and convict them in ascending order of their conspiracy,” I added from my chair beside Katie, pointing to the three numbered boxes on my screen, “watch what the Constitution and the United States Code do automatically:

“First, on Wednesday, the Senate votes on Secretary of Defense Bret Halverson—convicting and removing him by a two-thirds supermajority under Article I, Section 3, followed immediately by the simple-majority vote permanently disqualifying him from ever holding federal office again.

“Second, on Thursday, while Garrett Thorne is still President, the Senate votes on Vice President Julian Vance. The moment sixty-seven Senators vote Guilty to convict and remove Julian Vance, the office of Vice President of the United States becomes completely vacant. Under Section 2 of the Twenty-Fifth Amendment, a replacement Vice President cannot take office unless confirmed by a majority vote of both Houses of Congress—meaning our majorities in the House and the Senate simply decline to consider any nominee, keeping the Vice Presidency empty overnight.

“And third, on Friday afternoon, with the Vice Presidency vacant, the Senate votes to convict, remove, and permanently disqualify President Garrett Thorne. Under the Presidential Succession Act of 1947—Title 3, Section 19 of the United States Code—with both the Presidency and the Vice Presidency vacant at the same time, the line of succession skips straight across the Capitol Rotunda to the Speaker of the House.”

Across the mahogany table, Speaker Clara Morales looked at the forty-one-year-old Senator from Virginia Beach and her twin brother in quiet awe.

“Wednesday for Halverson, Thursday for Vance, and Friday for Thorne,” the Senate Majority Leader said, writing the three dates onto the official Senate trial calendar. “And Senator Prairie—because Naval Station Norfolk is your home turf, we want you delivering the final floor speech before the roll is called.”

Part 2: Route 36 to Timberline Shopping Center, Lunch at Don Miller Subs, Retro Games at Neat Stuff, & Suite 756

Date: 2027-04-03 at 12:05 America/New_York

Saturday, April 3, 2027, 12:05 PM — Riding CVTA Route 36 to Timberline Shopping Center & Family Lunch at Don Miller Subs

“Approaching State Route four-ten, Holland Road and Timberlake Road—Timberline Shopping Center,” the automated chime announced over the interior speakers of our forty-foot Coastal Virginia Transit Authority Route 36 bus as the driver signaled right and eased into the curb lane just east of where State Route 225 split off toward South Independence Boulevard and the Silverleaf commuter lot.

Up near the front wheel well, my twin brother Nate reached up from his compact SwiftChair and pressed the yellow request-to-stop strip along the wall, while our sixty-eight-year-old dad stood up from the forward-facing bench seat across the aisle and tucked his sunglasses into the breast pocket of his polo shirt.

Unlike the part-time Virginia General Assembly up in Richmond—which met for forty-five or sixty winter days and then sent us home for the rest of the year—the United States Senate stayed in session almost year-round from January 3rd right up to Christmas. Even so, the Senate’s weekly floor voting calendar almost always wrapped up around two o’clock on Thursday afternoon, allowing Nate, Dad, and me to catch the afternoon ARTS Northeast Regional train south from Alexandria to Norfolk and spend every Friday, Saturday, and Sunday at home in Kempsville. Better yet, this first full week of April fell during the Senate’s scheduled Spring State Work Period, giving the House impeachment managers and the White House defense counsel ten days to file their pre-trial briefs before the Senate impeachment trials of Secretary of Defense Bret Halverson, Vice President Julian Vance, and President Garrett Thorne gaveled in on Wednesday, April 14th.

“Have a great Saturday, Senator Prairie, Nate, Mr. Prairie!” the CVTA driver called out warmly as he kneeled the front air suspension, flipped the hydraulic fold-out ramp onto the concrete sidewalk of Holland Road, and waved as all three of us—having tapped our regular fare cards when we boarded—thanked him and rolled out into the bright sixty-eight-degree April sunshine.

Across the six lanes of State Route 410 on the south side of the highway stood Holland Square, anchored by the green signage of the Market Square grocery store. Here on the north side of Holland Road, however, we had just rolled into the parking lot of Timberline Shopping Center—a weathered, familiar 1980s neighborhood strip center anchored at its far end by a General Dollar discount store.

For Nate, Dad, and me, Timberline Shopping Center was one of our favorite Saturday afternoon stops along the Route 36 bus line between Buckner Boulevard and the Silverleaf transfer hub—and today was a special occasion. In five days, on Thursday, April 8th, Nate and I would turn forty-two years old. Every spring on the Saturday before our April 8th birthday, Dad rode the bus with us to Timberline Shopping Center to treat us to our traditional birthday lunch at Don Miller Subs and buy us a pair of vintage video game cartridges next door at Neat Stuff.

Steering our two SwiftChairs side by side along the covered concrete walkway toward the far-left bay of the five-storefront row, we rolled straight through the propped-open glass door of Don Miller Subs, where the warm, savory aroma of grilled ribeye steak, caramelized onions, and freshly baked sub rolls greeted us like an old friend.

“Well, look who’s back from Washington—and happy early birthday to the April eighth twins!” Marcus, the counter manager who had been grilling subs for the three of us since my years in the Virginia House of Delegates, beamed from behind the stainless-steel prep line. “The birthday usual for the Prairie crew? Two six-inch grilled steak-and-cheese subs with everything, one turkey-and-provolone, a large basket of hot french fries to share, and three tall cups of ginger ale?”

“You know us by heart, Marcus—and the birthday lunch is on Dad today,” Dad laughed, stepping up to the register to tap his debit card before I could reach for my wallet.

For the next thirty-five minutes, sitting at our usual accessible corner table where Nate and I could pull our wheelchairs right up to the laminate top without blocking the aisle, the three of us ate piping-hot subs and crispy french fries out of wax-paper baskets and clinked our three plastic cups of ice-cold ginger ale together in an early forty-second birthday toast. Nobody in the sub shop bothered us for speeches or talking points; a retired Navy chief at the next booth simply nodded with a quiet *“Proud of you up there on Capitol Hill, Senator,”* before letting us enjoy our Saturday lunch in peace.

Saturday, April 3, 2027, 12:50 PM — Hunting for Forty-Second Birthday Retro Cartridges at Neat Stuff in Suite 732

At ten minutes to one, after wiping our hands with napkins and tossing our paper baskets into the trash bin by the door, we rolled out of Don Miller Subs and turned one door to the right into Suite 732: Neat Stuff.

While everyone in Hampton Roads knew Pixel Haven as our region’s premier retro and modern video game store, Neat Stuff here in Suite 732 of Timberline Shopping Center was Pixel Haven’s sister store—a floor-to-ceiling treasure cavern packed with vintage console cartridges, classic handheld games, eight-bit and sixteen-bit hardware, comic books, and retro sci-fi collectibles. Ever since we were kids playing our Super Kinoka and Nova 64 consoles in our bedroom on Delaney Street—and trading PlayBrick cartridges in the back of Dad’s car—Nate and I had never outgrown our love for retro video games.

“Katie! Nate! Mr. Prairie—happy early birthday!” Devon, the bearded thirty-something clerk behind the glass cartridge counter, lit up the moment our two SwiftChairs rolled down the wide center aisle between the glass display cases. “You three picked the exact right Saturday to ride the 36 over here. Hold on—I put two cartridges in the lockbox under the register yesterday afternoon because I knew Mr. Prairie would be bringing you two in for your April eighth birthday!”

Devon unlocked the sliding glass door at the back of the counter and set two pristine, gray plastic cartridges on the felt mat in front of our wheelchairs: an original 1994 *Gorilla King ’94* cartridge for the PlayBrick with an unblemished holographic label, and a complete-in-box sixteen-bit *Super Kinoka* strategy role-playing game we had been hunting for since 2024.

Nate’s blue eyes lit up like he was twelve years old again. Picking up the sixteen-bit cartridge, he tilted the bottom edge toward the overhead fluorescent light to inspect the gold copper contact pins.

“Look at the board pins, Katie—not a single trace of oxidation, and the battery-backed save chip was just soldered fresh,” Nate said happily, handing me the cardboard box so I could admire the manual. “We can dump the ROM onto our local emulator in Bedroom 4 to preserve the save states and play the original cartridge on the CRT television in the living room tonight.”

“Happy forty-second birthday, you two,” Dad smiled, stepping up to the counter to pay for both games while Devon slipped them into a sturdy paper bag and hung the handles over my right armrest.

Saturday, April 3, 2027, 1:15 PM — The Banners at Suite 756 & Senatorial Curiosity

Rolling back out of Suite 732 onto the covered concrete sidewalk of Timberline Shopping Center with our paper bag of retro games tucked beside my armrest, Nate, Dad, and I turned right along the storefront walkway toward the Route 36 bus stop out on Holland Road.

For years, the five-bay strip along this end of Timberline Shopping Center had followed the exact same left-to-right rhythm: Don Miller Subs on the left, Neat Stuff in Suite 732, the quiet pink neon sign of Halo Nails & Spa in the middle, the busy tables of Pho 79 Vietnamese Kitchen in the fourth bay, and then Suite 756 on the far right—a narrow eleven-hundred-square-foot storefront that had sat completely empty behind dusty brown butcher paper since the spring of 2023.

As we rolled past Halo Nails & Spa and reached the front windows of Pho 79 Vietnamese Kitchen—where the rich, mouthwatering scent of simmering star anise, charred ginger, cinnamon bark, and slow-cooked beef pho broth drifted out through the exhaust vent into the April air—all three of us stopped in our tracks.

Suite 756 right next door to the Vietnamese restaurant wasn’t empty anymore.

Every square inch of its plate-glass facade had been plastered floor-to-ceiling with glaring crimson, white, and gold vinyl banners that read:

THE TIDEWATER THORNE & RTR SUPERSTORE — OFFICIAL RESTORE THE REPUBLIC CAMPAIGN HEADQUARTERS!

Behind the glass stood a six-foot cardboard cutout of President Garrett Thorne giving a grinning double thumbs-up, flanked by neon-red posters reading *THORNE: 3-0 UNDEFEATED — IMPEACH THIS!* and *THORNE 2028: THE REVENGE TOUR!*

“Good grief,” Dad muttered, staring at the giant vinyl banner taped right up against the brick pillar separating Suite 756 from Pho 79. “An ‘America First’ Garrett Thorne shrine sharing a party wall with a Vietnamese pho restaurant. You couldn’t make that up if you tried.”

Sitting in my SwiftChair on the sidewalk twenty feet from the door of Suite 756, I frowned thoughtfully at the words *OFFICIAL RESTORE THE REPUBLIC CAMPAIGN HEADQUARTERS* printed across the banner.

Over the past six weeks, our constituent caseworkers in Virginia Beach and Norfolk—along with my colleagues on the Senate Commerce Committee's Consumer Protection Subcommittee—had fielded dozens of inquiries about a sudden rash of brick-and-mortar "Thorne Stores" popping up in strip malls across Virginia. Every constituent who called our office believed the exact same rumor: that these storefronts were officially vetted, licensed, and authorized by President Garrett Thorne, Thorne Global Holdings, or his national campaign committee, and that buying forty-dollar hats and sixty-dollar flags inside them went directly to fund the President's impeachment defense.

Neither Nate, nor Dad, nor I had any idea who had leased Suite 756. As far as we knew, it was just another out-of-state novelty vendor looking to make a quick buck off Holland Road traffic before the next Route 36 bus arrived at one-thirty-five.

Curiosity got the better of the Senator in me.

"Wait a second, Nate, Dad," I said, resting my right hand on my joystick. "We still have twenty minutes before the one-thirty-five bus pulls up. People keep asking our Commerce Committee staff whether these 'Thorne Superstores' are actually vetted and licensed by Garrett Thorne, his company, or his campaign—or if they're unlicensed bootleggers tricking voters into thinking retail purchases are campaign contributions. Let's roll inside for sixty seconds and look at the merchandise tags and the business license by the register."

"Sixty seconds of consumer protection fieldwork," Nate agreed, glancing at his watch with a dry smile. "Lead the way, Senator."

Saturday, April 3, 2027, 1:18 PM — Inside Suite 756: Sharron Connects the Dots & Twenty-Four Years of Truth

When Dad pulled open the aluminum-framed glass door of Suite 756 and held it for Nate and me to roll our two SwiftChairs across the threshold, a cheap brass bell taped above the door frame jangled loudly.

The first thing that hit us inside the narrow storefront was the sensory clash: the sharp chemical smell of fresh overseas vinyl ink mixing with the unmistakable, delicious aroma of Vietnamese beef pho broth and star anise seeping straight through the thin drywall partition from Pho 79 next door.

Every wall was covered in pegboard hooks and wire racks overflowing with crimson Restore the Republic baseball caps, polyester three-by-five flags showing Garrett Thorne's head superimposed onto a bodybuilder holding an eagle, gold-foil novelty *"One Thousand Dollar Thorne Notes,"* and freshly unpacked shipping cartons stenciled *THORNE: 3-0 UNDEFEATED — ACQUITTED IN THE SENATE!*

Up at the glass checkout counter near the back wall—where a small tabletop television was tuned to a shouting panel on LibertyMax—an older husband and wife in matching red RTR windbreakers were handing a crisp hundred-dollar bill across the counter, while three sixty-something women wearing crimson Restore the Republic lapel pins stood near the back flag rack sipping iced coffees and browsing the shelves.

“We drove over from Kempsville as soon as we saw the sign on Holland Road,” the husband was saying earnestly to the woman behind the cash register, whose back was half-turned as she priced a box of white ceramic *THORNE 2028* coffee mugs with a handheld sticker gun. “We bought two flags and two of the ‘3-0 Undefeated’ hats because we want every dollar going straight to President Thorne’s Senate trial defense fund!”

“Oh, bless your hearts, patriots—President Thorne appreciates every single bit of your support, and those Senate Democrats don’t stand a prayer of getting sixty-seven votes next week!” the woman behind the register replied in a syrupy, familiar voice, never once correcting the couple’s false belief that her store was connected to the President’s defense fund.

While the couple zipped their new hats into a plastic shopping bag and walked past us out the front door, I reached out from my wheelchair and flipped over the neck tag of a *THORNE: 3-0 UNDEFEATED* t-shirt hanging on the nearest circular rack.

“Look at the collar tag, Nate,” I murmured quietly. “Manufactured in Guangdong Province for Wholesale Novelty Imports LLC. Zero union bug, zero Federal Election Commission disclaimer, and zero licensing mark from Thorne Global Holdings.”

Nate rolled his SwiftChair three feet closer to the glass checkout counter and pointed past a large plastic jar of five-dollar buttons that had been deliberately positioned at the corner of the register to block the counter mat. Taped flat beneath the jar in tiny eight-point font was a two-sentence notice:

Privately owned and operated retail establishment. Not authorized by, vetted by, licensed by, or affiliated with Garrett Thorne, Thorne Global Holdings, or any candidate or political committee.

“Every dime goes straight into the store owner’s pocket,” Nate said softly, his eyes lifting from the hidden disclaimer to the framed City of Virginia Beach Commissioner of the Revenue Business License hanging on the pegboard wall behind the cash register.

I followed my brother’s gaze up to the typed name on the municipal business license.

PROPRIETOR: BRENDA WALSH.

Across the narrow aisle beside my right wheel, I heard Dad draw in a sharp, silent breath.

Behind the counter, the sixty-five-year-old woman with dyed blonde hair finished sticking a twenty-four-ninety-nine price tag onto the bottom of a *THORNE 2028* mug, set her pricing gun down on the glass, and turned around with a practiced retail smile on her face.

“Welcome to the Tidewater Thorne Superstore!” she began brightly. “Everything in the store goes to—”

Her voice died in her throat.

The ceramic coffee mug slipped halfway out of her fingers and clattered upright onto the glass countertop.

Standing—and sitting—six feet in front of her cash register were her ex-husband David Prairie, her forty-one-year-old son Nathaniel Prairie, and her forty-one-year-old daughter, United States Senator Katie Prairie.

None of the three of us had laid eyes on our mother since the afternoon of Saturday, July 12, 2003—twenty-four years ago—when eighteen-year-old Nate and I had rolled our wheelchairs out the front door of the brick house on Delaney Street with Dad to move into Greenway Court Apartment A6.

For five full seconds, the only sound inside Suite 756 was the drone of the LibertyMax anchor on the corner television and the muffled clatter of soup spoons coming through the drywall from Pho 79 next door.

Brenda's face drained to chalk white, and then flushed a deep, blotchy crimson from her collar up to her roots. Her eyes darted in sheer panic toward the three women from her Restore the Republic chapter standing ten feet away by the back flag rack.

"What—what are you three doing in here?!" Brenda hissed, her voice dropping from its syrupy customer-service lilt to the sharp, defensive snap Nate and I still remembered from the hallways of our childhood. "Are you following me?! Did David tell you to come in here to harass me?!"

"Nobody knew you worked here, Brenda," Dad said, his voice completely calm, level, and devoid of anger as he stood with one hand resting steadily on the back push-handle of my wheelchair and the other near Nate's shoulder. "Your children turn forty-two on Thursday, April eighth. Just like we've done every spring for the past fifteen years, I rode the Route 36 bus over here with Katie and Nate to buy them their birthday lunch at Don Miller Subs and their birthday video games at Neat Stuff three doors down. We didn't even know Suite 756 had been leased until we rolled out onto the sidewalk two minutes ago."

At the mention of April 8th, Brenda's eyes flickered toward the wall calendar hanging beside her cash register—making it unmistakably clear that until Dad said the date out loud, the woman who had given birth to us forty-two years ago hadn't even remembered that our birthday was five days away.

Before Brenda could utter another word, one of the three women standing by the flag rack stepped forward into the center aisle, lowering her iced coffee cup as she stared in stunned recognition at Dad, then at Nate, and then at me.

It was Sharron—a former neighbor from two streets over in our old Kempsville subdivision who had known our family back in the nineties when Nate and I were growing up on Delaney Street, long before our neuromuscular diagnosis in 2001.

"David?!" Sharron gasped, her eyes widening as she looked from Dad's silver hair down to our two wheelchairs, and then straight across the counter at Brenda. "David Prairie?! Wait a minute… Katie and Nathaniel Prairie! I remember watching you two ride your bikes down Delaney Street when you were kids!"

Sharron spun around toward Brenda, her voice echoing across the narrow storefront as the other two Restore the Republic women—Donna and Carol—froze beside her.

“Brenda, wait a second!” Sharron demanded, pointing from the framed *Brenda Walsh* business license on the wall to my wheelchair. “When you joined our Restore the Republic chapter under the name Brenda Walsh, you told us you didn’t even know the Prairie family! For two straight years you’ve sat at our kitchen tables trashing ‘that Prairie woman’ on television like she was a total stranger! Wait—your daughter is *our* United States Senator?! *And* their birthdays are coming up on Thursday, and you didn’t even remember?! Brenda, it’s time for you to come clean!”

Beside Sharron, Donna and Carol stared at Brenda as if the floor had just opened beneath their feet.

“What is she talking about, Brenda?!” Donna asked, her voice rising in disbelief. “United States Senator Katie Prairie is your biological daughter?! You looked us dead in the eye at church coffee hour on Tuesday and swore you weren’t related to her!”

Behind the glass counter, Brenda’s hands trembled violently as her carefully constructed double life collapsed in front of her own friends.

“I—I went back to my maiden name Walsh because David and the woke universities brainwashed them against their own mother!” Brenda stammered, her face turning a blotchy, furious purple as she tried to fall back on the talking points that usually worked in her chapter meetings. “They turned their backs on me and became godless Washington liberals!”

Sharron didn’t buy a single word of it. She took a step closer to the counter, her face tightening with maternal disgust as she did the math out loud in front of Donna and Carol.

“Woke universities?!” Sharron shot back. “Brenda, I lived two streets over from you on Delaney Street in two thousand and one! Katie and Nathaniel weren’t at a university when you and David divorced—they were sixteen years old at Northwood High School, right after the doctors diagnosed their muscle condition and put both of them in wheelchairs! Every mother in the neighborhood heard how you threw a fit because you were embarrassed to be seen pushing wheelchairs in public!”

Beside my left wheel, Nate’s voice was quiet, steady, and devastatingly clear.

“Dad didn’t turn us against you, Brenda,” Nate said, looking straight across the counter. “You did that yourself in August of 2001 when we were sixteen years old and our legs were failing—when you maxed out the credit card to drag us onto a cruise ship against our will, screamed at us that we were ruining your vacation because we couldn’t walk up the gangway, and tried to force two high school juniors into a toddler character meet-and-greet line so you could take a fake photo for the neighbors. And when the doctors put us in wheelchairs that September, Dad built ramps and carried us up the stairs, while you locked yourself in the kitchen with a bottle of gin.”

“And the reason your name is Brenda Walsh on that business license behind you,” Dad added calmly, “is because in October of 2001, sixteen-year-old Katie and Nate asked me and my attorney to make restoring your maiden name a condition of paying off your cruise debt in the divorce decree—because neither of your children wanted you carrying the Prairie name ever again.”

Sitting in my SwiftChair with Dad's forty-second-birthday gift bag from Neat Stuff hanging beside my armrest, I looked from the six-foot cardboard cutout of Garrett Thorne grinning beside the register to Brenda, and then to Sharron, Donna, and Carol.

"Sixteen days ago, on the morning of March eighteenth," I said evenly, "the man on that cardboard cutout stood on the South Lawn of the White House on live national television and called me a 'nasty, bitter little cripple,' said I was 'slow' and had 'no stamina,' called us 'defective,' and mocked your son Nate as my 'crippled twin brother.' Not only did you build a shrine to the man who hurled derogatory slurs at your own children's wheelchairs on national television, Brenda—you're also deceiving your own friends and customers right here in Suite 756."

I pointed past the plastic jar of five-dollar buttons on the counter to the hidden eight-point disclaimer taped flat against the glass.

"Constituents have been calling my Senate Commerce Committee office all month asking if the rumors are true that these 'Thorne Superstores'—or the local Restore the Republic chapters—are officially vetted, endorsed, and licensed by Garrett Thorne, his company, or his campaign," I said, looking directly at Sharron, Donna, and Carol. "Look behind that button jar on the counter, ladies, and look at the Guangdong wholesale tags inside the collars. Just like the local chapters, this store has zero authorization or endorsement from Garrett Thorne or his campaign. When that couple from Kempsville just handed Brenda a hundred dollars thinking it was going to the President's Senate trial defense fund, every single dime went straight into Brenda's personal bank account."

Donna and Carol stepped up to the glass counter, peered behind the button jar at the tiny eight-point disclaimer, and looked from Brenda's blotchy face to the grinning cardboard cutout of Garrett Thorne.

As mothers and grandmothers themselves, the three women looked at what Brenda had done to make her own two children cut her off—forcing two sixteen-year-old teenagers with failing legs onto a cruise ship, screaming at them when they couldn't walk, retreating to a bottle of gin when they went into wheelchairs, forgetting their forty-second birthday, and then cheering on a man who mocked her own son and daughter on national television while she fleeced her own chapter friends behind a button jar.

In that quiet strip-mall storefront, the entire illusion of the movement they had been pouring their lives into shattered at once.

Sharron stared at the cardboard cutout of Garrett Thorne, and then looked straight across the counter at Brenda in horror.

"Wait—we worshipped a man who has said derogatory things about your own daughter?!" Sharron said, her voice trembling with maternal outrage. "Calling her a cripple, and slow, and saying she has no stamina?! No, Brenda, we can't support this anymore!"

Sharron set the two flags and the coffee mug she had been holding flat down onto the glass counter with a sharp thud—and then reached up to the collar of her cardigan, unpinned her gold-bordered crimson *Restore the Republic — Chapter President* badge, and dropped it onto the glass right in front of Brenda.

“I started our Virginia Beach Restore the Republic chapter three years ago—and just like your phony store, Brenda, President Thorne never endorsed or cared about a single one of us either,” Sharron said, her voice shaking with disgust. “I am a mother and a grandmother. Hearing what you did to your own sixteen-year-old twins when they went into wheelchairs—and watching you stand here worshipping a man who calls your own daughter a cripple and slow on national television while you use our members as your personal piggy bank—makes me sick to my stomach.”

Beside her, Donna and Carol reached up to their own lapels, unpinned their crimson Restore the Republic pins, and dropped them onto the glass countertop with two sharp metallic clicks.

“We’re done with you, Brenda, and we’re done with Restore the Republic,” Donna said firmly.

“I’m shutting the chapter down tonight,” Sharron told Brenda flatly, before turning around in the narrow aisle with Donna and Carol to face Dad, Nate, and me. All three women had tears shining in their eyes.

“David… Katie… Nathaniel,” Sharron said softly, her voice thick with genuine remorse as she looked down at our two wheelchairs. “We owe the three of you an apology. We bought into ugly lies on television about a family we should have been proud of all along. What your father did for you two—and what the two of you have built with your lives after what she put you through—is extraordinary.”

“We’re so sorry, Senator Prairie,” Carol said, wiping her cheek with the back of her hand. “Every single one of us—and our husbands—are voting Democrat in the next election, and you have our votes for as long as you run.”

“And happy forty-second birthday on Thursday, Katie and Nathaniel,” Donna added warmly as the three women stepped to the front door and held it open for us.

“Thank you, Sharron. Thank you, Donna, Carol,” I said, genuinely touched as Nate and Dad nodded warmly to all three of them.

Behind the glass counter, Brenda stood frozen in total, trembling silence—abandoned by the family she had mistreated twenty-six years ago and just walked out on by the friends and movement she had traded us for—inside an empty storefront that smelled of cheap vinyl ink and Pho 79’s simmering beef broth.

Out on Holland Road beyond the plate-glass window, the amber LED destination sign of the one-thirty-five CVTA Route 36 bus glided into view as it approached the Timberline Shopping Center stop—a bus route that only ran on Saturday afternoons because Nate, Dad, and I had fought to save and expand it sixteen years ago when I first took my seat on the Virginia Beach City Council.

I glanced once more at the stacks of newly delivered cardboard shipping cartons piled behind Brenda’s register—every single box stenciled *THORNE: 3-0 UNDEFEATED* and *THORNE 2028*.

“Goodbye, Brenda,” I said quietly, turning my SwiftChair smoothly in the narrow aisle alongside Nate’s chair as Dad walked beside us toward the open doorway. “And as your United States Senator—I hope you kept the wholesale receipts for those ‘3-0 Undefeated’ and ‘2028’ boxes before the Senate reconvenes on April fourteenth.”

The cheap brass bell above the door jangled once more behind us as Nate, Dad, and I rolled out of Suite 756 into the warm, clean Virginia Beach sunshine—waving goodbye to Sharron, Donna, and Carol on the sidewalk while the Route 36 bus kneeled at the curb to take the three of us home to Kempsville.

Part 3: The Words of Mason, Madison, and Lincoln, Three Guilty Votes in Forty-Eight Hours, & Swearing In President Clara Morales

Date: 2027-04-16 at 13:30 America/New_York

Wednesday & Thursday, April 14–15, 2027 — Convicting Secretary Halverson and Vice President Vance

Two years earlier, in January of 2025, I had been sitting at my desk in the Senate of Virginia in Richmond when President Garrett Thorne nominated Bret Halverson—the slick, hair-sprayed weekend host of *Patriot Watch Weekend* on the Liberty First Network—to serve as United States Secretary of Defense, and when Vice President Julian Vance cast the tie-breaking fiftieth vote to put him in charge of the Pentagon over the objections of every military family in Hampton Roads.

That weekend in 2025, Halverson had gone back on his old cable network for a victory lap, laughing with his former co-hosts about *"that little wheelchair state senator down in Richmond who thought she could stop the Pentagon."*

He wasn't laughing anymore.

On Wednesday afternoon, April 14, 2027, Bret Halverson sat pale and sweating at the respondent's table in the well of the United States Senate Chamber while Chief Justice Jonathan Sterling presided from the marble rostrum and the Reading Clerk called the final roll on Article One and Article Two of his impeachment.

Up on the top tier of the Senate Floor beside the accessible upper doorway, I sat alone at my custom-height mahogany Senator's desk in my compact SwiftChair with my electromagnetic drive brakes locked firm and my red-tabbed impeachment evidence binder resting flat across my lap. Because Senate rules strictly limit the chamber floor during an impeachment trial to sworn United States Senators and officers of the court, my twin brother Nate sat in his matching SwiftChair beside our dad at the brass railing of the Senate Family Gallery directly across the chamber, his blue eyes locked steadily on mine.

Down in the well, Halverson's defense attorneys didn't even look up toward my desk. After the House managers had displayed the screenshots of Halverson texting classified Naval Station Norfolk carrier strike group deployment schedules over a commercial phone app alongside the four-hundred-million-dollar Thorne Global Holdings kickback ledger Nate's scripts had uncovered, seventeen institutional Republican Senators from defense and coastal states had announced they were crossing the aisle.

"Mr. Mendoza," the Reading Clerk called out.

"Guilty," Senator Mendoza answered from across the aisle.

The clerk's eyes moved down the alphabetical tally sheet and looked up toward my mahogany desk at the top of the chamber.

"Ms. Prairie."

For half a second, the entire Senate Chamber went dead silent. Down at the respondent's table, Bret Halverson finally raised his head, looking up the tiered steps of the chamber straight at the wheelchair he had mocked on national television two years ago.

I didn't raise my voice, and I didn't take my hands off my armrests. Looking straight down into the well on behalf of every sailor at Naval Station Norfolk whose operational safety he had treated like a cable-news segment, I gave him the vote I had promised from Richmond in 2025.

"Guilty," I said clearly across the quiet chamber.

By a vote of seventy-one to twenty-nine—four votes above the two-thirds constitutional threshold required under Article I, Section 3 of the Constitution—the Senate convicted and removed Bret Halverson from office, followed ten minutes later by a simple-majority vote permanently disqualifying him from ever holding any office of honor, trust, or profit under the United States again.

Twenty-four hours later, on Thursday afternoon, April 15, 2027, the second domino fell.

Confronted with the unredacted Treasury wire tables proving that Vice President Julian Vance had personally co-signed the offshore routing waivers for the Naval Station Norfolk logistics kickbacks and sat on the exact same unsecured messaging thread while our Fifth Fleet sailors' movements were compromised, sixty-eight Senators—including me—voted Guilty at four-thirty on Thursday afternoon to convict and remove Julian Vance from the Vice Presidency, followed immediately by a second vote permanently disqualifying him from future federal office.

With the Democratic majority in the House of Representatives and our fifty-four-seat majority in the Senate refusing to entertain any Twenty-Fifth Amendment replacement nominee from a disgraced White House, the office of Vice President of the United States stood completely vacant as Thursday night fell over Washington.

Friday, April 16, 2027, 1:30 PM — The Words of George Mason, James Madison, and Abraham Lincoln

At three o'clock on Friday morning—less than eleven hours before the final Senate deliberation and roll-call vote on the Articles of Impeachment against President Garrett Thorne—the President had gone online from the residence of the White House to unleash one final, desperate tirade against Nate and me.

In all-capital letters, Thorne had called me a *"defective, bitter little cripple on wheels"* and a *"spinster who couldn't keep a man in her twenties and is trying to steal the Presidency from her wheelchair with her shut-in twin brother."*

Even at the very end, Garrett Thorne still didn't understand that every ugly, ableist insult he hurled at my wheelchair and my brother only disgusted more institutional Senators in his own party and cemented the two-thirds coalition against him.

At one-thirty on Friday afternoon, April 16, 2027, inside the closed marble chamber of the United States Senate during the final hour of deliberations before the roll call, I engaged the drive lock on my SwiftChair beside my top-tier mahogany desk, pressed my microphone button, and rested my hands on the edge of my lectern as all ninety-nine of my fellow Senators turned toward my seat.

"Mr. Chief Justice, and my colleagues of the Senate," I said evenly across the silent chamber. "Two hundred and forty years ago, right down the road from where my brother Nate and I grew up in Virginia, George Mason stood at the Constitutional Convention in Philadelphia and warned that no man who holds the executive power should ever be placed above the reach of the law when he corrupts his office, asking the delegates: *Shall any man be above justice? Above all, shall that man be above it, who can commit the most extensive injustice?*"

Up in the Family Gallery above the marble columns, Dad rested his hand on Nate's shoulder as Nate looked down at me from his SwiftChair.

"And when another Virginian, James Madison, wrote *Federalist Number 51*," I continued, my voice calm and unhurried, "he didn't tell us to trust the personal goodwill of a President or a Cabinet Secretary. Madison wrote: *If men were angels, no government would be necessary. If angels were to govern men, neither external nor internal controls on government would be necessary. In framing a government which is to be administered by men over men, the great difficulty lies in this: you must first enable the government to control the governed; and in the next place oblige it to control itself.* Madison and the framers gave this Senate the sole power to try all impeachments specifically to guard the republic against men who treat a public trust as a private business."

I looked down into the well toward the respondent's table where President Garrett Thorne's defense lawyers sat staring down at their legal pads.

"Abraham Lincoln once said that nearly all men can stand adversity, but if you want to test a man's character, give him power—and at Gettysburg, he charged every generation of Americans to ensure that government of the people, by the people, for the people, shall not perish from the earth," I said. "We gave Garrett Thorne, Julian Vance, and Bret Halverson the highest powers under this Constitution. They used that power to trade tariff waivers and Naval Station Norfolk fleet contracts for four hundred million dollars in offshore kickbacks, to leak the movements of six thousand Virginia sailors on commercial phones, and to mock the disabled citizens they swore an oath to serve. Mason, Madison, and Lincoln left us an exact constitutional remedy for men who fail that test—and when the Clerk calls the roll, I will vote Guilty."

Friday, April 16, 2027, 2:15 PM — Sixty-Eight Guilty Votes, Permanent Disqualification, & President Clara Morales

At two o'clock, the gallery doors were unlocked to the public and the press corps, and Chief Justice Jonathan Sterling rose in his black judicial robe at the marble rostrum.

“The Secretary will call the roll on Article One of the Articles of Impeachment exhibited by the House of Representatives against Garrett Thorne, President of the United States,” Chief Justice Sterling announced.

This was the third time in American history that the House of Representatives had impeached Garrett Thorne—and during his first two impeachments back in his first term, he had escaped removal only because the Senate tally had fallen short of the two-thirds constitutional wall.

This third time, the wall broke.

One by one, as the Reading Clerk called the alphabetical roll, fourteen Republican Senators who had voted to acquit Thorne in his earlier impeachment trials rose from their mahogany desks and answered *“Guilty.”*

“Mr. Mendoza,” the Reading Clerk called out.

“Guilty,” Senator Mendoza answered.

“Ms. Prairie.”

I kept my hands resting calmly on the armrests of my SwiftChair, my electromagnetic drive brakes locked tight against the blue Senate carpet. Twenty-one years after Brandon Mercer had switched off my powerchair outside the Williamsburg train station in the pouring November rain and told me I was powerless—and thirteen days after rolling into Suite 756 at Timberline Shopping Center on Holland Road and seeing the shrines and unopened crates of *“3-0 UNDEFEATED”* and *“THORNE 2028”* merchandise my own estranged mother had chosen over her children—I looked straight down into the well of the United States Senate.

“Guilty,” I said clearly.

Twenty minutes later, when the Reading Clerk handed the certified tally sheet up to the rostrum showing that sixty-eight Senators had voted Guilty on both Articles of Impeachment—exceeding the sixty-seven-vote two-thirds constitutional threshold required under Article I, Section 3—Chief Justice Sterling struck the marble rostrum once with his ivory gavel.

“The Senate having tried Garrett Thorne, President of the United States, upon two Articles of Impeachment exhibited against him by the House of Representatives, and two-thirds of the Senators present having found him guilty of high crimes and misdemeanors,” Chief Justice Sterling declared across the hushed chamber, “it is therefore ordered and adjudged that the said Garrett Thorne be, and he is hereby, removed from office.”

Before the defense table could even close their briefcases, our Senate Majority Leader rose and moved the second resolution under Article I, Section 3, Clause 7: permanent disqualification from ever holding any federal office again, which under settled Senate precedent required only a simple majority of fifty-one votes. When the clerk called *“Ms. Prairie”* on the permanent disqualification roll call, I delivered my second vote of the hour just as evenly as the first:

“Aye.”

The disqualification resolution passed sixty-eight to thirty-two. With that gavel strike, Garrett Thorne, Julian Vance, and Bret Halverson were not only stripped of their offices—they were barred for the rest of their natural lives from ever putting their names on a federal ballot or holding any office of honor, trust, or profit under the United States again.

And because we had convicted and removed Vice President Julian Vance on Thursday afternoon and left the Vice Presidency vacant, the Presidential Succession Act of 1947—Title 3, Section 19 of the United States Code—took immediate constitutional effect.

Fifteen minutes after the Senate doors swung open, Nate and Dad took the elevator down from the Family Gallery and rolled down the marble corridor beside my wheelchair into the Mansfield Room just off the Senate Floor.

Standing beneath the crystal chandelier—having just signed her formal resignation as Speaker and Representative from the House—was Clara Morales, her left hand resting on a bound copy of the Constitution and her family Bible while she raised her right hand before Chief Justice Jonathan Sterling to take the constitutional oath of office as the new President of the United States.

Nate locked his SwiftChair brakes right alongside mine at the front of the room and reached across the two-inch gap between our armrests to squeeze my hand while Dad rested his hands proudly on our shoulders.

“Clean sweep, Senator,” Nate whispered against my ear as the room erupted into applause for President Clara Morales. “All three of them gone for good.”

“Every single one, Nate,” I whispered back, squeezing my twin brother’s hand just as tight.